- Welcome to a study of the most important work of theology in the world: the book of Romans
  - As many of you probably know, this is not the first time I've taught this study for VBVMI
    - In fact, this is at least the fourth time I've gone through this book
    - And it's because I've studied through the book so many times, that I feel the need to do it again
    - That's how important the message of this book is…
    - How deep the concepts are, and how necessary it is that we understand it properly
  - In my previous study of this book, I used the first lesson to introduce the book
    - I explained Paul's reason for writing and his relationship to his audience
    - I still plan to provide some introduction tonight, but I want to refocus that introduction on the book itself
    - And along the way, I'll cover Paul's circumstances and his audience
- One of the things I've discovered in the years since my first study of Romans is how important it is to understand the structure of this book
  - I believe it's the key to appreciating its content
    - I've created a handout (available here) that breaks down the structure of the book in blocks according to topic

• We will refer back to this document throughout the course of our study

- The first block is Paul's introduction to his letter
- As he usually does, he identifies himself, his intended audience, and his occasion for writing
- Our study of his introduction will give me opportunity to address some important background to this letter

Rom. 1:1 Paul, a bond-servant of Christ Jesus, called as an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God,
Rom. 1:2 which He promised beforehand through His prophets in the holy Scriptures,
Rom. 1:3 concerning His Son, who was born of a descendant of David according to the flesh,
Rom. 1:4 who was declared the Son of God with power by the resurrection from the dead, according to the Spirit of holiness, Jesus Christ our Lord,
Rom. 1:5 through whom we have received grace and apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles for His name's sake,
Rom. 1:6 among whom you also are the called of Jesus Christ;
Rom. 1:7 to all who are beloved of God in Rome, called as saints: Grace to you and

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peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- Paul's salutation is similar to his other letters (though this is his longest), so elements will be familiar to many of us
  - In his typical humility, Paul addresses himself as a bond-servant of Jesus
    - In that day, the term bond-servant was used to describe a slave who had served his required time to repay a debt
    - But then later, because of the kindness of the master, the slave decided to renounce his right to freedom so he may remain in service to his master permanently
    - It was a lifelong, irrevocable commitment to live under the house of a good and faithful master
    - Paul frequently uses this term to describe himself and all Christians, since it captures the nature of our relationship with Christ
  - Secondly, Paul says he was an apostle called by God
    - Paul waged a life-long campaign to justify his apostleship with some in the church
    - His prior life as a persecutor and his unorthodox beginning in faith led some to question his authority
    - So Paul frequently reminds his readers of his authority given him by God
  - Ultimately, his apostolic powers authenticated his claims as they did all apostles
    - Only those men who possessed the supernatural powers of an apostle could lay claim to the title
    - In that way, the early church could safely distinguish between false apostles and true apostles
    - And since apostles were authors of scripture, it was especially important to know who the true apostles were
- Finally, Paul says his calling was to be set apart to preach the Gospel
  - And the way Paul describes the Gospel in vs.2-6 is our first clue to his audience and purpose in writing to Rome
    - Th elements in this description are uniquely targeted to a Jewish reader
    - First, Paul says this is the Gospel promised beforehand by the Old Testament prophets in the Jewish scriptures
    - Obviously, this would be a compelling argument for Jews
    - The Jews were looking for a coming Messiah because their scriptures foretold it, but Gentiles had no such advance notice
  - Secondly, Paul says those prophecies concerned a son of David – in human terms
    - Once again, the family identity of the Messiah was especially important to a Jew but largely irrelevant to a Gentile

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        - Furthermore, Paul reminds his readers that the truth of Jesus' claims were witnessed by His resurrection in Jerusalem and the Spirit of holiness
        - His last reference to the Spirit of Holiness would have hit home with Paul's readers
- Paul's writing principally to the Jewish leadership over the Christian church in Rome
    - The church in Rome was located in the largest, more powerful and prominent Gentile city in the world
        - The church was growing and flourishing by drawing converts from the city's vast Gentile population
        - So naturally, it consists largely of Gentiles
    - But that Gentile church was founded and overseen by Jewish men
        - These Jewish believers were converted at Pentecost while in Jerusalem for the Passover
        - So Paul is reminding them of that moment when he mentions the Spirit of holiness in v.4
        - Paul is speaking of the moment at Pentecost when the Spirit descended on these believers, a moment they will never forget
    - That group of converted Jewish men left Jerusalem soon after that moment, and returned to their homes in Rome
        - Once in Rome, they founded the church in that city
        - It was the only major church in the Roman empire NOT founded by an apostle
        - They were a successful church thriving in the empire's capital city, and they traced their start to Pentecost
        - Because of these unimpeachable credentials, this church had a chip on its shoulder
- Meanwhile, the church's most prominent Apostle, Paul, who had traveled throughout the Empire founding churches and visiting others, had yet to visit Rome
    - By the time Paul writes his letter to Rome, he has already taken three missionary journeys in Asia Minor
        - More over, he's begun writing letters to churches in the region
        - These letters are immediately recognized to be scripture and valued as such by the early church
        - By the time of this letter, Paul had already written Galatians, 1 & 2 Thessalonians, and three letters to Corinth (two of which are in the Bible)
        - But as yet Paul had never visited the Roman church nor even written to them
    - So the leaders in Rome were feeling overlooked by Paul
        - They wondered why the great apostle hadn't come to them yet
        - Perhaps he only cared for the churches he founded himself?
        - Perhaps Paul worried his preaching couldn't withstand the close scrutiny of

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learned Jewish believers, rather than the usual ignorant Gentile converts?
        - Perhaps Paul was ashamed to preach the Gospel in Rome fearing the Roman authorities
    - To make matters worse, Paul needed the church's help
        - Paul planned to travel to Spain after visiting Rome
        - And he knew he would need additional funds to make the trip
        - So Paul intended to ask the Roman church for financial help
        - A church that felt slighted by Paul
- So now, as Paul sets out to write to the Roman church, he knows he must repair the relationship on his terms while finding a way to make a financial appeal
    - But how do you identify with an audience you don't know and that you have never visited?
        - Paul couldn't speak in especially personal terms to this church as he typically does in his other letters
        - How do you mollify them for your perceived insult while also persuading them to contribute to your ministry?
    - Naturally, you write the single greatest theological explanation of righteousness ever penned
        - You appease the Jewish intellectuals leading this church by giving them your religious masterwork, a letter unrivaled by anything else in scripture
        - You honor this important church body residing at the center of the Empire by gifting them with the most influential evangelistic tool in the New Testament canon
        - In short, you bestow upon the Roman church your best work
        - So that at the end of that letter, you can ask them for money 😊
- In fact, Paul is more deferential to his audience in this letter than in any other he writes
    - Notice in v.5 Paul speaks of the church leaders in Rome as fellow evangelists and church planters
        - He says "we" have received apostleship
        - The Greek word for apostleship is different than the word Paul uses to describe himself in v.1
    - The word Paul uses in v.1 is *apostolos* which is a noun describing a person sent on a mission with a message
        - But in v.5 Paul uses the word *apostole* which is a noun describing the mission of going out
        - So Paul says he is an apostle, but yet the Jewish leadership in Rome – and all Christians – share a common mission of going out with the Gospel
    - These Jewish leaders have been living that calling in Rome, bringing Gentiles to the faith, as Paul says at the end of v.5

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        - Just as they themselves also are the called of Jesus Christ
        - So Paul recognizes their significant work to build another bridge with this community
- Then Paul concludes his opening sentence by naming his readers in v.7 as all the saints in Rome
    - Obviously, we know what Paul means by "saints"
        - This term is the Bible's label for anyone who is born again by faith in Christ Jesus
        - But the meaning behind the word is important to understand
    - The word in Greek is *hagios*, which literally means sanctuary
        - Therefore, all believers are called saints because by our faith in Christ, the Holy Spirit has made our body His sanctuary
        - So that collectively, we have become Christ's sanctuary on earth
        - We are the temple of God, as Paul says in 1 Cor. – His sanctuary
    - Some religions have redefined the term "saint" to mean a person who merits entrance into heaven by obtaining an exceptional degree of personal holiness
        - That's an ironic definition, one that reminds us why Paul needed to write Romans in the first place
        - The question of who enters Heaven is at the heart of Paul's purpose in writing this letter
        - And it's at the heart of the Gospel itself
    - The Bible calls us saints because God has taken up residence inside us to bring us to heaven by His work of righteousness
        - Yet the false definition of saint makes the opposite claim, that we enter heaven on our own merits
        - This one example, of the confusion over the word "saint" by itself, explains why we need to understand the book of Romans
- And with that, Paul follows with a customary benediction of grace and peace from God the Father and the Son
    - Paul's introduction is theological truth, but it's also an artful effort to draw his readers to Paul's side
        - And he continues the charm offensive in v.8

Rom. 1:8 First, I thank my God through Jesus Christ for you all, because your faith is being proclaimed throughout the whole world.
Rom. 1:9 For God, whom I serve in my spirit in the preaching of the gospel of His Son, is my witness as to how unceasingly I make mention of you,
Rom. 1:10 always in my prayers making request, if perhaps now at last by the will of God I may succeed in coming to you.

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Rom. 1:11 For I long to see you so that I may impart some spiritual gift to you, that you may be established;
Rom. 1:12 that is, that I may be encouraged together with you while among you, each of us by the other's faith, both yours and mine.
Rom. 1:13 I do not want you to be unaware, brethren, that often I have planned to come to you (and have been prevented so far) so that I may obtain some fruit among you also, even as among the rest of the Gentiles.
Rom. 1:14 I am under obligation both to Greeks and to barbarians, both to the wise and to the foolish.
Rom. 1:15 So, for my part, I am eager to preach the gospel to you also who are in Rome.

- Paul says this church's faith is proclaimed or announced throughout the whole world
  - We don't know what it was about the Roman's faith that inspired such talk, but we can assume some obvious things
    - They must have been fervent in their evangelism
    - They must have been devoted in their service to needs of the body
    - And they must have been resolute in the face of persecution
  - For all these reasons and perhaps others, Paul says he never failed to make mention of them
    - It would be easy to think Paul's statement was merely hyperbole or flattery
    - But read it as prophecy, because it's absolutely true
    - As a result of Paul's letter to Rome, the faith of this church has been proclaimed throughout the entire world over and over
    - Every time this letter is read, their faith is proclaimed once more
  - Also take note of Paul's extended commentary about his desire to visit them in Rome
    - He said he longed to see them and impart a spiritual gift
    - He doesn't mean he brought a gift of the Spirit
    - He clarifies the nature of this "gift" in v.12
  - He was saying he would gift them with his teaching and leadership to edify and establish (or strengthen) the church
    - In a sense, he was saying he would bring them the gift of himself
    - Paul's statement doesn't reflect a lack of humility on his part
    - He's speaking truthfully, because that was the impact Paul made on every church
    - After all, that's precisely why the church was so desiring of his visit
- But then it's back to the elephant in the room…why hasn't Paul visited Rome yet?

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- In v.13 he says I don't want you to be unaware (or "you should know") that I wanted to bear spiritual fruit with you even as I have with Gentiles
  - It's not Paul's fault…he says he's been prevented from coming to them
  - Who prevent Paul from coming? Obviously, he's implicating the Lord
- In v.14 Paul explains he was under obligation to Greeks and barbarians instead, to both Greeks and non-Greek Gentiles, that is to both the wise and foolish
  - That even though Paul desired to teach the church in Rome, the Lord had called Paul to reach the Gentile world instead
  - Which meant that a prosperous, Jewish-led church in far-away Rome was not a top priority for his ministry
- We can clearly see Paul's charm offensive here
  - Paul knew they were offended that he spent so much time with uneducated barbarians, instead of paying tribute to faithful Rome
  - So Paul acknowledges their concerns but then excuses his absence by saying don't blame me
  - God wouldn't let me come to you
- There are times we may blame God, and this is one example
  - When God prevents us from giving people what they desire because the Lord has a better plan
  - You can blame God, so to speak, but just make sure you defend His decision
- And it's revealing to see that even Paul experienced times when his personal desires for ministry conflicted with the Lord's desire
  - Even the great Paul experienced frustration
  - Even his discernment, as great as it was, still fell short at times
  - He wanted to go to Rome, but the Lord stopped him
- That should encourage all of us through our personal struggles in obeying the Lord vs. pleasing others
  - We may want to please everyone, but anyone can want for the wrong things
  - Therefore, the Lord knows we all need help to follow Him and He guides us all

- I mentioned earlier that it's likely some were even wondering if Paul was ashamed to bring the gospel to Rome
  - Which explains Paul's next comment, which serves as his transition into the theology of his letter

Rom. 1:16 **For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.**

- Paul states plainly he wasn't ashamed of the gospel

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- How could Paul be ashamed of a message that contains the power of God to save everyone who believes?
  - Moreover, why would Paul be ashamed to share this message with these Jewish leaders, since the message was to be delivered to everyone
  - First to the Jews but then to the Gentiles as well
  - Here, "First" is meant in all respects, because the Lord determined that the Jewish people would be at the center of His plan to save mankind
  - As Jesus tells the Samaritan woman at the well in John 4, "salvation is of the Jews"
- The Jews were the first to receive God's promises of salvation in the covenants
  - They heard of it first through their prophets
  - They had the honor to birth the Jewish Messiah into the line of David
  - They were the first to witness the preaching and miracles of the Messiah in the Galilee
  - And they also rejected Him first before His crucifixion
- Later, Jewish apostles were the first to deliver the Gospel to their countrymen
  - They established the Church in Jerusalem at Pentecost
  - Eventually, Paul and others brought the message of salvation to the Gentiles as the Lord promised Abraham that He would

- Paul calls his message of salvation the "gospel"
  - As most Sunday school children could probably tell you, the word itself means good news
    - Paul's message was the good news of how a person may be saved
    - It is the message for how we may enter Heaven, how we may live forever and conquer death, how we may escape sin
  - In that sense, calling the salvation message "good news" is probably the greatest understatement in human history
    - God's message of salvation is not just good news…it's great news!
    - Never has there been any greater news than how a person may be saved!
  - But thanks to the enemy's lies, the word "gospel" is losing its meaning in and around (many of the) churches today
    - Today we have many messages competing for the title of the "gospel"
    - False religions pretending to be Christianity claim that the gospel says we must earn our entrance into heaven (what's good about that news?)
    - False teachers claim the gospel is a message offering the promise of earthly riches and freedom from earthly worries
    - Still others claim the gospel is a message of physical healing
  - Here again, this is why it's so important that we study Romans today

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    - Because believers must know precisely what our gospel message says, and what it does not say
    - The gospel is a message of how we may enter into Heaven and it is good news because it doesn't depend upon us
    - It says how we may be freed from the sin that rages in our bodies and in our world
    - Of how we can face death in hope that we will live again
    - Of how we may have peace with God
- So over the next 15 chapters or so, Paul will explain this message of good news in all its fullness
    - Beginning in v.17 with a concise definition of the Gospel, which serves as his thesis for the entire letter

Rom. 1:17 For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith to faith; as it is written, "but the righteous man shall live by faith."

- There are three key parts to his thesis statement, each of which Paul will examine in greater detail in later chapters
    - First, the message of the gospel is a message of righteousness
    - The word righteousness means innocent, just, being right
    - Righteousness is the opposite of sinfulness and wrongdoing
- Obtaining righteousness is the central dilemma for all humanity
    - How can human beings be right in all respects?
    - How can we forever and entirely remove that part of us that leads us to think, say and do what is unrighteous?
    - Every person instinctively recognizes his or her own unrighteousness and longs for what is right, both in ourselves and in the world
    - But who determines what is "right?"
- This leads to the second part of Paul's thesis: the righteousness of the gospel is that "of God"
    - The righteousness we need to seek is the righteousness of God
    - As the Creator and Law Giver and Judge, God alone determines what is right
    - He sets the gold standard, the only standard for what's required to enter Heaven
    - So we could say, that which is of God is righteous and that which is not of God is (by definition) unrighteous
- So our pursuit of righteousness must begin with understanding God and His righteousness
    - From that point we may then ask the question, "How do I equal the standard of

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God?"

- How do I become as righteous as God?

- This leads to the third part of his thesis: we obtain the righteousness of God through a revelation
  - The word "revealed" in Greek here is in the third person middle tense
    - This form indicates that the subject is acting in its own interest or on its own behalf
    - So Paul is saying the righteousness of God reveals itself to us in the message of the Gospel
    - We don't discover righteousness, we don't search for a message of righteousness and find it
    - The righteousness of God finds us in a message that reveals itself to us by faith
  - Paul says it does so "from faith to faith"
    - Our faith in the message, is the manifestation of God's righteousness in us
    - And that righteousness is manifested from faith to faith
    - The righteousness of God is being revealed from one believer to the next
  - Paul has much more to say about this process in coming chapters, so we will leave it for then
    - Moving on, Paul adds that this process is nothing new
    - The Lord announced it in the Old Testament scriptures
  - Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4

Hab. 2:4 **"Behold, as for the proud one,**
His soul is not right within him;
But the righteous will live by his faith.

- The prophet says the one who takes pride in himself does not possess a right heart
- A person may think himself a good person or worthy of heaven, but if he does, he is self-deceived
- For a righteous man lives by his faith
  - To live means two things here
  - First, to live means to go through life depending on faith alone for salvation
  - Secondly, to live means to receive eternal life as a result of faith
  - So a righteousness man lives in hope having placed his faith in God and by that faith he lives eternally
- Having laid down his thesis, we should expect Paul would now dive into a discussion of these points

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- And he will…but not yet
  - This is where understanding the structure of the book becomes valuable
  - Notice that the second block in my diagram (i.e., Paul's thesis) is followed by a third block of arguments on a different point
- Before Paul elaborates on the means to righteousness, he will first address the common misconceptions men hold for how to be righteous
  - Before Paul will explain how we become righteous, he explains how we do NOT become righteous
  - This section runs until chapter 3:20 and includes four major divisions
  - These divisions correspond to the four major world views for how a person becomes righteous (or goes to heaven)
- Paul refutes all four fallacies in turn
  - The first is paganism
  - The second is moralism
  - The third is nomianism
  - And the fourth is Judaism
- Only after refuting these false views does Paul return to describing the correct way to righteousness
  - In fact, if you glance ahead to Romans 3:21-22 you can see how Paul picks up again in his discussion there
  - So his teaching between 1:17 and 3:21 is on a different topic

- As we study these false views, you'll see they all share one common misconception
  - They all hold a false understanding of the standard to enter Heaven…that is, of how righteous we must be to enter Heaven
    - Sinful humanity has always assumed that the standard for heaven is within their reach
    - Though we may not believe we are good enough as yet, we do believe we can get there
    - That self-deception begins with a wrong definition of the word righteous (or we could say good)
  - For example, are you a good person?
    - Before you answer, consider how Jesus defines the term good in Luke 18

Luke 18:18 A ruler questioned Him, saying, "Good Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"
Luke 18:19 And Jesus said to him, "Why do you call Me good? No one is good except God alone.

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- A man of power and wealth asked Jesus the age-old, eternal question: what must I do to inherit eternal life?
  - His question brings certain assumptions and it includes a contradiction of sorts
    - First, he asks what must I do, as in what works must I perform?
    - He is assuming the solution centers on his works, and that it lies within his ability to obtain
    - We know that is his thinking, because no one asks for directions to a place they can't possibly reach
    - For example, no one asks how can I fly to Jupiter?
  - Yet we can no more find our own way into Heaven than we can fly ourselves to Jupiter
    - So it's the height of presumption that a man should ask such a question of God
    - Tell me what I must do to enter Heaven and I will do it
  - But even then, the man contradicts himself, because he says what must I do to "inherit" eternal life
    - An inheritance is – by definition – something assigned to us by another
    - An inheritance doesn't depend on our work, because no one earns an inheritance
  - So the man acknowledges that God alone has the authority to grant someone entry into heaven
    - So essentially, this man is asking how, by his actions, can he influence God such that would grant him the favor of eternal life
    - That's how men of great power and wealth think about most things
    - They assume their influence can be cause for others to do their bidding…even God
- To this, Jesus asks the man, why do you call me "good?"
  - Jesus focuses in on the key misconception driving the man's wrong thinking about heaven and righteousness
    - The man has a warped, self-serving sense of what "good" is
    - Mankind generally acknowledges that God is perfect and mankind is imperfect
    - But nevertheless, we also imagine ourselves good enough to warrant heaven even in our imperfect state
    - That assumption lies at the heart of this man's question…I think I'm close, but how much better do I need to be to enter Heaven?
  - He has the wrong standard, and Jesus illustrates this by asking why the man called Jesus good?
    - We know the man probably meant it as an idle compliment, a greeting intended to gain Jesus' attention and flatter Him a little
    - But his too-casual use of the word exposes his lack of thought concerning its

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meaning

- Jesus says no one is good but God alone
  - Goodness is not measured on a scale from 1–100
  - Either a person is as good as God or they are not good at all
  - To be less good than God is to be 100% bad, Jesus says
- So the standard to enter Heaven is to equal God's goodness…close doesn't count
  - The world's false view of righteousness operates on the assumption that righteousness is found on a sliding scale…close is good enough
  - We imagine this to be the standard because otherwise heaven would be out of reach
  - So everyone assumes a standard for goodness that is within their reach and therefore not good at all

- Paul alludes to this common misconception as he introduces the next section on paganism

Rom. 1:18 For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men who suppress the truth in unrighteousness,
Rom. 1:19 because that which is known about God is evident within them; for God made it evident to them.
Rom. 1:20 For since the creation of the world His invisible attributes, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly seen, being understood through what has been made, so that they are without excuse.

- Far from being righteous (or even close to righteousness), Paul says the world is filled with ungodliness and unrighteousness
  - Men and women are both ungodly and unrighteous
    - To be ungodly means to be unlike God in every way
    - We are not just a little unlike Him, so that we have only a small gap to cross to enter Heaven, as the ruler supposed
    - In reality, we are entirely unlike Him by our nature
  - Moreover, we are unrighteous
    - We are not merely short a little righteousness
    - But as Jesus said, no one is good but God alone
    - We are 100% bad
  - And yet despite the world's ungodliness and unrighteousness, it thinks itself unworthy of God's judgment, His wrath
    - In order to arrive at these views, the world suppressed the truth, Paul says, which is further unrighteousness

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        - The world suppresses the truth by perpetuating a lie that we are all good enough and that God does not care about our sin
        - Or even that there is no God at all, or that our lives lead to nowhere in the end
    - But Paul says the wrath of God will be revealed upon these people
        - God's wrath is coming for the world, though it hasn't been revealed yet
        - Individually, it is revealed at a person's death, when they are brought to their end in judgment
        - And in a time to come, the wrath of God will be revealed upon the earth itself in fire, Peter says
- God will hold the world accountable for its ungodliness for He can do nothing less, being truly just
    - And yet God will not have been unfair in this judgment because He did not leave them unaware of Himself
        - Paul says in v.19 that which is known about God is evident within them
        - It's important to understand what Paul IS saying here and what he is NOT saying
    - First, Paul is saying that God has placed inside every person both the capacity and the opportunity to know of God
        - The Greek word for evident means something that is plainly seen
        - We sometimes say self-evident
        - For example, I could say that the existence of the sun and moon is plainly evident or self-evident
        - No one needs to be taught of their existence, since they are plainly seen by all (except perhaps a blind person)
    - Similarly, the existence of the God of Creation is plain to all humanity, because His existence is self-evident to our conscience
        - We know instinctively that He exists because He has placed that knowledge in us
        - Solomon says it this way:

Eccl. 3:11 **He has made everything appropriate in its time. He has also set eternity in their heart, yet so that man will not find out the work which God has done from the beginning even to the end.**

- Solomon says God has set eternity in the human heart
- No man upon his death will truly be surprised to learn that God exists, not even those who claim no belief in God while they live
- Since they suppressed this truth planted in their heart, God will justly reveal His wrath against their ungodliness
- On the other hand, Paul is NOT suggesting that this instinctive knowledge of God is

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sufficient to bring us to a saving faith in Jesus Christ

- The phrase “that which is known” at the beginning of v.19 uses a verbal form of the word knowledge
  - So Paul is saying the knowable things of God are evident
  - Not everything about God or Christ or the Gospel has been placed in our hearts
  - No one is saved merely by the knowledge of God planted in our hearts
- Yet what is knowable of God is enough to convict us for ignoring Him
  - It leave us without excuse, Paul says in v.20
  - So men suppress the truth of God inside themselves

- Moreover, Paul says they also suppress the truth of God evident in Creation by perpetuating the lie that the Creation is God
  - This is the oldest lie in the book, literally
    - It’s the lie Satan authored…that the creation can replace the Creator
    - Whether it’s something they see in the cosmos or in nature or even an angel or man, the pagan’s lie is that the created thing is God
  - You can understand a lot about God by examining what has been made
    - You can see the immensity of the Creation and recognize that the Creator must be a God of unimaginable power
    - And anything that powerful should be feared if we don’t please Him
    - We can observe the perfect order of Creation, from the balance of nature, the orbit of planets, the mathematics of natural forces
    - In seeing these things, we understand God is a God of order, not chaos
    - And any God of order can be known and understood
  - Furthermore, we can see in the Creation a world specially designed for the needs of man
    - From the atmosphere, the food supply, the cycles of nature, the dominion man has over all creatures
    - Clearly God has provided good things for us, which suggest the Creator has taken a personal interest in mankind’s needs
    - And so we can know He is a God of mercy and love
  - We can also see the world is wearing out and that men die
    - So as beautiful as this Creation may be, it’s not perfect
    - It leaves us wanting for a solution to death, destruction and sin
    - And though we may not know the solution, we know that a caring, loving God must have a way prepared for us
    - So we may seek for that answer in confidence and hope
    - Finally, we can fairly assume that a God of such power and mercy will also hold

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us accountable should we rebel

- These are the invisible attributes of God, yet they are clearly visible to us in the plan of Creation
  - We see his eternal power and divine nature in these things, and so we cannot live as if there is no God over His Creation
    - All mankind has the ability to know these things about God, Paul says, so all will be without excuse
    - But once again, mankind cannot arrive at the Gospel merely from observing Creation
    - The Creation is a testimony to God's nature and power, but more revelation is still required to know the Gospel
    - Nevertheless, they can be judged simply on the basis of the testimony of Creation
  - Psalms explains it this way:

Psa. 19:1 The heavens are telling of the glory of God;
And their expanse is declaring the work of His hands.
Psa. 19:2 Day to day pours forth speech,
And night to night reveals knowledge.
Psa. 19:3 There is no speech, nor are there words;
Their voice is not heard.
Psa. 19:4 Their line has gone out through all the earth,
And their utterances to the end of the world.
In them He has placed a tent for the sun,
Psa. 19:5 Which is as a bridegroom coming out of his chamber;
It rejoices as a strong man to run his course.

- The heavens testify to God's glory
  - To His existence, power and nature
  - If you have marveled at the genius of an artist or musician or scientist because of what they created
  - Then how can you not marvel at God's attributes when you witness Creation?
  - Just as we can see a work of art like the statue of David or the Sistine Chapel and recognize the unique genius of Michelangelo
  - Then even more, we should look at the Creation and understand it what it says about God
- Moreover, it should lead us away from assuming too much about our own power or the power of the created world
  - After all, how significant do you feel when you witness the vastness of the stars and galaxies?

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- How wise do you think you are while you're struggling to understand the intricacy of atoms and DNA and cells and the other building blocks of creation?
- How self-made do you feel when you see the perfection of the design of the human body?

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- Having put the introduction behind us, it's time to dive headlong into the theology of Paul's most important letter
  - We've heard Paul's introduction as he attempted to build a bridge with his audience in Rome
    - We heard his thesis in Block 2 of the outline, where Paul laid down the central message of his letter
    - His theme is found in vs.16-17 where Paul says the message of the Gospel is (or possesses) the power of God to save those who believe it
    - There is only this one message that saves, for it is sufficient for all men both Jew and Gentile
    - And it reveals the righteousness of God through our faith
  - In short, this is a letter about how anyone may become good enough to enter Heaven
    - Or as Paul says, how we may become righteous
    - This is a letter about righteousness
  - So now all that remains for Paul to do is to elaborate on how we may obtain the righteousness required for Heaven; by a message we call the Gospel
    - It's no small task
    - So it will require the better part of 15 chapters for Paul to do so
  - But before Paul even gets started, he moves first into a series of counter-arguments against false ways to become righteous before God
    - He refutes the claims of the four major categories of religious lies
    - All human religions can fit into one of these four categories
    - Paul will address these lies first before explaining the one true way God has provided for righteousness
- Block 3 begins in v.18 with Paul's opening statement concerning all false religion
  - As we studied last week, Paul says that the wrath of God is to be revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness
    - Paul's saying that there is an unseen God prepared to hold humanity accountable for sin
    - He will hold us accountable because the existence of a true Creator God is undeniable
  - Paul says the knowledge of God is self-evident being witnessed by our conscience
    - The knowledge of God is present in every person
    - That knowledge is general, not specific
    - Everyone has an instinctive understanding that a Creator God exists
    - But our instinct is insufficient to explain God completely and truly, as Solomon declared:

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Eccl. 3:11 He has made everything appropriate in its time. He has also set eternity in their heart, yet so that man will not find out the work which God has done from the beginning even to the end.

- Despite having been born with an instinctive knowledge of God, mankind is so desperately evil that we suppress this truth by substituting lies
  - And we call these lies we tell ourselves "religion"
    - Though we think a wide variety of religions exist, scripture teaches here in Romans that there are only 4 types of false religion
    - Within each type we can find countless variations
    - But those variations are meaningless…they are just playing with the details
    - So now Paul deals with the first of these four types: paganism (see chart)
  - The lie of paganism asserts that some part of Creation is our god
    - Pagans worship what they can see instead of the invisible God Who made it all
    - Pagans are people who worship the sun, moon or stars (e.g., astrology)
    - They may worship nature in various forms (e.g., mother nature, science)
    - They may worship animals or people (e.g., reincarnation, cults)
    - They may worship angels or aliens or demons or the devil himself
    - Into this category, you can fit religions like Buddhism, Taoism, Hinduism, Unitarianism, Scientology, Zoroastrianism, Earth religion, humanism, astrology, Darwinism, etc.
  - But the common denominator among all paganistic systems is worship of created things
    - In all cases, the pagan has suppressed the truth that these things have no power to create anything
    - Therefore, pagans conveniently overlook the question of where did everything come from?
    - They look only within Creation for their solution, and as a result they become increasingly foolish
- Paul explains the pagan fallacy next:

Rom. 1:20 For since the creation of the world His invisible attributes, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly seen, being understood through what has been made, so that they are without excuse.
Rom. 1:21 For even though they knew God, they did not honor Him as God or give thanks, but they became futile in their speculations, and their foolish heart was darkened.
Rom. 1:22 Professing to be wise, they became fools,
Rom. 1:23 and exchanged the glory of the incorruptible God for an image in the

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form of corruptible man and of birds and four-footed animals and crawling creatures.
Rom. 1:24 **Therefore God gave them over in the lusts of their hearts to impurity, so that their bodies would be dishonored among them.**
Rom. 1:25 **For they exchanged the truth of God for a lie, and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator, who is blessed forever. Amen.**

- Paul walks his readers through the history of paganism and its effects on the heart of mankind
  - Paganism owns the dubious distinction of being the first false religion man invented
    - Paganism traces its origins to the Tower of Babel, where Nimrod lead mankind for the first time into the worship of the Creation
    - The people declared they would come together in a city and construct a tower so tall its top would be in the heavens
  - The subtext of that account in Genesis 11 is that people believed themselves powerful enough to define a new heaven for themselves
    - They declared let us make a name for ourselves
    - The Hebrew word for “name” is *shem*
    - And interestingly, God invested His seed promise in the man Shem, the son of Noah
    - So it seems as if the people are saying let us make our own “Shem”, that is our own way to God – and so paganism was born
  - But remember, Chapter 11 of Genesis takes place after the Flood, almost 2,000 years after the fall of Adam
    - So mankind didn’t embrace worship of the creation right away
    - It took a while to get there, and Paul explains that process
- In the beginning, the reality of God was evident to all
  - Mankind beheld the glory of the Creation and understood that an all-powerful God had made it
    - But then a process of spiritual deterioration began
    - The catalyst for this process, of course, was the fall of Adam and the curse that God pronounced on Creation
    - The fallen state of mankind didn’t just put his soul in mortal jeopardy
    - It also placed a cancer in our hearts, one that slowly robbed us of our ability to truly know God
  - Paul says that in the beginning, men knew God
    - Men like Cain knew God and even sacrificed to Him as we read in Genesis 4
    - But as the account of Cain illustrates well, these men did not honor God nor continue with an attitude of thankfulness

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        - Instead, they became futile in their speculations
        - "Futile" could be translated vanity, so in vanity they began to speculate
        - They substitute opinions of God for the truth of what they knew
    - And in time this process of substituting foolish speculations for the truth darkened the human heart
        - The truth of God is light to our soul
        - But when we push that light away, rejecting truth and instead choosing to believe opinions and speculations about God, we grow more foolish
    - And we lose the ability to find our way back
        - Imagine someone in complete darkness with a single candle for light
        - Then they begin walking away from the candle in the darkness
        - In time, they will find themselves so far from the candle they can't see it any longer
        - And in the darkness, they can't find their way back to the light
        - Mankind made a similar journey, spiritually speaking
- So in v.22, Paul says mankind was professing to be wise yet they became foolish
    - The word "professing" means to make an assertion
        - Anyone can assert anything
        - But our assertions are not automatically truth
        - Just because someone in a small group Bible study declares "what this verse means to me is…" doesn't mean they know what it means
        - In fact, that statement almost always precedes a foolish statement
    - From darkened, foolish hearts, mankind continued its downward decent in v.23
        - The next step in this spiral is to exchange the glory of a creator God for a lie, the lie of paganism
        - They began worshipping and serving created things
    - Among the things we worship instead of God include corruptible man, birds, four-legged creatures and even crawling creatures
        - Notice the progression within that list
        - First men traded worship of God for God's greatest creation, man
        - That was bad enough, for it should have been obvious that there was no man worth worshipping since all are corrupted
- But mankind's decent into foolishness didn't stop there
    - We moved to worshipping birds, which are lower than mankind
        - They can't even think and talk, like us, yet we think they are superior to us?
        - But at least they can fly

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- But we moved from them to dumb four-legged animals that can't talk, can't think, and can't even fly
  - Bulls, goats, jackels, cats, etc.
  - The worst, of course, is poodle worship, for which there is no hope of redemption
- Lastly, mankind began to worship the least of creation: insects
  - Paul's point is to mock the stupidity and foolishness of a heart that walks away from God
  - We can't shake our instinctive desire to worship something, but our spiritual blindness directs us to fulfill that need in the strangest ways
  - Including calling bugs our gods
- And even our so-called sophisticated modern world has continued this decent
  - In Paul's day, the worst he had seen was worshipping insects
  - But today you can find people worshipping rocks and trees
  - We've moved to the most meaningless parts of Creation

- All this pagan foolishness would be laughable except that it produces such devastating consequences within society
  - In v.24 Paul explains the next step down this decent into oblivion
    - He says the Lord gave men over to their lusts so they would dishonor their bodies
    - We could rephrase Paul's statement this way:
    - Because they walked away from the light, the Lord gave them over to their dark desires so that would suffer the consequences together
  - Mankind came to this point because it exchanged the Creator for the lie of paganism
    - Paul uses the word "exchanged" to reflect that men made this trade willingly
    - Mankind began with a knowledge of God yet they chose to trade it for something less
    - So that in future generations, mankind had forgotten they ever possessed God in the first place
  - That exchange then set the stage for our lustful desires to plunge mankind into ruin
    - Elevating the creation above the Creator amplifies the importance of physical things over spiritual things
    - As physical things increase in importance to us, we will give physical needs priority over spiritual needs such that the flesh will begin to rule
    - Ultimately, fulfilling our body's desire becomes the end purpose of life rather than pleasing the Creator
  - This leads mankind to devolve in our flesh in the same way we devolved in our spirit
    - Just as mankind's worship started with God but ended with rocks and trees…

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        - Similarly, our physical lusts descend into increasing depravity

Rom. 1:26 For this reason God gave them over to degrading passions; for their women exchanged the natural function for that which is unnatural,
Rom. 1:27 and in the same way also the men abandoned the natural function of the woman and burned in their desire toward one another, men with men committing indecent acts and receiving in their own persons the due penalty of their error.
Rom. 1:28 And just as they did not see fit to acknowledge God any longer, God gave them over to a depraved mind, to do those things which are not proper,
Rom. 1:29 being filled with all unrighteousness, wickedness, greed, evil; full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, malice; they are gossips,
Rom. 1:30 slanderers, haters of God, insolent, arrogant, boastful, inventors of evil, disobedient to parents,
Rom. 1:31 without understanding, untrustworthy, unloving, unmerciful;
Rom. 1:32 and although they know the ordinance of God, that those who practice such things are worthy of death, they not only do the same, but also give hearty approval to those who practice them.

- Once again, God gave mankind over to passions that dishonor or degrade the person
    - He allowed mankind's physical condition to find its bottom just as He did for our spiritual condition
        - And what is the low-water mark for mankind physically?
        - When men and women trade the natural sexual desire for that which is unnatural
    - Of course, Paul is speaking of homosexuality behavior, except that word didn't exist in Paul's day
        - Society had not yet given this behavior such a respectable word
        - In Paul's day, it was simply described as he does here
        - And this is Paul's example of the worst form of human foolishness and rebellion
    - Today, it's become fashionable to assert that homosexuality is compatible with Christianity
        - Paul calls such acts indecent, which literally means shameless
        - They are shameless in the sense that society no longer considers the acts to be cause for shame but rather approves them
    - Despite this our Lord condemns such behavior in the strongest of terms in various places in scripture
        - Prior to the Law, the Lord showed His displeasure with this type of conduct by judging Sodom and Gomorrah with fire from heaven
        - In the Law, the Lord called for the death penalty for those who might practice it

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in Israel

- And in the New Testament, the Word of God condemns it in the strongest terms, as you see here

- But there is always a consequence for sin, and Paul says the consequence for this type of sin will be a due penalty received in their own person
  - Due penalty refers to those necessary, inevitable outcomes
  - These aren't specific judgments of God but rather the natural consequences of going against God's design for Creation
- People who engage in these things risk receiving the due penalties in their persons
  - Persons refers to all aspects of their being: spiritual, emotional, and physical
  - And of course, history has shown Paul's words to be true as evidence for the devastating consequences of this perversion continues to pile up
- Then notice in v.28 Paul moves one step further to detailing the consequences for accepting such depravity
  - The Lord gives mankind over to a depraved mind
  - The word "depraved" means not standing the test or unapproved
  - So once more, the Lord allowed mankind to experience the consequences of their darkened hearts and perverse choices
  - The end of which is a mind that cannot stand the test, that is unapproved
  - In other words, our minds can no longer grasp what is good and proper
  - Our every thought is evil
- Glancing through vs.29-31 we find a succinct and accurate description of the society in which we live today
  - These are the due penalties inflicted upon society for their paganism
  - Having elevated the creation above the Creator, mankind engaged in lustful pursuits of the unnatural
  - And the polluting of our bodies leads to a polluting of our minds with the result that society is filled with the traits Paul lists
- The Bible is not claiming that homosexuality was the direct cause of these things
  - Rather Paul is drawing a conclusion about any culture that embraces perversion
  - The same social forces that render homosexuality acceptable will also lead to the acceptance of other forms of depravity
  - Before long greed, malice, wickedness, arrogance, disobedience to parents and all manner of evil will become the norm
  - These societal woes are all the result of the deteriorating spiritual condition of mankind according to the pattern of the first lie:

Knowing God —> Worshipping Physical Creation —> Lusting —> Depravity —>

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Wickedness

- Finally, Paul reminds us that all these behaviors are worthy of death according to the Creator, the author of the Law
  - So the great irony of paganism is that while pagans have forgotten God, God has not forgotten them
    - Despite paganism's determination to push God aside, the wrath of God will be revealed against them for their evil deeds
    - And notice at the end of the verse that death isn't just deserved for those who practice such things
    - But also for those who approve of such things
  - Today very few people, statistically-speaking, engage in the kind of depravity Paul describes
    - But very many approve of such things believing them to be good
    - They celebrate those who practice it
    - And Paul says any society who agrees with such things is as guilty as those who practice it
- How do we preach the gospel to these two camps of religious deception?
  - For the paganist, the question must be what came before what is and who made it?
    - The best appeal for a paganism is the appeal of a Creator God, as Paul explained
    - Paul follows this model elsewhere as he confronted paganism

Acts 14:8 At Lystra a man was sitting who had no strength in his feet, lame from his mother's womb, who had never walked.
Acts 14:9 This man was listening to Paul as he spoke, who, when he had fixed his gaze on him and had seen that he had faith to be made well,
Acts 14:10 said with a loud voice, "Stand upright on your feet." And he leaped up and began to walk.
Acts 14:11 When the crowds saw what Paul had done, they raised their voice, saying in the Lycaonian language, "The gods have become like men and have come down to us."
Acts 14:12 And they began calling Barnabas, Zeus, and Paul, Hermes, because he was the chief speaker.
Acts 14:13 The priest of Zeus, whose temple was just outside the city, brought oxen and garlands to the gates, and wanted to offer sacrifice with the crowds.
Acts 14:14 But when the apostles Barnabas and Paul heard of it, they tore their robes and rushed out into the crowd, crying out
Acts 14:15 and saying, "Men, why are you doing these things? We are also men of the same nature as you, and preach the gospel to you that you should turn from these vain things to a living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the

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sea and all that is in them.
Acts 14:16 **"In the generations gone by He permitted all the nations to go their own ways;**
Acts 14:17 **and yet He did not leave Himself without witness, in that He did good and gave you rains from heaven and fruitful seasons, satisfying your hearts with food and gladness."**
Acts 14:18 **Even saying these things, with difficulty they restrained the crowds from offering sacrifice to them.**

- Paul's appeal was to bring their attention to the origins of the very things they worshipped
- So the first religious lie, paganism, asserts that the creation is God
  - That lie gave license for mankind to amplify the importance of the physical world over the spiritual world
    - Inevitably, their pursuit of the physical triggered lusts which lead to greater and greater depravity
    - And a culture of depravity opened the door for all manner of sin over time
  - Self-evidently, paganism does not and cannot lead to righteousness
    - In fact, it appeals to the worst side of our nature
    - So that it increases depravity and unrighteousness
    - Which rightly deserves the Creator's wrath
- So one lie down, three to go…

Rom. 2:1 **Therefore you have no excuse, everyone of you who passes judgment, for in that which you judge another, you condemn yourself; for you who judge practice the same things.**
Rom. 2:2 **And we know that the judgment of God rightly falls upon those who practice such things.**
Rom. 2:3 **But do you suppose this, O man, when you pass judgment on those who practice such things and do the same yourself, that you will escape the judgment of God?**

- Notice, Paul moves into the second category of false religion: moralism
  - Moralism is the practice of making judgments about one's or others' righteousness
    - In effect, moralism is making ourselves the judge over both ourself and others
    - And based on the judgments we make, we assume God will follow suit as if we know the mind of God
    - Moralism is the second great religious lie after paganism
  - Paul transitions with the connecting word "therefore"

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        - He connects his earlier discussion with this new topic, so how are paganism and moralism connected?
        - Paganism gave rise to lust and depravity but not everyone in society participates to the same degree in these behaviors
        - The worst are pursuing unnatural lusts, while others are merely condoning it
    - So this gives rise to judgments
        - In a depraved society, mankind can begin to make distinctions between the good, the bad and the ugly
        - These moral judgments are relativistic and we make them according to our advantage
        - Like the young ruler who called Jesus good teacher
- But notice Paul says to his readers that "you" have no excuse for your sin
    - Paul is speaking to everyone because everyone is guilty
        - Paul says that as we judge others we condemn ourselves
        - When we judge someone, we're deciding that this person is unrighteous and therefore they are due a penalty
        - But when you make that determination, you are implying that standards for righteousness exist
        - You can't say someone is doing something wrong (in your view) without also agreeing that rules for right and wrong exist
    - So if you judge others, then you acknowledge that standards for righteous exist, and those standards are not your own
        - Self-evidently, we didn't make rules for society
        - And we certainly don't decide who enters Heaven
        - Yet we speak confidently that those who practice terrible things are due a penalty
        - Which means we know there is a lawgiver Who must judge these things
    - And logically, if we are acknowledging the existence of a lawgiver and a Law that must be followed, then we have condemned ourselves
        - Because as Paul says we have practiced the very same things that we accuse others of doing
        - Obviously, we haven't all committed exactly the same deeds
        - But we share a great many of the same offenses
    - And even beyond our actions, we share the same heart desires
        - Not all of us have killed a person, but we've all wished someone dead
        - Not all of us have stolen, but we've all longed for something we didn't possess
        - Not all of us have committed infidelity, but most have been attracted by the possibility

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- How do we pass judgment so easily then?
  - Passing judgment always involves making comparison, and moralism involves making wrong comparisons that favor our ego
    - We judge someone who commits a certain sin by comparing them to ourselves
    - Since we have never committed that particular sin, we can feel good about ourselves in making that comparison
    - And we can feel right in judging the person who fell
  - If we share their sin, then we judge them for having a more severe case, or worse consequences, or even a less repentant heart, compared to us
    - Whatever way we can compare ourselves favorably, we'll find it
    - And as we find it, we find cause to declare ourselves righteous
    - We draw the line between righteous and unrighteousness in that small crack that separates us from that "bad" person
    - And we take comfort that, once again, we're on the right side of the line
  - Of course, this line moves daily
    - As long as the moralist can find someone who is worse than we are, then we are safe
    - And the very fact that life seems to be going so well for us is our proof that our methodology is working
  - Moralism finds its reassurance in the way they avoid the worst of society
    - The moralist may have been convicted of cheating on taxes, but at least he didn't defraud millions like those evil men at Enron
    - The moralist may have dumped used motor oil in his backyard, but at least he didn't pollute the Alaskan coast like Exxon
    - The moralist may have cheated on his wife, but at least he didn't have sex with another man
    - The moralist may have killed someone, but at least he didn't murder six million like Hitler!
- The moralist can always find a comparison that affirms he is righteous enough to warrant heaven
  - So if you think you are good enough because you are better than Hitler, then ask yourself this…
    - Do you think Hitler was a liar? Yes…but have you ever lied?
    - Do you think Hitler ever spoke a hateful thought? Of course…but have you?
    - Do you suppose Hitler ever stole or deceived someone? Or coveted or betrayed or insulted someone? Undoubtedly…
    - But haven't you done these very same things too?
  - And of course Hitler also murdered, and perhaps you have never committed murder

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        - But is that what you're resting on when you say you're better than Hitler?
        - You can share every manner of sin with the man, but because you find one difference that justifies your superior place?
        - Are you willing to rest on that difference? Are you confident that God's standard requires that *only* mass murderers go to Hell?
- That's why Paul asks in v.3 do you suppose, O moralist, that you will escape the judgment of God?
    - God is the Author of the Law and the Creator of all things under His Law, and therefore He will judge all things according to His standard
        - Simply put, it's His Heaven, so He gets to decide the standard for entry
        - And unlike the moralist, the judgment of God is unbiased
    - Why has the moralist "supposed" he will escape judgment someday? Because the moralist assumes God's lack of response to date is proof all is well
        - Ask a moralist if he or she is afraid of death or the judgment that follows, and he will probably tell you no
        - He will tell you that he has no reason to fear, because he is a "good person"
        - The fact that his life is going the way he desires and he has avoided disaster is evidence that he is making "right" choices
        - Sometimes people express this concept as "karma"
        - It leads to greater confidence in their self-righteousness and a heartless, judgmental attitude towards others
    - So the lie of moralism is that righteousness is a sliding scale, and we can be our own judge
        - We judge ourselves as basically good people, good enough to get to heaven
        - And we find confidence in our assumptions because our life is going well, God seems pleased with us and is rewarding us with a good life
        - When we see people suffering, we tell ourselves they did something wrong and are getting what they deserved
        - And we take satisfaction in knowing that the truly bad people are going to hell
- But Paul says things are not as they seem for the moralist

Rom. 2:4 Or do you think lightly of the riches of His kindness and tolerance and patience, not knowing that the kindness of God leads you to repentance?
Rom. 2:5 But because of your stubbornness and unrepentant heart you are storing up wrath for yourself in the day of wrath and revelation of the righteous judgment of God,
Rom. 2:6 who will render to each person according to his deeds:
Rom. 2:7 to those who by perseverance in doing good seek for glory and honor and immortality, eternal life;

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- The moralist is thinking lightly of the riches of the kindness, tolerance and patience of God
  - The word for tolerance can be translated delaying
    - God, in His kindness, is delaying addressing the sin of the moralist
    - And the word for patience is also translated long-suffering
    - So while God waits to see you at your judgment, he's suffering watching you take His patience for granted
  - The moralist takes for granted their good life, and he views the absence of God's judgment as confirmation he is righteous
    - But God's delay is not an endorsement
    - It's kindness from God intended as an opportunity for repentance
  - When the moralist dies and faces the righteous judgment of God, he or she will realize that those good years were wasted, Paul says in v.5
    - Paul contracts the moralist's self-serving judgment with the judgment of God which will be righteous
    - God doesn't grade on the curve
    - We won't get by with the nonsense we tell ourselves; how we're good enough because we're not the worst we could be
- Paul says that as the moralist tells himself he is safe, in reality he is storing up wrath for his day of judgment
  - Imagine we could measure God's wrath in increments, like filling a measuring cup with wrath
    - Paul uses that idea to remind the moralist that his good days on earth should not give him confidence going into his judgment
    - For as each sinful day passes, the moralist's sins don't go unnoticed by God
  - The wrath those sins warrant is being stored up
    - The Lord is delaying bringing His wrath, but only for a time
    - Meanwhile, the moralist believes he has avoided wrath simply because he hasn't seen anything happen yet
  - But as Paul quotes from Proverbs, the Lord will render a judgment for each man that fully reflects that person's deeds
    - Each man's life is storing up something
    - God's judgment of us is connected to our deeds
    - This is a general principle guiding God's judgment
- Paul then gives contrasts of how believers and unbelievers store up for eternity
  - In v.7 Paul says that when God judges the believer, the Lord will assign reward according to our service to God
    - If the believer perseveres in doing good, seeking glory and honor, then that

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person is storing up eternal life
        - Now at first hearing, that conclusion sounds wrong to us, especially since Paul says later that works do not earn salvation
        - But remember, Paul's talking about judgments, and the only judgment believers face is the Judgment seat of Christ
    - So v.7 is describing the judgment God makes of believers for the assigning of reward, not for determining if we may receive salvation
        - Concerning that judgment, we are storing up eternal life
        - Or we could say we are determining the nature of our eternal life
        - The more we serve, the more good deeds we accomplish, the more there will be waiting for us there
- But then Paul moves to the other side, when the Lord judges the unbelieving

Rom. 2:8 but to those who are selfishly ambitious and do not obey the truth, but obey unrighteousness, wrath and indignation.
Rom. 2:9 There will be tribulation and distress for every soul of man who does evil, of the Jew first and also of the Greek,
Rom. 2:10 but glory and honor and peace to everyone who does good, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.
Rom. 2:11 For there is no partiality with God.

- The Lord will render punishment to unbelievers according to the degree of a person's sinful deeds
    - The worse the sins a person commits during their life on Earth, the worse the punishment will be
        - So we can take some satisfaction knowing that the "Hitlers" of the world will get what they have coming
        - But that will be little satisfaction to those who find themselves at the "cooler" end of Hell's furnace
        - God's wrath will be unbearable regardless, and all men should seek to be rescued from the just penalty their sins deserve
    - The sold-out moralist isn't bothered by that arrangement
        - He's already convinced he will get a passing grade
        - He's told himself that his days are filled with good deeds and he has conveniently overlooked his sins
    - That's the conceit of the moralist
        - He has declared himself to be righteous and expects God to agree with his decision
        - The moralist has an unrealistic view of sin, both of others and himself

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- So the second great religious lie follows naturally from the first
  - As paganism gave rise to an increasingly evil and depraved society, it produced opportunity for men to distance themselves, one from another
    - Some declared themselves to be better than others
    - It became possible to make judgments of "good" and "bad"
    - Which gave rise to a pecking order of morality within society
  - But that pecking order was self-serving and relativistic and not at all according to the standard God uses
    - So while men were judging themselves above God's wrath, they were only fooling themselves
    - God has been watching them as they sin, storing up wrath
    - And one day the Lord will bring that wrath according to their deeds
- Finally, how do we appeal to the moralist?
  - The moralist must come to appreciate his or her own sin and that the standard of God is exact, unbending and not in their favor
    - The best lesson for the moralist is the one Jesus taught the young ruler which we covered last week
    - There is no one good but God alone
    - And unless we equal the goodness of God, we cannot receive what is His
  - Remember how that encounter ended?

Luke 18:20 "You know the commandments, 'Do not commit adultery, Do not murder, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Honor your father and mother.'"
Luke 18:21 And he said, "All these things I have kept from my youth."
Luke 18:22 When Jesus heard this, He said to him, "One thing you still lack; sell all that you possess and distribute it to the poor, and you shall have treasure in heaven; and come, follow Me."
Luke 18:23 But when he had heard these things, he became very sad, for he was extremely rich.
Luke 18:24 And Jesus looked at him and said, "How hard it is for those who are wealthy to enter the kingdom of God!
Luke 18:25 "For it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God."
Luke 18:26 They who heard it said, "Then who can be saved?"
Luke 18:27 But He said, "The things that are impossible with people are possible with God."

- Jesus knowing the man was expecting to work his way to Heaven, played along with him

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at first

- He gave the man a list of works to perform to enter Heaven
- The man, a moralist, responded he liked what he was hearing
- In his mind, he judged himself successful against all those commandments

- The Lord intentionally picked commandments that were likely to please the man, since these rules were among the most severe
  - The man says he has kept them from his youth, meaning as far back as could remember
  - Again, his standard was that he felt good about himself, not that God did
- So Jesus lowers the boom asking the man to do something not found in the Law at all
  - He tells him to sell everything to bless the poor so that he may receive a rich reward in Heaven
  - But this was too much to ask, and so the man left very sad
  - Notice he didn't leave angry or defensive
  - He didn't argue the point, because he knew instinctively that Jesus was asking for something "good"
- The man simply couldn't agree to those terms, and in that way Jesus exposed his biased scale
  - The man had judged himself worthy of eternal life using a scale tipped in his favor
  - But when Jesus changed the scale, the man wouldn't (not couldn't, but wouldn't) meet the terms
  - Of course, he wasn't truly innocent of those other laws either
  - But rather than getting into an debate with the man over his past imperfections, Jesus simply exposed his hypocrisy
- So the answer for the moralist is that we expose his hypocrisy by explaining from scripture what the true standard is for entry into Heaven
  - It is to meet God's standard
    - As Jesus says:

Matt. 5:48 **"Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.**

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- Paul is at work knocking down the major religious lies that deceive mankind
  - So far, Paul has dispensed with two of these lies
    - First, Paul shot down paganism
    - In fact, Paul demonstrated how paganism, the first false religion, is the course for humanity's depraved condition
    - They are focused on the creature rather than the Creator
  - Out of paganism came the second great religious lie: moralism
    - Moralism is a belief that people are good enough to get into heaven
    - It assumes God grades on a curve or gives credit for trying, and therefore all but the very worst of humanity get into heaven
    - Today, you can find so-called Christian pastors teaching that hell doesn't exist, which is an example of the lie of moralism
  - Those two lies cover a lot of ground, and many of the world's religions and even the non-religious fit into these two categories
    - But there are still two more broad religious lies that must be discounted before Paul is ready to explain the one true way we may become righteous
    - Tonight we study the third of these four lies: Nomianism
    - You see in your chart of the structure of Romans that this topic begins in Chapter 2:12
  - Following Nomianism comes Judaism in Chapter 3
    - In this context, Judaism describes the attitude that a Jew is saved automatically because they are descended from Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob
    - But of course, living as a Jew also included following the Law of Moses
    - And this aspect of Judaism may lead you to think that these two sections – Nomianism and Judaism – are actually one and the same topic
    - But as we move through them tonight, we'll see the differences between them
- Let's begin with Paul's argument against Nomianism

Rom. 2:12 **For all who have sinned without the Law will also perish without the Law, and all who have sinned under the Law will be judged by the Law;**
Rom. 2:13 **for it is not the hearers of the Law who are just before God, but the doers of the Law will be justified.**

- Paul's treatment of the the third religious lie begins as a transition out of v.11 where he stated that there is no partiality with God
  - He means that God does not change His standards from one person to another
    - No human being is graded differently than any other, so no one should expect special treatment

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        - God will judge each person against a set of expectations or laws
        - And He will assign an eternal outcome to each that is just
        - And God is so impartial that He will hold us accountable regardless of whether we know His expectations or not
    - In v12, Paul begins this section by talking about the Law
        - He says all who have sinned without the Law will also perish without the Law
        - He's raising the third religious system of Nomianism
        - Nomianism is the pursuit of righteousness by means of observing laws (or rules)
    - The largest world religions follow this system including Catholicism and Islam
        - These systems prescribe an intricate system of rules and rituals and teaches that these methods bring a person into heaven
        - They usually include a belief in the exclusivity of their rules
        - Catholics believe that only Catholics go to heaven, muslims believe only muslims go to heaven, etc.
        - So if one does not have the right set of laws or rules, they perish
- Paul addresses this idea in v.12
    - In the first half of the verse, he agrees that those without God's Law will perish in their ignorance
        - They perish, of course, because in their ignorance they did not keep the Law and therefore they sinned
        - No man or woman facing God in their judgment moment may claim they deserve Heaven despite their sin, merely because they didn't know God's law
        - Their ignorance of the law will not be a defense
        - They will experience the second death of spending eternity in the Lake of Fire
    - If that sounds unfair, remember that we have the same principle in our system of law
        - If you drive too fast through a school zone not realizing that school was in session, you're still going to get a ticket
        - If you don't pay enough taxes because you didn't realize an additional tax was required, you're still going to pay a penalty
        - Your ignorance of the law or the situation is no defense
- Nomianism agrees with this philosophy, at least in theory
    - Nomianism maintains that "good" people are those who keep the rules and "bad" people are those who break the rules
        - When good people keep the rules, they will be rewarded
        - When bad people break the rules, they will be punished
    - Many people find this thinking appealing, especially those of us raised in a Greek-thinking, western culture

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        - We're taught to respect law and order, and that playing by the rules is the right way to achieve what we want
        - We're raised to appreciate hard work and to expect that our efforts deserve reward
        - So it makes sense to us when someone tells us that God will reward us by this same criteria
        - If we keep God's rules and observe His rituals, we get to go to heaven
    - But of course, the opposite must also be true
        - Those who break God's rules must expect to pay the price for their lawbreaking
        - The punishment is just desserts
        - If you do the crime, you should expect to do the time
- While Nomianism largely holds true in human society, it conceals a fatal flaw when attempting to explain God's standard for heaven
    - Nomianism claims that keeping rules is required but then makes exceptions for those who don't keep the rules
        - Religious groups teach that living according to rules and traditions is the way to righteousness and heaven
        - And that failure to keep the rules leads to damnation
        - But everyone breaks rules sooner or later
    - So Nomianism holds that *pursuing* laws (i.e., rules, rituals) is sufficient to gain God's approval
        - Nomianism does not require that followers actually *keep* those laws to receive heaven
        - For example, have you ever heard someone describe themselves as a "good Catholic" or a "good Muslim?"
        - They aren't saying they are perfect rule keepers
        - They're saying they are one who is sincerely trying
    - In fact, Nomianistic religions assume their followers *will* fail
        - But these violations do not automatically disqualify someone from heaven
        - Conveniently, these religious systems have rules to cover the inevitable violations and restore the sinner to good standing
    - For example, Catholics teach that those who violate Catholic dogma may receive absolution through confession and doing penance
        - Mormons prescribe a process called repentance and restitution
        - Muslims are taught they may be forgiven by praying day and night, calling upon Allah using specific names they memorize
        - Rule-breaking Jehovah's Witnesses must submit to a re-education process while demonstrating a proper repentant attitude

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- So, every Nomianistic system includes more rules for how the guilty may amend for breaking the initial rules
  - And this is the flaw in Nomianism
    - These system profess that keeping rules is the way to heaven
    - But just as quickly they acknowledge no one keeps the rules
    - Yet somehow they still expect to receive a good judgment from God in the end
  - A cynical follower might conclude that they can ignore the rules altogether while pursuing a life of sin
    - But when death approaches, they can perform the steps for absolution and still get into heaven
    - That kind of hypocrisy is the logical outworking of nomianism
    - It's just another lie we tell ourselves, similar to the one moralists profess
  - Both nomianism and moralism pervert the standard God will use to judge
    - Moralism overestimates man's goodness by assuming he will measure up to God's standards for heaven
    - While nomianism underestimates God's standards for heaven, by assuming man's mistakes aren't disqualifying
    - These are two sides of the same counterfeit coin
- In the second half of v.12, Paul exposes the hypocrisy of nomianism
  - He reminds them that those who sin under the Law will be judged by the Law
    - To be under the Law means to have been notified of God's rules and to be obligated to keep them
    - Should such a person continue to violate those rules despite their knowledge, they too will receive a just penalty
    - Because the Law will condemn them
  - There is no advantage to having the knowledge if it isn't put to use
    - And since God shows no partiality, we can expect Him to take note of every rule we break
    - Nomianism's assumption that effort and sincerity will be enough will be proven wrong in the end
  - Paul targets this flaw in v.13 when he declares that God does not give credit for effort
    - Those who wish to be judged by a law must be prepared to keep it
    - Only those who keep God's law perfectly should expect to be justified (i.e., declared innocent)
    - Paul's statement defeats both moralism and nomianism
    - God's standard for entering heaven isn't as low as you had hoped, and you're not as good as you assumed

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- Obviously, Paul's referring to the Jewish people
  - Gentiles did not receive the Law of God, so they were "without the Law"
  - But Jews were given the Law at the mountain as part of the Old Covenant, and they agreed to keep it

- Perhaps there is no one who practices nomianism more fervently and more scrupulously than a Jew following the Mosaic Law
  - To be clear, Judaism is NOT nomianism
    - For example, King David and the prophet Daniel, like all Jewish saints, practiced Judaism
    - But scripture testifies that neither of them sought to be righteous before God merely by obeying the Mosaic Law
    - Nevertheless, many Jews throughout history have made that mistake, seeking to be righteous by zealously keeping the Law
    - They twist what the Lord gave Moses into the lie of nomianism
  - But rule-keeping Jews distance themselves from other religions by telling themselves they have the inside track with God
    - While Muslims and Catholics and Mormons and other Gentile religions also follow rules hoping to please God
    - Jews know these Gentiles are following the *wrong* rules, so they won't be rewarded in the end
  - Jews on the other hand, have God's Law given directly to them by the finger of God
    - So while everyone says they have the "right" rules, only Jews actually do
    - And they suppose that this will make the difference for them
  - This is Jewish nomianism, and it has always been prevalent within the Jewish nation
    - The Pharisees of Jesus' day practiced Nomianism in this way
    - They claimed to keep the Mosaic Law perfectly, and they found confidence in having the right law and in their own piety
    - But Jesus succeeded in exposing their hypocrisy over and over again
    - He called them white-washed tombs, clean only on the outside
- The sad truth is that even the most accomplished practitioner of nomianism will be disappointed upon their death to learn their efforts were insufficient
  - The Law of God was simply too demanding and their ability to keep that law was woefully inadequate
    - Everyday, many "good" Catholics and Muslims and Mormons enter into an eternity of punishment because they lacked the right rules and the ability to keep them
    - But likewise, many "good" Jews enter punishment as well though they heard the correct Law

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        - Because it matters only if they actually keep the Law, Paul says
    - To prove his point, Paul raises the example of a Gentile who knows nothing of the Law of Moses, yet instinctively conforms his life to the Law's requirements

Rom. 2:14 For when Gentiles who do not have the Law do instinctively the things of the Law, these, not having the Law, are a law to themselves,
Rom. 2:15 in that they show the work of the Law written in their hearts, their conscience bearing witness and their thoughts alternately accusing or else defending them,
Rom. 2:16 on the day when, according to my gospel, God will judge the secrets of men through Christ Jesus.

- The word instinctively could also be translated "by nature,"
- It refers to a desire within us that is not taught
- So a Gentile who shows mercy or charity or respects another man's property or tells the truth or honors his marriage vows, is doing the Law
    - Paul says he is showing the work of the law written on his heart, which we call following our conscience
    - The work of the Law is to produce righteous behavior, so we see the Law of God at work in his heart though he's never heard it
    - God is at work in mankind in this way all the time
    - It's how otherwise sinful people may accomplish good things from time to time
- Paul says a person's conscience will be his witness when he stands before God
    - His conscience will defend him in times when he followed it
    - But it will accuse him in the times when he ignored it
- Paul's point is that Jews should take no satisfaction merely in the fact that they possessed the "right" law
    - The only question that will matter in the end, for both Gentile and Jew, is whether we kept that law
        - In v.16 Paul says a day is coming when we will be judged and even the secret things we've said or done will be exposed
        - But that judgment will come "through" Christ Jesus
        - Meaning Christ will judge us against Himself
        - We aren't judged against ourselves or others, but against the sinless Savior
    - So if you want heaven, you must keep the Law as Jesus did
        - But many Jews in Paul's day believed they were keeping the Law perfectly
        - Just like the orthodox or ultra-orthodox Jews today feel they've met the mark
        - They hold the same point of view of that young ruler

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        - After Jesus named off various commandments, the ruler replied, “I’ve kept them from my youth.”
- So Paul next exposes the self-deception that drives nomianism among Jewish people… thinking they are actually keeping the Law when in fact they are not

Rom. 2:17 But if you bear the name “Jew” and rely upon the Law and boast in God,
Rom. 2:18 and know His will and approve the things that are essential, being instructed out of the Law,
Rom. 2:19 and are confident that you yourself are a guide to the blind, a light to those who are in darkness,
Rom. 2:20 a corrector of the foolish, a teacher of the immature, having in the Law the embodiment of knowledge and of the truth,
Rom. 2:21 you, therefore, who teach another, do you not teach yourself? You who preach that one shall not steal, do you steal?
Rom. 2:22 You who say that one should not commit adultery, do you commit adultery? You who abhor idols, do you rob temples?
Rom. 2:23 You who boast in the Law, through your breaking the Law, do you dishonor God?
Rom. 2:24 For “The name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you,” just as it is written.

- Notice first that Paul is talking to the one who is a Jew and relies on the law and boasts in God
    - That’s Paul’s description of Jewish nomianism
        - First, they call themselves “Jew” meaning they see themselves as part of the privileged group who have the right rules
        - They rely on those rules (i.e., the Law) as their means to righteousness or heaven
        - And they boast in God, meaning they believe God is pleased
    - Remember, Paul is focusing on Jewish nomianism as his example, but this description would apply equally to every law-keeping religion
        - Other systems of nomianism simply change the nouns in that sentence
        - For example, we could say, “You who bear the name ‘Catholic’ and rely upon the magisterium and boast in Mary, etc.”
        - Or we could say, “You who bear the name ‘Muslim' and rely upon the Qur’an and boast in Allah.”
        - Or “You call yourself ‘Mormon’ and rely on the Book of Mormon and boast in Moroni”
        - In all cases, it’s conceit and self-righteousness

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- Nevertheless, the Jewish people were privileged to have the right law
  - Paul says in v.18 that they knew the will of God as revealed in His word
  - And they approved the things that were essential
  - Paul means they accepted and practiced the rituals that the Lord used to make Israel distinct in the world
  - Things like the feasts and sacrificial system and dietary laws

- So Israel had the right law, but the question remains were they successful in keeping it as some claimed?
  - Paul answers that question by asking a series of rhetorical questions intended to expose their hypocrisy
    - He begins by drawing into question their success
    - He asks are you confident that you are guide to the blind and a light in the darkness?
    - A corrector of the foolish and a teacher of the immature?
  - Paul's sweeping descriptions alert us to his skepticism as to their claims
    - Notice how he ends v.20
    - Paul asks if they believe that merely possessing the Law has somehow produced these outcomes in them?
    - That the Law has become the embodiment of knowledge and truth for them?
  - The word embodiment means outward form
    - So Paul is asking has the presence of the Law among the Jewish people produced righteousness in their lives?
    - It's like asking if I gave your son a rulebook for the game of baseball, would that rulebook (by itself) cause your son to become a Hall of Fame pitcher?

- Knowing that someone in his audience might have been tempted to answer yes, Paul narrows his point through a series of examples
  - In v.21 Paul asks, you Jew who claims to teach the Law to others, are you sure you're keeping it yourself?
    - You who preach that the Law forbids stealing, have you stolen?
    - He asks the same for adultery and idolatry
  - Jewish people were renown for finding ways around their own laws when it suited their purposes
    - They would find creative ways to charge interest when the Law prohibited the practice, thus stealing from someone
    - They found creative ways to dissolve marriages and permit remarriage (which is adultery) even though the Law said no
    - They would rob pagan temples to obtain gold for themselves, thus revealing their true god, which was money

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- Paul's point is obvious…the Jewish people (and all people) fall short of the rules somewhere, as I discussed earlier
  - Though they claim perfection in keeping their law, they obey it selectively and inconsistently
  - So they are breaking the Law even as they claim to follow it, which is not righteousness at all
- In short, no one who pursues righteousness by keeping rules will be found innocent in the end
  - Even if we were to reduce our system of laws down to just one law, sooner or later we would break it
  - If you doubt me, remember that Adam had only one rule to keep in the Garden and we know how that turned out
- So the conclusion is inescapable
  - In v.23 Paul says those who "boast" in the Law are dishonoring the Lord as they break that law
  - Notice he changed their boast from boasting in God to boasting in the Law
  - Because that's what nomianism does: it makes rules into a god
  - Nomianism doesn't seek to serve God
  - It seeks to serve the rules we set for ourselves
- Remember what the Pharisees said to the blind man Jesus healed:

John 9:28 **They reviled him and said, "You are His disciple, but we are disciples of Moses.**
John 9:29 **"We know that God has spoken to Moses, but as for this man, we do not know where He is from."**

- They admit to being disciples of Moses (not of God)
  - They say they follow Moses because they know God spoke to Moses
  - What they're truly saying is they are disciples of the Law because they know those rules came from God
- To prove his assessment is accurate, Paul quotes scripture where God foretold Israel's hypocrisy
  - Paul quotes in v.24 from Isaiah 52:5 where the prophet described this very behavior in his day
    - Israel was blaspheming God before the Gentile nations (who lacked the Law) by their failure to keep the Law
    - So if God declares that those who fail to keep His law are blasphemers, then what prospect did those Jews have of reaching Heaven?
    - Wasn't their eternal future in jeopardy though they attempted to keep the Law?

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        - What does that say about our prospects for the same?

Rom. 2:25 For indeed circumcision is of value if you practice the Law; but if you are a transgressor of the Law, your circumcision has become uncircumcision.
Rom. 2:26 So if the uncircumcised man keeps the requirements of the Law, will not his uncircumcision be regarded as circumcision?
Rom. 2:27 And he who is physically uncircumcised, if he keeps the Law, will he not judge you who though having the letter of the Law and circumcision are a transgressor of the Law?
Rom. 2:28 For he is not a Jew who is one outwardly, nor is circumcision that which is outward in the flesh.
Rom. 2:29 But he is a Jew who is one inwardly; and circumcision is that which is of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter; and his praise is not from men, but from God.

- Simply put, having the Law won't be an advantage to the one who can't keep it
    - Paul says their circumcision is only of value if they are living according to the Law they uphold
    - Circumcision is a euphemistic way of describing those who are part of the family of Israel by birth
    - If a circumcised Jew is a transgressor of the Law, then he might as well be uncircumcised like a Gentile
    - Paul's saying that being a Jew is no better than being Catholic or Muslim if you don't live up to the standards revealed in God's law
- So our identity offers no advantage unless it's an accurate description of our heart
    - It all comes down to performance
    - A Gentile will get credit for keeping the Law though he never became part of Israel
    - And such a one will stand as a witness against those Jews who ignored the Law despite having the privilege to be among God's people
- Paul's conclusion is that our outward condition is not the measure of our righteousness
    - We cannot be judged by how we perform, or even which system we join
        - Who we are before God is not what we show to others
        - Or even what we tell ourselves
        - It's what's true about us on the inside
    - Paul says a Jew is not determined outwardly
        - The mark of a true follower of God is not something made in the flesh
        - It's a mark on the heart made by God by His spirit
    - Imagine a bottle with a label on the outside

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        - The label's description doesn't determine the contents of the bottle
        - If we scratch out the description and write a different description, the contents of the bottle don't change to match our new description
        - Instead, the contents of the bottle will determine the description on the label
- That's Paul's point to the Jew seeking to follow the Law
    - His or her approval won't be determined by the "letter" Paul says in v.29
        - Notice earlier in v.27 Paul referred to the letter of the Law
        - So Paul's referring to law in general
    - Our approval before God will not be determined by our accomplishments under a law, not even the Mosaic Law
        - And it certainly won't depend on the praise of men
        - Only God sets the standards for Heaven, and only He can approve our entrance into His eternal kingdom
- So to summarize the lie of nomianism, it is a religious lie that claims we obtain righteousness by observing laws and rules and rituals
    - It's the philosophy of major religions including many Jews
        - It's chief mistake is in overlooking the impact of breaking the rules
        - Everyone breaks the rules in these systems, but they assume God doesn't mind
        - Even within Judaism, which does have the right set of rules, they still ignore the consequences of breaking the Law
        - But the word of God says that those who break God's law will be judged for it
    - So how do we reach out to those trapped in these systems of religious rule-keeping?
        - Frankly, it can be very difficult to pull people out of these systems
        - Jews, Catholics, Mormons and Muslims are some of the hardest people to evangelize – for at least two reasons
    - First, nomianism systems tend to be rooted deeply in culture
        - Generation after generation of families participate in these systems
        - So a person's very identity is connected to these systems
        - Furthermore, if you indict their system, you're implying that their deceased family and friends are not in heaven
        - Often these implications are so threatening that the person shuts down the conversation
    - There's no easy way to address these concerns except to redirect their attention back to themselves and the question of their future
        - If they find the truth of the Gospel compelling, there will be time to reconcile with the implication for others
        - No one has a perfect family history, so everyone has relatives who have gone to

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the grave without knowing the truth
    - So perhaps reassure the person they are not alone
- But secondly, people who are caught in nomianistic systems have difficulty accepting that entry into Heaven won't be based on personal performance
    - When you tell them that God is even prepared to grant a murderer entry into heaven, they reject that idea as illogical and unfair
        - They see that all achievements in life are based on performance, reward and punishment
        - So how can they believe the Creator does not work in the same way?
    - Jesus addressed this objection specifically when talking to committed law-keepers, the Pharisees

Matt. 5:17 "Do not think that I came to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I did not come to abolish but to fulfill.
Matt. 5:18 "For truly I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not the smallest letter or stroke shall pass from the Law until all is accomplished.
Matt. 5:19 "Whoever then annuls one of the least of these commandments, and teaches others to do the same, shall be called least in the kingdom of heaven; but whoever keeps and teaches them, he shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 5:20 "For I say to you that unless your righteousness surpasses that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.
Matt. 5:21 "You have heard that the ancients were told, 'You shall not commit murder' and 'Whoever commits murder shall be liable to the court.'
Matt. 5:22 "But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother shall be guilty before the court; and whoever says to his brother, 'You good-for-nothing,' shall be guilty before the supreme court; and whoever says, 'You fool,' shall be guilty enough to go into the fiery hell.

- Jesus' strategy begins by acknowledging that performance is required to enter Heaven
    - In fact, those who suggested that Jesus was attempting to abolish the Law got it wrong
        - That's the essential objection of those coming out of a rules-based religion
        - They reject the notion that God doesn't care about rule keeping
    - And Jesus agrees with them!
        - He says that setting aside even the least Law will have negative consequences
        - While those who keep and teach them will be honored
    - In fact, Jesus says He came into the world to fulfill the Law
        - To fulfill is a Greek word that means to accomplish in full, to fully carry out

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        - So Jesus is saying He came to keep the rules of the Law *for us* so we wouldn't be judged by them when we fail
    - That's your first answer to someone caught in these systems
        - Our Gospel message doesn't claim that God doesn't care about keeping rules or Law
        - On the contrary, the Gospel tells us how we can keep the rules
        - All God's rules have already been kept for us by Jesus
        - He lived a sinless life, without breaking any rule, so He has already done all that's required to satisfy entry into Heaven
- On the other hand, should a person remain determined to keep those rules themselves, they had better be prepared to meet the standard God will use at the judgment
    - Remember, nomianism underestimates the consequences of breaking the rules
        - People caught in these systems are taught that breaking the rules is no big deal
        - They need only say a few words, perform a certain ritual, and God forgives and forgets
    - But Jesus says that our righteousness must surpass that of the Pharisees, which is an unimaginable standard
        - Pharisees lived a lifestyle we can hardly imagine, and few of us would tolerate very long
        - Their every minute was directed by scrupulous rule keeping
        - They fasted several times weekly, said prayers at all hours, and tithed on even the herbs that grew in their garden
        - Rule keeping drove their every thought and action
        - You can see examples of this type of extreme nomianism still alive in Israel among the ultra-orthodox Jews
    - Even these scrupulous law keepers are falling short of God's standard, Jesus declares
        - And if you want to know exactly what God's standard is for entry into Heaven, consider Jesus' example
        - He says you've no doubt heard of the rule that murder is sin and if you murder you will be judged by God
        - Certainly, any one caught up in nomianism would agree that murderers shouldn't be in Heaven
    - But then Jesus says God's standard is much stricter than that
        - Have you ever been angry with a brother?
        - Have you ever said an unkind word against someone?
        - Have you ever judged someone to be a fool?
        - Each of these offenses is sufficient to place you in Hell

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- So if you have taken comfort in the fact that you haven't committed murder, you should take a second look at your life
  - Are you sure you have the right rules?
    - Are you sure you're even keeping the ones you do have?
    - Are you sure God overlooks your mistakes?
    - If God is willing to overlook your failures at the rules, why is keeping the rules even necessary?
    - How does anyone know when they've done enough to satisfy God?
  - Or maybe you're the person who has committed murder? Or you've done something you feel is equally disqualifying?
    - And so you struggle to find hope in any system that teaches heaven is reserved for good people
    - Jesus says everyone is in the same boat with you
  - So on Hell's death row we find murderers seated next to those who hate and those who use profanity and those who call another a fool
    - If calling someone a fool is a disqualifying offense for heaven, then who can qualify?
    - Clearly, systems based on personal performance aren't going to make us righteous enough
    - If anything, they simply expose our sin and leave us more vulnerable to judgment
    - And so we must look for another solution
- Now as we end Chapter 2 and prepare to move into Chapter 3 next time, notice Paul's transition
  - He was discussing the nature of a true Jew verses that of one who misuses Jewish Law
    - That is but one major way Judaism is distorted
    - There is another way, which then forms the fourth major religious life
  - I'll call it Judaism, but here again I'm not talking about authentic Judaism
    - It's a system of assuming righteousness by identity
    - It's unique to Judaism
    - And it was a major force in the church in Paul's day

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- At the end of Chapter 2 Paul began to shift away from his argument against nomianism, or righteousness by keeping law, to his fourth and final argument
  - That final argument is against the inherent righteousness of Judaism
    - The Jewish people hold a unique place in the world
    - They are the only nation of humanity to have a covenant relationship with the Living God
  - No other people group can make such a claim
    - Other religions may claim to have a special relationship with God
    - But only Judaism *actually* possesses such a relationship…and they know it
  - Therefore, it's easy for the Jewish people to overplay their hand
    - They might assume their unique position in the world assures them a good judgment
    - That their Jewish identity by itself was enough
    - And so we saw Paul moving into a discussion of Jewish identity at the end of Chapter 2 when he raised the topic of circumcision
  - Jewish identity is typified by the act of male circumcision
    - Jewish men became a party to the covenant God gave Abraham by physical circumcision
    - And women in Israel shared in that identity through the headship of their circumcised Jewish fathers or husbands
    - The Bible says circumcision is a sign of the covenant God made with Abraham
    - But over the centuries Jews came to confuse the sign with the substance
- This overemphasis of Jewish identity led to a fourth false view of righteousness, which I'm calling Judaism
  - I'm referring to the view among the Jewish people that Jewish identity alone is a means to righteousness
    - Though Jews are sinful like all humanity, nevertheless they believe that the Lord overlooks their sin based on their relationship with Him
    - That God's favor for His people made accommodation for their sin
    - Those Jews holding this view called Gentiles dogs, and claimed that God created Gentiles merely to fuel the fires of Hell
    - They taught that Abraham guarded the gates to Hades, and that should a Jew find his way to the entrance, Father Abraham would turn him around and send him to Heaven
  - This is the lie that Jews tell themselves, so it's unique to Judaism
    - Therefore, it's not an issue outside of the Jewish people
    - But given the importance of the Jewish people to God, it's still an issue that requires discussion

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        - Furthermore, in the early church this was of special concern, since Judaizers were at work to convince Gentiles they must be Jewish to be saved
- So even as Paul was wrapping up his argument against nomianism in Chapter 2, he's already lining up his arguments against the fourth and final religious lie: Judaism
    - His first argument appears at the end of Chapter 2 and deals with the fallacy of trusting in circumcision (i.e., Jewish identity)
        - As we studied last week, Paul connected circumcision with law
        - He said that Jews couldn't rely on the Law for righteousness unless they do the law
        - Merely having the right law isn't enough
    - In fact, doing the law was so important that if someone who wasn't circumcised did the law, they would be righteous
        - Meanwhile, a circumcised Jew who failed to do the Law wouldn't gain the benefits of their identity
        - Or as Paul put it…

Rom. 2:28 **For he is not a Jew who is one outwardly, nor is circumcision that which is outward in the flesh.**

- Circumcision was a sign of a covenant, but possessing a sign doesn't automatically convey the substance of that covenant
- For example, water baptism is the sign of the New Covenant in Christ
    - But going into the water doesn't automatically confer salvation to a person
    - If their heart isn't in agreement with the covenant, then the sign is meaningless
- Likewise, a Jew who trusts in the Law and in their identity as a Jew, is missing the big picture
    - The identity God cares about is our spiritual identity, not our physical identity
    - What matters is our spiritual state before God
    - It's keeping the Law that matters, not possessing it
    - It's having a heart that belongs to the family of God, not a body that belongs to the nation of Israel
- And with that, we now move into Paul's treatment of the fourth spiritual lie: Judaism

Rom. 3:1 **Then what advantage has the Jew? Or what is the benefit of circumcision?**
Rom. 3:2 **Great in every respect. First of all, that they were entrusted with the oracles of God.**

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- Paul addresses the lie of trusting in Jewish identity by asking and answering five questions
  - This is a typical Pauline technique
    - He asks questions he believes his audience will be asking
    - And then he answers them one at a time
    - In the process, he refutes the lie
  - He begins with the question most Jews (and many Christians) ask when they learn that all men are treated the same by God at the judgment
    - What advantage was there to being Jew, then?
    - What was the benefit of being party to the covenant God gave Abraham?
  - The answer Paul gives is "great in every respect"
    - There were significant advantages to being Jewish
    - Their first and greatest advantage was to receive the oracles of God
  - Israel was the nation of people entrusted to receive the word of God on behalf of all humanity
    - No other people on earth received this blessing
    - Gentiles didn't have the word
    - Most Gentiles lived and died having never heard it
  - The Greek word translated "first of all" means of first importance
    - Having the word of God was Israel's chief advantage in the pursuit of righteousness
    - Of course, simply possessing the word of God wasn't a means to righteousness any more than possessing the Law
    - Nevertheless, having the word of God gave them a distinct advantage in that pursuit
    - Because in the word of God, the people of Israel had all they required to find, know and follow God
- This leads to the second question

Rom. 3:3 What then? If some did not believe, their unbelief will not nullify the faithfulness of God, will it?
Rom. 3:4 May it never be! Rather, let God be found true, though every man be found a liar, as it is written,
"That You may be justified in Your words,
And prevail when You are judged."

- So if God singled out Israel for special revelation yet not all of them demonstrated faith in God's word, what do we conclude about God?

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- Does the fact that some within Israel didn't follow the Lord faithfully suggest God was not faithful to His covenant people?
  - This is the chief flaw in the lie of Jewish identity
  - Jews assume that God deals with all Jews in a similar way
  - And that if God were to turn His back on one Jew, He has been unfaithful to Israel overall
- So Paul asks that question…would an unfaithful member of Israel be proof that the Lord has not been faithful to His covenants with His people?
  - To prove the error in this logic, Paul quotes from a case study of one of the most famous Jews in history
  - This man received great promises from God
  - And yet this man was unfaithful to God at times
  - Here's what that man, King David, wrote about his situation:

Psa. 51:2 **Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity**
And cleanse me from my sin.
Psa. 51:3 **For I know my transgressions,**
And my sin is ever before me.
Psa. 51:4 **Against You, You only, I have sinned**
And done what is evil in Your sight,
So that You are justified when You speak
And blameless when You judge.

- Paul quotes David's confession of sin
  - And he declares that when the Lord judged David's sin, the Lord was blameless
    - The Lord judged David by taking the life of his young child by Bathsheba
    - David mourned his child's death but he acknowledged the Lord's judgment was righteous
  - So here we have an answer to the very question Paul raises
    - Is the Lord unfair when He holds an unfaithful Jew accountable? Should God overlook the sin of a Jew simply because they are a Jew?
    - If that's how it worked, then David (of all people) would have been excused for his sin
    - But David himself declares that the Lord was blameless when He judged David for his sin
- That leads to the third question

Rom. 3:5 **But if our unrighteousness demonstrates the righteousness of God, what shall we say? The God who inflicts wrath is not unrighteous, is He? (I am**

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speaking in human terms.)
Rom. 3:6 **May it never be! For otherwise, how will God judge the world?**

- The argument suggests that when God's people are unrighteous and God judges them, their sin highlights God's righteousness
  - We can understand this argument with a simple comparison
  - When you speed on the highway you are breaking the law
  - Because you were speeding, you gave opportunity for a policeman to chase you down and give you a ticket
  - In a sense, your sin gave the policeman opportunity to show his righteous judgment
  - Therefore, when you go to court, you tell the judge he should dismiss your ticket because you were doing your civic duty
  - You merely highlighted your city's excellent justice system
- So this argument suggests that the God who inflicts his wrath against those in Israel who sin, would be unrighteous
  - As crazy as it may seem to us, this is the argument coming from Jewish identity proponents
  - God can't put Jews in Hell to suffer His wrath because it would make God appear unrighteous
  - Paul distances himself from this claim at the end of v.5
  - This is an ungodly "human" perspective, but it's not the truth
- Paul answers if God could overlook the sin of Jews merely because they were Jewish, then how could God justly judge the rest of the world?
  - God would be a hypocrite to hold a sinning Gentile accountable while ignoring the sin of a Jew
  - He would no longer be qualified to serve as humanity's fair and impartial judge
  - Double standards are not just
- This leads to the fourth question

Rom. 3:7 **But if through my lie the truth of God abounded to His glory, why am I also still being judged as a sinner?**
Rom. 3:8 **And why not say (as we are slanderously reported and as some claim that we say), "Let us do evil that good may come"? Their condemnation is just.**

- The fourth question is a corollary to the third question
  - Speaking on a personal level, the question asks isn't the unrighteousness of a Jew actually helping God?
    - When we sin don't we give God more opportunity to show grace?

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        - Shouldn't He congratulate the sinning Jew rather than condemn him?
    - Paul answers their question with a sarcastic question of his own
        - If someone was going to suggest this, then shouldn't they live according to this motto at all times?
        - Paul sums up this perspective simply as "Let us do evil that good may come."
    - In other words, if you really believe this kind of absurd logic, then why are you endeavoring to do anything good at all?
        - Shouldn't you do all evil all the time?
        - Paul says some have slanderously accused him of making this very claim elsewhere
    - But self-evidently, no godly person sincerely believed that this was true, as evidenced by the fact that no one was living that way
        - If they did, they would soon be in prison or dead!
        - And with that Paul leaves the argument unaddressed so as not to dignify it
        - He simply says those who hold to such a view are justly condemned
- The fifth and final question returns to where Paul began…

Rom. 3:9 What then? Are we better than they? Not at all; for we have already charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin;
Rom. 3:10 as it is written,
"There is none righteous, not even one;
Rom. 3:11 There is none who understands,
There is none who seeks for God;
Rom. 3:12 All have turned aside, together they have become useless;
There is none who does good,
There is not even one."
Rom. 3:13 "Their throat is an open grave,
With their tongues they keep deceiving,"
"The poison of asps is under their lips";
Rom. 3:14 "Whose mouth is full of cursing and bitterness";
Rom. 3:15 "Their feet are swift to shed blood,
Rom. 3:16 Destruction and misery are in their paths,
Rom. 3:17 And the path of peace they have not known."
Rom. 3:18 "There is no fear of God before their eyes."

- So what do we conclude then concerning Jews vs. Gentiles? Are we better than they?
    - Paul uses the pronoun "we" to refer to Jews, because he was a Jew and so were the leaders in the Roman church
        - So he asks are we the Jews better than Gentiles when it comes to judgment and

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righteousness and heaven?

- When all is said and done and we are facing our eternal judgment, will we be able to rest upon our Jewish heritage to save us?
- Will that get us into Heaven, which is the essence of the lie of Jewish heritage?

- To that Paul answers plainly, not at all. Jews are not better than Gentiles on the question of righteousness
  - Jews may have had advantages and received certain promises as a people
  - But individually no Jew stands in a better place than any Gentile
- And to prove this point from scripture, Paul quotes from two Psalms (14 & 53) to close the door on any thought that we are righteous
  - This passage is one of the key passages of the New Testament
  - It addresses a number of theological issues, including original sin, total depravity, & mankind's universality of guilt before God

- First, notice in v.10 Paul quotes the word of God testifying that there is none among humanity who are righteous, not even one
  - This is a sweeping statement
    - The Bible says there is not a single human being descended from Adam who may stand before God without condemnation
    - None are righteous, that is without sin
    - And to be sure we understand, the Lord repeats "not one"
  - It matters not who we are, where we were born, who our parents were, how many sins we've committed, how much sorrow we've expressed
    - It matters not our age, whether an infant or an old man
    - It doesn't matter if we are a genius or mentally incapacitated
    - It certainly doesn't matter if we are a Jew or Gentile
    - Not a single person is righteous before God
- And the reason for this universality of guilt is that our unrighteousness was present in us at birth
  - Adam's fall in the Garden changed his spiritual nature irreparably
    - And when he reproduced, he created new life that shared in his spiritual nature
    - So because Adam's spirit was fallen, he produced children with a fallen nature
    - So in turn do we, as David acknowledged about himself

Psa. 51:4 **Against You, You only, I have sinned**
And done what is evil in Your sight,
So that You are justified when You speak
And blameless when You judge.
Psa. 51:5 **Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity,**

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And in sin my mother conceived me.

- Therefore, by nature the children of Adam are unrighteous
  - As some have observed, we aren't called sinners because we sinned
  - Rather, we engage in sin because we were born sinners by nature
- This is the doctrine of Original Sin, the concept that all humanity is born with a spiritual defect
  - Paul describes it this way in Ephesians

Eph. 2:1 **And you were dead in your trespasses and sins,**
Eph. 2:2 **in which you formerly walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.**
Eph. 2:3 **Among them we too all formerly lived in the lusts of our flesh, indulging the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, even as the rest.**

- We come into the world with a spiritual deadness to God
- We are pledged to Satan and we live in our flesh
- As a result we are not children of God but children of His wrath, just as the rest of humanity, Paul says in v.3
- There are important spiritual consequences of this spiritual deadness
  - The first of these consequences is given in the first half of Romans 3:11
    - Paul says there is no human being who understands [God]
    - As a result of our spiritual deadness from birth, mankind is incapable of understanding the truth about God, to know Him truly
    - Spiritual truth lies outside our grasp
  - Paul says it this way in 1 Corinthians:

1Cor. 2:12 **Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit who is from God, so that we may know the things freely given to us by God,**
1Cor. 2:13 **which things we also speak, not in words taught by human wisdom, but in those taught by the Spirit, combining spiritual thoughts with spiritual words.**
1Cor. 2:14 **But a natural man does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; and he cannot understand them, because they are spiritually appraised.**

- The believer receives the Spirit of God so that the person may gain the ability to know the truth about God

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    - To know the things we were given freely by God, by His grace
    - In turn, we speak spiritual truth not because we've been taught these things by other people but because we were taught by the Spirit
    - Because a natural man, an unbeliever, cannot accept the truth of God
    - They are foolishness to him
- That's what Paul means when he quotes the psalmist to say no one understands
    - No one reasons themselves into believing in the Gospel
    - By human reason, the Gospel is nonsense
    - The ability to understand God lies outside our grasp, and that spiritual blindness is a consequence of our spiritual birth defect
    - It takes a living spirit to understand spiritual truth from God, but we're born with a dead spirit
- Which leads to the third implication in the second half of v.11
    - There is no one in the human race who seeks for God
        - Paul isn't saying no one seeks for religious experiences
        - Or that no one seeks for a god
    - The Bible's saying no one seeks for the true living God
        - No one finds the path to God on their own
        - And of course, this makes sense when we remember that all have been born with a dead spirit
        - Spiritually dead things don't seek for anything
        - As Paul said in Ephesians, we were dead in our sins, seeking only to serve our flesh
        - Even those who pursue religion in some form do so for fleshly reasons, ironically
    - Theologians call this principle total depravity, which means the deadness of man's heart precludes him from ever rising above his nature
        - He does not know God
        - Nor will he ever seek to find him
        - And even if someone should share spiritual truth with this person, he couldn't understand it
    - It's the definition of being lost
        - Our sin nature is so corrosive that it only serves to drive us further and further away from God
        - Like a rock dropped in the sea
        - It moves only downward, away from the light of the surface
        - And unless someone reaches down into the dark, the rock will continue to fall and can never rescue itself

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- Because we are blind and deaf to God and spiritually unable to find Him, we are useless to Him
  - Together, Paul says in v.12 that all humanity has become useless (or could be translated corrupt) to God
    - He gains nothing from unsaved humanity
    - We do not thank Him
    - We do not honor Him
    - We do not praise Him nor serve Him
  - And notice again, the psalmist clarifies that not even one exception exists
    - The name of a good person might come to our mind about now
    - Some civic or social leader, some heroic figure from history or a dear family member
    - Someone we supposed has done much good in life, even if they are a sinner
  - But the Bible testifies against such thinking, at least in a spiritual sense
    - War heroes may do good acts, but they don't do "good"
    - Social leaders may accomplish good works for the poor, but they don't do good
    - Your grandmother may have loved you dearly, but she didn't do good
  - Because the Bible says that even our so-called good works amount to nothing to God

Is. 64:6 **For all of us have become like one who is unclean,**
And all our righteous deeds are like a filthy garment;
And all of us wither like a leaf,
And our iniquities, like the wind, take us away.

- How can this be true? Because we measure good in ways different to God
- We see good from a selfish perspective
- If something pleases us, helps us, let's us feel better about ourselves or others, if it seems good to us, then it's "good"
- But the true and only measure of good belongs to God, Who we already learned is alone good
  - And God's definition of good is one of perfection
  - And a person who is operating in a dead and sinful spirit is incapable of doing good
  - And even if we should accomplish a good deed, it's spoiled coming from a selfish sinful heart
- Finally, Paul finishes in vs.13-18 with a summary of the sinful behaviors that exemplify fallen humanity
  - Our mouths are like open graves, in that the things that come out are like death

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itself

- We speak in deceiving ways, hurtful ways
- We use our tongues to further our selfish desires and to bring down those around us
- If we took a careful inventory of the sin committed by just our tongue, we would run out of paper to write it all down
- There is no better measure of the unrighteousness of humanity and the universal nature of our condition than the common sin of our tongues

- But of course, we have much more than that
  - Our feet are quick to shed blood
  - And these feet beat a path of destruction for ourselves and others
- This summary is an allusion to the fall itself
  - The sin that began all sin was the lie told by Satan in the Garden
  - It led to the feet of Adam and Woman leaving the garden
  - Which quickly led to Cain shedding Abel's blood
  - And Cain walked a path of destruction away from his family
- Eventually, we have a world filled with misery where no one has ever known true peace
  - So when you hear people asking why do bad things happen and why does suffering exist, the answer is v.18
  - No one born of Adam and living in the deadness of their spirit fears God or even knows Him
  - And without a fear of God, we have no reason to restrain our sin nature

- Before moving ahead in Paul's analysis, we need to ask how do we reach the Jew who relies on their family heritage to save them?
  - Perhaps take them to this account in the Gospels

Luke 19:1 **He entered Jericho and was passing through.**
Luke 19:2 **And there was a man called by the name of Zaccheus; he was a chief tax collector and he was rich.**
Luke 19:3 **Zaccheus was trying to see who Jesus was, and was unable because of the crowd, for he was small in stature.**
Luke 19:4 **So he ran on ahead and climbed up into a sycamore tree in order to see Him, for He was about to pass through that way.**
Luke 19:5 **When Jesus came to the place, He looked up and said to him, "Zaccheus, hurry and come down, for today I must stay at your house."**
Luke 19:6 **And he hurried and came down and received Him gladly.**
Luke 19:7 **When they saw it, they all began to grumble, saying, "He has gone to be**

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the guest of a man who is a sinner."
Luke 19:8 **Zaccheus stopped and said to the Lord, "Behold, Lord, half of my possessions I will give to the poor, and if I have defrauded anyone of anything, I will give back four times as much."**
Luke 19:9 **And Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house, because he, too, is a son of Abraham.**
Luke 19:10 **"For the Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost."**

- The point in this passage is that Zaccheus is a Jewish man, albeit a man with significant sin
  - And for that reason, Jesus declared that his response to Jesus dictated His salvation
    - Notice the Lord declared that "today" this man became a son of Abraham
    - Sonship isn't by physical birth but by spiritual birth
    - And if this Jew could be the "lost" then clearly Jews don't have an inside track to heaven
  - Still, making this claim depends on their willingness to submit to the authority of scripture
    - Which reminds us that coming to faith is ultimately a matter for the Lord to decide
    - We may use His word and hope for His grace, but we cannot work without it
- So Paul quotes these two Psalms as a capstone argument against all four religious lies: paganism, moralism, nomianism and Judaism
  - Every possible way men have imagined for how to get to Heaven has been shown to be corrupt
    - They don't work, they can't work and in the day of judgment all who follow them will be sorely disappointed
    - Moreover, if no one is righteous, than it raises the more fundamental and frightening question:
    - How can anyone get into Heaven?
  - Does anyone survive the judgment moment with God?

Rom. 3:19 **Now we know that whatever the Law says, it speaks to those who are under the Law, so that every mouth may be closed and all the world may become accountable to God;**
Rom. 3:20 **because by the works of the Law no flesh will be justified in His sight; for through the Law comes the knowledge of sin.**

- God sent His Law into the world principally for the purpose of educating mankind on the standard for heaven

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- It was not intended to be a recipe for meriting heaven
- In fact, Paul says that whatever the Law may say about one thing or another, it's saying it to those who are to be judged by it, so that we may be accountable to God
    - A more literal translation of v.19-20 reads this way

Rom. 3:19 And we have known that as many things as the law saith, to those in the law it doth speak, that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may come under judgment to God;
Rom. 3:20 wherefore by works of law shall no flesh be declared righteous before Him, for through law is a knowledge of sin.

- The ultimate effect of God revealing His Law to mankind was not redemption but condemnation
- This is an inevitable conclusion, logically speaking
- If every human being is born with sin…
    - This means we have already lost our race to heaven before we even start to run
    - Since this is true, what can be the purpose of God giving us the rules to the race, the Law?
    - The only thing those rules do now is remind us that we couldn't have won the race even if we had tried
    - And so it shuts up any disagreement or debate
- How ironic that someone would then try to follow those rules having already been disqualified?
    - Paul says in v.20 that because of mankind's dilemma, no one will be successful in achieving a declaration of righteousness before God
        - You can't do it by trusting in created things
        - You can't do it by trusting in yourself
        - You can't do it by trusting in laws or rules
        - And you can't do it by trusting in your identity as a Jew
    - The Law of God reminds you that you were condemned long before you started to care about such things
        - So once again we have to ask, how does anyone get to heaven?
        - May I suggest that effective evangelism should include some aspect of this truth?
        - We must find the right way to inform a person that they are a sinner, that the standard for heaven is perfection, and they don't meet it
        - Otherwise, they have good reason to question why they need what you're "selling"

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- You're selling the answer to THE great spiritual dilemma of mankind
  - You're offering the way sinful people can meet the standard required for heaven
  - We all know we're sinful, because our sin is self-evident even if we are reluctant to acknowledge it
  - And since sin is an imperfection, we know it means we are not righteous, not right before God
  - So if we enter God's presence at our judgment in this condition, we have reason to expect to receive His judgment
- So how does someone become good enough to get to Heaven? How can we be declared righteous?
  - This leads us to the turning point in Paul's letter, the point where we return to the main thesis of the letter
    - Before we take this turn, go back briefly to Chapter 1
    - Remember how he set up his thesis to explore these four religious lies

Rom. 1:16 For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.
Rom. 1:17 For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith to faith; as it is written, "but the righteous man shall live by faith."

- The gospel message has the power of God to save everyone who believes, Jew and Gentile
  - And what is that power? How does it solve our dilemma?
    - It reveals how we may obtain the righteousness of God
    - It does not tell us how we may be righteous ourselves
    - It says how we may have the perfection we lack
  - And so now in Chapter 3, Paul is ready to summarize that message with the power to save

Rom. 3:21 But now apart from the Law the righteousness of God has been manifested, being witnessed by the Law and the Prophets,
Rom. 3:22 even the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ for all those who believe; for there is no distinction;

- We're beginning Paul's most thorough summary of the Gospel from all his letters (second choice is 1 Corinthians 15)
  - Paul begins saying "apart from the Law"
    - He means that what he's about to tell us has nothing to do with following law

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        - Following law or rules of any kind will not bring you to the righteousness you need to enter Heaven
    - Remember, we were sinking to the bottom of the ocean long before we even knew we should have been swimming
        - Our sin began at birth, so how can doing law now help us arrive at our righteousness?
        - We know our past is filled with sin, but we can't change our past
        - And the passing grade required for heaven is 100%, so why bother doing works of law now? What good will that do?
        - The solution MUST be found apart from law
- So then, Paul says the righteousness we need is the righteousness of God
    - This conclusion is absolutely unavoidable
        - The only person who has the required righteousness to enter Heaven is God Himself
        - Remember Jesus said no one is good but God alone
    - If no one is good but God alone, then we're stuck
        - We either need to become God
        - Or else I need to gain God's righteousness
        - Well, the Gospel is NOT a story of how you become God (that's the lie of Mormonism)
        - But the Gospel does tell you how you may obtain God's righteousness for yourself
- Paul says the righteousness of God has been manifested to us
    - The verb manifest means to be revealed, to be made known
        - God's righteousness has been made known to us
        - The message of the Gospel is an explanation for how we can obtain God's righteousness
    - The Greek verb tense is in the middle voice, so Paul is saying this revelation came to us by God, He revealed it to us
        - We didn't discover it on our own, of course, because we weren't seeking God in the first place
        - And even if we stumbled upon it, we couldn't understand it because we were spiritually dead
        - Jesus refers to this situation as pearls before swine (Matt 7:6)
    - Instead, God had to make this truth known to us
        - He had to seek us out
        - And He had to give us the means to understand His revelation, otherwise we would have automatically rejected spiritual truth

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- There is a very old joke I know you've heard that goes something like this:

A traveler on a country road comes to a creek where the bridge has been swept away by a recent flood. The traveler sees an old farmer standing next to where the bridge used to be and asks, "Is there a way to back track and find some where else to get across the creek?"

The farmer responds, "Yep. Just, go back two miles turn right and... No, go back one mile and turn left..." The farmer stops for a minute, shrugs his shoulders, scratches his head, and then says to the traveler, "Come to think of it, you can't get there from here."

- "You can't get there from here" is an appropriate way to summarize Romans 1-3
  - Men in their ignorance have imagined countless ways they might merit entrance into heaven when they die
  - All those inventions can be categorized into one of the four religious lies Paul has addressed in these chapters
  - Paganism, Moralism, Nomianism and patriarchal Judaism
- Each of these categories possess a critical flaw
  - Pagans worship creation yet overlook the question of Who created everything they worship
  - Moralists judged themselves worthy of heaven, while supposing their obvious sin won't disqualify them in the end
  - Nomianists define for themselves rules for entry into heaven making sure the standard is low enough they can reach it
  - And patriarchal Judaism ignores all questions of standards or personal goodness while trusting that God plays favorites
- Paul has shot down all four categories by exposing each system's flaw
  - None of these imagined ways to heaven are *actual* ways to heaven
    - Because none of them corrects for the reason why men were barred from the presence of God in the first place
    - None of them answers the fundamental question of how did mankind get into this situation in the first place?
  - Paul raised this fundamental question in Romans 3:10-18 during last week's study
    - The problem is our sin nature, which produces our sinful actions
    - We were born with a spiritual birth defect, and this defect must be corrected before we may enjoy fellowship with God
    - We inherit our sin nature from our parents, who inherited it from their parents, and so on

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    - We all descend from a common ancestor who passed along his sinful nature through reproduction
        - Placing all humanity in our common predicament of sin with all its horrible consequences
        - And unless, and until, we correct our sin nature, we cannot reach the standard of perfection required by God
    - So to summarize, we aren't sinners because we sin; we sin because we're sinners
        - So it's not enough to address our sinful behaviors
        - Even if we could erase our past track record of sin and avoid any future sinful acts, nevertheless we would *still* be sinners by nature
        - And it's our sinful nature that bars us from heaven
        - So if you're trying to get to Heaven without changing your spiritual nature…you can't get there from here
- So because we couldn't solve this problem in our own strength, God made a way available to us

Rom. 3:21 But now apart from the Law the righteousness of God has been manifested, being witnessed by the Law and the Prophets,
Rom. 3:22 even the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ for all those who believe; for there is no distinction;
Rom. 3:23 for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,
Rom. 3:24 being justified as a gift by His grace through the redemption which is in Christ Jesus;
Rom. 3:25 whom God displayed publicly as a propitiation in His blood through faith. This was to demonstrate His righteousness, because in the forbearance of God He passed over the sins previously committed;
Rom. 3:26 for the demonstration, I say, of His righteousness at the present time, so that He would be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.

- These verses begin Paul's summary of the solution to our sin
    - The summary runs from vs.21-26 and is one sentence in the Greek language
        - This is Paul's unfolding of the plan of God to bring men and women into heaven despite our sin nature
        - God's plan has seven parts, which we will examine one at a time
        - And Paul himself will examine each part in depth over the next two chapters
    - All together, God's plan addresses all the problems Paul has raised in his earlier chapters concerning the sin nature of mankind
        - God's solution does away with condemnation and in the process He overcomes the spiritual barrier created by our fallen nature

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        - Remember, Scripture declares that every human being is born spiritually blind
        - Our sinful spiritual nature blinds us to spiritual truth and prevents us from truly seeking for God
        - But God's solution solves all these problems
- It begins with Paul's opening statement which we read briefly last week: apart from law (no "the" in Greek)
    - I call this first part The Disclaimer because it sets aside any notion of performing works to obtain righteousness
        - And based on Paul's analysis of religious lies, this makes perfect sense
        - Obviously, our solution to entering heaven won't be found in following Law, not even God's own Law
        - Because a new course of actions can't address our sin nature
    - Simply put, our problem isn't *what* we do; our problem is *who* we are
        - Who we are spiritually drives what we do, and therefore we can't solve our problem merely by changing what we do
        - We need a new spiritual nature, not a new list of works
    - We need to find a way to change who we are, spiritually speaking
        - We need a nature that is as good as God's nature, for that's the standard for heaven
        - Once we obtain the spiritual nature of God, we can expect that our behaviors will change as well
- Which moves us to Part 2 of the solution: the Righteousness of God manifested
    - Since we cannot help ourselves, we have no choice but to look to the mercy of God
        - And God grants us mercy by assigning us His righteousness in place of our unrighteousness
        - We trade in our old nature for the perfect nature of God Himself
    - This solution makes perfect sense given what we've learned earlier about our sinful nature
        - It won't be enough for us to simply try harder to do better
        - We must discard the source of our bad behaviors
        - We must become perfect by nature, which then will lead to better behaviors
        - And the only nature that is perfect belongs to God Himself
    - Furthermore, Paul says the righteousness of God is manifested to us
        - The Greek word for manifested could be translated "is now forevermore revealed"
        - Paul is clarifying that God's solution is something brought to us; it's not something we discover on our own
    - Here again, this makes perfect sense, since we know our sinful spiritual nature is a

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barrier

- It blinds us to spiritual truth and leads us away from seeking God
- So how else could we ever hope to find a solution to our problem unless God Himself should reveal it to us

- And Paul adds that the revelation of God's righteousness began long ago in the word of God
  - The Law and the Prophets foretold of God's plan to give sinful mankind His righteousness
    - The Law refers to all that Moses wrote
    - And the Prophets refer to the prophetic works of scripture
    - Collectively, Paul's referring to the entire Hebrew Bible
  - The Old Testament bears witness to God's plan to bring us His righteousness through a great Good Cop, Bad Cop routine
    - Both show us the impossibility of reaching the standard of heaven on our own
    - The law shows the impossibility of God's standard
    - While the prophets reminded God's people how far away they were from that standard
  - Secondly, the Law and the prophets taught that the Lord would make a way for His people to receive His righteousness
    - For example, in the Law we read the story of Abraham being declared righteous because of his faith
    - Or of Abraham taking Isaac to the mountain where he tells his son this:

Gen. 22:8 **Abraham said, "God will provide for Himself the lamb for the burnt offering, my son." So the two of them walked on together.**

- These moments suggest God's plan to bring us His righteousness by His own means
- Later in the prophets, God says He will bring us a new righteous spiritJer. 31:31 "Behold, days are coming," declares the Lord, "when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah,

Jer. 31:32 **not like the covenant which I made with their fathers in the day I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, My covenant which they broke, although I was a husband to them," declares the Lord.**
Jer. 31:33 **"But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares the Lord, "I will put My law within them and on their heart I will write it; and I will be their God, and they shall be My people.**
Jer. 31:34 **"They will not teach again, each man his neighbor and each man his brother, saying, 'Know the Lord,' for they will all know Me, from the least of**

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them to the greatest of them," declares the Lord, "for I will forgive their iniquity, and their sin I will remember no more."

- So Paul's explanation for how we find heaven isn't new or surprising, at least not to anyone who has read their Bible
  - Some Christians mistakenly assume that God offered men and women of times past one solution for heaven in the Old Covenant
    - But now He offers us a different solution in the New Covenant in Jesus
    - But Paul says the solution has always been the same
    - We need the righteousness of God, and this is what the Old Testament taught too
    - Paul explores the significance of this fact in the next chapter, so we'll wait until then to deal with it
- So Paul is teaching that our solution to reaching heaven is by obtaining the righteousness of God
  - But naturally, the next question we should ask is *how* does one obtain God's perfection, especially after we've already lived a life of sin?
    - How is this even possible?
    - That's what Chapters 4 and 5 explain, but for now Paul summarizes the answer in Part 3
  - In v.22 Paul says God's righteousness is revealed to us through faith in Jesus Christ
    - Pay particular note of Paul's choice of preposition: through
    - The preposition "through" emphasizes the word "manifested"
    - It explains how we came to know we obtained God's righteousness
  - In Heaven, God grants a person His righteousness as an act of His grace and mercy
    - Then His heavenly decision was manifested (i.e., made known, revealed) THROUGH a person's faith in Christ
    - So then faith becomes the instrument through which we come to know God's righteousness
- Theologians refer to this process as imputed righteousness
  - The word imputed means to attribute to an individual the actions or qualities of another individual as a result of the other's actions
    - For example, when a child is adopted, that child is imputed with a new family name
    - The child received the quality of the parents because of an action taken by the parents
    - The child did nothing to acquire the parents' family name
    - But by the actions of the parents, the child was imputed a new name

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- And so it is for those who receive God's mercy
  - God imputes His righteousness to us
  - God assigns us His spiritual nature (i.e., His righteousness) because of an act of another
  - We didn't obtain that righteousness for ourselves; it was given to us
  - And the act that made it possible wasn't our own either; God acted to bring it about

- So once God imputes His righteousness to us, how do we become aware of it?
  - Paul says the righteous of God has been manifested to us *through* faith in Jesus Christ
    - Paul never teaches that we obtain righteousness *because* of our faith in Jesus Christ
    - Saying that would imply that our action of believing is a "switch" that lead God to impute His righteousness to us
    - If we say we are saved *because* of our faith, it puts our faith in the driver's seat of a process which God then responds to
    - And that flip of the narrative of scripture suggests we initiate the process of our own salvation
    - It would be like saying that an adopted child first took for himself a certain family name, which then lead that family to adopt the child
  - Remember, Paul has already established from scripture that we are all lost, without an understanding of spiritual truth and do not seek God
    - So if the process of our salvation did depend on us taking the first step, no one would ever be saved
    - Because by our fallen nature, we have no inclination to take that step
    - It would like offering a comatose patient the cure to his condition…he can't respond to the invitation
  - So Paul says righteousness comes through (or sometimes Paul says "by") faith to indicate that faith is the means God uses to deliver us His mercy
    - Like a man who receives a telegram announcing he has received a large inheritance on the occasion of his uncle's death
    - The man became an heir the moment his uncle died
    - But it waited for the arrival of the telegram before the man became aware of that grant
    - So we could say that the uncle's grant of inheritance was manifested or revealed through a telegram message
- Now Paul moves to Part 4: This grant of salvation is for all who believe, there is no distinction
  - Paul's emphasis in Part 4 is on the word "all", meaning both Jew and Gentile

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        - God's plan of salvation will be manifested in everyone by the same means: belief, that is faith in the Gospel of Jesus Christ
        - The Jews didn't receive one way to heaven while Gentiles received another
        - All saints, whether Old Testament or New Testament, have always been granted God's righteousness through the same means
    - And this makes sense, Paul says in v.23, because all (both Jew and Gentile) have the same problem
        - All people have sinned and therefore all have fallen short of the mark required to enter Heaven
        - Once again, Paul says that the standard for entry into Heaven is to share in the nature of God
        - It's not enough to say we have no sin; we cannot even have a nature to sin
        - We must be as perfect as God is perfect, and anything less is to fall short of the glory of God
    - If all men are in the same predicament, then all men need the same solution
        - So God's manner of saving men from their sin has never varied over time
        - What has varied is the degree of that plan that God has explained in His word
        - In early times, the need for God's mercy and a provision of His righteousness was evident
        - But what was unknown was exactly how the Lord would make that provision for us
        - But now that plan is fully known, as the writer of Hebrews explains:

Heb. 1:1 God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways,
Heb. 1:2 in these last days has spoken to us in His Son, whom He appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the world.

- The next question we might ask Paul is how can God grant us His righteousness just because we believe in Jesus Christ?
    - How can God overlook our sin and wipe the slate clean?
        - Paul's fifth point answers that question in v.24
        - We are justified as a gift of God's grace because Christ Jesus has redeemed us
    - Let's look at three important theological ideas in that verse
        - First, we are justified
        - The word is a legal term meaning acquitted
        - To be acquitted means to be declared innocent, as when a defendant is acquitted by a jury at trial

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- Remember, to be acquitted doesn't mean we are actually innocent
  - Rather, it's a declaration made by a court
  - And the effect is to relieve the person from paying any penalty
  - That's why our judicial system declares a person "not guilty" rather than innocent
  - So God's means of assigning us His righteousness begins with God's court rendering a verdict of not guilty for us

- Secondly, Paul says this verdict is a gift given to us by the grace of God
  - Notice that the gift of God is a declaration of our innocence
    - The gift is not the opportunity to be declared innocent
    - The gift is a declaration already made for us
  - So that the decision to enter that verdict was a decision God made as a result of His grace toward us
    - Grace means undeserved favor, with an emphasis on the word undeserved
    - God's favor toward us was not triggered by anything we said or did
    - God determines to declare us justified simply as an act of His grace
    - Like a defendant appearing at trial only to learn that the judge has already decided to acquit him
  - Furthermore, justification is an act, not a process
    - A defendant is declared innocent (or not guilty) in an instant, and there is no process for bringing this to pass
    - The declaration is true instantly, and forever remains true
    - Never again can the decision be revisited
    - Our jurisprudence includes a concept of double jeopardy which finds its source in the biblical idea of justification

- Finally, God's actions to acquit are valid and lawful because another has redeemed us before the Law
  - Paul says Jesus has redeemed us
    - Redemption is also a legal term and it means to have paid a ransom to free one in bondage
    - So a slave could be redeemed from a debt owed his master
    - Or a prisoner could be redeemed from prison by payment of a bond to the court
  - Similarly, all men and women are under bondage to sin, in debt to God's court for our lifetime of sin
    - That debt must be paid or else a verdict of innocence would be a miscarriage of justice
    - We know God is perfect, without sin Himself, and therefore He can only declare us innocent of our sin should our debt be paid

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        - Paul says our justification is legally possible because Christ paid our price redeeming us from the penalty we rightly deserved
    - Speaking personally, all believers should say the following:
        - God declared me righteous, not guilty of my sins, apart from anything I've said or done, merely because of His grace
        - And He was able to do so because Jesus Christ was willing to pay my price for my sins
- What was the payment? Paul explains the payment in part six of his summary found in v.25
    - The payment God required was a blood sacrifice to satisfy God's justice
        - The Biblical word for this concept is propitiation, and it's a very important concept in our faith
        - The idea of propitiation is found all across the Bible, and it's one of the most prevalent concepts in the Old Testament
    - Remember, I asked how can God be fair in erasing our record of sin and assigning us His righteousness?
        - Isn't that unjust, by definition?
        - If justice means the guilty are punished and the innocent are set free, than wouldn't it be unjust for God to set us, the guilty, free?
        - Yes it would, unless a satisfactory payment is made on our behalf
    - If a payment were offered that satisfied the Judge's demand for justice, then the Judge could be just in allowing the guilty to go free
        - Imagine if you were guilty of failing to pay taxes, but as you arrive for your day in court, you learn that a neighbor has paid all your back taxes and even the penalties for you
        - Since the demands of the court have been met, the judge could set you free justly
        - And that's where Christ's propitiation comes in for us
- Paul says God publicly displayed Christ as a blood sacrifice, or propitiation
    - The penalty God decreed for sin was death

Gen. 2:16 The Lord God commanded the man, saying, "From any tree of the garden you may eat freely;
Gen. 2:17 but from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat from it you will surely die."

- The penalty of death God decreed for sin was spiritual death, which means eternal separation from God
- When Adam brought all mankind into sin, he brought us all under this penalty

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- We may escape this penalty by God's grace manifested through our faith in Jesus, but still the wrath of God must be satisfied
    - Wrath is the Bible's word for a holy God's just response against that which is not righteous
    - To remain just, God's holy wrath against sin must be satisfied
    - And since the penalty for sin is death, God demands a substitutionary payment of death, a propitiation
- But the death that substitutes for us cannot be that of another sinner, since then their death would merely become payment for their own sin
    - No, our propitiation must be someone who was innocent of sin
    - They can neither share in our sinful behaviors nor even in our sinful nature
- Jesus Christ is the One God prepared to be our propitiation
    - Scripture testified that Jesus shared neither our nature nor our record of sin
        - The gospels tells us Jesus was born of a virgin
        - Which was necessary to ensure Jesus was not a descendant of Adam and therefore He didn't inherit the sin nature of Adam
        - And therefore Jesus never participated in the rebellion of Adam
        - Paul will explain more about Christ as the new Adam in Chapter 5
    - And as a result Jesus was innocent and undeserving of the penalty of death, and yet the Father displayed Jesus publicly as a sacrifice for us
        - Christ's public suffering and death satisfied the wrath of God for sin
        - Notice Paul adds again "through faith"
        - The application of that payment to our heavenly account is made known to us through our faith
        - You can know that you have been justified before God in the court of Heaven because you possess faith in that payment
- Finally, we come to Paul's seventh and final point in his summary in the second half of v.25 and into v.26
    - Paul says God has made belief in Christ's substitutionary death the necessary means of salvation, so that God's justice could be understood
        - Notice at the end of v.25 Paul says that in forbearance, God passed over the sins previously committed
        - Forbearance means delaying a response
        - God delayed His judgment of humanity for their sin, passing over generations without bringing a final judgment upon the world
    - Of course, the Lord was forbearing because He knew the time had not yet arrived to bring His Son into the world to make His payment on the cross
        - While he waited, Paul says He passed over the sins previously committed

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        - Passing over doesn't mean forgiving
        - Passing over means not having acted to bring an end to sin
    - But when the time was right, God manifested His grace publicly as Christ gave Himself as our payment
        - And furthermore, God established that faith in that payment would be the means by which He manifests His grace at the present time
        - So today the world may know that God is still at work declaring people righteous on the basis of Christ's propitiation
        - And the evidence of God's grace is seen by a person's faith in Christ
    - The point in this exercise is to ensure the world understands that God has remained just through this process even as He justifies sinners
        - We can see how God is connecting the dots
        - He made a payment on a certain day, a payment that satisfies His wrath for sin
        - And then God assigned that payment to men and women as a matter of His grace alone declaring them justified, innocent
        - As we receive His gift of justification, we manifest His grace through our faith in that payment
    - In that way the world can see that God is just in His forgiveness as He justifies sinners
        - It's often called the Great Exchange
        - Christ took our penalty
        - And we were assigned credit for His perfect, righteous, nature
        - Our Heavenly account is credited with Christ's righteousness
- That's how we receive the righteousness of God
    - Our account of sin is wiped clean and we are credited with Christ's work because God by His grace grants it to us
        - That grace is manifested through our faith, which demonstrates to the world that we trust in Christ's payment for our sake
        - And in that way, we testify to the world that God has remained just in justifying us
    - This is the one and only true Gospel
        - It explains our predicament, the need for a God-provided solution and how we may obtain it
        - It offers explanation for how we find spiritual truth despite our fallen nature
        - How we can receive something we don't know about and weren't seeking
        - It explains how we might merit heaven when we are sinners
    - But we've only touched the surface of these concepts, and so Paul will spend the next two chapters delving into these seven points in greater detail

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        - And then there are a host of other questions that come to mind
        - For example, how can one man's death be enough to pay for the sins of millions of people?
        - And how does God's plan go beyond merely paying the price for our sin, to correcting our sin nature?
        - And if God declared us innocent, why do we still sin and will our new sin disqualify us from Heaven?
        - Paul answers these questions in the following chapters
- For now, let's look at how Paul elaborates on the first points in his summary: salvation is apart from Law having been witnessed by Law and Prophets

Rom. 3:27 Where then is boasting? It is excluded. By what kind of law? Of works? No, but by a law of faith.
Rom. 3:28 For we maintain that a man is justified by faith apart from works of the Law.
Rom. 3:29 Or is God the God of Jews only? Is He not the God of Gentiles also? Yes, of Gentiles also,
Rom. 3:30 since indeed God who will justify the circumcised by faith and the uncircumcised through faith is one.
Rom. 3:31 Do we then nullify the Law through faith? May it never be! On the contrary, we establish the Law.

- Paul begins with a pre-emptive strike against any who might object that salvation is apart from good works
    - Because it makes sense to us that our path to holiness depends on our own actions
        - We must put away sinning and seek for doing good so that we might be like God
        - How can a plan to save us ask nothing of us?
    - That thinking conceals its source, because while it sounds generous and self-sacrificing, it's actually the result of pride
        - We prefer to be captains of our own ships, responsible for our own future
        - And then when we reach our goal, we can take pride in our accomplishment
        - That's what Paul is referring to when he mentions boasting
    - But God will not share His glory with anyone, nor will He allow us to perpetuate our self-deception that says we play a part in His plan of redemption
        - First of all, we have no part because we could do nothing at all anyway
        - But more over, the plan God has constructed to save us excludes the possibility of boasting, Paul says
        - Had God devised a plan that required something of us, then we could rightly boast about our part

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        - Such a plan would be a law of works
    - But God devised a plan or law for salvation that excluded (prevented) such boasting
        - God has established a law (or means) for bringing men into righteousness
        - Remember, this law doesn't yield human righteousness
        - Rather it imputes God's righteousness to men
    - And this law has only one rule or requirement – faith in Christ
        - And that faith is the manifestation of God's grace, so even it is not of us

Eph. 2:8 **For by grace you have been saved through faith; and that not of yourselves, it is the gift of God;**
Eph. 2:9 **not as a result of works, so that no one may boast.**

- God's plan leaves men with nothing whatsoever to boast about
    - Paul says clearly in v.28 that we maintain that men are justified apart from the works of the Law
    - "We maintain" means this is the Christian position; the orthodox view of Christianity
    - Such that should anyone try to change this precept, they are no longer preaching Christianity or the true Gospel (e.g., Mormons, Catholics, certain other factions)
    - Any other view that introduces the requirement of human works according to any law as a means to righteousness has departed from Christianity
- For God is working in all mankind through the same means
    - Both as God of the Jews and as God of the Gentiles
    - He will justify both the circumcised and uncircumcised the same way
- Finally, Paul asks does salvation by faith nullify (i.e., make empty, void) the law?
    - He's addressing the question some might pose in light of salvation by faith
        - Does the plan of God render the law of God given to Israel in the Old Covenant meaningless or useless?
        - Has it any purpose?
    - To that Paul answers "on the contrary"
        - The true answer is exactly the opposite
        - When we acknowledge that we cannot meet the demands of the law and may only be saved by our faith in Jesus Christ, we're affirming the law
        - We're agreeing that the Law must be met AND that we can't meet it
    - Ironically, when someone (Nomianistic/Judaistic) attempts to follow a law they have already broken and continue to break daily, yet still expect to enter heaven, they are the ones nullifying the law

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        - In following the law, they affirm that meeting its requirements is a necessity
        - But then when they break the law (as all men do), they still maintain that God will approve them and grant them heaven
        - They are nullifying the very law they claim to follow when they assume God will overlook their failure to keep it perfectly
    - So as Paul says, on the contrary, agreeing with a law of faith establishes (or affirms) the unyielding requirements of the law
        - Because the Law is true and demanding and uncompromising, we must depend on faith in Christ
        - Christ fulfilled the Law's requirements perfectly because we couldn't
        - So we turn to God in faith rather than trusting in our works under Law

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- To those who survived my fire hydrant of Christian doctrine last week from the end of Chapter 3, welcome back
  - Last week we focused on Paul's summary of how we may obtain righteousness
    - God's solution solved all the problems to gaining heaven that Paul outlined in the earlier chapters
    - Which explained why Paul's summary was long and wordy
    - Paul put the whole solution out on the table knowing he's going to explain each part in detail in coming chapters
  - So let's run through the summary quickly looking at it as a roadmap for where we go next
    - First, in v.21 Paul says the solution is "apart from the Law"
    - So therefore we can expect Paul to explain more about the relationship between God's law and our salvation
    - Secondly, Paul says the righteousness we need for heaven is God's own righteousness, not some repaired version of our own
    - So we want a better explanation of how we get God's righteousness
  - At the end of v.21, Paul says this plan was promised in the Old Testament by the prophets
    - So Paul will need to show us where that is true
    - And He says the righteousness we receive from God is manifested through our faith in Christ
    - So we want more details on how this process of imputing righteousness actually happens through our faith
    - Paul adds this process is without distinction, so we would like to see how it's been true for both Jew and Gentile
  - Then, Paul wrapped up the summary saying this solution arrives at us being declared justified or innocent in God's court
    - We need to understand just how innocent we are in God's eyes
    - And God is able to remain just in declaring us innocent because He publicly displayed His Son as a sacrifice for our sake
    - We certainly want to know more about how one man's death can save us from judgment and save God from accusations of injustice
- We have all of that to examine in the coming chapters
  - Knowing these things will be very helpful in defending your faith and maintaining your hope in the face of the enemy's schemes
    - The more we know about how we're saved in Christ, the less likely we are to doubt in that salvation
    - And the better we can explain why we will be in Heaven the more easily we can share this truth with others

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- So as we move ahead, we're going to dive into the details of that summary, block by block
  - The very first of those explanations actually comes at the end of Chapter 3 in vs.27-31 after Paul's summary
  - We studied these last week, as Paul elaborated on the meaning of "apart from the Law"
- He said the fact that the Lord has designed the plan of redemption without works of Law, removes any possibility that mankind could claim to play a part
  - Paul talked of a law of works vs. a law of faith
  - You could replace the word "law" with the word "solution" or "means"
  - Paul was asking how does God exclude the possibility of us boasting?
  - He couldn't do that with a solution of works but He does do that with a solution dependent on faith
  - Especially when that faith is itself something that God produces in our heart
- And because the solution works through faith and not by works, it becomes equally available to Jew and Gentile
  - Only the Jews had the Law, so if the solution were on the basis of Law only the Jews could be saved
  - That's what many Jews thought, of course, because they misunderstood the role of the Law
  - But since the solution is based on faith, then salvation is equally available to both Jew and Gentile
- But does a solution of faith nullify the Law? No, Paul says
  - The fact that the solution requires faith is an acknowledgment that the Law is so demanding we can't meet its terms
  - So because the Law must be met perfectly, we needed a solution that didn't depend on us keeping the law in our own effort
  - We needed someone else do that hard work for us

- Which brings brings us to Chapter 4, and our fifth block in this study, the Old Testament proofs
  - Remember, Paul began by saying that the salvation we have was witnessed by the Law and Prophets
    - That phrase refers to the Hebrew Bible, the Old Testament
    - So now Paul uses Chapter 4 to make those proofs
    - And in the process, we learn some interesting things about how this salvation plan relates to Old Testament concepts like circumcision and the covenants
  - Starting with THE classic example of salvation by faith; Abraham

Rom. 4:1 What then shall we say that Abraham, our forefather according to the

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flesh, has found?
Rom. 4:2 For if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to boast about, but not before God.
Rom. 4:3 For what does the Scripture say? "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness."
Rom. 4:4 Now to the one who works, his wage is not credited as a favor, but as what is due.
Rom. 4:5 But to the one who does not work, but believes in Him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is credited as righteousness,

- Paul opens asking what would we say about Abraham's relationship with the father?
  - Paul says Abraham was the forefather of the Jewish people, by the flesh
    - All Jews descended from this man
    - And as such, he is the most revered man in Judaism
    - Only Moses is close
    - Because this man is such a powerful icon for every Jew, Paul uses Abraham's example to prove his point about salvation apart from works
  - The Bible calls Abraham a friend of God, which tells us that the Lord found a just way to overlook Abraham's sin and restore relationship
    - But Abraham lived long before God gave Israel the Law at Sinai with the Old Covenant
    - Which raises some obvious and important implications
    - Abraham could not have known of the requirements of the Old Covenant
    - He didn't possess the tablets with the Law nor the tabernacle for sacrifice nor was the priesthood in existence
  - So Abraham's good standing with the Lord couldn't have been on the basis of doing works under that Law
    - It was literally impossible
    - So God must have had some other way for Abraham
- Paul says if Abraham had been restored on the basis of good works, then the Bible would have acknowledged Abraham's excellent service to God
  - We would forever be talking about Abraham as the example of good works, perfect obedience and piety
    - And Abraham could have boasted for his own sake
    - We could find examples in scripture of Abraham bragging to Isaac about his accomplishments
    - And when he blessed his children as patriarchs did, he would have pointed to that example for the family
  - But the Bible never speaks of Abraham in those ways and neither does Abraham

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boast of himself in that way

- Instead, the Bible calls Abraham the father of faith
- Paul quotes Genesis 15:6 when the Lord testified that Abraham believed God
- The Lord promised Abraham that his wife would bear him a son though she was long past child bearing years and had never given birth yet
- Based solely on the revealed word of God, Abraham believed this promise would come true

- Then, because of Abraham's faith in God's word, the Lord credited Abraham's faith as righteousness
  - This is an example of the imputation of righteousness, which we discussed briefly last time
  - God assigned something (righteousness) to Abraham that Abraham did not possess
  - And that assignment was not based on Abraham's act or decision but God's
  - Like a child chosen for adoption by new parents

- Paul elaborates on this key point in v.4 saying Abraham didn't earn something in this exchange
  - If Abraham was being declared righteous because of something he did, then the scriptures wouldn't have described it as a "credit" of righteousness
    - Instead, the Bible would say Abraham earned his righteousness, which was a wage paid to him by God for his hard work
    - But the Bible says Abraham's righteousness wasn't paid to him, but credited or reckoned to him
    - God, in His role as the bookkeeper of men's souls, lined out Abraham's debt of sin in His heavenly ledger and credited Abraham's account as paid in full
  - In v.5 Paul adds this credit came to Abraham solely because of his faith in God, Who is the justifier of the ungodly
    - This statement raises another important aspect of our doctrine of salvation by grace and not works
    - Notice what Abraham was believing in
    - He believed in Him who justifies the ungodly
- Three details emerge from that statement, and these statements give us the framework of the saving Gospel
  - First, Abraham's faith was in a person
    - Notice it says Abraham believed in Him, referring to God and perhaps more specifically the Messiah
    - In the Gospels, Jesus said this:

John 8:56 **"Your father Abraham rejoiced to see My day, and he saw it and was**

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glad."

- Abraham's faith was not in an event or a blessing
  - Yes, Abraham believed in the promise God gave Him concerning a son, but his faith wasn't in the blessing itself
  - If someone makes you a promise, what causes you to trust in their promise?
  - Isn't your faith based in the trustworthiness and capacity of the person to keep that promise?
  - If a used car salesman promises to give you a million dollars and Warren Buffet promises to give you a million dollars, which promise do you believe?
  - The promises are exactly the same, but the promiser is very different
- Abraham believed the promise God gave concerning Isaac because Abraham trusted in the Lord to be faithful concerning His word
  - And so it was Abraham's faith in the trustworthiness of God that lead him to believe
  - And by that faith, God was pleased to credit Abraham with righteousness
- This is the same process for anyone who is saved by the grace of God
  - The person receives a promise from God, and the person places faith (belief) in God to fulfill that promise
  - They expect what has been promised to come to pass, and they put aside all doubt
  - The future promise of God is as certain as history because we know the One Who promised is faithful to keep His word
  - As the writer of Hebrews says

Heb. 11:1 **Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.**
Heb. 11:2 **For by it the men of old gained approval.**

- This leads us to the second important theological point raised by this verse
  - Throughout history the object of a saving faith has never changed
    - The object of our faith is always the Person of God and His faithfulness to keep His promises
    - Once again, Hebrews says it best:

Heb. 11:6 **And without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is and that He is a rewarder of those who seek Him.**

- So like Abraham, a Christian today has faith in God (Christ) to fulfill His promises to justify us and raise us from the dead

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- We place our trust in Him to keep that promise to us
- And we base our trust in Him on the basis of the testimony of His power and authority to keep His word
- His resurrection from the dead was intended as proof to us that we can take Him at His word when He promised to do the same for us

- But while the object of our faith never changes, the content of our faith does differ from age to age in God's plan, which is the third point from this verse
  - In early times, the Lord had revealed only parts of His plan to redeem mankind
    - Men knew God would make a way to justify them despite their sin
    - But they didn't necessarily understand all that God would do to bring it about
    - Noah, Abraham, David, and even the prophets knew only parts of this plan
  - So we say the content of their faith varied
    - Noah was told to build a boat to survive a flood
    - Abraham was told he would have son in his old age
    - David was told he would have an heir Who would rule on the throne of Israel forever
    - The prophets were told that God would give His people a new covenant and a new heart and a kingdom where a Messiah would rule
  - In each case, the content of God's promise differed, growing from generation to generation as God revealed more of His plan
    - But in all cases the object of faith remained in God to justify His people
    - Today, the full plan of God has been revealed in Christ, the promised Messiah
    - With the full plan now revealed, the content of our faith and the object of our faith have become one in the same: Jesus Christ
    - We place our faith in the God Man and the promise we believe is that He is our Messiah…the object and content are now complete
    - Hebrews again has the summary:

Heb. 1:1 God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways,
Heb. 1:2 in these last days has spoken to us in His Son, whom He appointed heir of all things, through whom also He made the world.

- Finally, the last point raised by v.5 is that saving faith is a trust in God to justify the ungodly
  - Our faith in God begins with a recognition that we are unworthy of entering His presence on our own merits because we are ungodly
    - Therefore we turn to God to solve that problem for us

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        - We recognize He is a justifier of the ungodly
        - That he can overcome our sin problem for us, and therefore we place no confidence in our own ability to solve the problem
    - In the Gospels, this point is typically described as the repentance that leads to salvation

Rom. 2:4 Or do you think lightly of the riches of His kindness and tolerance and patience, not knowing that the kindness of God leads you to repentance?

- Repentance is a personal awareness that we cannot find the solution to Heaven on our own, so we stop trying
- Instead, we trust in God to justify us, the ungodly
- So Abraham was declared righteous because of His faith in God's trustworthiness to keep His promises and to justify him, an undeserving and ungodly sinner
    - And because of that faith in God, He credited Abraham's faith as righteousness
        - Notice, God didn't make Abraham righteous
        - Rather God credited Abraham's account in Heaven
        - So that at the moment Abraham stood before God following His death, he would be acquitted of his sin at that point
        - Including the sin that Abraham committed after Genesis 15
    - The rest of the story of Abraham reminds us that this man was not sinless following his justification by faith
        - Abraham commits several high profile sins yet his justification remained in effect
        - The Judge's declaration of not guilty is never reversed
        - Because justification is not a description of Abraham's condition (i.e., it doesn't declare Abraham was sinless)
        - It's a declaration of God's judgment of Abraham (i.e., it says Abraham was guilt-less for his sin)
    - So Abraham's example is proof to us that salvation was never by doing works of Law
        - It's proof because of when Abraham lived
        - He lived prior to the giving of the Law, so Law can't be a necessity for salvation
        - And if the Lord could find a way to offer righteousness to even one ungodly person apart from the Law, then the Law is clearly not necessary
    - Secondly, Abraham's example is proof of salvation without works because of how the Lord declared he was saved
        - He was credited with righteousness, he didn't earn it
        - So works have zero bearing on our righteousness

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        - And if this is true prior to being justified, then it remains equally true after we are justified
        - A Christian does not become more righteous because of good works after faith than he or she did before faith
        - Our righteousness comes by means other than works. Period.
- We might think Abraham's example shuts the door on these questions, but it doesn't, which is why Chapter 4 doesn't end after v.5
    - If the chapter had ended here, some could argue that God changed the rules after Abraham's day
        - A Jew particularly might say that once the Law came through Moses, the rules for salvation were updated to reflect the Law's demands
        - So that following Moses, a person must keep the Law to be saved
        - You may have heard some argue this point, even to Christians, and they argue that why else would God have provided His Law?
    - So Paul continues his explanation of Old Testament proofs by introducing his second major Old Testament example: David

Rom. 4:6 just as David also speaks of the blessing on the man to whom God credits righteousness apart from works:
Rom. 4:7 "Blessed are those whose lawless deeds have been forgiven,
And whose sins have been covered.
Rom. 4:8 "Blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will not take into account."

- Paul quotes from Psalm 32, a psalm written by David
    - In the first two verses of that psalm David declared that the blessed man (or woman) is one whose lawless deeds or sins have been forgiven by God
        - Specifically, he says whose sins have been covered
        - To cover a sin is euphemism for atonement, making payment for a debt of sin
        - In the same way that we might say we "cover" our debts
        - So being blessed is having your sin debt paid for
    - And he says a person is blessed when the Lord does not take sin into account
        - The Septuagint words it a little differently

Psa. 32:2 Blessed is the man to whom the Lord will not impute sin, and whose mouth there is no guile.

- There's that word again: impute
- Only it's used here in the negative fashion as David says we're blessed when the Lord does not count our sin as our own

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- Rather we are blessed when the Lord would do the opposite, imputing us with His righteousness
- Notice how Paul introduced this quote in v.6 when he says David was testifying that God credits righteousness apart from works
    - David said that blessedness was having our debts covered, that is, paid for by someone other than us
    - And that God would not hold our debts against him, that is He would forgive them some other way
    - David said this is how we are blessed by God, therefore trying to work off our debt by ourselves is NOT being blessed
    - And anyone who has ever labored under the misconception that works get us into heaven can testify to the fact that this is not a blessed way to live
    - It's almost nonstop condemnation and doubt interrupted only by periods of self-righteous pride
- David's example serves as a "second witness" in support of Paul's point, but Paul chose to use Abraham and David for a very specific reason
    - These two men slam the door on any suggestion that the Law of Moses has some connection to the Lord's plan of redemption
        - Abraham was clearly saved before the Law was even known or available
        - His sin was covered, and a relationship with the Lord was established on the basis of his faith in God's promises
    - And then we have David who lived after the Law, and yet David continued to testify that blessedness from God was on the same basis
        - God pays our sin debt for us and will not count our sins against us
        - We do not work our way to righteousness
    - So if salvation was by trusting in God to justify the ungodly before the Law and it was still the same way after the Law came, then the Law did not change that plan
        - The Law is good and holy and necessary for reasons Paul will address later in this letter
        - But the Law has never been a means to salvation, whether in whole or part, whether before we're saved or after
- So Paul said in Chapter 3 that God's plan of salvation was witnessed in the Law and the Prophets, and now he's shown that to be true
    - Abraham's story is found in Genesis, which is one of the books of the "law" according to Jewish reckoning
        - And the same message is repeated in the Psalms, which is part of the "prophets" as Jews divide their scriptures
        - God has always described the means of salvation in the same terms in His word
        - The only thing that's changed over history is how much detail of the plan was known

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- Next, Paul moves to exploring another point from his Chapter 3 summary: this salvation plan is for all mankind, there is no distinction between Jew and Gentile

Rom. 4:9 Is this blessing then on the circumcised, or on the uncircumcised also? For we say, "Faith was credited to Abraham as righteousness."
Rom. 4:10 How then was it credited? While he was circumcised, or uncircumcised? Not while circumcised, but while uncircumcised;
Rom. 4:11 and he received the sign of circumcision, a seal of the righteousness of the faith which he had while uncircumcised, so that he might be the father of all who believe without being circumcised, that righteousness might be credited to them,
Rom. 4:12 and the father of circumcision to those who not only are of the circumcision, but who also follow in the steps of the faith of our father Abraham which he had while uncircumcised.

- Paul answers simply, "What was Abraham's state when he was declared righteous? Was it before or after he was circumcised?"
  - Circumcision was like a Jewish birth certificate
    - It was the basis for Jewish identity and it was the sign of belonging to the Abrahamic covenant
    - Every boy born in the family of Israel was to be circumcised at the age of 8 days old
  - Women are not circumcised, of course, but they were included under this sign through association with the male authority of their family
    - A daughter was covered by the sign of her father
    - And when the girl was married, she was covered by the sign of her husband
- Therefore, circumcision was a key distinction between Jew and Gentile
  - And since Paul used Abraham, the father of the Jewish people, as his example, the question arises was God's plan only for Jews?
    - But here again, the Lord orchestrated Abraham's life and the timing of these events to ensure we could not make such a mistake
    - Paul says in v.10 that Abraham's justification – the moment he was declared not guilty by God – happened while he was still uncircumcised
    - So clearly, circumcision is not part of the process of salvation
  - But more than that, it means that Jewish identity is not a part of the plan either
    - The Jewish people are important to God's plan
    - But Jewish identity is not a prerequisite for salvation, which Abraham proves
- So what is the significance to circumcision? Paul gives that answer in vs.11-12
  - Paul says Abraham received circumcision as a sign, a seal of the righteousness of the

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faith Abraham had beforehand

- Paul means that the sign is a witness to the covenant that God made with Abraham
- The mark in the person's body served as evidence the person was in covenant with God
- And God ordered that Abraham take the mark of circumcision after he believed to make a point

- A sign isn't the enacting of a covenant; it *follows* the enacting of a covenant
  - A sign signifies that a covenant *has been* formed
  - Like a highway sign that announces you are approaching a city
  - The sign doesn't make the city a reality…the city doesn't appear because we erected the sign
  - We only erect the sign after a city has been established
  - Circumcision gave outward evidence of Abraham's faith in the promise of God, which Abraham had beforehand, Paul says
- God even designed the method of circumcision to reflect this truth

Gen. 17:10 "This is My covenant, which you shall keep, between Me and you and your descendants after you: every male among you shall be circumcised.
Gen. 17:11 "And you shall be circumcised in the flesh of your foreskin, and it shall be the sign of the covenant between Me and you.
Gen. 17:12 "And every male among you who is eight days old shall be circumcised throughout your generations, a servant who is born in the house or who is bought with money from any foreigner, who is not of your descendants.
Gen. 17:13 "A servant who is born in your house or who is bought with your money shall surely be circumcised; thus shall My covenant be in your flesh for an everlasting covenant.
Gen. 17:14 "But an uncircumcised male who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person shall be cut off from his people; he has broken My covenant."

- God commanded that the mark be taken at a very early age to reinforce the meaning of the sign
  - A mark in the flesh is given to male Jewish children at 8 days old, before the child is old enough to choose this mark for himself
    - This reminds us that the covenant is already in force for each Jewish child on the basis of God's promise to Abraham, without respect to the child's personal choice
    - Just as the covenant was in effect for Abraham before he was circumcised
    - Furthermore, if a child is not circumcised, the child breaks the covenant, and

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you can't break a covenant unless it's already in effect

- This same relationship between covenant and sign holds true for the New Covenant
  - The Lord makes promises to us concerning His Son, our Savior
  - And as we trust in those promises (i.e., believe in the Gospel), we're declared righteous on the basis of our faith in that promise
  - Then later we take a sign of that covenant when we submit to water baptism
  - Water baptism follows our entry into the covenant, it doesn't bring the covenant into effect (it doesn't save us)
- So God determined the timing of circumcision to teach the relationship between His covenant to Abraham, and its sign
  - Abraham's faith brought him to righteousness before the covenant was put in place
  - And the sign was taken after the covenant was formed to ensure we would know it didn't create Abraham's righteousness
  - So Abraham serves as a model for both the Jew (who has been circumcised) and for the Gentile who has not
  - For both groups, the answer to the question of how we become righteous is the same: by faith – irrespective of when or if we are circumcised

- This leads to an important distinction between the Abrahamic covenant and the New Covenant
  - The Abrahamic covenant promised the blessing of Jewish identity for those born into the line of Abraham
    - Jews entered into that covenant by birth into the physical line of Abraham
    - And the mark of circumcision is a sign of that relationship
  - But that covenant doesn't automatically convey the spiritual blessings Abraham received by faith in God's promises
    - That 8-day old Jewish boy is included in the Abrahamic covenant
    - But that child is not credited with the righteousness Abraham received
    - Only if that child repeats the faith of Abraham will he receive the credit of righteousness
  - So the Abrahamic covenant was not a means of salvation, though it implies the coming of the New Covenant
    - It established a series of promises to be fulfilled in Abraham's family later to be called Israel
    - God is fulfilling those promises through his family line, and their accomplishments are not dependent on faith
    - Each child receives the mark of circumcision to reflect they have been born into that covenant
  - But only the one who believes, as Abraham did, in the promises of God will be

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credited with righteousness as was Abraham

- Paul says in v.12 that Abraham is the father (in the flesh) of those who have received physical circumcision
- But more importantly, he is also the father (i.e., an example) for all who follow in him in faith
- So he serves an example of how one obtains righteousness by faith, whether you are a Jew (circumcised) or Gentile (uncircumcised)

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- My teaching on the first half of Romans 4 ended in a place of confusion, I feel, so I need to clarify my teaching from the previous lesson
    - First, let's take another look at our Structure of Romans chart
- We're in Chapter 4: Paul's proofs from the Old Testament
- Paul's seeking to prove three basic points related to obtaining righteousness
- First, Paul proved that salvation has always been a matter of faith, not works
    - He used the example of Abraham as his proof
    - Abraham was credited with righteousness because he believed in God to keep a promise concerning a future son
    - He wasn't credited on the basis of his works, therefore Abraham proves works are not the way to righteousness
    - Abraham is Paul's example to prove that salvation by faith is not a new idea
- Secondly, Paul proved that the means to salvation didn't change after the Law came to Israel
    - He used the example of David declaring in the Psalms that a blessed man is the one who has his lawless deeds forgiven and his sin debt covered
    - Once again, scripture testifies that blessedness (i.e., righteousness) is according to God's mercy only
    - David lived after the Law, so his example proves that the Law's arrival didn't alter God's plan
    - So David proves that salvation by faith alone has never changed
- Thirdly, Paul proved that God made faith the means to salvation so that both Jew and Gentile could receive His mercy
    - To prove this point, Paul returned to the example of Abraham in v.9 asking when was Abraham circumcised
    - This is where my teaching wasn't clear enough, so I want to spend a moment revisiting Paul's third proof
- Circumcision was commanded under two of the five covenants God gave to Israel: the Abrahamic and Mosaic Covenants
    - The Abrahamic Covenant came first, and it established Jewish identity
        - In that covenant, circumcision was the sign of the covenant
        - As such, it was like a Jewish birth certificate demonstrating who had been included in the covenant
        - It was performed at 8 days because it didn't depend on personal agreement
        - Every child born to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob was a party to the covenant and circumcision was the sign of that covenant
        - If a child was not circumcised, then the covenant was broken for that individual and they were cut off from the Jewish nation
    - The Mosaic Covenant also expected males to be circumcised

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        - Obviously, Jewish males were already commanded to be circumcised under the Abrahamic Covenant
        - But under the Mosaic Law, Gentiles who wanted to join in the commonwealth of Israel were also circumcised
        - So circumcision became a way for Gentiles to submit to the Law
        - That's why Paul warned the Galatians that if they took circumcision, they were obligating themselves to keeping the whole law
    - So that leads to the question, must a Gentile become a Jew before they may be included in the promises of the covenant?
        - To address this point Paul asks when did Abraham receive his declaration of righteousness: before or after circumcision?
        - The answer is before, and Paul says this proves that salvation didn't depend on being Jewish
        - Abraham didn't have the sign of the covenant yet was still declared righteous by faith alone
    - Therefore, Paul concludes that Abraham serves as an example (i.e., a father) to both Jews and Gentiles
        - His faith preceded his entry into the Abrahamic Covenant
        - Therefore, he is an example for all mankind, both those who descended from him and those who didn't
        - Any man or woman who repeats Abraham's example of faith will receive the same outcome: a heavenly credit of righteousness
- Today, we are entering into the New Covenant by faith, because the content of God's promise has been expanded to its fullness in Christ
    - Abraham received a promise with a lessor content but his faith was in the same object: the faithfulness of God
        - We too place our faith in the faithfulness of God

1John 1:9 **If we confess our sins, He is faithful and righteous to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.**

- And like Abraham, we are justified by our faith in God's promise
- But the promise God gave to us in the New Covenant holds greater content concerning God's plan of redemption
- Still, the process works the same
    - We receive the promise
    - We believe in the One Who promises
    - And we receive the credit of righteousness that Abraham received
- Following our faith we follow Abraham's example in taking the sign of a covenant

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- By faith, we receive the sign of our faith which is the baptism of the Spirit, called the circumcision of the heart
- Our spirit baptism happens without any action on our part, since it is accomplished by the Spirit at our moment of faith
- In the same way that the sign of the Abrahamic covenant was given to an infant
- We don't chose to enter in…our Father brings us in
- Later, we give testimony to our spirit baptism by taking water baptism as a public witness

- In the last part of the chapter, Paul refutes once again that the Law's arrival and its requirement for circumcision changed the rules
  - Remember, the Mosaic Law also mandated circumcision
    - That fact suggested to some Jews that the blessings of the Abrahamic Covenant were to be obtained through the Law
    - That was the argument being made by the Judaizers in the first century…
    - They said one must be under the Law to receive the blessings of the New Covenant
  - So that leads Paul to give further argument on this point

Rom. 4:13 For the promise to Abraham or to his descendants that he would be heir of the world was not through the Law, but through the righteousness of faith.
Rom. 4:14 For if those who are of the Law are heirs, faith is made void and the promise is nullified;
Rom. 4:15 for the Law brings about wrath, but where there is no law, there also is no violation.

- As we read this section, we need to pay attention to Paul's vocabulary in this section
  - Paul mentions the promise to Abraham and the Law
    - The promise to Abraham refers to the Abrahamic Covenant
    - The Law refers to the Mosaic Covenant
    - The Abrahamic covenant was a one-way grant, where the blessings were given as a promise based on faith
    - The Mosaic Covenant was a two-way agreement, where the blessings were earned by performance of works
    - Both required circumcision, which was the mark of Jewish identity and submission to the Law
  - Secondly, Paul talks of heirs
    - In the covenant God spoke to Abraham, He made promises to both Abraham and his descendants (*see Gen 15:18*)
    - Likewise, in the Mosaic Covenant, the Lord made an agreement with all future

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generations of Israel (*see Deut 29:14-15*)

- So the question is who are the heirs of the covenant God spoke to Abraham?

- Since both covenants commanded circumcision, which covenant is responsible for delivering the promises God gave Abraham's descendants?
  - Or we could ask it this way: which covenant did God intend to use to fulfill His promises to Abraham and his descendants?
  - Did God intend for Abraham's descendants to keep the Law in order to receive the promises He gave Abraham?
  - Did God add circumcision to the Law so that the two covenants would work together to bring about the promised blessings?
  - Or did these two covenants stand apart?

- To this Paul says plainly in v.13 that God's promises to Abraham were to be obtained in the way Abraham obtained them, by faith alone, not by the Law
  - In Genesis, God promised Abraham that his descendants would be heirs of the world
    - God made a grant to Abraham, a grant of land and prosperity
    - The Lord said that this blessing would be Abraham's inheritance
    - And like any inheritance, Abraham would pass that inheritance down to his descendants
  - Earlier, Paul taught that Abraham's descendants were those who share in his faith
    - So the connection between Abraham and his heirs will be spiritual not physical
    - Abraham received that promise when he put his faith in it
    - After Abraham believed God, God established His promise as a covenant
  - But Paul says if those blessings were later incorporated into a covenant of works (i.e., the Law), then they would no longer be on the basis of a promise
    - He says in v.14 that if those who are Abraham's heirs were those who were party to the Law, then it would mean that the promise was void or nullified
    - The original promises that God gave Abraham were received on the basis of faith only
    - But if the Law was the means of receiving the blessing, then it would be by doing works of Law
    - That would have made that earlier promise of no effect

- Let me use an example to explain Paul's point more easily
  - Imagine I promise my son $100 for his birthday and he believes my word and looks forward to his gift
    - I've told him that this blessing will be his without any condition
    - By my word alone, he expects to receive a blessing
  - But what if later I return to him and say that he can have that $100 only if he keeps his room clean

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        - At that point, my earlier promise is no longer in effect
        - He is no longer assured the money simply because of my word
        - Now he must obey my rule if he is to receive the money
        - So my law has nullified my earlier promise
    - Paul says that if this were how God's covenants worked, then it would have had a profound effect
        - In v.15 Paul says law always brings about wrath
        - He means that laws are cause for accusation
        - They do not makes us do the right thing; rather they expose us when we fail to live right
        - When I added my rule for my son, I introduced the possibility of failure and condemnation
        - I didn't increase the chance of receiving the money; I greatly decreased that possibility
    - But when no law exists, there can be no violation, Paul says
        - Before I added the rule for my son to follow, there was no chance he would fail to receive the money
        - There was nothing he could do to ruin it, since I never connected his receiving of the blessing with his behavior at all
        - Without law there can be no violation and without violation there is nothing standing in the way of blessing
    - That's the difference between works and grace
        - In the first situation, my son was looking forward to a reward and had no reason to fear or even labor to obtain it
        - In the second situation, he had little hope for a reward and lived under the burden of constant effort yet with little or no hope to escape judgment
        - One is a blessing, one is a curse
- So it was with the Abrahamic Covenant
    - God only asked Abraham to believe in the promise
        - And on that basis the promise was assured
        - From that point forward, nothing could stop it from coming to Abraham, since its fulfillment wasn't connected to his behavior

Rom. 4:16 For this reason it is by faith, in order that it may be in accordance with grace, so that the promise will be guaranteed to all the descendants, not only to those who are of the Law, but also to those who are of the faith of Abraham, who is the father of us all,
Rom. 4:17 (as it is written, "A father of many nations have I made you") in the

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presence of Him whom he believed, even God, who gives life to the dead and calls into being that which does not exist.

- Paul says "for this reason" the blessing of righteousness was to come by faith (in the way of the Abrahamic Covenant) and not by works (Mosaic Covenant)
  - Paul means for all the reasons he's covered in the chapter up to this point
  - The first reason: the blessing must be by grace, not by works, because righteousness is credited not earned
- Secondly, it must be apart from circumcision (i.e., Jewish identity) so that it could available to both Jew and Gentile
  - If Jewish identity were part of the process of salvation, then it would only be available to those who were Jewish
  - But Abraham was promised to be a father of many nations, Paul says in v.17
  - Meaning, that many would be spiritual heirs of that man for following his example of faith
- Finally, God's blessing must be by faith in a promise and not by law because otherwise no one could have expected to receive the blessing
  - God is the One Who gives life to the dead and calls into being that which did not exist
    - In Abraham's case, Paul is describing the arrival of Isaac from a dead womb
    - But that statement has a double meaning
    - It also refers to the bringing of new life to a spiritually dead person
    - Calling into existence a faith and trust in God that previously didn't exist
  - This is how Abraham stands as ultimate proof for the manner of salvation
    - He is our example of how a person can be lead to faith in a promise from God

Rom. 4:18 **In hope against hope he believed, so that he might become a father of many nations according to that which had been spoken, "So shall your descendants be."**
Rom. 4:19 **Without becoming weak in faith he contemplated his own body, now as good as dead since he was about a hundred years old, and the deadness of Sarah's womb;**
Rom. 4:20 **yet, with respect to the promise of God, he did not waver in unbelief but grew strong in faith, giving glory to God,**
Rom. 4:21 **and being fully assured that what God had promised, He was able also to perform.**
Rom. 4:22 **Therefore it was also credited to him as righteousness.**
Rom. 4:23 **Now not for his sake only was it written that it was credited to him,**
Rom. 4:24 **but for our sake also, to whom it will be credited, as those who believe**

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in Him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead,
Rom. 4:25 **He who was delivered over because of our transgressions, and was raised because of our justification.**

- Paul ends the chapter with an extended examination of the faith Abraham had in God's promise
  - The point in this examination is to understand how closely we follow in his footsteps as we believe
    - We aren't just repeating his example of faith
    - We are actually believing in essentially the same thing
  - In v.18 Paul says that Abraham believed in hope against hope
    - That phrase means that Abraham had hope in something that he ought not have had reason to hope in
    - Abraham had been promised by God that he shall have innumerable descendants
  - But Abraham contemplated his own body, Paul says
    - Contemplated could be translated "understood"
    - Abraham understood his situation
    - He was not naive or ignoring the obvious
    - He knew that he – and particularly his wife – were past the age when children could be expected
    - They had no reason to hope for a baby
  - But there was God promising to bring new life from something dead
    - And Paul says that Abraham understood his situation but nevertheless, he didn't let that fact weaken his faith in God's promise
    - Instead, Abraham did not waiver
    - He put no hope in his flesh to solve the problem, but he placed his faith entirely in the Lord to solve it
    - He gave glory, being fully convinced that what God had promised He was able to perform
- This is exactly how we follow in Abraham's footsteps in obtaining God's righteousness as he did
  - We receive a promise that God will bring new life from our dead spirit
    - That by faith in Christ we may be born again, made new spiritually in the likeness of Christ
    - As Jesus told Nicodemus

John 3:3 **Jesus answered and said to him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is**

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born again he cannot see the kingdom of God."
John 3:4 **Nicodemus said to Him, "How can a man be born when he is old? He cannot enter a second time into his mother's womb and be born, can he?"**
John 3:5 **Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.**
John 3:6 **"That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.**

- If we contemplated our deadness, our sinfulness, and our rebellious hearts, then we would have no reason to hope for heaven
  - But we don't place our hope in our flesh, just as Abraham didn't place his trust in his own flesh to solve his problem
  - We hope against hope, putting our trust in God to justify the ungodly
- More than that, God also promises that out of this dying body He will bring a new eternal body that will never die again
  - Paul explained that promise to us

1Cor. 15:42 So also is the resurrection of the dead. It is sown a perishable body, it is raised an imperishable body;
1Cor. 15:43 it is sown in dishonor, it is raised in glory; it is sown in weakness, it is raised in power;
1Cor. 15:44 it is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body. If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body.

- If you look at your own dying body, you have no hope to live eternally
- You see your body getting older, getting weaker, getting sicker
- You put no trust in it to solve the problem of death
- Instead, you place your hope in God's promise to raise you as Christ was raised
  - So hoping against hope, you expect to live again one day
  - In that future day, God will give you a new living eternal body
- What explains such a confidence?
  - Intellectually, we struggle to explain our confidence to others, don't we?
    - Imagine Abraham explaining to others that he was confident that he would receive a son despite being 100 yrs old
    - I'm sure anyone who asked for defense of his confidence would have heard Abraham speak of the glory of God (v.20)
    - But in the end, there was no proof possible
    - His confidence was a faith that defied explanation
  - That faith was a product of God's supernatural work in Abraham's heart
    - Hebrews says that Jesus is the Author and Perfecter of our faith

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        - He brings us the supernatural confidence not to waiver in that confidence
    - But what about that episode of Abraham and Hagar?
        - While Abraham was waiting for the Lord to fulfill His promise to Abraham, he took matters into his own hands
        - Abraham took Hagar as his concubine for the purpose of producing the child he expected from God's promise
        - He did this at the suggestion of his wife, but nevertheless Abraham went through with it
    - It seems as Abraham did exactly the opposite of what Paul was saying here in Romans
        - It seems that Abraham contemplated the weakness of his wife's body and then he wavered in his faith because of it
        - And so he doubted God, and it lead him to his sin with Hagar
- But that's not how to understand Abraham's actions
    - He didn't seek for a son through Hagar because he doubted God's promise
        - He did it because he had faith God was at work to produce an heir
        - Notice that Paul says Abraham was about 100 when he had this confidence
        - But Abraham received the promise when he was 75, and it was at that time he was declared righteous by his faith
    - So Abraham received a promise at 75, and believed and was credited with righteousness
        - Then time begins to pass
        - Even as time passes, Abraham's confidence in that promise doesn't waiver, but his patience did
        - The long time caused Abraham to second guess God's timetable and presuppose how the promise would be fulfilled
        - So that at a point Abraham becomes convinced, perhaps by his wife, that the child would simply come in a conventional way
    - Eventually, Abraham assumed that God intended to keep his promise through the son he produced with Hagar
        - To Abraham, God's promise was still trustworthy and the blessings were no less true
        - But he wasn't patient
- Then after 25 years, the Lord announced that the time had come for the child to be born and that the son would come by Sarah, not Hagar

Gen. 18:9 **Then they said to him, "Where is Sarah your wife?" And he said, "There, in the tent."**
Gen. 18:10 **He said, "I will surely return to you at this time next year; and behold,**

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Sarah your wife will have a son." And Sarah was listening at the tent door, which was behind him.
Gen. 18:11 **Now Abraham and Sarah were old, advanced in age; Sarah was past childbearing.**
Gen. 18:12 **Sarah laughed to herself, saying, "After I have become old, shall I have pleasure, my lord being old also?"**
Gen. 18:13 **And the Lord said to Abraham, "Why did Sarah laugh, saying, 'Shall I indeed bear a child, when I am so old?'**
Gen. 18:14 **"Is anything too difficult for the Lord? At the appointed time I will return to you, at this time next year, and Sarah will have a son."**
Gen. 18:15 **Sarah denied it however, saying, "I did not laugh"; for she was afraid. And He said, "No, but you did laugh."**

- By this point, neither Abraham nor Sarah are looking for the fulfillment of God's promise because they assume it has already happened
  - They suppose it has already been fulfilled in Ishmael, the son from Hagar
  - This isn't a lack of a faith in God's promise; it's a lack of perspective and appreciation for God's ways
- They both believed in the promise but they thought they understood God's plan
  - So when they heard the Lord promising to bring a son through Sarah, after Ismael was already 13, they couldn't understand it
  - Sarah laughed at the suggestion, Abraham puzzled at it
  - Much like a 100 year old woman might laugh at the suggestion today or an old man might assume he didn't understand something
- Then God explained the plan to Abraham and when Abraham finally understood what God was going to do, he realigned his expectations
  - That happened when he was about 100, as Paul says
  - And at that point, Abraham demonstrated his confidence in God's promise by acting without wavering
  - First, Abraham obeyed God by sending his beloved son Ishmael out of the house
  - Secondly, he willingly sacrificed Isaac when God required it
- Abraham's story is so interesting precisely because it features such a contrast of highs and lows
  - Abraham hopes against hope for a child and later nearly sacrifices him at God's request – what great examples of faith!
    - But in between those two high points, Abraham lies about his wife rather than trusting in God to protect them while waiting for the promised son
    - And he beds another woman in an attempt to have the promised son rather than wait patiently
    - From the first moment Abraham was trusting in God to fulfill His word

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        - And as a result he was declared righteous from the beginning
        - But he didn't walk in perfect obedience or understanding
    - Abraham's life is evidence that a journey of faith doesn't always reflect our great confidence in God for our eternal future
        - We may have saving faith in His promises but we will waiver at times in our obedience
        - We may assume too much about how God plans to work out His plan
        - Or we may decide to take matters into our own hands
        - But our faith is intact as is our justification
- And so Paul says in v.22 that's why God chose to declare Abraham righteous in Chapter 15 of Genesis, at the start of this journey…it was for our sake
    - In Genesis 15 Abraham was at the beginning of that journey, and his faith was childlike
        - He knew nothing of the future
        - He had no idea that God intended to make him wait a quarter of century before his promised son was given
        - He simply heard a promise and he believed it
        - And so God credited Him with righteousness
    - Even as God made that credit the Lord knew all that would come later for Abraham
        - He knew the sin Abraham would accumulate in those coming years
        - Yet He was already prepared to cover that sin under this grant of justification
        - Abraham was credited as righteous and his credit was a forever decree
    - Paul says we needed to see this order of events too
        - We needed to see that faith produces righteousness regardless of the walk our life may take after that point
        - Like Abraham, our faith saves us from the penalty of sin and it also saves us despite our sin
        - So that even as we stumble like Abraham, we remain credited with righteousness as he was
    - These things we share with Abraham even as we believe in a different promise than Abraham did
        - The content of our promise has fully matured
        - At the end of v.24 Paul says we are those who have believed in the promise of Jesus raised from the dead, which is something more than Abraham received
        - Nevertheless, we have what he had
- But eventually, Abraham's understanding of God's plan was fully informed, and at that point his behavior aligned with his faith
    - I think that's one of the reasons we have the story of Abraham sacrificing Isaac in

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Genesis 22

- Had that story never happened, we might still be debating Abraham's faith
- Because after his declaration of righteousness in Genesis 15, his record of obedience wasn't very good
- So we might assume his faith wasn't genuine or we might doubt the Lord's willingness to remain faithful to His promise

- But then we reach the point that Abraham sends Ishmael away and is then ready to sacrifice his other son Isaac, the promised son
  - That moment confirms for us that Abraham was truly trusting in God and not flesh
  - He was willing to put flesh to an end in the form of his son, yet remain confident in God to bring back the dead
  - The writer of Hebrews explains Abraham's thinking in that moment

Heb. 11:17 By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac, and he who had received the promises was offering up his only begotten son;
Heb. 11:18 it was he to whom it was said, "In Isaac your descendants shall be called."
Heb. 11:19 He considered that God is able to raise people even from the dead, from which he also received him back as a type.

- How encouraging for those of us who depend on God's grace yet repeat the same mistakes Abraham made!
  - We can know that our salvation is secure despite our sin
    - And all the more because of our sin
    - As Paul says in v.25 Christ was put to death because we have so much sin
    - Someone needed to cover it, because we simply can't escape it on our own
  - But then Jesus was raised for our justification, that is He was raised from the dead to gives us confidence that our account in Heaven is truly clear
    - When Jesus returned to life, God brought life from that which was dead
    - And He gave us our proof that He can keep His promise to us
    - He has proven death is not a barrier to fear when God is on your side
  - So as we walk by faith, we have our confidence that our faith has cleared our account, and we maintain our faith in that future outcome
    - But like Abraham, we don't know how long the Lord will tarry
    - We don't know the length of our life or the trials we will face
  - Somedays our path in life may depart from the faith in our heart
    - We may try to work the plan ourselves

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        - We may try to find our blessing in the wrong way
        - We may cling to the physical life rather than seeking for spiritual life
        - But none of those things can change that heavenly credit of righteousness
        - They only prove we needed God's grace all the more
- Meanwhile we grow, and as we do, our faith and our behavior are to grow closer together
    - As the Lord reveals more of Himself and His plan to us in His word and by His Spirit, His expectation is that we begin to live in the light of that knowledge
        - Our goal should be to begin our walk of faith like Abraham did
        - And that we should end our life as he did, acting according to that faith
        - As James said:

James 2:20 **But are you willing to recognize, you foolish fellow, that faith without works is useless?**
James 2:21 **Was not Abraham our father justified by works when he offered up Isaac his son on the altar?**
James 2:22 **You see that faith was working with his works, and as a result of the works, faith was perfected;**
James 2:23 **and the Scripture was fulfilled which says, "And Abraham believed God, and it was reckoned to him as righteousness," and he was called the friend of God.**

- Our faith is saving us from the first moment, but is it useful to God?
    - Does it bring Him glory?
    - Does it testify?
    - Abraham's faith was justified or proven when he offered up Isaac on the altar
    - And his faith was finally working to perfect or complete his faith
    - And finally, the scripture that declared Abraham as righteous could be seen to be fulfilled
- That's our goal, that our life would become a testimony to all that we claim to hold true in our hearts

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- We're moving into a new chapter of Romans tonight, Chapter 5
  - This chapter is the third part of Block 4 (as I count it) in the structure of Romans
    - This block in Romans is the core section explaining how we receive the righteousness required to enter heaven
    - How sinful men and women, who fall short of the glory of God, obtain a solution outside ourselves
  - Paul began in Chapter 3 with the explanation of how we obtain the righteousness of God by faith
    - Then he moved to Chapter 4 where he proved from the Old Testament that grace has always been the Lord's plan
    - Salvation was never by works or Jewish identity
- Now as we enter Chapter 5, Paul addresses two possible objections to his explanation of God's plan
  - First, one might ask how can we be sure that we stand cleansed before a Holy God?
    - How do I know that I have the justification that is promised?
    - Since I'm still experiencing hardship and trials in this life, might those things be evidence that God is still dissatisfied with me?
    - Aren't they an indication I am still in jeopardy?
  - Secondly, how can it even be possible for this plan to work?
    - How can a ransom paid by one man, be sufficient to solve the sin problem for millions of people?
    - For example, wouldn't we need one sacrifice for each of us?
    - Can such a sweeping plan of salvation rest on the shoulders of just One?
  - So Paul addresses these two concerns in turn
    - The question of how can I know for sure that I am justified, is answered in vs.1-11
    - Paul gives two answers to this question
    - Then Paul addresses the second question – how can one man's death pay the debt for so many sinners – in the remainder of the chapter

Rom. 5:1 Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,
Rom. 5:2 through whom also we have obtained our introduction by faith into this grace in which we stand; and we exult in hope of the glory of God.
Rom. 5:3 And not only this, but we also exult in our tribulations, knowing that tribulation brings about perseverance;
Rom. 5:4 and perseverance, proven character; and proven character, hope;
Rom. 5:5 and hope does not disappoint, because the love of God has been poured out within our hearts through the Holy Spirit who was given to us.

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- Paul opens with the classic conclusionary word, “therefore”
  - He’s moving forward from his previous analysis and drawing conclusions from it
    - As we move into the text, it’s important to understand that the conversation in this chapter presupposes we understand justification by faith alone
    - These questions arise from the fact that Paul taught faith alone was sufficient to bring us to God, but some think it sounds too easy
    - But such questions never come to mind for the person who thinks they work for salvation
  - Notice in v.1 Paul opens with the presupposition that we are justified by faith alone
    - The Greek verb tense is the aorist tense, which means an action that is complete but the consequences continue forever
    - We have been declared innocent, and that declaration has never changed
    - Nor will it ever change
  - How can we be sure that this declaration never changes? Because Paul says we have peace with God through Jesus Christ
    - This is an important concept in the New Testament, obtaining peace with God
    - The word “peace” appears 58 times in just the Epistles

Eph. 2:14 For He Himself is our peace, who made both groups into one and broke down the barrier of the dividing wall,
Eph. 2:15 by abolishing in His flesh the enmity, which is the Law of commandments contained in ordinances, so that in Himself He might make the two into one new man, thus establishing peace,
Eph. 2:16 and might reconcile them both in one body to God through the cross, by it having put to death the enmity.

- In Ephesians Paul says Jesus Christ is our peace
  - Because in His dying on a cross, He put to death the cause for our enmity with God
    - Paul says that cause for God to be our adversary were the commandments of the Law
    - Those commandments convicted us of our sin
    - They stood as silent witnesses against us, reminding us that we were in trouble with a holy God Who must act in justice
  - But when Jesus died, He took the penalty of the Law for us
    - So that once a penalty was paid, there was no longer cause for enmity
    - God no longer had just reason to be our enemy
- So the Bible’s idea of peace with God means freedom from condemnation under Law
  - It’s the opposite of enmity with God
    - Instead of God being our adversary because of our sin, we now have a peaceful relationship with God

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        - It's the difference between Adam walking with God in the Garden, and Adam being barred from the Garden by angels
    - Our relationship with God doesn't turn on emotion or feelings
        - God is holy and just in all He does
        - Sin sets us against God because we're in jeopardy of His judgment
        - And when the cause for our condemnation is removed, there is no longer jeopardy
- So in v.2 Paul says it's Christ who gave us peace with the Father
    - We obtained peace with God by Christ's death in our place, which is the grace of God by which we stand before Him without condemnation
        - Then at some point, that grace became ours as we were introduced to it by a faith
        - Paul's describing a chain of events
        - First came the payment which made peace with God possible
        - Then secondly came our introduction to that act of grace by our faith in that payment
    - Here we are today, standing by God's grace, exulting or boasting in our hope of seeing the glory of God
        - And we boast of a future hope even as we endure tribulations of one kind or another, Paul says in v.3
        - Our confidence and hope in the face of troubling things in this life is extremely confusing to the unbelieving world
        - They ask questions like how come bad things happen to good people
        - And after disasters, they ask how can there be a loving God?
    - Meanwhile, we boast that we have peace with God and we hope in a glory to come
        - To our own glorification with Him
        - To God's name praised throughout the earth rather than ignored or cursed
        - To Christ ruling over men in perfect justice
        - Ultimately, to a world without sin and free from the curse
    - And even as the world gets worse, we continue to hold to this belief
        - In fact, Paul says in v.3 that further tribulation only serves to cement this attitude among believers looking to the Kingdom
        - It leads to our perseverance in that hope
- What greater proof that we have been changed by our faith and that our standing before God has changed from condemnation to peace?
    - Where before we feared death the way the world does
        - And we feared trials of any kind since we had no assurance of what may come

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after the grave

- But now we can see tribulation without concern since, at worst, it merely hastens our transition to glory

- And as we endure suffering for His name sake, in whatever form, we persevere because of our hope
  - And as we persevere, our perseverance grows our spiritual character, and strengthens our resolve
  - The development of spiritual character through trials is a blessing to the believer, for the character growth is what lasts into eternity
  - A persecuted church is a strong and growing church while a comfortable church is a weak and lethargic church
- Finally, as our character strengthens under trials, we become all the more sure in our hope for God's glory
  - And Paul says in v.5 that our hope will not be disappointed, because it's not without solid foundation
  - Because we have in us proof that we are at peace with God
  - We have the presence of God dwelling in us
  - Clearly, if we were God's enemy He would not set up His temple
  - So as we increase in godly character having persevered in trials, we see the word of the Spirit in our hearts
  - That work is our confirmation that we are at peace with God

- Your changed life, made possible by a hope in God and the presence of the Holy Spirit, is proof #1 that your faith has truly accomplished something real in eternity
  - You have been justified, your salvation is real, your hope will not disappoint
    - Just consider how you have changed since before you knew Christ, to who you are now
    - That's fruit, good fruit
    - And the Bible says that good fruit like that can't come from evil hearts
    - It can only happen when something good lives in you, and only God is good
  - That's our first proof…God is living in us to make His grace known and our hope for what comes grows day by day
    - Even as the unbeliever lives with increasing fear of what lies ahead
    - You exult in God, you feel peace with God

Phillips Brooks, former minister of Boston's Trinity Episcopal Church, is perhaps best known as the author of "O Little Town of Bethlehem." He was a very busy pastor, yet he always seemed relaxed and unburdened, willing to take time for anyone in need. Shortly before Brooks died, a young friend wrote to him and asked the secret of his strength and serenity. In a heartfelt response,

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Brooks credited his still-growing relationship with Christ.

He wrote, "The more I have thought it over, the more sure it has seemed to me that these last years have had a peace and fullness which there did not used to be. It is a deeper knowledge and truer love of Christ…I cannot tell you how personal this grows to me. He is here. He knows me and I know Him. It is the most real thing in the world. And every day makes it more real. And one wonders with delight what it will grow to as the years go on."

- But Paul has a second argument to make in assuring you that your salvation by faith is real

Rom. 5:6 **For while we were still helpless, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.**
Rom. 5:7 **For one will hardly die for a righteous man; though perhaps for the good man someone would dare even to die.**
Rom. 5:8 **But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.**
Rom. 5:9 **Much more then, having now been justified by His blood, we shall be saved from the wrath of God through Him.**
Rom. 5:10 **For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son, much more, having been reconciled, we shall be saved by His life.**
Rom. 5:11 **And not only this, but we also exult in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received the reconciliation.**

- Back in vs.1-2, Paul gave a brief chain of events
  - First came the payment which made peace with God possible
    - Then secondly came our introduction to that act of grace by our faith in that payment
    - This order is important to understanding the argument Paul is about to make to answer the first question
    - Which came first? God's act of grace or our act of faith?
  - Obviously, Christ died before anyone in the church placed faith in that sacrifice
    - In fact, God proclaimed His intention to put His Son to death as early as Genesis 3
    - So the point should be obvious
    - The Lord was working this plan long before we got personally involved
  - More than that, His work on our behalf started when we were helpless and ungodly

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        - Paul says that while we were still helpless, Christ was dying for the ungodly
        - Helpless refers to mankind's prospects for finding salvation
        - Before Christ made the one and only payment God will accept, there was literally no way for us to find God
        - Even the OT saints that died in faith had to stay in Sheol, waiting for the death of Jesus before they could enter the throne room
        - So God was enacting the plan before we were even in a position to act, much less contribute to the process
- Paul compares God's sacrifice for us, to a human being dying for another person to live
    - Generally, we consider this to be the highest act of sacrifice possible
        - There is nothing greater we can give another than our own life
        - And it's so precious to us that we hesitate to give it at all
        - Paul says that it's exceedingly rare for someone to give up their lives for another person
    - And even then we would only consider the possibility for someone good
        - In our world, good means someone we perceive as innocent or undeserving death
        - Like our own children or spouse
        - Or maybe an innocent bystander or fellow comrade in arms
        - We've all seen news reports of these moments and we admire the one who gives the ultimate sacrifice
    - But what would you say if someone suggested you die for an evil person?
        - Would you die to free a murderer from death row?
        - The very thought seems ridiculous
        - Yet that's exactly what Jesus did
        - The ultimate good person gave His life for the ultimate evil people, you and me
    - Paul says that demonstrates how much God loves us
        - So that if you doubt whether your faith is sufficient to ensure your justification, you're thinking about the problem wrong
        - You forgetting all the Lord did before you were ever introduced to His faith by your faith
        - You're suggesting that God would put His own Son to death for you, introduce you to His grace by faith and give you His Spirit…but then the plan fails in the end?
- Paul says in v.9 that if God did so much for you while you were still ungodly and unable to seek salvation, then how much more should we expect the plan to work after we have come to know Him and desire to have His grace?
    - In v.10 Paul asks if while we were doing everything wrong, God reconciled us to

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Himself by Christ's death, then how much more shall we be saved by His life

- This logical argument is a source of great confidence for any Christian burdened by worries about sin and security
- How can you worry about the certainty of God's promises to you when He put His Son to death for you?
- If you had any reason to think the plan wasn't going to work, then how do you explain Christ's death?

- Imagine two soldiers are at war on opposing sides, when suddenly one of the soldiers acts at great personal risk to save the life of his enemy
  - The one soldier proved his love for the other by risking his life for his enemy
  - After the war is over, the two men decide to meet in a local cafe
  - When they meet, they strike up a friendship made possible by that noble act
- But then imagine that as they leave the table, the soldier who had been saved turns to his rescuer and says I'm sorry but we can't meet again
  - And when his friend asks why, the soldier says I just can't trust you. I'm afraid you will pull a gun and shoot men when I least expect it
  - The other soldier is shocked and asks, if I was willing to rescue you when you were my enemy, why would I kill you now that you're my friend?
  - That's like us wondering if our justification by faith in Christ is a certainty
  - If God was willing to reconcile us when we were farthest from Him, then we have nothing to fear now that we are close to Him

- Which leads us to the second question of the chapter: how can one man's death accomplish so much for so many? Exactly how does this work?

Rom. 5:12 Therefore, just as through one man sin entered into the world, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men, because all sinned —
Rom. 5:13 for until the Law sin was in the world, but sin is not imputed when there is no law.
Rom. 5:14 Nevertheless death reigned from Adam until Moses, even over those who had not sinned in the likeness of the offense of Adam, who is a type of Him who was to come.

- To explain how God is working through Christ to free us from condemnation, Paul takes us back to where our condemnation started: in Adam
  - Paul is going to examine the start of our sin problem in Adam and then compare how Adam brought us down, to the way Christ lifts us up
    - In this comparison, Paul will refer to "one man" who is obviously Adam
    - Later Paul will refer to another Man, Christ
  - The point is for us to understand how the solution draws from the problem

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        - That what we're trusting in is based in what happened in Adam, so that if it was true with Adam, it can be true in Christ
        - In other words, we can see the effect how Adam (one man) changed all humanity for the worse
        - Therefore, we can also understand how another Man can change humanity for the better
    - Each man – Adam and Christ – acts as the federal representative of a group of people
        - A federal representative means someone who rules or makes decisions on behalf of a group they represent
        - All democracies work in this way, with elected officials representing groups of constituents
        - Their actions carry consequences for their respective representatives
        - We accept the notion that an elected official may make a decision on behalf of a group
- So it works also with humanity in a spiritual sense
    - In v.12 Paul says that through Adam sin entered the world
        - That when Adam ate the fruit he disobeyed the word of God
        - Before that moment, God proclaimed that if Adam disobeyed he would surely die

Gen. 2:16 **The Lord God commanded the man, saying, "From any tree of the garden you may eat freely;**
Gen. 2:17 **but from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat from it you will surely die."**

- After Adam disobeyed and ate, he still lived over 900 years
    - Since Adam didn't physically die on the day he ate, then we know the death God threatened was not a physical death
    - It was a spiritual death, which is the Bible's terminology for the arrival of a sinful corrupt nature in Adam
- So as Adam disobeyed God, he changed spiritually
    - He became dead spiritually, and in that sense he died on that very day
    - The power for that change was the word of God itself, since it was the decree of God that Adam would experience spiritual death
- Furthermore, the Lord responded to Adam's sin by cursing the earth, that is the ground and all that came from the ground

Gen. 3:17 **Then to Adam He said, "Because you have listened to the voice of your**

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wife, and have eaten from the tree about which I commanded you, saying, 'You shall not eat from it';
Cursed is the ground because of you;
In toil you will eat of it
All the days of your life.
Gen. 3:18 **"Both thorns and thistles it shall grow for you;**
And you will eat the plants of the field;
Gen. 3:19 **By the sweat of your face**
You will eat bread,
Till you return to the ground,
Because from it you were taken;
For you are dust,
And to dust you shall return."

- Since Adam's body was made from the dirt (*Adam* means earth in Hebrew), then God was cursing Adam's body to die one day
  - So Adam's choice brought sin into existence, which brought spiritual death to all humanity
  - And it lead indirectly to physical death for all humanity
- And Paul says this "spread" to all men
  - Spread is *dierchomal* – to go through, pass through
  - Death was passed through Adam to his descendants
- The change in Adam's spiritual nature became part of him, inseparable from his physical existence
  - So that as Adam reproduced, he passed this fallen sinful nature down to his children
  - All humanity has been born in the nature of their father, Adam
  - And therefore all suffer death as well, since death is the result of sin
- Therefore, God doesn't individually assess each descendant of Adam
  - God doesn't determine if each individual descendant of Adam has his or her own sin
    - And then pronounce the same sentence against that person
    - Death, the penalty of sin, spread (passed from) one person to the next because all sinned
  - But remember death happens at all ages, even at childbirth
    - So if all die, it means all are sinful immediately right from birth
    - There is no magical age when we suddenly become accountable for our sin
    - We are accountable from birth which is evidenced in the fact that people die at all ages
  - Paul says in v.13 that this principle held true in the world even before the Law came

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to Israel

- He says sin was not imputed without Law
- He means that no one could say definitively what was sin before God defined it for mankind in His law
- And yet sin existed, and this we know because men died

- Something was passed from Adam to all his descendants that results in 100% of his descendants sharing in his penalty
  - This is the meaning of original sin
  - Men inherit a nature from our parents that drives us to sin
  - We call ourselves sinners because at some point in our life we begin to act in sin
  - But we are born sinners, even before we have the capacity to act it out
  - But it doesn't take long, since two-year olds are nothing but blatant sinners

- So Paul says in v.14 that death reigned from Adam to Moses even though the Law was around to convict and define the nature of sin
  - Death held people accountable for sin even though they hadn't made the same mistake Adam made
    - Even the best person on earth was still dying
    - That proves that sin was something received through a birth process and not dependent on each person's choices or actions
    - Their choices and actions were the result of that inherited nature
  - That's how you must understand the life of every unbeliever
    - They are programmed to offend God
    - That programming came from Adam, but they agree with it in their hearts
    - It's all they know
    - And they are incapable of changing the programming on their own
  - So one man's decision created a chain reaction through the reproduction process that led to all men sharing his nature
    - And if this process can work to lead mankind into condemnation then it can be harnessed to provide a solution
    - One man can reverse the process and provide a solution to a new group of descendants
- Before we look further in Paul's argument, we need to pause here for a moment to appreciate an important implication of this truth
  - Paul's statement in v.12 stands at odds with the teaching of Evolution
    - The theory of evolution maintains that mankind evolved from lower order creatures over millions of years
    - Before the first human existed, many other living beings existed

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        - These creatures lived and died over millions of years, growing in complexity and evolving into more sophisticated species
    - The engine for this change is natural selection, a set of forces that lead to the survival of the fittest and the elimination of the weak
        - The idea says that natural selection forces the advancement of life
        - The weak die out, and the strong reproduce
    - There are many problems with this idea, but one theological issue stands out
        - The Bible says death didn't exist until after human beings existed
        - Not just human death…but all death
        - Because in Genesis 3 the arrival of physical death came as a result of God's curses, which He spoke as a result of Adam's actions
    - So evolution says death came before mankind evolved from apes, while the Bible says death came after mankind as a result of Adam's sin
        - If evolution is correct and the Bible is wrong, then not only is Genesis wrong but so is Romans
        - We're no longer arguing simply over which story of origins is accurate
        - We're also arguing over the cause of death
        - And if the cause of death is in doubt, then the meaning of Christ's death is equally in doubt
    - And if death is natural and not the result of sin, we have no reason to trust in the death of Christ on our behalf
        - To what good purpose could Christ's death be for us, if death is not a result of sin?
        - Because the Gospel says that death can only be stopped by sinlessness
        - But evolution says that death has no relationship to sin or sinlessness
        - In which case, Christ's sinless life and sacrificial death simply don't have meaning in a search for the problem of death
- So now Paul explains how Christ can solve this problem for the world, though He is but one man

Rom. 5:15 But the free gift is not like the transgression. For if by the transgression of the one the many died, much more did the grace of God and the gift by the grace of the one Man, Jesus Christ, abound to the many.
Rom. 5:16 The gift is not like that which came through the one who sinned; for on the one hand the judgment arose from one transgression resulting in condemnation, but on the other hand the free gift arose from many transgressions resulting in justification.
Rom. 5:17 For if by the transgression of the one, death reigned through the one, much more those who receive the abundance of grace and of the gift of

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righteousness will reign in life through the One, Jesus Christ.

- Paul compares what Christ does for mankind to what Adam did
  - He starts saying that the free gift of salvation through Christ is not like the transgression we experience through Adam
    - He means it's like the first in the sense that it works in an opposite way, though according to a similar principle
    - By Adam's life and death, many died with him
    - But by the life and death of Christ, by God's grace, many will have eternal life
  - These two men had an opposite effect on humanity
    - One produced judgment from a single transgression resulting in condemnation for all
    - But the free gift of salvation covered man transgressions resulting in our justification
  - In v.17, Paul says if we can accept that one man could bring the world into bondage and under the penalty of eternal death
    - Then we should accept that one Man could deliver eternal life to many
    - The mechanism that makes this possible is the same: inheritance
  - In Adam, we all inherit a sinful nature and a dying body
    - And in Christ, we are born again
    - We are literally reformed spiritually in the likeness of our new Adam
    - We now receive Christ's nature in place of Adam's
  - So if one man's nature could be spread to all his descendants by physical birth, then Christ's perfect nature can be spread to all His descendants by spiritual rebirth
    - The Holy Spirit birthed Christ in Mary's womb
    - And likewise the Holy Spirit births us again spiritually when we believe
- In fact, our manner of entering into God's grace is also a direct reversal of Adam's actions
  - Adam's mistake in the Garden was to reject God's word, to fail to believe in what God promised concerning the fruit
    - There was a promise
    - The content of the promise was consequences of eating the fruit
    - The object of the promise was God's faithfulness
  - Adam heard the promise and then acted in a way that repudiated faith in God's promise
    - He acted without faith in God to keep His word
    - So a lack of faith brought about the Fall and sin and death

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- So God devised His plan of redemption to reverse that error in the experience of every born again believer
  - Every believer must place his or her trust in God's promises concerning Christ
  - We must believe a promise and place our trust in God's faithfulness to His word
  - When we do, we reverse Adam's mistake and then we are born again in the line of Christ

Rom. 5:18 So then as through one transgression there resulted condemnation to all men, even so through one act of righteousness there resulted justification of life to all men.
Rom. 5:19 For as through the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, even so through the obedience of the One the many will be made righteous.
Rom. 5:20 The Law came in so that the transgression would increase; but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more,
Rom. 5:21 so that, as sin reigned in death, even so grace would reign through righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

- So now one act of sin is reversed by one act of righteousness
  - One act drove mankind away from the Father, and by one act we are brought back to the Father
    - One man's mistake made many sinners
    - One man's obedience made many into the righteous
  - The Law never corrected this problem, because it wasn't even capable of doing so
    - By the time you tell someone about the Law, they have already sinned a million times over
    - They were born that way, they can't help it
    - And the Law only serves to highlight all that sin, not to stop it, not entirely
  - So in that sense Paul says in v.20 that the Law's arrival only served to "increase" sin by making it more evident
    - But then that only serves to magnify God's grace in Christ
    - The more you realize how much you offended God in your sin, the more amazing grace is to you
    - Like Jesus said to the Pharisee

Luke 7:47 "For this reason I say to you, her sins, which are many, have been forgiven, for she loved much; but he who is forgiven little, loves little."

- Paul ends in v.21 making the ultimate comparison between these two federal

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representatives

- Sin is reigning over the unsaved of the earth
- It is their master and they live under its power to condemn them

- Meanwhile, grace reigns in the life of the believer to bring righteousness and eternal life through Jesus Christ
  - We are not under a curse of death
  - Nor does death master us, since we will live again without condemnation

"Adam came from the earth, but Jesus is the Lord from heaven (1 Cor. 15:47). Adam was tested in a Garden, surrounded by beauty and love; Jesus was tempted in a wilderness, and He died on a cruel cross surrounded by hatred and ugliness. Adam was a thief, and was cast out of Paradise; but Jesus Christ turned to a thief and said, 'Today shalt thou be with Me in Paradise' (Luke 23:43). The Old Testament is 'the book of the generations of Adam' (Gen. 5:1) and it ends with 'a curse' (Mal. 4:6). The New Testament is 'The book of the generation of Jesus Christ' (Matt. 1:1) and it ends with 'no more curse' (Rev. 22:3)."

- So everything Adam did, Jesus reverses

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- It's time to begin the next section of our Romans study
  - In this section, Paul explores the ramifications of being saved by being declared justified, yet still living in a sinful body
    - Paul is wading into topics that dominate the concerns of every Christian
    - These topics arise out of the unique situation we all find ourselves in after coming to faith in Jesus and obtaining our salvation
    - We are justified before God, but yet remain sinful in our flesh
    - We have a new life in Christ but still feel drawn back into our old life of sin
  - And therefore, believers are likely to raise several concerns or questions about the consequences of our salvation
    - What should life look like for the one saved by faith and not by works?
    - If suddenly we're declared justified by a faith in God's promises and not by good works, then do our behaviors matter at all?
    - And if we are truly saved, why do I still have a desire to sin?
    - Shouldn't I be completely free of evil if I've been given God's righteousness by faith?
  - Finally, if I'm declared justified by my faith in an instant, and yet I go on sinning thereafter, might my relationship with God change?
    - Could this salvation I obtained merely by faith be undone by my actions or those of someone else?
    - Or could I reverse the process in some way and end up perishing in the end?
- Paul now moves to addressing these questions in three chapters that comprise our fifth block in the book
  - These three chapters are the consequences of our salvation by faith:
    - The consequences for our spirit
    - The consequences for our flesh
    - And the security of God's righteousness, or we could say the consequences for eternity
  - Each of these three parts is found in its own chapter
    - Chapter 6 is the consequences for our spirit
    - Chapter 7 is the consequences for our flesh
    - And Chapter 8 is the security of God's righteousness
- Today we consider the first, the consequences for our spirit

Rom. 6:1 What shall we say then? Are we to continue in sin so that grace may increase?
Rom. 6:2 May it never be! How shall we who died to sin still live in it?
Rom. 6:3 Or do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ

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Jesus have been baptized into His death?
Rom. 6:4 Therefore we have been buried with Him through baptism into death, so that as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, so we too might walk in newness of life.
Rom. 6:5 For if we have become united with Him in the likeness of His death, certainly we shall also be in the likeness of His resurrection,

- Paul begins the new section with his favorite rhetorical device…asking what shall we say then?
  - We could rephrase his question to be "what do we conclude from this", referring to what Paul taught in the prior chapter
    - In Chapter 5, Paul taught that we received mercy from a God who acted for us before we even knew Him
    - And God's act of mercy in Christ had the power to reverse the mistake that Adam made in placing all humanity in bondage to sin
  - So what do we conclude from this truth?
    - One of the possible answers to that question might be that our justification gives us license to sin as much as we want
    - And that if we continue to sin as we prefer, we are actually multiplying the amount of grace God is required to extend
    - Since God's plan of redemption in Christ reflects glory upon Himself, then we are furthering God's purposes when we give Him greater opportunity to cover our sin
    - The more we sin, the more God can be seen to be loving and merciful by extending us grace
- That's the first question Paul mentions at the end of verse 1
  - Are we to continue in sin so that God's grace must increase to cover that sin?
    - Paul says no, that's not the correct response to God's grace
    - At this point, what reason could Paul give for fighting against sin?
    - He can't tell us that we should fight against sin because our righteousness depends upon it
    - Because our righteousness doesn't depend on what we do, otherwise that would be salvation by works
    - By faith alone in Christ, we are already 100% righteous before God
  - So what does Paul say to this comment?
    - He says we have died to sin, so we may not live in sin
    - Right away we reach the core idea of this chapter, the main point of teaching on the consequences of salvation for our spirit
    - Our old spirit was put to death with Christ and so it has ceased to exist

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    - Paul uses the concept of baptism to explain what happened when we were saved by our faith in Jesus Christ
        - And to understand this comparison properly, we first need to understand the term baptism properly
        - The word baptism means a washing, and there are two baptisms described in the New Testament
        - One is spiritual, one is physical
        - One God does, one we do
        - One produces a death and rebirth, the other pictures a death and rebirth
- The first baptism the Bible describes is spirit baptism or the baptism of the Holy Spirit
    - This is a baptism of spirit in the sense that a person is immersed by the Spirit of God
        - The Spirit of God comes to live inside a person, so in that sense the person is completely immersed by the Spirit
        - The baptism of the Spirit is the moment we are born again, as Jesus said to Nicodemus

John 3:3 **Jesus answered and said to him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God."**
John 3:4 **Nicodemus said to Him, "How can a man be born when he is old? He cannot enter a second time into his mother's womb and be born, can he?"**
John 3:5 **Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.**
John 3:6 **"That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.**

- This is the moment of our salvation, the moment faith comes and we are born again
- At the moment of our spiritual baptism, something dies and something is brought to life
    - First, our old spirit is put to death
    - The spirit we inherited from Adam, the spirit that was fallen, ceases to exist
    - In its place, we receive Christ's spirit, that is we receive a spirit that has descended from Christ
    - Literally, we have been born again spiritually, and the new spirit living in us traces its genealogy to Christ
- Paul says it this way elsewhere

2Cor. 5:17 **Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creature; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come.**

- When Paul mentioned "new creature" and "old things" he's speaking about the spirit

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- We are literally something entirely new spiritually than we were
- Obviously, God does this work, because we couldn't do it to ourselves
  - We were dead in our sins, and a dead spirit cannot raise itself
  - As we learned in Romans 3, no one seeks for God
- Following this moment, we are called by Christ to take part in a second baptism, one we perform ourselves by entering a body of water
  - Our second baptism is a physical act, not a spiritual act
    - It's a physical baptism with water that pictures our earlier spiritual baptism act
    - We do it in obedience to Christ's word as a result of being saved
  - Water baptism pictures the dying of our old spirit and the coming to life of our new spirit
    - The water pictures a grave in the earth
    - So when we go down into the water, we are picturing our old spirit dying with Christ
    - And when we emerge from the water, we are picturing our spirit coming to life as Christ was resurrected
    - Obviously, the intended meaning of water baptism requires that the baptism be done through immersion, not sprinkling
  - Paul refers to this picture in vs.3-4 when he says we were baptized into Christ's death
    - Spiritually speaking, our old spirit was buried with Christ
    - When Jesus died on the cross, He was taking God's wrath for the sin of that old spirit
    - So spiritually speaking, Christ was acting in our place dying as our sinful spirit deserved to do
    - By our faith in Christ, the Father counts Christ's death in our place
  - But then Paul adds that just as the Father raised Jesus from the dead, He has also raised us into a new life in the spirit
    - So by our faith in Christ, we are given Christ's raised spirit
    - In v.5 Paul says we have become united with Christ in the likeness of His death and in the likeness of His resurrection
  - The term likeness reflects that we shared in those events spiritually, not physically
    - Obviously, you and I weren't in Jerusalem 2,000 years ago when Jesus was crucified and resurrected
    - But spiritually we relived those moments when we were born again
- So the consequences for our spirit of salvation by faith in Christ is profound
  - By the baptism of the Spirit, we became a new person spiritually, and our new person shares in the nature of Christ

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        - As much as you were like Adam before you came to faith, you are now just as much like Christ now
        - Your spirit is every bit as perfect and sinless as Jesus' spirit is
        - It's the same spirit, one came from the other
    - Every believer has a perfect, sinless spirit given to him or her by the Holy Spirit
        - If you ever wondered what Jesus Christ must have felt and thought as He walked the earth, you need not worry
        - You have His spirit now, so you possess the same source for your thoughts and feelings
        - The overused adage of "what would Jesus do?" suggests that we have to imagine or guess what Jesus might have done
    - In reality, you already know…but are you paying attention?
        - Though we have a perfect sinless spirit now, we obviously don't act sinlessly
        - The reason we still sin is not because our spirit is flawed
        - It's because we still have a source of sin apart from our spirit
        - That source is our physical body
- Notice what Paul says in vs.6-11

Rom. 6:6 knowing this, that our old self was crucified with Him, in order that our body of sin might be done away with, so that we would no longer be slaves to sin;
Rom. 6:7 for he who has died is freed from sin.

- Paul says our old self (i.e., our old spirit) was put to death through Christ's death so that our body might be done away with too
    - Our sinful spirit was due condemnation, and the day of our judgment by God is the day that our body dies, as Hebrews says

Heb. 9:27 And inasmuch as it is appointed for men to die once and after this comes judgment,

- So had our body died before we came to faith and our spirit was born again, then our sinful spirit would have been judged by God
- It would have received the justice it deserved in eternity, which is the second death – eternal separation from God
- But because of His love and mercy for us, God acted in Christ to put our sinful spirit to death before our body died
    - Our sinful spirit was condemned in Christ when He died in our place on the cross

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- And at the moment of faith, we experienced the baptism of the Holy Spirit
- Our sinful spirit was replaced with a new spirit made in Christ's likeness

- So now when our body eventually dies, our spirit will already be sin-free and without condemnation, so no judgment will follow
  - That's what Paul means in v.6 when he says that our old spirit was put to death so that our body could be done away with
  - Our spirit is the eternal part of us, so by replacing our spirit before our body died, God did away with the penalty of death
  - Now the death of our body is of no concern to us, because our spirit is already right with God
  - Our spirit, our true identity, has already been perfected
- So in a future day, the Lord will put our body to death too, so that we will no longer be slaves to sin Paul says
  - In that future day the part of us that continues to sin, that is our fallen body, will also be taken away
  - Like our old spirit, it will be put to death
  - And when it dies, we will truly be freed from sin
- In the meantime, our spirit has been freed from sin while our body continues to be enslaved to sin
  - And this in-between state of existence requires we adopt a new attitude and perspective

Rom. 6:8 **Now if we have died with Christ, we believe that we shall also live with Him,**
Rom. 6:9 **knowing that Christ, having been raised from the dead, is never to die again; death no longer is master over Him.**
Rom. 6:10 **For the death that He died, He died to sin once for all; but the life that He lives, He lives to God.**
Rom. 6:11 **Even so consider yourselves to be dead to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus.**

- Notice in this passage Paul says "we" have died with Christ
  - We know our spirit has died with Christ but our body has yet to die
    - Therefore, the "we" here must refer to the spirit in us, not to our physical death
    - Therefore, we need to read v.8 this way:
    - "Now if our spirit died with Christ, we believe that our body will live with Him too"
  - Jesus saw His spirit condemned on the cross and His body died as well
    - Then His body was raised from the dead never to die again

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        - Therefore, Paul says, death is no longer a master over Him
        - Christ no longer lives with the concern of a future death, no worry, no weight of that burden
        - In v.10 Paul says Christ's death was a selfless act in service to all of us who needed that payment
        - But having put death behind Him, now Christ's sole purpose in life is to serve God
- Then in v.11 Paul gets to his point…our faith in Jesus means that our spiritual life will follow in Jesus' footsteps
    - Just as Christ died on the cross, our spirit was put to death when we believed
        - And just as His body was resurrected, so will our body one day be raised new
        - And just as death ceased being a master over Christ, death is no longer a concern for us either
    - Therefore, just as Christ could live solely to serve God, likewise we must adopt that attitude as well, Paul says
        - We must consider ourselves to be dead to sin also
        - To consider means to think in this way
        - We must consider who we are
    - When we speak of ourselves, we are speaking about the spirit, not the body
        - You are not your body, because that body is going to die one day, but scripture says "you" never die
        - Furthermore, your spirit is perfect and sinless, like Christ, so "you" never sin in the spirit
        - But you do sin, of course, so the sin you commit is not of "you"
        - Your sin originates in that which is destined to die, that which is not you, that is your body
    - Therefore, since concerns of death are behind us, we should consider our life to be lived in service to God hereafter
        - As the great philosopher, Bob Dylan, once said…
        - "You gotta serve somebody"
        - You could spend your new life serving useless causes like trying to earn your righteousness (i.e., doing good works)
        - Or serving the devil out of fear of death, as Hebrew says

Heb. 2:14 **Therefore, since the children share in flesh and blood, He Himself likewise also partook of the same, that through death He might render powerless him who had the power of death, that is, the devil,**
Heb. 2:15 **and might free those who through fear of death were subject to slavery all their lives.**

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- Obviously, Christians don't need to work for salvation nor live in fear of the devil
  - But regrettably, many Christians still choose to live for another purpose rather than serving God
  - They live to serve their own dying body

Rom. 6:12 Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body so that you obey its lusts,
Rom. 6:13 and do not go on presenting the members of your body to sin as instruments of unrighteousness; but present yourselves to God as those alive from the dead, and your members as instruments of righteousness to God.
Rom. 6:14 For sin shall not be master over you, for you are not under law but under grace.

- Paul says we should not allow the sin in our dying body to rule over our perfect, eternal, sinless spirit
  - When we let it decide our choices, we are obey its lusts
    - This is completely backward to the reality of who we are in Christ
    - We're letting that part of us that is going to die control that part of us that is going to live forever
    - We're letting the part that is not us control us
  - We are presenting the members of our body to sin, Paul says, but present ourselves to God and our members as instruments for righteousness
    - To understand what Paul is saying, we need to understand terms he is using
    - When Paul uses the second person pronoun, he is referring to our eternal sinless spirit
    - When Paul uses the term sin, he is describing the sinful nature of our physical body
    - And when he says the "members" of our body, he's describing our life of service in the body
  - So the choices we have that Paul is describing is this:
    - Either we (our spirit) presents (or dedicates) our life in this body to serving our sin nature leading to unrighteousness
    - Or we (our spirit) presents (or dedicates) our life in this body to serving God leading to righteousness
    - You serve either God or you serve your own body
    - Your sinful body will always lead you to sinful choices
    - God will always lead you to righteous outcomes
- Sin (your sinful body) is no longer master over you, you are no longer under Law but under grace

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- Here again, these terms need defining
  - Sin refers to your sinful body,
  - "You" refers to the part of you that is eternal, your new perfect, sinless spirit
  - Law refers to the condemnation that sin deserves under God's law
  - Grace refers to the salvation we have in the New Covenant, made possible by Christ's death in our place
- So Paul is saying that we are to follow in Christ's footsteps in this too
  - Christ died according to the requirements of the Law, though He Himself never violated the Law
  - In dying He paid our penalty in His body, so we are no longer under that penalty
  - So the Law no longer condemns us, it no longer rules us by dictating what we must do to be righteous
  - So now having been saved by grace, we are free to live for God and not for our own sake

- Some in Paul's day probably heard that they were no longer under law and would have been aghast at the thought
  - They react much as some Christians still do today when we say that the Christian is not bound by the Law, not even by the ten commandments
    - They say how can this be…
    - Are you suggesting it's OK for me to lie, or steal, or murder???
    - Of course, they ask the question to mock the idea that we are no longer bound to the law
  - Paul asks the question in that same spirit as if to mock his own suggestion

Rom. 6:15 What then? Shall we sin because we are not under law but under grace? May it never be!
Rom. 6:16 Do you not know that when you present yourselves to someone as slaves for obedience, you are slaves of the one whom you obey, either of sin resulting in death, or of obedience resulting in righteousness?
Rom. 6:17 But thanks be to God that though you were slaves of sin, you became obedient from the heart to that form of teaching to which you were committed,
Rom. 6:18 and having been freed from sin, you became slaves of righteousness.

- Are we now allowed to sin all we want since we're no longer under the law?
- Since our spirit is now without condemnation, can we do whatever we please?
- Paul says the same things I say to those who ask me that same mocking question…of course not!
  - We have presented ourselves to Christ as His slave, indebted to Him for the ransom He paid for us with His blood

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- Since He bought us, we are now His slaves, so we must present ourselves to Him, obeying His desires
- Since Christ is inside each of us, His Spirit living in us, then we must obey that perfect sinless spirit
- If we are to be good slaves, we must obey that Master Who bought us
- Just as we once were slaves to our sinful nature and obeyed it without question

- That should be your goal in life…to obey your new master, your sinless spirit, as consistently as you once obeyed your previous master, your sinful spirit
  - Before you came to faith, you were a perfectly obedient slave
    - You did everything your master wanted you to do
    - The problem is, that master was evil and everything it required was unrighteous
  - Now you have a perfect, sinless spirit inside you, one that is Christ's spirit, and it only directs you into righteousness
    - Paul says thanks to God that He has made you obedient from the heart, to the teaching to which you were committed
    - To a form of teaching
  - This form or pattern of teaching that directs us now is very different than the law men previously followed
    - The previous pattern of teaching men followed was one written on stone, speaking of the Law
    - But it only brought condemnation and had no power to break the master that ruled over men's hearts, which was sin itself
  - But the Greek word for form is *tupos*, which means die or stamp
    - There was something stamped or impressed on our hearts that compelled our obedience and formed our commitment
    - It was the gospel of grace that now rules us from our hearts
    - And we have become 100% obedient to the new law written on our hearts, it is our new master
    - Where before you were a slave to sin, you have been freed
    - Now, you are a slave to righteousness
- So we were entrapped by sin and a slave to it until God freed us by making us obey the call of the Gospel
  - And that, Paul says, made a slave to righteousness in our spirit
    - Now the question is whether you will obey that spirit with equal conviction
    - Where before you only had one voice directing you, now you have two
    - You have the voice of the spirit and the old voice of your flesh
  - Which one will you obey?
    - In human terms, we sense we have good days and bad days

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        - We feel as though we are doing well at times and then at other times we feel as though we are losing ground
        - In reality, the spirit in us remains 100% sinless, while our body remains 100% sinful
    - But the intersection of these two brings opportunity for a battle, and in that battle one side will be strengthened and one side will be weakened
        - So in human terms, we feel the waxing and waning of our sanctification
        - Paul speaks of this feeling next:

Rom. 6:19 I am speaking in human terms because of the weakness of your flesh. For just as you presented your members as slaves to impurity and to lawlessness, resulting in further lawlessness, so now present your members as slaves to righteousness, resulting in sanctification.
Rom. 6:20 For when you were slaves of sin, you were free in regard to righteousness.
Rom. 6:21 Therefore what benefit were you then deriving from the things of which you are now ashamed? For the outcome of those things is death.
Rom. 6:22 But now having been freed from sin and enslaved to God, you derive your benefit, resulting in sanctification, and the outcome, eternal life.
Rom. 6:23 For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

- The weakness of our flesh refers to our inability to perfectly discipline the lusts of our flesh
    - We are imperfect in containing our lusts, because we are spiritually weak, like a muscle that hasn't been exercised enough
        - Before we came to faith, we spent our entire existence presenting ourselves as slaves to our sin nature
        - We were slaves to impurity and lawlessness
    - Now at this point, we can continue down that path by remaining weak, or we can consciously choose to serve our spirit
        - That will involve a struggle
        - It will require we begin to act in new and different ways
        - It means going against a lifetime of training in unrighteousness
    - This is a simple application of the rule of slavery
        - You can't be slave to two masters

Matt. 6:24 "No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to one and despise the other. You cannot serve

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God and wealth.

- Billy Graham told a story about a man going to a dog fight, and it was revealed that whichever dog the owner fed, that was the dog he bet on to win
- It's a good analogy here – the winner is the side we feed
  - We either feed the spirit through the disciplines which grow us spiritually eg. Bible study, prayer, fellowship
  - Or we indulge in the lusts of the flesh
- Paul says, but now having been freed from that slavery, you have an opportunity
  - You can derive a benefit from acting according to your new master
    - Your old master demanded a behavior that led to death
    - Your new master demands behavior that leads to sanctification, eternal life, glory
    - Which one is the better master to serve, then?
  - Paul ends with one of the most powerful verses in all the Bible
    - For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life
    - This is a summing principle for the entire chapter
  - When we obey the master of sin, we disobey the master who saved us
  - You don't fight sin by stopping your sinning, you fight sin by strengthening your spirit
    - Fasting is a good way to discipline the flesh and strengthen the spirit
  - We have a perfect spirit waiting to take us away from sin – let us listen to Him instead of our body

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- Moving ahead in our section exploring the ramifications of salvation by faith
  - Last week we studied the implications of our salvation for our spirit
    - We learned that our spirit has been made new in Christ
    - We now share His perfect spirit
    - And we have the Holy Spirit indwelling us
  - So as we live today, we are alive in Christ, spiritually new and forever changed
    - There are still many more profound consequences of having been born again spiritually
    - Paul is moving to explain those consequences in the coming chapters
  - Today, Paul covers two of these consequences
    - First, Paul looks at the consequences for our relationship to the Law God gave to Israel
    - Secondly, Paul looks at the consequences for our relationship with our own flesh
    - And as it turns out, these two ideas – the law and our flesh – are closely related
- Let's start with our first topic, which runs from vv.1-6

Rom. 7:1 Or do you not know, brethren (for I am speaking to those who know the law), that the law has jurisdiction over a person as long as he lives?
Rom. 7:2 For the married woman is bound by law to her husband while he is living; but if her husband dies, she is released from the law concerning the husband.
Rom. 7:3 So then, if while her husband is living she is joined to another man, she shall be called an adulteress; but if her husband dies, she is free from the law, so that she is not an adulteress though she is joined to another man.
Rom. 7:4 Therefore, my brethren, you also were made to die to the Law through the body of Christ, so that you might be joined to another, to Him who was raised from the dead, in order that we might bear fruit for God.
Rom. 7:5 For while we were in the flesh, the sinful passions, which were aroused by the Law, were at work in the members of our body to bear fruit for death.
Rom. 7:6 But now we have been released from the Law, having died to that by which we were bound, so that we serve in newness of the Spirit and not in oldness of the letter.

- The opening of the chapter begins with a conjunction (or) so we know we're dropping into the middle of a thought that began at the end of Chapter 6
  - That chapter ended with Paul saying

Rom. 6:22 But now having been freed from sin and enslaved to God, you derive

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your benefit, resulting in sanctification, and the outcome, eternal life.
Rom. 6:23 **For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.**

- **Paul was contrasting two forms of bondage**

- First, there was our previous bondage to sin
- We were born in the nature of Adam and that nature was fallen, sinful and incapable of acting contrary to its nature
- So in that sense we were in bondage to sin prior to coming to faith
  - We could compare it to someone born with a physical birth defect, like blindness
  - We might say such a person is in bondage to blindness, because they cannot escape its grip
  - Similarly, we are born with a spiritual defect, a fallen spirit
  - And we are all in bondage to sin because we cannot escape its grip on us
- But when we were born again by the Spirit of God, our old enslaved spirit was taken away and we were enslaved to God, Paul says
  - The Lord gave us a new spirit and He placed His own Spirit in us
    - Our new spirit is formed in the likeness of Christ and shares His perfect nature
    - And the Holy Spirit living in us assures us that what God has begun in us He will complete one day, bringing us a new body
  - Now as a result we're enslaved to God, Paul says
    - He means we're enslaved in the same sense as we were previously
    - Today by faith we have a perfect sinless spirit, and like Christ it cannot sin
    - Furthermore, the Holy Spirit living in us will not leave us nor forsake us
  - So we cannot escape these any more than we could our earlier condition
    - These things are not a product of the will
    - Before you came to faith, you didn't choose to be a sinner…it's all you knew how to do
    - And you didn't choose to receive Christ's Spirit…it was given to you by God resulting in your sanctification and eternal life, Paul says
- So to explain how this changes our relationship with the Law, Paul begins with an analogy in Chapter 7
  - He introduces that analogy by saying or do you not know…
    - We could say it this way: "As you already know…"
    - And notice he says he's speaking specifically to the Jewish believers in Rome
    - This first consequence is unique to Jewish believers, because only Jews were

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under the Law given to Moses

- Paul says that the Law has jurisdiction over a Jewish person as long as he lives
  - The concept is simple to understand for a Jew
  - The law God gave to Israel came as part of a covenant, the Mosaic Covenant
  - Obviously, only those who were party to that covenant were bound to follow its Law
- You could compare it to a man or woman enlisting in the military
  - As a recruit enlists, he or she enters into a contract with the government
  - And the recruit then becomes subject to military laws and regulations
  - Only someone who has enlisted is bound to follow these laws
  - And when the enlistment contract expires, the person is freed from that law
- Similarly, when Israel entered into the Old Covenant at Mt. Sinai, they obligated themselves and future generations of Israel to follow the Law
  - But in the case of a covenant, the terms are binding until death
  - There is no expiration or cancellation with a covenant, because all covenants are for life
  - So in order for a covenant to end, a death is required

- And Paul is explaining this principle using the example of a covenant of marriage
  - In v.2 Paul says that if while a woman's husband is living she is joined to another man (i.e., remarries), then she shall be called an adulteress
    - A marriage is a covenant, and like all covenants, it can only be broken by death
    - Nothing else ends a covenant
    - So if while a spouse is living we marry another, we are committing adultery
    - That's why Jesus said this, in speaking of marriage and divorce:

Luke 16:18 **"Everyone who divorces his wife and marries another commits adultery, and he who marries one who is divorced from a husband commits adultery.**

- But Paul goes on to say that if a husband dies, the woman is free to remarry
  - His death has ended their covenant and makes possible a new covenant without adultery
  - This is why marriage ceremonies still include the declaration that what God has joined no one may separate
  - Society may prescribe legal ways to dissolve a marriage but God doesn't submit to the decisions of our local county judge
- Working from this principle, Paul now makes his application to the Jews' relationship to

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the Law through the covenant given by Moses

- The Jewish people are bound to God to the terms of the Mosaic Covenant, particularly the Law and all its requirements
  - That covenant remains in effect until there is a death
  - And for as long as that covenant was in place, it acted to condemn any who couldn't follow it perfectly
  - It was a ministry of death, Paul says in 2 Corinthians
- So to free us from the condemnation of God's Law, God acted in our place to die, thereby putting an end to the covenant for those who are in Christ
  - When Jesus died, we were seen to die with Him spiritually
  - By grace through our faith in Jesus, God put our spirit to death
  - And a new living spirit came in its place
- At that point, our old person was gone, dead
  - And because our old self died, we were no longer a part of the Mosaic Covenant and subject to the Law of Moses
  - That death put an end to the covenant and to the Law the covenant required
  - Like the military recruit ending his enlistment…the military laws and regulations no longer apply
- Remember, Paul prefaced this section saying he was speaking to those who know the law, that is to the Jew in the church
  - For Jews who wondered why they could dispense with the Law simply because they accepted Jesus as Messiah, Paul says it's because you died
  - They had literally escaped the covenant that was formed by their forefathers on their behalf
  - The covenant has been ended for their sake through their faith in Jesus
  - He has completed all the terms of the Law and His death puts an end to the covenant for the sake of those for whom He died

- Gentiles are equally free from the Law, because we were never under that covenant in the first place
  - No Gentile was party to the Mosaic covenant
    - But we are held to God's standard of holiness
    - In other words, we don't need to be party to the Mosaic covenant to be accountable for our sin
    - Remember what we learned in Romans 2

Rom. 2:11 **For there is no partiality with God.**

Rom. 2:12 **For all who have sinned without the Law will also perish without the Law, and all who have sinned under the Law will be judged by the Law;**

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- Having the Law and being bound to the Mosaic Covenant doesn't offer a person any advantages in terms of righteousness
  - Because that law only served to convict us for our unrighteousness
  - It lacked the power to compel us into righteous living
  - So on that day of eternal judgment, Gentiles and Jews alike will be convicted for their sin, regardless of how much of God's law they knew
- But for the Jew, the issue of their relationship to the Mosaic Law was important, because it defined Jewish life at every level
  - Paul is explaining a life in Christ opens the door for a Jew to live an entirely new life of freedom from the Mosaic Life
  - And that's a big deal to any Jew
  - It's also a big deal to the Gentiles entering the church, since some Jews were intent on making Gentile converts practice Jewish law (and this continues even today)
  - But all Paul is saying is that the Law is no longer in effect, because our death in Christ frees us from that covenant
- Notice in v.4 Paul says we were made to die to the Law through Christ
  - Our separation from the covenant of Law isn't optional, it's not something we have to agree to
    - The covenant has ended because we have been made to die to it
    - Like a woman who has been widowed by her husband's death
    - Her marriage ended the moment of her husband's death, because the covenant ended at that moment
    - We could say she has been made to be single again
  - Now, that woman could continue to live as if she were married
    - She could continue to wear a wedding band
    - She could call herself "Mrs…."
    - She could refuse to seek a new husband
    - But these things are merely pretending
  - Likewise, some Jews in the church will continue living under the Law, or parts of it, voluntarily, but they do so for their own sake, not for God's
    - God has not placed them under that obligation
    - In fact, through Christ's death God has freed them from that obligation
    - And that's why Paul tells the church elsewhere not to be deprived of their freedom by agreeing to be subject to the Law unnecessarily

Col. 2:20 **If you have died with Christ to the elementary principles of the world, why, as if you were living in the world, do you submit yourself to decrees, such as,**

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Col. 2:21 "Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!"
Col. 2:22 (which all refer to things destined to perish with use) — in accordance with the commandments and teachings of men?

- Notice again in Colossians, Paul mentions our having died with Christ
  - That death freed us from the covenant of Law or any reason to take it up
  - And so he asks why the church has submitted itself to following the dietary and cleanliness rules of the Law?
  - These rules were merely commandments of men and therefore not of God, he says
- So in v.6 Paul says that we are released from the Law, so that we might serve God in a new way – by the Spirit
  - This statement summarizes the first consequences of salvation for our flesh or body
    - We are now serving God in a new way
    - Before faith in Christ, a Jew was instructed to serve God by accomplishing the requirements of the Mosaic Covenant
    - Doing works of the Law was the spiritual service required by everyone bound by that covenant of Law
  - But now having been freed from that Law, we serve God in a different way, following the leading of the Spirit Who directs us
    - The old Law written on stone is no longer our guide
    - In its place, we have a law written on our heart, so to speak
    - We have the mind of Christ and the Spirit of God
    - We have a sinless spirit from Christ
  - So you either serve God through one system or the other
    - Either you are under the Law and follow those rules
    - Or you are freed from the Law and follow the leading of the Holy Spirit
    - One came through the Old Covenant and one through the New Covenant
  - That's why Paul says in v.4 that we were freed from one to be joined to the other, because to mix the two is equivalent to adultery
    - Being in two covenants is like having two husbands
    - Therefore, Christians have no business mixing observance of the Old Covenant law with following Christ in the New Testament
    - We can observe an occasional ritual as a memorial or teaching example (like conducting a Seder meal at Passover)
    - But we should not submit to a lifestyle of Law keeping because to do so suggests we are still bound to that covenant
- So the first consequence for our body is how we serve God now

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- Having come to faith, we serve Him according to our new spiritual life
  - That new spiritual life is boundless in its opportunities
  - Under the law, only certain men could be priest and serve God in the tabernacle
  - But now we are all priests, representing God before men
  - Peter calls all believers a royal priesthood
- And we are no longer called to serve Him according to set rituals that never change, as was the case under the law
  - Instead, we are serving Him according to what we find in the truth of God's word and from the leading of the Spirit
  - That's what Jesus meant when He said:

John 4:23 **"But an hour is coming, and now is, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth; for such people the Father seeks to be His worshipers.**
John 4:24 **"God is spirit, and those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truth."**

- Before moving to the second consequence for the body, Paul stops to address an obvious question that emerges at this point in his teaching
  - Back in v.5 Paul says that while we were in the flesh (meaning still unbelieving) sinful passions in our flesh led us into sin
    - Those passions were already at work in the members of our body, meaning in the way we lived in the body
    - Our body lusted and drove us into one sin, after another
  - And when the Lord gave the Law to men in Israel, it only served to focus those passions
    - Remember, the sinful nature of humanity is set against God
    - So as God defined for us what was holy, it gave opportunity for the sin nature in our flesh to focus its opposition
  - And that raises a question: is the Law a cause for sin then?
    - Was the Law the source of our sin because it directed our sinful nature?

Rom. 7:7 **What shall we say then? Is the Law sin? May it never be! On the contrary, I would not have come to know sin except through the Law; for I would not have known about coveting if the Law had not said, "You shall not covet."**
Rom. 7:8 **But sin, taking opportunity through the commandment, produced in me coveting of every kind; for apart from the Law sin is dead.**
Rom. 7:9 **I was once alive apart from the Law; but when the commandment came, sin became alive and I died;**

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Rom. 7:10 and this commandment, which was to result in life, proved to result in death for me;
Rom. 7:11 for sin, taking an opportunity through the commandment, deceived me and through it killed me.
Rom. 7:12 So then, the Law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good.

- As expected, Paul says the Law is not sin but is actually the opposite
  - The Law is the definition of holiness, not a recipe to sin
    - Paul says he came to know what sin was in him because the Law gave it a name
    - For example, the urge to covet was always a part of man's sin nature
    - But only after the Lord defined coveting in the Law, only then did men understand it as sin
  - Notice that Paul used one of the Ten Commandments as his example
    - And in the same context, Paul refers to coveting as part of the Law
    - That means that when Paul says we are not under the Law, he is also including the Ten Commandments
    - We are not bound to the Law of Moses in any part
  - Now, having a definition of what was sin, our fallen nature had a target and it took opportunity to violate that rule at every turn
    - This is the pervasive nature of sin working in our flesh
    - Our sin is a force of nature, literally
    - It has its own drive, its own goals, its own master
    - This force used to define the nature of our spirit, and even now it still lives in the members of our physical body
  - It's not a mental process, but it influences our thinking; it's not a physical force, but it influences our feelings and actions
    - It's a spiritual force that lives in the members of our body, independent of our spirit
- You can see the moment this force came into being in Genesis 3

Gen. 3:6 When the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was desirable to make one wise, she took from its fruit and ate; and she gave also to her husband with her, and he ate.
Gen. 3:7 Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loin coverings.

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- When Adam and Woman sinned, they put into effect the word of God promising spiritual death
  - They both immediately changed in their spirits, becoming fallen creatures
  - And that change produced a new, evil spiritual force in their bodies
  - That spiritual force recognized it was an enemy of God and under a sentence of death
- And it immediately came to influence the thinking and actions of the Man and the Woman
  - First, both their eyes were opened, which is a way of describing the arrival of evil into their spirits
  - They were no longer innocent and unfamiliar with sin and evil
  - Now they knew it intimately, and in that sense their eyes were opened
- Next, they sensed they were naked
  - They had always been without clothing but that reality was of no concern before this moment
  - But now they were experiencing a sub-conscience change
  - Their fallen spirit was now an enemy of God and under judgment
- That spiritual vulnerability manifested itself as a physical vulnerability and shame, which caused them to seek covering
  - This wasn't a matter of culture…it was instinctive
  - Of course, the need for physical cover is a reflection of their need for spiritual covering, the covering of Christ's blood
  - Later, when God entered the Garden they felt the need to hide from Him, knowing Him to be their adversary
- From that point forward, humanity has shared this sense of God as our enemy and that we are vulnerable to His judgment
  - We see men fall in fear when in the presence of the holiness of God
    - And we are always set against the things of God
    - Yet we are also ignorant of God, so until God tells me what He approves, my flesh is unaware of what to oppose
  - That's what Paul means in v.8 when he says that apart from the Law, sin was "dead"
    - He means it wasn't aware of what to oppose
    - That particular sin was dormant, just waiting to be aroused in the day when it learned what God condemned
  - Conversely in v.9, Paul says he was "alive" apart from the Law
    - He means he was ignorant of his own sin
    - Alive means self-righteous, thinking himself approved by God
  - But then as the Law is made known in his heart, Paul says two things happened

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        - First, sin became alive
        - It was awakened to the possibilities of opposing God, like a sleeping lion aroused by an intruder
        - Once your flesh understood God said we couldn't covet, we suddenly want to covet all the more
    - And secondly, Paul's conscience came to understand he was vulnerable before God for that sin
        - Like Adam and Woman in the Garden, Paul suddenly felt guilt and condemnation for coveting
        - That feeling was his spirit instinctively knowing that he would be held accountable to God for the coveting he was doing
- So the Law was a commandment explaining the way to holiness, but its effect in a fallen person's nature is to bring us to death
    - It excites the part of us that brings us under condemnation
        - For the fallen part of our nature, it becomes a roadmap for how to sin more
        - Paul says in v.11 that sin (speaking of our flesh) took opportunity through knowing of the commandment, to bring us into more of the same
        - It deceived us in that it causes our heart to move in a direction that is inherently hurtful to our own best interests
        - Like the original life in the Garden, our sinful nature will tell us that what is evil is good and what is good is evil
        - The effect of this deception is to bring us into death, both spiritual and physical
    - Paul summarizes his explanation of the law in v.12: the law is holy and its instructions to us are holy and righteous and good
        - The problem isn't the Law itself
        - The problem is how our sinful flesh responds to such instructions
- This background leads Paul to the second major consequence of salvation for our body in the next passage

Rom. 7:13 Therefore did that which is good become a cause of death for me? May it never be! Rather it was sin, in order that it might be shown to be sin by effecting my death through that which is good, so that through the commandment sin would become utterly sinful.
Rom. 7:14 For we know that the Law is spiritual, but I am of flesh, sold into bondage to sin.

- Paul moves his line of reasoning one step further…he asks can we say that the Law being good is still to blame for causing our death?
    - Paul says the cause of death was not the Law, but rather it was sin itself

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        - We die because of sin, not because a Law exists that we violate
        - Paul says the law gives us opportunity to see how sinful we truly are
        - It shows how evil we are that we turn something good into something leading to death
        - We were always sinful, but by giving us His Law God showed men how utterly sinful we are
    - We could say the Law is a light, but if so it's like the light of an open flame
        - And our sinful nature is like a pool of gasoline in our heart
        - So that as the light of that Law comes to us, it ignites our passions to oppose God and sin all the more
        - We don't blame the Law, we blame the response of our heart
- Now, all this talk of the Law and its strange power to excite our fleshing rebellion introduces a new and important theological principle
    - This principle is a corollary to the one we learned last week in Chapter 6
        - Last week we learned that by faith in Jesus we gain a new spirit, one that is sinless and perfect
        - So that as we experience sin in our lives, that sin isn't originating from our spirit
        - It's originating from some other place
    - And now we're learning that the source of our sin is our flesh
        - Paul says in v.14 that the Law is spiritual
        - It has a spiritual source (God) and it describes the perfect nature of the divine, as Jesus said only God is good
        - To keep the Law is to share in the nature of God
    - But then Paul says we are of flesh, meaning our spirit coexists with a fallen sinful body
        - And this union of perfect spirit and sinful flesh results in ever-present warfare
        - It's spiritual schizophrenia
    - We have two opposite personalities now
        - We have Christ's spirit and Adam's body
        - It's like sharing the backseat on a long road trip with your older sibling
        - It's like Donald Trump taking Hillary Clinton to the prom
        - It's like brushing your teeth and drinking orange juice
        - It's like half golden retriever, half poodle
- So a consequence of salvation by faith is that our spirit is reborn, but for a time our body remains unchanged, leading to spiritual conflict
    - Paul describes the conflict in the next passage

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Rom. 7:15 For what I am doing, I do not understand; for I am not practicing what I would like to do, but I am doing the very thing I hate.
Rom. 7:16 But if I do the very thing I do not want to do, I agree with the Law, confessing that the Law is good.
Rom. 7:17 So now, no longer am I the one doing it, but sin which dwells in me.
Rom. 7:18 For I know that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh; for the willing is present in me, but the doing of the good is not.
Rom. 7:19 For the good that I want, I do not do, but I practice the very evil that I do not want.
Rom. 7:20 But if I am doing the very thing I do not want, I am no longer the one doing it, but sin which dwells in me

- Paul speaks of himself to describe the experience of every Christian
  - First, we see ourselves sinning and we wonder why we still have this desire to do the wrong thing
    - Paul says in v.15 that we do things we don't understand
    - You know that feeling…it usually hits you right after you've done or said something you shouldn't have done or said
    - We aren't practicing what we want to do and we're continuing to do the very things we hate
  - He's describing the frustrations we all know of living with a sinful nature
    - But Paul is asking us to think again about what we're experiencing in those moments
    - In v.16 he says if I do something I don't want to do, then I'm showing that I agree with God's law and confessing it's good
    - My dislike for my own sin is evidence that my spirit shares the mind of Christ
    - Previously I wouldn't have felt that way, and in fact, I couldn't have felt that way before I was born again
  - And this recognition leads to an important conclusion: I'm not the one seeking to sin but sin dwelling in me is driving that behavior
    - When Paul uses the first person pronoun (me, I), he's referring to our new spirit in Christ
    - It's the part that agrees with the Law and confesses it's good
    - So I (my spirit) is not the one doing the sin, as I said last week
    - It's impossible for our spirit to sin, because we were given Christ's sinless spirit when we were born again
- But then where is the desire to sin coming from? All that's left is our body, our flesh, which Paul calls "sin"
  - Paul says in v.18 that sin dwells in my physical fleshly container, my body

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        - That container is absolutely, 100% sinful
        - Nothing good dwells in it, Paul says
        - It is the source of my desire for doing wrong and it is opposed to my spirit
    - The result is that the willing to do good is in "me" (my spirit) but the actual doing of good is often fleeting
        - Christians will struggle with living in ways contrary to our confession
        - As Paul neatly summarizes in v.19…we do not do the good we want, and we do the evil we do not want to do
    - How is this even possible? Why aren't we in control of ourselves?
        - The answer in v.20 is that there are two sources of power working in us
        - Your spiritual will and your physical will
        - Your spiritual will wants what God wants, while your physical will wants what the enemy wants
        - It causes you to go against your own wishes
        - It gets its way because you listen to its desires and give in to its requests
- That leads to a principle

Rom. 7:21 I find then the principle that evil is present in me, the one who wants to do good.
Rom. 7:22 For I joyfully concur with the law of God in the inner man,
Rom. 7:23 but I see a different law in the members of my body, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin which is in my members.

- Since we can see plainly that we do things we don't want to do, then we have our proof that those desires are not our true self
    - They are a part us, for now, but they are *not* us
    - Evil is something that is present in us even as we want to do good
    - In my spirit, Paul says, I love what God loves and want what God wants
    - But in my physical body, I find a source of evil that is actively opposing my efforts to follow God and serve Him
- It isn't merely a bad influence on me…it's more significant than that
    - It is actively working against me
    - It's a foreign invader, a virus, something that fights back
    - Paul says it makes me a prisoner, preventing me from completely escaping sin
- So with what we learned from Chapter 6 and now what we've learned from Chapter 7, we have powerful insight to do battle

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    - We know that we have all we need for pleasing God living in us
    - I don't need laws written on stone, I don't need ritual or religion
    - I just need the word of God and the Spirit of God, because inside me I have the perfect mind and will of Christ
- But I also have an enemy living in me, an enemy that always wants to do the opposite of God's law
    - That force is never at rest
    - It's at war with my spirit, and it tempts me into lusts of one kind or another
    - And it wants me to fail in my service to God
- I'm a prisoner of this enemy because he lives in my physical body, and obviously I can't exist on earth serving God without that body
    - Yet I'm not without defense in this battle
    - The stronger my spiritual will grows, the more control I can exert over the physical will
    - And Paul will talk more about that in the next chapter
- Meanwhile, he finishes this chapter with the ultimate question, the one we would all ask at this point: how can i get rid of this stupid, evil body?

Rom. 7:24 Wretched man that I am! Who will set me free from the body of this death?
Rom. 7:25 Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord! So then, on the one hand I myself with my mind am serving the law of God, but on the other, with my flesh the law of sin.

- We are wretched in this present state
    - We're all like a walking Greek tragedy
        - We've been equipped to know what God wants and given a desire to please Him
        - And yet we're shackled to a body dedicated to opposing Him
        - It seems like a recipe for frustration
        - But in reality it's a temporary situation
    - Paul says we need someone to set us free from this body of death, meaning a body that just wants to lead us into sin
        - And he follows with thanks be to God that this is exactly the plan, through Jesus Christ
        - For just as Jesus gave us a new spirit, He will also one day bring us into a new body
    - This is the hope of our faith; our hope of resurrection
        - All believers from all time look forward to this coming moment, when we

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receive a new body

- The Bible teaches that each distinct group of saints throughout history will receive their new body at the same moment
- All Church saints receive their new bodies in a single moment at the rapture
- And all Old Testament and Tribulation saints receive their bodies at Christ's Second Coming

- Our resurrection is the moment of our glorification, but even before that moment, we will be freed from the scourge of this body
  - At our death, when our spirit leaves this body behind, we enter into the presence of Christ in heaven, Paul says in 2 Corinthians
  - The only thing standing between us and Heaven is our sinful body
  - Once the body is gone, our spirit can enter Heaven, which proves that our spirit is sinless already

- Finally, Paul summarizes the main point of the chapter in v.25
  - With my mind (or we could say with our spirit), we serve the law of God through our life lived in Christ
    - But through our flesh, I'm serving the principle of sin, that is opposition to God
    - So when you sin, you're seeing your flesh winning the day
    - When you live in holy and pleasing ways, you're seeing your spirit in control
    - Watch for which one is winning the day more often, and you'll have a measure of how sanctified you are in your walk with Christ
  - The life goal of every Christian should be to build up the spiritual strength of the spirit and to discipline the flesh
    - In working on these things, we bring glory to Christ
    - We show His love to other people
    - And we serve Him faithfully as His ambassador
    - That's the mission of every Christian life, and it begins with understanding how the war is fought and won

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- Tonight we reach the climactic chapter of the book of Romans
  - This is the chapter where Paul pulls everything together
    - He reconciles the effects of a sinless spirit and a depraved, sinful body
    - He addresses concerns for how our sinful tendencies might impact our eternal future
    - He answers the doubts for any who might wonder if they are truly saved
    - He even considers what our death in the body says about our relationship with Christ
  - In light of all that Paul covers in this important chapter of scripture, we need to return once more to our structure chart
    - Chapter 8 is the final part of the fifth block in this book
    - This block has been examining the consequences of our salvation by faith alone in Christ alone
    - Chapter 6 addressed how that salvation changed our spirit for the better
    - And Chapter 7 explained why, despite our perfection in Christ, we still experience sin in our body
  - Those two conflicting consequences create the potential for confusion and misunderstanding among uninformed believers
    - First, does the fact that I continue to experience sin following my salvation suggest that I am not truly saved at all?
    - Secondly, how do we tell the difference between an unbeliever playing Christian and a true believer ruled by their sinful flesh?
    - Finally, how do we understand the trials of daily life that come upon us while living in our present condition? Are they evidence of God's displeasure with us?
- All of these issues revolve around a single concern: our eternal security
  - If we were entirely sinless now, if we didn't have this sinful body, we wouldn't have this concern at all
    - If our flesh were as sinless as our spirit is now, then we would live in perfect obedience and confidence in our relationship with Christ
    - Moreover, we would live in a world without sin, where no one else's disobedience could come against us to cause us trial or loss
    - Therefore, we would have no reason to doubt that God was pleased with us or that our relationship would endure
  - One day soon that's the world we will know, but until then we still live in a sinful world and we still let our sinful flesh corrupt our walk
    - As a result our confidence may be shaken at times
    - Others' sins against us, or our own disobedience, may seem like cracks in the wall of our security in Christ
    - So Paul addresses these concerns in Chapter 8, in a chapter I call the

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consequences for our eternal security

Rom. 8:1 Therefore there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.
Rom. 8:2 For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and of death.
Rom. 8:3 For what the Law could not do, weak as it was through the flesh, God did: sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and as an offering for sin, He condemned sin in the flesh,
Rom. 8:4 so that the requirement of the Law might be fulfilled in us, who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.

- Chapter 8 opens with a powerful statement of assurance of our security in Christ
  - Paul starts with the word "therefore" because he's applying the truths he taught in the prior chapters
    - In a sense, v.8:1 is the conclusion of all Romans
    - As a result of your salvation by grace through faith…
    - As a result of receiving the righteousness of Christ rather than relying on your own righteousness…
    - As a result of possessing a perfect spirit and despite temporarily inhabiting a sinful body…
    - There is now no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus
  - Notice Paul's emphasis on the word "now"
    - We're free of condemnation not only at our judgment moment in the eternal age, but even now you stand without condemnation
    - Even now as you continue to experience sin because of your body, you are approved by God
  - How can this be true? Well remember, the eternal you is not your body
    - The sinful body is destined to go to the grave
    - It will pay for its sin with a death, just as God requires
  - But you are your spirit, and your spirit is sinless, made in the image of Christ
    - Your sinful spirit died on the cross with Christ
    - So even as you experience sin, you have no condemnation
- Paul describes this as the spirit of life in Christ vs. the law of sin and death
  - In v.2 Paul says that the spirit of life in Christ sets us free from the law of sin and death
    - The spirit of life in Christ refers to that new spirit we received from Christ at the moment of our faith

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        - That new spirit is not under condemnation, because Christ already paid the price for our sin on the cross
    - Therefore, we were set free from the law that condemned our sin
        - That law demands death for sin, and Christ took that death in our place
        - So when we received our new spirit through our faith in Christ, we were set free from, no longer bound to, the law that called for our death
    - So God has no reason to be our enemy now
        - God does what He does according to what is right and just
        - When our body dies and we're set free from it, our spirit will be the only thing that remains for a time
        - Our spirit, being perfect, cannot be condemned, for it would be unjust for God to judge us
    - Paul explains this conclusion in v.3, saying the law couldn't compel us to live perfectly, which is why it only served to condemn us
        - The Law spelled out what was right, but it couldn't make our sinful flesh conform to its requirements
        - In fact, as we learned earlier, our sin took pleasure in doing whatever the Law prohibited
    - Therefore, the Father sent Christ to live it perfectly for us and then to die as payment for our sin
        - By living according to the Law, Christ's spirit remained perfect and sinless from birth to death
        - By faith, His perfect spirit has given birth to our perfect spirit, and His death paid the price for our sin, freeing us from condemnation
- And so in v.4, Paul says by receiving Christ's spirit, the requirement of the Law has been fulfilled in us
    - In other words, when the Father looks upon us now, what does He see?
        - First, He sees our sinful deeds done in this body, but those deeds are the result of our flesh, not our spirit
        - But one day our body will go to the grave, which is the just penalty for its sin
    - But our body is not the eternal "us" because it's not the part of us that will pass over into the next age
        - The eternal part of us is our spirit
        - So when the Father looks upon our spirit, all He sees is Christ's perfect spirit
        - Our spirit does not sin and therefore, there is no condemnation for our spirit… not now and not ever
        - Our spirit is the only part of us that carries on into the presence of the Lord
        - So our body's sin has no bearing on our spirit's standing before God
- With this argument, Paul addresses the first doubt I mentioned in my introduction

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- For the Christian who wonders if the continuing presence of sin draws our salvation into question, the answer is clearly no
  - Because the source of our sin is our flesh, which will go to the grave prior to our judgment
  - So that as we arrive before Christ, we will have already shed that part of us that remains unrighteous
  - All that will remain at that moment is our perfect spirit, made so by Christ
- It would be hard to find a truth of scripture more important than this one
  - A Christian cannot engage in a serious and productive pursuit of God's grace, truth and godliness until he or she understands this truth
  - As long as we remain confused about this point, we will either revert to self-righteousness, trying to work for something we have already obtained by faith
  - Or we will become so discouraged or defeated by our sin that we give up the pursuit of Christ altogether…both are mistakes
- Instead, we need to appreciate the freedom we have now to serve Christ without worry for our future
  - Because we have already been granted all that's required to be approved by God…we have Christ's perfect spirit
  - And while our flesh's sin is ever before us…and that's good, since it works to motivate us to seek for something better…
  - Nevertheless, that sin does nothing to weaken our relationship with Christ
- In fact, our concern over our sin is merely proof that we are a child of God and we have the mind of Christ

Rom. 8:5 For those who are according to the flesh set their minds on the things of the flesh, but those who are according to the Spirit, the things of the Spirit.
Rom. 8:6 For the mind set on the flesh is death, but the mind set on the Spirit is life and peace,
Rom. 8:7 because the mind set on the flesh is hostile toward God; for it does not subject itself to the law of God, for it is not even able to do so,
Rom. 8:8 and those who are in the flesh cannot please God.
Rom. 8:9 However, you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. But if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Him.
Rom. 8:10 If Christ is in you, though the body is dead because of sin, yet the spirit is alive because of righteousness.
Rom. 8:11 But if the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit who dwells in you.

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- Paul labels the unsaved human condition as living according to the flesh
  - Before coming to faith in Jesus Christ, there was no tug of war inside us
    - There was only the desire of the flesh with no counterweight to resist it, apart from our conscience
    - Paul says the unsaved mind – the way unbelievers think about life – is set entirely on the flesh's desires, which are always sinful
    - While we were unbelievers, to the extent we refrained from doing what the flesh wanted, it was only because we were avoiding the negative consequences we assumed would follow
    - But there was nothing righteous in our motives or desires
  - Notice Paul says in v.6 that the mind set on the flesh is death
    - He's saying that the mind we possessed before faith was one that knows only sin and condemnation, which Paul sums up as "death"
    - And in v.7 Paul says that the mind was hostile toward God and it would not be subject to the Law of God
    - In fact, as we learned, the flesh isn't even able to do so
  - So the fleshly mind of every unbeliever is set against God and toward sin, to such an extent that it can't think in any other way
    - It's literally impossible to please God because what God wants is opposite of what the fleshly mind wants
    - And even when the Lord did reveal His desires to men, the fleshly mind merely took opportunity in that knowledge to sin all the more
  - So under these circumstances, certainly the unbeliever gives absolutely no concern to their own sin – apart from whatever consequences arise
    - They aren't troubled by the notion of doing wrong, of displeasing God
    - They do not understand what God wants because they lack access to His thoughts
    - They do not have the internal desire to please Him
- By contrast, after we come to faith in Jesus Christ our spirit is born again and becomes aligned perfectly with the will of God
  - From that point, our mind is set on righteous things
    - Paul says in v.6 that the mind we receive following faith knows only eternal life and the peace we have with God
    - Our thinking moves 180° from opposing God to pleasing God
  - And that difference means that now we think about eternal matters and we share the Lord's concern for sin
    - Where before we had concern only for the consequences of sin
    - Now we feel burdened over the presence of sin in our life
  - And even our thoughts about the consequences of our sin have changed

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        - Now we care more about the eternal consequences of our sin rather than the earthly consequences
        - So concerns about eternal security, or worries about pleasing God, become chief concerns
    - These are concerns unique to the believer
        - I often say that only believers worry about not having salvation
        - Unbelievers don't sit around worrying over whether they are saved, for that notion never even enters their mind
    - But the believer, especially the new immature follower of Christ, may become fixated on that concern
        - Ironically, it's our living spirit that makes possible such a concern
        - In other words, *because* we are alive in Christ, we now have the capacity to appreciate what it means not to be saved
        - Which is why Paul wants us to understand that our new thinking is proof in itself that we are not under condemnation

Rom. 8:9 However, you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. But if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he does not belong to Him.
Rom. 8:10 If Christ is in you, though the body is dead because of sin, yet the spirit is alive because of righteousness.
Rom. 8:11 But if the Spirit of Him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, He who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit who dwells in you.

- Now Paul moves to addressing the second question: if believers sin at times like unbelievers, how do we know we are saved?
    - The answer, for several reasons, is the Holy Spirit living in us is the ultimate proof of our salvation
        - The Spirit comes to every believer at the moment of salvation
        - It is the Spirit Who regenerates us, bringing us to faith
        - Our new birth in Christ is accomplished by the Spirit of God, just as Christ Himself was conceived in the flesh by the Holy Spirit
    - Therefore, Paul says if a person does not have the Spirit of Christ, then that person does not belong to Christ
        - It was the presence of Christ's Spirit in you, birthing you anew, that brought you into righteousness and freed you from the condemnation of the Law
        - So that even though your body remains dead because of its sin, nevertheless the spirit has made you alive
    - Moreover, Paul says in v.11 that the same Spirit Who raised Jesus from the dead will

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do the same for you

- The fact that the Spirit took up residence in your dead body tells us He intends to bring us into a living body one day
- After three days, the Spirit of Christ brought Christ's body back to life
- Those three days were merely an interlude during which Christ's body was dead

- Likewise, the Spirit of Christ has made you spiritually alive now even while your body remains "dead" in sin
  - And this interlude will last for a while, but eventually the Spirit will finish the job He started
  - So one day He will bring your living spirit back into a new, eternal living body
  - As Paul says elsewhere

Phil. 1:6 **For I am confident of this very thing, that He who began a good work in you will perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus.**

- So the first proof that sin isn't undoing your salvation is that your spirit will one day receive a new body, and that work is promised to be completed
  - So the sin of this temporary body isn't changing God's plan
    - He knew it was a problem which is why He's promised to replace it
    - In the meantime, we can wait in confidence
  - Then Paul moves to the second reason we know that our conflict with sin isn't reason to doubt our salvation

Rom. 8:12 **So then, brethren, we are under obligation, not to the flesh, to live according to the flesh —**
Rom. 8:13 **for if you are living according to the flesh, you must die; but if by the Spirit you are putting to death the deeds of the body, you will live.**
Rom. 8:14 **For all who are being led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God.**

- The language of v.12 is bit awkward in English, but we could rephrase Paul's statement this way…
  - So brothers and sisters, we are obligated by God not to live according to the wishes of our flesh
    - Because Paul says if someone is living according to the flesh, that person must die
    - At first we may wonder if Paul is talking about an outcome for believers, but the context will show us otherwise
    - As we'll see, Paul is contrasting two ways of life and what they say about a person's identity

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- On the one hand, there are people who are living according to the flesh
  - These people are controlled by their sinful flesh and as a result will know death in the end
  - Paul's describing the identity of the unbeliever
  - The unbeliever's body will die for its sin
  - And their spirit will likewise experience the second death, which is eternity in the Lake of Fire
- If Paul was describing an unbeliever, why did he use the second person pronoun, "you"?
  - Because he's speaking parenthetically
  - Notice at the end of v.12 your English version probably has an em dash (–)
  - That punctuation choice reflects the interpreters' awareness that Paul is taking a detour in v.13

- Back in v.12 Paul explains the Christian is under obligation to struggle against the flesh
  - But then in v.13 Paul takes a moment to remind us that our prior state of unbelief presented no such struggle yet it resulted in death
    - So while our new state may involve struggle, that struggle is proof to us that we will live eternally
    - So Paul's parenthetical statement simply reminds us that our current struggle against sin is better than our life lived for the flesh
    - The struggle that leads to life is better than the blissful ignorance of unbelief that leads to death
  - So the Spirit of God obligates us to put to death the deeds of the flesh
    - When he says obligation, Paul doesn't mean we have a responsibility to engage in this battle
    - Paul means it literally…God obligates this battle and you can't avoid it
    - Because we are now two parts – perfect spirit and sinful flesh – we *will* wrestle with sin
    - The fight isn't optional; you can't avoid it because the Spirit in us leads us and He doesn't need our permission to prosecute the battle
  - We can resist His will, but we will only be a miserable creature
    - The most miserable person you'll ever meet is a Christian determined to let their sinful body rule their life
    - Because while we might have enjoyed our sin before we were saved, we will not enjoy it after
    - The sinning believer still suffers the consequences of their sin like everyone else
    - But on top of that, they also feel guilt from the conviction of the Spirit, so ironically, they can't even be free to enjoy it
  - So we don't really have a choice to fight

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        - Our only choice is whether we will seek to win this battle, or to just keep losing it over and over again
        - That fight will be a slow, progressive battle that lasts a lifetime
        - The process is messy and complicated and subject to setbacks from time to time
        - But the very fact that the wrestling happens, is a reflection of our new identity
- We can see confirmation that Paul was speaking about two different identities in v.13, when we look at v.14
    - Paul's conclusion is to give the definition of a believer: the believer is the one who is being led by the Spirit of God
        - To be led by the Spirit means to have the indwelling of the Spirit
        - And it's the presence of the Spirit that made possible our new birth and obligates us to wrestling against the body's sin
        - It's the evidence to us that we are truly saved
    - But be careful…you can't apply this standard in measuring another person's faith, as if their good works are a litmus test of their faith
        - Paul is speaking to believers concerning our identity in Christ, not someone else's
        - That is, the work of the Spirit in our life is proof of our faith
        - So that if sin in your life concerns you, rest assured it testifies to your new birth
    - But we can't look at another person and decide for them whether the presence of sin in their life means they are believing or not
        - Because it's not the presence or absence of sin in a person's life that reflects true faith
        - It's our heart response to that sin that demonstrates our new life in Christ
        - A true believer is under obligation by the Spirit to not live in agreement with the sinful flesh, and so we will struggle when we do
        - And that struggle is not something another person can know or measure in us, nor we measure in another
- And so Paul concludes his answer to that second question with a final effect of the Spirit dwelling in a believer

Rom. 8:15 For you have not received a spirit of slavery leading to fear again, but you have received a spirit of adoption as sons by which we cry out, "Abba! Father!"
Rom. 8:16 The Spirit Himself testifies with our spirit that we are children of God,
Rom. 8:17 and if children, heirs also, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him so that we may also be glorified with Him.

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- Paul says the presence of the Spirit living in us eliminates our natural fear of death
  - The spirit we received from Adam was a spirit of slavery, Paul says
    - It was enslaved to a fear of death created by our sinful jeopardy before God
    - Like a poor student who stands in fear of the day they receive their report card
    - That fear burdens them all the more as the day grows closer, and in that sense they are enslaved
  - But when we received a new spirit in Christ, that old spirit that feared death went away
    - Now our new spirit, having descended from Christ, is a fellowship child of God
    - And as a fellowship child of God, we no longer fear seeing Him face to face
    - Rather, that new spirit led us to cry out to Him as a young child might cry out to daddy (*abba* in Aramaic)
  - The Spirit's arrival effected an adoption on our behalf
    - While we were natural born in the image of Adam, now we've been adopted into the family of Christ
    - As an adopted child, we have all the privileges and rights of a natural born child
    - So we have nothing to fear of God, or the day we face Him
  - We will also be an heir with Christ
    - We will share in God's inheritance
    - The Bible says that Christ as the Son of God received an inheritance on the occasion of His own death
    - An inheritance is something a person receives on the occasion of a death
    - A person's wealth is transferred to someone else at the moment they die
    - When your rich uncle dies, he leaves his inheritance to his heirs
    - That transfer of wealth couldn't happen until he died
  - Normally when a person dies, his Last Will and Testament dictates that his wealth be transferred to a living relative
    - But in the case of Christ, He died but then He lived again
    - So at His resurrection, He received His own inheritance back
    - The irony is, Christ's own death produced His inheritance
  - So Christ's inheritance will be shared among all the children of God
    - Because we are all children of God by faith, then we are also heirs who share in the inheritance of God
    - As Paul says in Galatians

Gal. 4:6 **Because you are sons, God has sent forth the Spirit of His Son into our hearts, crying, "Abba! Father!"**

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Gal. 4:7 **Therefore you are no longer a slave, but a son; and if a son, then an heir through God.**

- Take note, Paul is not saying we have no reason to fear anything or that we are going to be fearful at times
  - He's speaking specifically about fearing death and the judgment that comes
    - And many times when we know fear, it's because we're letting our flesh rule our hearts momentarily
    - Because in your spirit, you have no fear of death, and therefore most of the things in life that scare you are irrelevant
    - Because even something that might take your life is simply hastening your glory…who could fear that?
  - So if you suffer in your struggles against sin or because of others' sins, just know that you are sharing in Christ's life
    - He suffered and He was glorified
    - You will know the same because you are also a child of God
    - These realities are no reason to doubt your salvation
    - If anything they confirm you are different
- Next time, we address Paul's third question – that is what do trials and tribulations in this life say about our relationship with God?
  - Or as some people might say, why do bad things happen to good people?

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- We're returning to Chapter 8 and Paul's climactic explanation of our security in Christ
  - Starting in Chapter 6, Paul began explaining what changed for the Christian as a result of having placed faith in Jesus Christ
    - First, we received a new spirit given to us by the Holy Spirit, made in the nature of Christ's sinless spirit
    - Secondly, for a time we contend with a sinful, fleshly body, which means we still experience sin until the body dies
    - Nevertheless, despite the presence of sin in our life, we are still righteous in the spirit, made so by Christ
  - Furthermore, when Christ lived on earth in the flesh, He satisfied all the requirements of the Law, including paying the Law's price for sin which He did not commit
    - Christ did all the right things while suffering the penalty for our wrong things
    - Therefore, God can be just in assigning us His sinless spirit by faith, giving us credit for what Christ accomplished on our behalf
    - Our new spirit is alive in Christ, credited with having met the Law and free from the penalty of our sin
  - So now our minds are set on the things of the Spirit, sharing a desire for what God desires, acknowledging the Law is right even as we fail to keep it on occasion
    - We live a life of peace with God and set our minds on our eternal future
    - And these things remain true despite our sin because our spirit remains Christ-like
    - And as our body goes to the grave, so goes its condemnation
    - So that at our judgment, we stand approved in the spirit because Christ has won that victory for us
- Therefore, Paul opened Chapter 8 declaring that there is now no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus
  - There will be no condemnation at our judgment moment, but there is now no condemnation either
    - When the Father looks upon us now, He sees our sinless spirit
    - That righteousness was won by Christ and credited to us
  - Paul then continued in the first half of the chapter contrasting the way of life and future for the unbeliever vs. the believer
    - He used several arguments to reassure the believer that we have been changed by our faith
    - And though we still stumble, our concern over sin and our worry about salvation are themselves evidence of our changed heart
  - While before we had a mind hostile to God, now we call Him Father
    - Where before we lived in the flesh on a path to death, today we operate with the Spirit and mind of Christ

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        - Where before we had a spirit enslaved by sin, today we have a choice of whether to sin or not
        - Where before we were distant from God, today His Spirit lives in us testifying to our heart that we are His
    - All of these experiences are unique to the believer and therefore they reinforce to us that something is different, something has changed
        - These experiences become our assurance that we have no condemnation
        - A Father doesn't condemn His children
        - The Lord can't condemn a perfect spirit
        - The Lord didn't die for us only to require we die for ourselves also
        - And the very fact that we have concerns for our salvation is proof in itself that we are saved
- That leads us to the second half of Romans 8, where Paul begins to consider external threats to our salvation
    - Specifically, the question of suffering
        - Sometimes it's expressed as "Why do bad things happen to good people?"
        - The question presupposes that the Universe hands out consequences according to personal value or worth
        - Those who do wrong will suffer bad things while those who do well will experience only good things = karma
        - Or at least that's how we feel it should be
    - And because even Christians may tend to think that way, the question arises of what does our suffering say about our relationship with God?
        - Might our suffering for one reason or another suggest that our eternal security is in doubt?
        - For if God truly loves us and if we have no condemnation, then why would God permit bad things to happen to us?
        - Why would Christians see suffering?
        - Why would the Lord treat His children no differently than the rest of the world?
    - It's a legitimate question, but when we ask it, we're thinking too narrowly about God's purposes in our life and in Creation overall
        - So for the rest of this chapter, Paul addresses the question of suffering
        - Why does God permit suffering and what does suffering say about our eternal security?
        - Paul begins looking at the question in terms of His plan for Creation itself

Rom. 8:18 For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory that is to be revealed to us.

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Rom. 8:19 For the anxious longing of the creation waits eagerly for the revealing of the sons of God.
Rom. 8:20 For the creation was subjected to futility, not willingly, but because of Him who subjected it, in hope
Rom. 8:21 that the creation itself also will be set free from its slavery to corruption into the freedom of the glory of the children of God.
Rom. 8:22 For we know that the whole creation groans and suffers the pains of childbirth together until now.

- Obviously, Paul's moved to the topic of suffering, but it actually starts a verse earlier
  - Last time, we looked at vs.16-17 where Paul introduced the idea of suffering as part of the Christian experience in this age
    - Just as we will share in Christ's glory in the age to come, we will also share in Christ's experience on earth
    - God's children will know suffering on earth for the same reason Christ did
    - Because the enemy seeks to persecute those who belong to God
    - And the sin of the world serves as the enemy's tool box, which he can bring to bear against the believer as God permits
  - Paul then moves directly into a discussion of the meaning of suffering, and of course the first thing he does is put sufferings in perspective
    - Specifically, he puts them in an eternal perspective
    - He says the sufferings of our present time are not comparable to the glory to be revealed
    - That's where we start whenever we broach this topic
  - We can't evaluate outcomes until all is said and done
    - Until we see how God deals with each person in the end can we say for sure who has received good things and who has received bad things
    - Remember the story Jesus tells of Lazarus and the Rich Man in Luke 16

Luke 16:19 "Now there was a rich man, and he habitually dressed in purple and fine linen, joyously living in splendor every day.
Luke 16:20 "And a poor man named Lazarus was laid at his gate, covered with sores,
Luke 16:21 and longing to be fed with the crumbs which were falling from the rich man's table; besides, even the dogs were coming and licking his sores.
Luke 16:22 "Now the poor man died and was carried away by the angels to Abraham's bosom; and the rich man also died and was buried.
Luke 16:23 "In Hades he lifted up his eyes, being in torment, and saw Abraham far away and Lazarus in his bosom.
Luke 16:24 "And he cried out and said, 'Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and

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send Lazarus so that he may dip the tip of his finger in water and cool off my tongue, for I am in agony in this flame.'
Luke 16:25 **"But Abraham said, 'Child, remember that during your life you received your good things, and likewise Lazarus bad things; but now he is being comforted here, and you are in agony.**

- If we tried to assess God's goodness for each of these men prior to their deaths, we would have been working with only half the data
  - But after they died, then the full story will be known
  - And according to what Jesus taught, the rich man (who is an unbeliever) received good things in the first life
  - This was God's choice for the man, yet it didn't begin to reflect on the man's true relationship with God
  - The mere fact that God granted the man earthly riches said nothing about God's pleasure with the man
  - Instead, they were a limited benefit that disappeared in eternity
- Following death, the man began to experience his eternal existence, which was far less desirable
  - Conversely the man who suffered most of his life on earth – again, by the Lord's sovereign will – saw great comfort
  - Now we understand that the Lord's love truly rested on this man, despite his poor circumstances on earth
- So this story teaches two fundamental truths:
  - God lets His children suffer for purposes of His own
  - And our relationship with God cannot be measured by the quality of our earthly life
- Obviously, Christ's own life is the ultimate example of this principle
  - Christ suffered in ways none of us ever will, since He experienced eternal separation from the Father – to say nothing of his pain and suffering
    - Yet Christ is beloved of the Father, His only begotten Son
    - Clearly, we can't measure the Father's pleasure in His Son, as Isaiah says

Is. 53:10 **But the Lord was pleased**
To crush Him, putting Him to grief;
If He would render Himself as a guilt offering,
He will see His offspring,
He will prolong His days,
And the good pleasure of the Lord will prosper in His hand.

- Notice the before-and-after quality to this verse

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- The Father was pleased to crush His Son, putting Him to grief
- But in doing so, the Father would prolong Christ's days and the good pleasure of the Father would be Christ's
- He's referring to the glory that Christ will enjoy when He rules the world from the seat of David

- So Christ too experienced suffering while on earth, but we can't judge God's pleasure in His Son from that perspective
  - We have to wait to see the end of the story, which we won't see until we're in the next age with Christ
  - That's the age Paul is speaking about when he says that our present sufferings can't be compared to what's in store for us
  - If we could look ahead to see what God has planned for us, we wouldn't be thinking much about our problems now
- In fact, they would seem like nothing compared to what's coming
  - You might compare them to the relationship between the pain of childbirth, compared to the joy of having a child for all your life
  - A few hours of discomfort can't compare to years and years of joy
- Likewise, we can't lose an eternal perspective on our sufferings or else we let them erode our confidence in God's love
  - If you're having an especially bad day or week or year or season of life, it doesn't mean God has stopped loving you, stopped caring, or stopped listening
    - There is something God is doing for your benefit
    - But for some reason that benefit depends on you suffering, at least for a time
    - The benefit God has planned literally couldn't be achieved any other way
  - And you're not alone, because Paul says the entire Creation is in the same boat with you
    - In vs.19-22 Paul describes the suffering of the Creation
    - He's speaking literally of the entire Universe, everything God created in the first week
    - In v.19 Paul says the entire creation anxiously longs for the arrival of that next age
    - Anxious longing could be translated as eager anticipation, a desire or longing for the arrival of that outcome
  - How can inanimate things long for something?
    - It's not necessarily a conscious longing
    - Rather, Paul's referring to Creation's situation under the curse
    - It's not that the Creation is consciously aware of its fallen state, but that it exists in an unnatural state
    - It experiences death, disease, wearing down and corruption as a result of the

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curse

- This is not the natural, intended state of God's design for His Creation

- Nevertheless, the Lord placed the Creation into this state when He pronounced a curse on it
  - Paul says in v.20 that the creation was "subjected" to this futility
    - The One Who subjected it was God, of course
    - So this is the ultimate example of God allowing suffering
    - When someone tries to tell you that God isn't responsible for suffering existing in the world, remind them where the curse came from
    - Obviously, the curse itself was the result of Adam's sin,
    - But nevertheless the Lord is the One who place the world in this state of futility
  - But Paul also says that the Creation didn't accept the curse "willingly," that is, it wasn't the result of anything the Creation did to deserve it
    - The creation itself was innocent in the matter of the Garden
    - Still, the world was unwillingly subjected to the curse
    - Just as God's children often find themselves under difficult circumstances that were no fault of their own
  - Paul says that it was subjected in this way by God, in hope that Creation itself would be set free from slavery
    - Paul's referring to God's ultimate plan for Creation
    - When Adam sinned, he brought sin into the life of mankind
    - Left unchecked, Adam's mistake would have doomed all mankind to live with sin, apart from God
  - And even if God acted to redeem mankind, as He has done through Christ, still we would have bodies corrupted by sin
    - So there could be no escape from sin and sin's consequences
    - This would have been the eternal state for mankind
- Therefore, God acted to correct for that problem, but His solution required that pain and suffering precede glory
  - Before God could put an end to sin in the life of every believer, He needed to put an end to all sinful human flesh
    - To do this God pronounces a curse on the earth, from which all flesh comes
    - He did this to set up opportunity for our bodies to be replaced
    - And with us, the earth itself will be replaced
  - So once more we see this before-and-after process
    - Initially, the news is bad
    - The world is subjected to futility

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        - But it was done in hope of being set free from its corruption to sin
        - And to be prepared to receive the sons and daughters of glory who will occupy it one day in new, eternal, sin-free bodies
    - Can you make the comparison to your own situation again?
        - Just as Lazarus suffered before receiving his reward
        - Just as Jesus suffered to receive His reward
        - Just as the Creation suffers for a time looking forward to its day of redemption
        - So then we too will know suffering for a time prior to receiving the fullness we're anticipating through our faith in Jesus
    - Remember my example of childbirth from a moment ago?
        - Paul alludes to this same analogy in v.22
        - He says the world is suffering the pains of childbirth
        - It's a reference to this theological principle, that God brings us sufferings to lead us into glory
        - That He must deal with sin through a period of atonement and anxious longing before He reveals the glory to come
    - The delay between one and the other is explained in Hebrews 11
        - God has designed the plan of redemption so that no one will receive their glory apart from the rest of those included in God's plan
        - We all go into glory together, which means those who lived earlier in this age must wait for those to come later
        - And the Creation itself must exist in this state of futility for many centuries awaiting the final generation of God's people to be born
        - Or as Hebrews says:

Heb. 11:39 And all these, having gained approval through their faith, did not receive what was promised,
Heb. 11:40 because God had provided something better for us, so that apart from us they would not be made perfect.

- The saints of old never received what they had been promised, the writer says, speaking of the promises of a kingdom on earth
    - Why have they not received it?
        - Because the writer says that God had something better for us, that is the saints of the New Testament
        - God had a plan to reveal His Son and grant the earth a time to know Him prior to the judgment and the kingdom
        - So that those OT saints could not be made perfect apart from us, the writer says

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- This is the fundamental reason for why suffering precedes glory
  - We must live in a sinful body before we occupy a sinless body
  - We must live a life on a sinful earth before we can enter into the life in the kingdom
  - And we must all wait for the arrival of that kingdom because we all spend the same length of time in it
  - So no one can arrive earlier than anyone else
- Paul says this principle can be pictured through childbirth
  - The pain of childbirth was something God instituted when He responded to the sin of woman
  - But when God brought pain to childbirth, He was granting women a blessing of carrying an example of this principle in their bodies
  - All mothers are giving a living example to the plan of redemption
  - As Christ had to suffer to make possible our spiritual birth and a life of glory, so women suffer pain to bring forth new life
  - God made the pain a part of Creation, but He instituted the suffering to bring the world to glory

- Next Paul moves from suffering in Creation, to examining the meaning of suffering in our personal experience

Rom. 8:23 And not only this, but also we ourselves, having the first fruits of the Spirit, even we ourselves groan within ourselves, waiting eagerly for our adoption as sons, the redemption of our body.
Rom. 8:24 For in hope we have been saved, but hope that is seen is not hope; for who hopes for what he already sees?
Rom. 8:25 But if we hope for what we do not see, with perseverance we wait eagerly for it.

- We too suffer (or groan) under the burden of the curse in our bodies
  - We too feel the weight of the curse in our own bodies
    - We suffer sickness, pain, toil, sweat, weakness, aging, and physical death
    - Paul says we know these things even though we have the first fruits of the Spirit
  - The term “first fruits” refers back to the requirement in the Law
    - In the Law, a farmer’s proper service of worship to God was to offer back to God the first produce from his harvest
    - It was a way of acknowledging to God that all the farmer received was from God’s grace
  - Paul uses that term to refer to the deposit of the Holy Spirit in each believer
    - The Spirit is the first part of what God has planned to give us in Christ

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        - He is the first fruits of glory, and Paul says despite having this deposit, nevertheless we still suffer
    - This one verse is a silver bullet putting to death the prosperity Gospel or any version of that lie which maintains that God wants us to be happy, rich and free of sickness
        - Paul says that's not true, at least not while we live on this earth in this body
        - He says even we groan within ourselves
        - That's another way of saying we too know the feeling of suffering inside ourselves
        - Even believers will have this experience, and it's one God ordained for all humanity in the curse
        - Just as God brought childbirth pains to women and brought the Creation under a curse and brought Jesus to pain on the cross
- But like Creation itself, we bear up under the curse knowing that in a day to come we will experience the redemption of our body
    - That's what living with eyes for eternity means
        - It means not fixing your gaze on the problems of today to the exclusion of appreciating where the Lord is going
        - Rather, we are to live in the midst of suffering without allowing that suffering to define us or obscure our hope for the eternal
    - Too often Christians respond to this truth with a "yes, but…" mentality
        - We agree that the eternal place of our glory should be our focus
        - But then we quickly say but I have to deal with the problems of today and they are causing me great grief
    - That's trying to have your cake and eat it too
        - Of course, we must deal with what life brings us
        - Just as Christ had to deal with the cross
        - But for Christ, the suffering of the cross wasn't a problem to be solved
        - It was an experience to submit to, for the good things God intended to accomplish through it
    - So it should be with us in our everyday concerns
        - They are not problems to be solved, even as we must work to address them in one way or another
        - Rather they are experiences to submit to in a trust that God is using them to produce good for us
        - And in that we can endure the present without losing an eternal perspective
- More importantly, we don't begin to worry that they are a threat to our relationship with God
    - We have been saved by a hope that Christ will raise us from the dead, just as He was raised

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        - And that hope is based in a promise from God, so we have taken it as trustworthy
        - But still, it is a hope, since we have not seen it happen as yet
    - Therefore, Paul reminds us in v.24 that we shouldn't be surprised that we don't see good things while we're waiting for our redemption
        - We hope for good things in eternity, and that hope is our faith in God to fulfill His promises to us
        - But when we demand that He present those good things to us now, as those who preach the prosperity Gospel will tell you, then we stop operating in faith
        - Paul says who hopes for what he already sees or has?
    - So in truth, those of faith should expect to be without what we expect while we are in the body
        - But we expect good things to follow this age
        - And that's why we call it faith
        - Don't trade that eternal hope for something of this world, for Paul says that isn't faith
    - But for the one who remains fixed in that eternal hope, who lives with eyes for eternity, that one will persevere
        - Perseverance is not something that comes and goes for the believer
        - The believer who has his or her hope in eternal things, will persevere in earthly suffering because we understand that's what comes before glory
        - Like the mother who preservers through childbirth pain because she knows where it's leading
    - So ironically, the one who puts his hope in temporal glory, prosperity or healing or whatever, that person is less likely to persevere
        - Because as they place their trust in something they expect to see, when it doesn't materialize they give up
        - But since we know we will not see our glory before our death, we have every reason to persevere in waiting and serving Christ
- And we don't do this waiting alone

Rom. 8:26 In the same way the Spirit also helps our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we should, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words;
Rom. 8:27 and He who searches the hearts knows what the mind of the Spirit is, because He intercedes for the saints according to the will of God.

- In the same way the Spirit works with us to support us through our weaknesses
    - When we feel like we can't go longer in this world, when we can't find hope, when

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we don't see the goodness of God, or when we doubt God's love…

- Then the Spirit intercedes for us
- When we don't even know how to pray or don't even think to do it, the Spirit prays for us
- The Spirit of God brings petitions before the Lord on our behalf, interceding for us

- This is a stunning revelation for the believer
  - None of us are satisfied with our prayer life
  - We all know we should spend more time in prayer, but even when we're failing in this area of our walk, did you know the Spirit is still interceding for us?
- And His interceding far exceeds even our own
  - He can communicate with the Father in ways too deep to be expressed in words
  - So that even if we were inclined to pray as the Spirit does, we couldn't do it
  - We don't have the capacity to speak to God the way God can speak to Himself
- And when the Spirit prays, he knows our hearts even more fully than we know ourselves and He knows the will of God perfectly
  - So when the Spirit prays on our behalf, He prays for exactly what you need, even things you yourself don't know or won't acknowledge
  - And He prays in keeping with the will of God, something He knows infinitely better than we do

- So here's what that means…the Spirit is bringing us through this life in ways perfectly suited to benefit us and please the Lord
  - Which means that when we were too busy pursuing the world instead of praying, or praying for selfish, stupid things, the Spirit was way ahead of us
    - He knows the sin in our heart, so He prayed for circumstances to expose it causing us to confess it and put it away
    - Or when we were getting spiritually lazy, He prayed for the Lord to send us trials so we could experience some suffering to strengthen our walk
    - In other words, the suffering we know is sometimes things the Spirit intercedes to bring us so that we might please God
  - This whole world of suffering is a learning laboratory for us while we wait for what God has promised
    - We make the best of it by learning the lessons the Lord brings us, while maintaining eyes for eternity
    - Knowing that the present sufferings are not worthy to be compared to the glory that is to be revealed
- When you understand this principle properly, you begin to see everything that's happening in your life in a different, and more spiritually-mature, way
  - You begin to understand God's control over everything that happens

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        - And equally important, you appreciate the potential for good things to come from even the worst experiences in life
        - Just as your own salvation came from God dying in your place
        - Paul summarizes this in one of the best known passages in the New Testament

Rom. 8:28 And we know that God causes all things to work together for good to those who love God, to those who are called according to His purpose.
Rom. 8:29 For those whom He foreknew, He also predestined to become conformed to the image of His Son, so that He would be the firstborn among many brethren;
Rom. 8:30 and these whom He predestined, He also called; and these whom He called, He also justified; and these whom He justified, He also glorified.

- While many believers can probably quote Romans 8:28, we probably overlook where it starts
    - And we know...
        - Paul begins with an assumption that we understand and agree with this principle
        - It's almost as if he doesn't think he needs to convince us of anything
    - How can he be sure?
        - Because it's the natural conclusion we come to after appreciating the enormity of Romans 8:1-27
        - Those circumstances that lead to suffering are ordained by God according to His will for us and to our benefit
        - Often they are the direct result of the Spirit of God interceding to bring them about
    - Therefore, there can be no such thing as something bad that God isn't using or in control of for His purposes
        - Paul says God is not passive in the time we spend on earth waiting for our glory
        - Rather God is active in our circumstances, causing things to go as they do
        - He works, He actively intercedes and brings to a purposeful and intentional end
- But notice an important caveat in this verse: God is working in these ways for the good of those who love Him, those called into faith according to God's purpose
    - So there are the "haves" and the "have-nots" in God's economy
        - The believers will find that all circumstances in their life, even the very bad ones, will have been used by God to bring good outcomes in eternity
        - While in the case of unbelievers, God is no less in control, but His purpose is not to bring them good, eternally speaking
    - There would be no purpose in God causing things to happen for good in the life of

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someone not called into a relationship with God

- Because that person will never be able to take advantage of that good outcome
- It would be like God working circumstances for the good of that Rich Man from Luke 16
- If God has no plans to call such a man into faith, then those good lessons will never pay off for him

- So the confidence we have in God's plans are limited to those who are God's (or will be in an appointed day)
  - We can't tell the unbelieving world that everything will be OK in the end
  - Or that God is on their side
  - These are false assurances
  - Instead, we must tell them the Gospel so that Romans 8:28 will become true for them

- So as we reach v.28, we come to understand that as we wait patiently in hope for our resurrection, nothing we face here poses a threat to that outcome
  - Life may be hard, we will have trials, the enemy will bear down on each of us in his own way
    - But nothing comes between us and God
    - Nothing can frustrate our hope, nothing has enough power to stop the good that God intends to bring His children
- Which leads Paul to his crescendo

Rom. 8:29 **For those whom He foreknew, He also predestined to become conformed to the image of His Son, so that He would be the firstborn among many brethren;**
Rom. 8:30 **and these whom He predestined, He also called; and these whom He called, He also justified; and these whom He justified, He also glorified.**

- Understanding this verse properly rests on two things
  - First, are you keeping Paul's point in mind and not straying into wrong alleys?
  - Secondly, are you willing to read the words and accept their plain meaning without explaining their meanings in novel and imaginative ways?
- Let's begin with some observations
  - First, there is an obvious chain of events being described here
  - Paul connects his chain with the linking word "also"
  - And God is the actor in this chain
  - Paul repeats "He" before every verb in the chain
- So God does one thing, and then He follows with another thing for the same group

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- And each link in the chain is as certain as the previous link, according to Paul
- So if the first link is true, then all that follows will always be true
- Paul never inserts a conditional phrase or thought in this chain so if the first is true, then the last will be true
- Likewise, if the last is true for someone, then the first link and everything in between was also true

- Second observation, Paul is using these verses to support his earlier statement that we can be assured no bad experiences in this life will bring our undoing
  - You can see his point clearly by briefly looking at the succeeding verse

Rom. 8:31 What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who is against us?

- Clearly, Paul wants to assure the reader that what God has begun, He will certainly finish, since all the work is His
- In fact, if any link in the chain could be seen as in doubt, then Paul's entire point becomes moot
- If the entire chain is not unbreakable, then Paul's assurance is empty and worthless
  - He can only assure us of God's faithfulness and sovereignty over all circumstances in our lives if his example is without exception
  - Every link in his chain is an absolute certainty, because each step is accomplished in God's will and plan
  - And God's will cannot be challenged
- So now let's look at the chain
  - First, who are those in this verse?
  - Is it all mankind?
  - No, because the people in view in this chain are the same ones as those in v.28: Christians
  - So we're not talking about unbelievers
- Next link: God foreknew
  - Much has been made of this word – *proginosko* – from which we get the word prognosticate
    - It means to understand the future with certainty
    - God's understanding predates all knowledge
    - He knew the Christians before time began
    - We were on His mind before we had a mind
  - Those He foreknew, God also predestined to become conformed to the image of His Son, so that He would be the firstborn among many brethren

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        - Here's where our careful observation of the plain language is key
        - Those He foreknew God also predestined
    - I can't hardly think of a word in scripture more emotionally charged than predestined
        - *Proorizo* – It means to determine beforehand
        - One of my favorite uses of the word comes in an often overlooked passage of Acts

Acts 4:27 **"For truly in this city there were gathered together against Your holy servant Jesus, whom You anointed, both Herod and Pontius Pilate, along with the Gentiles and the peoples of Israel,**
Acts 4:28 **to do whatever Your hand and Your purpose predestined to occur.**

- In that context, the meaning of the word is easy to see
    - Stephen is speaking about how God had intended that Jesus would die on the cross
    - His death was no accident. It was bad luck
    - It didn't happen at the whim of Pontius Pilate
    - It didn't happen because the Jews conspired to cause Jesus' death
- Stephen reminds the crowd what we all know from scripture, that the Father intended to put His Son to death from long before it happened
    - And He determined the manner of that death
    - Stephen says that Jesus died because God predetermined that Jesus would die on the cross
    - And when the appointed time arrived, God's predetermined plan was carried out under God's guidance and direction
    - As Stephen says, they did whatever your hand and purpose predestined
- So let's take that simple meaning and bring it back to the text
    - God predetermined that "those" He foreknew would be conformed to the image of His Son
    - Image means likeness or representation
        - To be conformed to His likeness means to be a Christian, to be saved – but it's deeper than that
        - It's also to join Him in His suffering and ultimately to join Him in glory
    - Remember Paul's point is that nothing can stop this chain of events
        - God knew you from before the beginning, assigned you to become like His Son and made that determination before the world began
        - How can anything in this world interrupt a plan that began before the world itself was established?

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- That's how Paul can bring the chain to conclusion in the next verse: called, justified, glorified
  - Since God determined to conform you to His Son's likeness, then naturally God must act according to His plan to call you into a relationship
    - So that as you answer that call, you can be justified through faith
    - And surely if you have been justified through faith, then you can be sure that you will see the glory or resurrection on a future day
    - That's Paul's point…it's the climax of his essay on righteousness
  - He has been describing a chain of events that led to your salvation
    - And for every believer who has ever read this letter, they can look back and see every step in this chain as a part of their personal history…
    - Every link except one…no believer reading Paul's letter will have yet experienced the last step
    - The step of glorification…this is the final step for all of us
  - So Paul wants the believer to be as assured of the future fulfillment of that step, as we are sure of our past steps that bought us to where we are now
    - This assurance is possible because God had the whole thing determined before even step one happened

Eph. 1:3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places in Christ,
Eph. 1:4 just as He chose us in Him before the foundation of the world, that we would be holy and blameless before Him. In love
Eph. 1:5 He predestined us to adoption as sons through Jesus Christ to Himself, according to the kind intention of His will,
Eph. 1:6 to the praise of the glory of His grace, which He freely bestowed on us in the Beloved.

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- Our previous lesson ended in Romans 8 at v.30 and the end of that glorious chain of events which Paul declared was the future of every believer
  - The ultimate consequence of our salvation by grace through faith in Jesus Christ is that we are assured a future of glory with Christ
    - And that assurance isn't based in anything of ourselves
    - Paul's chain of events is entirely a work of God on our behalf
    - Beginning with God's choice of us before the foundations of the earth
  - The chain was unbreakable and inevitable, as Paul describes each link connected with the prior link without doubt
    - So for everyone God includes in the plan of salvation, He will not fail to finish the work He begins
    - And as I ended the last lesson, I explained that every believer in the church, past, present or future, sits at the fifth link together
    - We all were foreknown by God, predestined to become His child, called on a day into faith, and justified in God's sight by our faith
  - So now we are all waiting for that final link in the chain, our glorification
    - And that's the main thrust of Paul's argument and why he laid out each step in the chain so carefully
    - There were five links for everyone, and five of the six have already come to pass for all of us
    - So Paul draws our attention to where we sit on the chain today, and he leads us to the inevitable conclusion
  - If God has taken us this far, by His power and not because of anything we've done, then how can we doubt He will bring us to the final link
    - To assume otherwise is both illogical and unbiblical
    - The only conclusion we can make from what God has already done for us is that our future of glory with Him is equally assured
    - And that's the conclusion Paul makes as well

Rom. 8:31 What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who is against us?
Rom. 8:32 He who did not spare His own Son, but delivered Him over for us all, how will He not also with Him freely give us all things?

- Paul asks the question raised by his unbreakable chain…if God is working so hard to bring us to Himself in a day to come, then what can stop it?
  - Who is more powerful than God? Who could change His mind or thwart His desires?
    - Obviously, we know the answer is "no one"
    - But let the implications of that answer sink in for a moment

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        - The highest power in the universe has determined you will be glorified in a day to come
    - No other actor or power has the capability to change that plan, so it puts to an end any concerns for your eternal security
        - There may be moments of despair or frustration when we let our minds wander to think we are in jeopardy
        - Or our lack of commitment to the faith leads us to wander away and question whether we are at an end with God
        - But if God determined to bring you to glory, then who are you to stop Him? before the devil even existed
    - Paul says the ultimate proof that God will not be swayed in His support for us is seen in His willingness to put Christ on a cross for our sake
        - Once again, Paul is asking us to consider the implications of what we already know to be true
        - The Father took the thing most precious to Him, His only begotten Son, and delivered Him over to die a horrible death
        - He did this to bring you and me to Himself, having already foreknown us and predestined us to receive His grace
    - So how ridiculous would it be to consider that after God had done such extreme things for our sake that He would then allow the plan short to fail in the end
        - That's why Jesus said this:

John 6:37 **"All that the Father gives Me will come to Me, and the one who comes to Me I will certainly not cast out.**
John 6:38 **"For I have come down from heaven, not to do My own will, but the will of Him who sent Me.**
John 6:39 **"This is the will of Him who sent Me, that of all that He has given Me I lose nothing, but raise it up on the last day.**

- Notice Jesus' choice of verbs and you'll find the links in Paul's chain
    - The Father "gives" Jesus the people that Jesus will save (**foreknown** and **predestined**)
    - Those He gives "will" come to Jesus (**called**)
    - Those who come will not be rejected by God (**justified**)
    - And in v.39 Jesus concludes that all the Father gives Him in this way, Jesus will lose none (all will be **glorified**)
- We can sum up Paul's analysis with a simple but profound statement
    - God only calls and justifies those He intends to glorify in Christ
        - The Bible calls these people "the elect" because God selects them from among all fallen humanity to receive glory

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        - So you aren't standing on the fifth link of Paul's chain because of your merits or effort or even because of your desire to be saved
        - You're there because God put you there
    - As John wrote

John 1:12 But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, even to those who believe in His name,
John 1:13 who were born, not of blood nor of the will of the flesh nor of the will of man, but of God.

- We were given the right to be children of God
    - And John says God didn't give us that blessing because of our family connections (blood) or our good works (will of flesh)
    - Nor even because of our own desire (will of man)
    - But solely because God elected us to be His
- As Paul says in 1 Corinthians, you are in Christ by His doing

1Cor. 1:30 But by His doing you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, and righteousness and sanctification, and redemption,

- And if God has elected you to be with Him in glory, can we imagine anything that could stop God from getting what He wants?
    - Paul explores some possibilities next

Rom. 8:33 Who will bring a charge against God's elect? God is the one who justifies;
Rom. 8:34 who is the one who condemns? Christ Jesus is He who died, yes, rather who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who also intercedes for us.
Rom. 8:35 Who will separate us from the love of Christ? Will tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?
Rom. 8:36 Just as it is written,
"For Your sake we are being put to death all day long;
We were considered as sheep to be slaughtered."
Rom. 8:37 But in all these things we overwhelmingly conquer through Him who loved us.
Rom. 8:38 For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor things present, nor things to come, nor powers,
Rom. 8:39 nor height, nor depth, nor any other created thing, will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.
Paul begins in v.33, could our enemy stop God's plan?

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- The Bible says Satan is the accuser of the brethren
    - So perhaps we might imagine him coming before the throne with a damning accusation against us
    - Telling God of some terrible secret sin in our life
  - Would this cause God to change His mind concerning our glory?
    - Paul says remember, God is the one who has declared you justified
    - His is the judge and if the judge has already acquitted you of sin, then he will not entertain any new arguments from the prosecutor
    - How can you be condemned for sin when the One with the power to condemn has already taken that condemnation for you
    - And now He sits at the right hand of God as your advocate
    - Therefore no sin you commit, no matter how grievous, can separate you from the love of God
  - Then Paul asks in v.35, who else might separate us from the love of God?
    - If not Satan, can some tribulation or distress separate you?
    - A tribulation is an external threat to our peace, while distress is a personal difficulty
    - What about persecution perhaps leading us to deny Christ like Peter did?
    - Or perhaps a famine causes us to steal or turn our back on God in anger
    - Or nakedness (which is a reference to public shame)
    - Or peril, meaning physical violence, or sword, referring to execution?
- Before we give the obvious answer, did you notice something about that list?
  - The seven things Paul lists are an inventory of what the Lord experienced on the way to cross
    - He endured all these things for our sake
    - Paul's subtle point is that whatever has potential to cause us to act in unfaithful ways, Christ already walked those steps for us
    - And He was faithful all the way to death
  - And since we have been credited with Christ's perfect life by our faith, it matters not what we are able to endure in the face of such things
    - Paul explains this in v.37 when he says in all these things we overwhelmingly conquer through Christ
    - Paul's not promising that because we are Christians we will always be victorious over the troubles in our life
    - He's saying that Christ conquered them during His life, and since we have been credited with His success, we can't be defeated by them now
  - So even if we should fail at some step along the way, Christ's success will stand in place of our failure

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        - We have been credited with that faithfulness
        - So we can never be separated from the love of God
- This leads Paul in vs.38-39 to give perhaps his most sweeping and powerful statement of the assurance of eternal security for every believer
    - Given all that he's argued throughout this chapter, Paul says He has full conviction and confidence that we cannot be separated from God for any reason
        - To ensure we understand how sure Paul is in his convictions, he adds a series of ten forces that represent the extremities of this life and the next
        - Which he introduces with the first pair of death or life
        - Nothing on this side of the grave or on the other side of the grave holds the power to separate us from the love of God
    - And more specifically, no spiritual power or earthly power, no present existence or future existence
        - No power is greater than God
        - We can't go high enough to be out of His reach (so even Christian astronauts remain in God's love)
        - We can't go deep enough to hide from God's love (so Christian divers are still secure in Christ)
        - Simply put, nothing in Creation is capable of coming between us and the Lord Who has saved us and promised us glory in a day to come
- With that statement, the first Act in Paul's thesis on righteousness comes to a dramatic close
    - Looking down the left side of our Structure of Romans chart, we see Paul's logical development of his thesis clearly
        - He's walked us through a series of ideas carefully and methodically
        - He explained what righteousness is and why we need it
        - He explained how mankind errs in trying to find it in wrong ways
    - Then Paul explained the one and only way God grants it to us
        - He proved the plan has never changed since times of old
        - And he reflected on the implications of God's plan in the life of everyone who is saved by it
        - Ending here with the most important implication: we are His forever, without any doubt
        - God is faithful to do for us just as He promised
    - Now before we move into Paul's second act, you may have noticed that I skipped over v.36
        - In that verse, Paul punctuated his argument by quoting from Psalm 44
        - The psalmist declared, speaking as Israel, that God has allowed His children to be killed by their enemies "all day long"

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- The psalmist was lamenting Israel's difficult circumstances suffering under God's judgment
  - The phrase "killed all day long" is a euphemism
    - As Calvin explains, "the psalmist intimated that death was so suspended over them, that their life differed but little from death"
    - Israel has known many generations of such suffering as consequence for having violated the Old Covenant
    - They have been overrun by their enemies, exiled, persecuted and killed
    - And as the psalmist remarks, these things come at the hand of God, as a result of His will for His people
  - Paul's point in quoting this psalm was to demonstrate that throughout history God's people have been made to suffer at times
    - We are considered by God as sheep to be slaughtered, the psalmist says
    - So if necessary, God may bring us to death to achieve an eternal good purpose in us
    - Therefore, nothing that happens to us in this life – not even death itself – is a threat to God's plan for us
    - After all, He's the One Who gives life and takes it away
- But even with that explanation, Paul picked an odd verse to quote as proof for his argument, didn't he?
  - In fact, if we look at more of that psalm, Paul's choice becomes even more interesting and perplexing

Psa. 44:9 Yet You have rejected us and brought us to dishonor,
And do not go out with our armies.
Psa. 44:10 You cause us to turn back from the adversary;
And those who hate us have taken spoil for themselves.
Psa. 44:11 You give us as sheep to be eaten
And have scattered us among the nations.
Psa. 44:12 You sell Your people cheaply,
And have not profited by their sale.
Psa. 44:13 You make us a reproach to our neighbors,
A scoffing and a derision to those around us.
Psa. 44:14 You make us a byword among the nations,
A laughingstock among the peoples.
Psa. 44:15 All day long my dishonor is before me
And my humiliation has overwhelmed me,
Psa. 44:16 Because of the voice of him who reproaches and reviles,
Because of the presence of the enemy and the avenger.
Psa. 44:17 All this has come upon us, but we have not forgotten You,

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And we have not dealt falsely with Your covenant.
Psa. 44:18 **Our heart has not turned back,**
And our steps have not deviated from Your way,
Psa. 44:19 **Yet You have crushed us in a place of jackals**
And covered us with the shadow of death.
Psa. 44:20 **If we had forgotten the name of our God**
Or extended our hands to a strange god,
Psa. 44:21 **Would not God find this out?**
For He knows the secrets of the heart.
Psa. 44:22 **But for Your sake we are killed all day long;**
We are considered as sheep to be slaughtered.
Psa. 44:23 **Arouse Yourself, why do You sleep, O Lord?**
Awake, do not reject us forever.
Psa. 44:24 **Why do You hide Your face**
And forget our affliction and our oppression?
Psa. 44:25 **For our soul has sunk down into the dust;**
Our body cleaves to the earth.
Psa. 44:26 **Rise up, be our help,**
And redeem us for the sake of Your lovingkindness.

- From reading more of the psalm, we come to see it's a lamentation for Israel
  - The psalmist says the nation feels rejected by their God
    - He seems to have forsaken His people
    - Rejecting them and leaving them to the mercy of their adversaries who desire to destroy them
    - They are a derision, are a reproach, reviled
    - God allows them to be sold cheaply as slaves, scattered like sheep
  - Now this hardly seems like the psalm to choose if your point was to demonstrate that we can have confidence in God to protect us
    - Paul was arguing that nothing can separate us from the love of God
    - And in the midst of that argument, Paul cites a psalm that has as its major theme the lamentation of a seemingly rejected Israel
    - If anything, the psalm seems to make the opposite argument
  - But if we look at the psalm again, we find an interesting detail
    - At the end of the psalm, just after the part Paul quoted, the psalmist suddenly turns optimistic
    - In v.23 the psalmist describes God's rejection of His people as a "sleep" from which God may at some point awaken from
    - And then He may cease His rejection of His people and return to them

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- And so he asks the Lord to "rise up" and to be Israel's help in their affliction
  - He asks the Lord to redeem His people Israel for the sake of God's lovingkindness
  - That word is a reference to God's covenants
  - Lovingkindness is a covenant word that describes the Lord's willingness to make covenants with men unconditionally
  - And to keep them faithfully as a measure of His love for us
  - So the psalmist is referring to the Lord's covenants with Israel, asking the Lord to keep them faithfully

- So why did Paul quote this psalm to argue his point of eternal security? Why pick a passage that seems to argue for an opposite conclusion?
  - He picked it because of what the psalmist says at the end
    - Despite the Lord's hard treatment of His people at various times in history, the end ultimately determines God's faithfulness
    - Just as our own life has many twists and turns, trials and disappointments, we can't judge God's faithfulness to us until we see how it ends
    - The psalmist declares confidently that the Lord's lovingkindness would prevail in the end
  - But Paul used this passage for another reason, one that sets up the next three chapters of the book
    - Paul wanted to draw his readers' attention to the question of Israel
    - Israel's relationship to the Lord was a complicated situation, one that seemed to argue against Paul's teaching on eternal security
  - At the time Paul wrote this letter to Rome, the church was quickly becoming a Gentile organization
    - What had started as a Jewish movement in Jerusalem was now largely centered in Asia Minor among Gentiles
    - What's more, the vast majority of Jews had rejected Christ as their Messiah
    - In fact, Jews were frequently persecuting those who declared Jesus as Messiah
  - So it was becoming increasingly apparent that the Jewish people were not going to embrace Christ
    - And if they do not acknowledge Jesus as Messiah, then the people of Israel cannot be saved
    - And if they are not saved, then what does this say about the faithfulness of God?
    - Didn't God promise that Abraham, Isaac and Jacob would have innumerable descendants who would receive the promises of the Kingdom?

- So one could ask, is God rejecting His people after all?
  - That's the conclusion some come to at the point of Chapter 8
    - Paul has proven that righteousness comes only through faith in Christ…not by

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birth to Abraham but only by the faith of Abraham

- So if the Jewish nation is to receive the promises God gave to their forefathers, the nation must come to accept Jesus
- But in Paul's day it was becoming increasingly obvious that this wasn't happening, and in fact the church was becoming less and less Jewish

- Yet Paul said that God is in control of the saving process, including predestining the elect from before time
  - If so, then Israel's rejection of Jesus would seem to suggest God has purposely rejected them
  - And if God has rejected Israel after having made promises to them, how can we be sure God will keep His promises to us too?
- In other words, Israel's rejection of Christ calls into question everything Paul has argued for the Church
  - How can we feel secure in our salvation when we see God's people, Israel, rejected?
  - What's to stop God from rejecting us too?
- Remember, the leadership of the church in Rome were Jews who received the Gospel at Pentecost
  - Many of those Jewish founders were still leading the church in Rome in Paul's day
  - And Paul knew they would be sensitive to the question of Israel's state of unbelief
  - So Paul knew he needed to address that question

- So for the next three chapters, Paul focuses on answering the question "What about Israel?"
  - More specifically, why didn't God elect Israel to receive their Messiah, which God promised to send them?
    - What does Israel's situation say about God's faithfulness?
    - Has God forsaken His people as the psalmist feared?
    - Or will God one day fulfill His promises to His people as the psalmist pleaded at the end of Psalm 44?
  - Paul spends three chapters addressing the question "What about Israel?
    - In Chapter 9 Paul reviews Israel's past relationship with God
    - The history of Israel is important to understanding what God is working to achieve in that nation
  - In Chapter 10, Paul moves to explaining Israel's present circumstances of having rejected their Messiah
    - Paul's dividing point between past and present is the Messiah's first coming
    - So Chapter 10 examines God's plan for Israel during the time following Christ's

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appearing

- Finally in Chapter 11 Paul reveals God's future plan for His people Israel
  - He'll explain how God remains faithful to Israel just as the psalmist hoped
  - And he explains why Israel's temporary rejection was necessary to achieve the good things God promised to them and to us
- So Chapters 9, 10 and 11 are Israel's past, present and future
  - And together, these chapters address the question of what about Israel?
  - Altogether, they put to rest any concerns that Israel's unbelief casts doubt on God's faithfulness to His children

- Before we dive into the start of Chapter 9, take a brief look at the opening of Chapter 12
  - Compare the opening line of that chapter with the ending of Chapter 8
    - You'll notice that the two chapters flow together almost seamlessly
    - In fact, if I removed Chapters 9-11 from your Bible, you would never have noticed they were missing
    - Paul's discussion of righteousness flows easily from the end of 8 into 12
  - This affirms for us that these next three chapters are a sidebar in Paul's main discussion
    - His thesis on righteousness is essentially suspended for three chapters while he deals with this important question
    - So that's where we're going to be too for a while
- Let's look at the start of Chapter 9; Israel's past
  - As we do, we need to appreciate an important shift in Paul's focus
    - Where before Paul taught about an individual's relationship to God, now Paul is describing a nation's relationship
    - Paul uses these chapters is specific address Israel's past, present and future as a nation
    - Obviously, the nation is made up of individuals, and each individual still has a requirement of faith in order to be saved
  - But the question we're examining is what do we make of God's obvious choice to leave Jewish people largely outside the call of the Gospel for this time?
    - It's self-evident that the Church is almost entirely Gentile
    - And we know God determines His elect, as Paul taught
    - So the question is why did God not permit His people to embrace the Messiah while He brought Gentiles from all over the world
  - This distinction is important to remember, because it will guide our interpretation of some important concepts presented in these chapters
    - So when interpreting Paul, we must ask is Paul speaking about the experience of an individual believer or the unique experience of Israel

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        - And then allow our interpretation to fit the context

Rom. 9:1 I am telling the truth in Christ, I am not lying, my conscience testifies with me in the Holy Spirit,
Rom. 9:2 that I have great sorrow and unceasing grief in my heart.
Rom. 9:3 For I could wish that I myself were accursed, separated from Christ for the sake of my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh,
Rom. 9:4 who are Israelites, to whom belongs the adoption as sons, and the glory and the covenants and the giving of the Law and the temple service and the promises,
Rom. 9:5 whose are the fathers, and from whom is the Christ according to the flesh, who is over all, God blessed forever. Amen.

- Paul opens this section in a diplomatic fashion, defending his motives concerning Israel
    - Paul recognized he was wading into dangerous waters and his answers might not please everyone
        - The history of the church has validated Paul's concerns
        - Paul's explanation in this chapter and the ones that follow have stirred considerable controversy
        - Many Christians have simply rejected what Paul teaches, preferring a different explanation
    - So Paul begins by reassuring his audience that he is no antisemite
        - It's hard to believe anyone could think Paul was against the Jewish people
        - But remember Paul's ministry was focused on Gentiles, even as he also spent time seeking Jews too
        - So now as he begins to explain God's plans for Israel, he wants his audience to trust his personal motives
    - Paul says he is not lying in what he will say about Israel, and the Holy Spirit testifies in agreement to all who receive these words
        - That Paul grieves for Israel's loss as they reject Christ
        - In fact, Paul says if it were up to him, he would willingly trade his own salvation for Israel's
        - Obviously, that wasn't possible and Paul acknowledges that reality
    - But the fact that Paul says this (he's not lying) is remarkable, because Paul knew better than most what he would have been trading away
        - And that's not a deal most (if any) of us would make, is it?
        - It's a very strong statement about Paul's personal convictions for his people
        - We can hardly indict Paul's genuine concern for Israel given he was willing to spend eternity in Hell for their sake

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- And speaking of Israel, Paul offers a definition to guide his discussion
  - In vs.4-5 Paul gives the definition of Israel, the people in view in these three chapters
    - They are the Israelites, those descended from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob (the "fathers" in v.5)
    - They were a nation of people created by God and adopted as His people from among all the nations on earth
    - They were the people who live in the presence of God's glory in the tabernacle
    - They received the covenants of God, the Law of God and the temple and the promises of the prophets
    - Most importantly, they were the people from whom came Christ as promised
  - This definition is critical because it clarifies that Paul was talking about an earthly, physical Israel
    - He's not talking about the Church or Gentiles certainly
    - He's not talking about a "spiritual Israel" or some group of people who mimic Israel's lifestyle or culture or share in their beliefs
    - He's speaking only of the literal, physical descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob
    - The people from whom Jesus came
- And concerning these people, what do we say about their past relationship with God?
  - Would we dare say that the people of God have failed to receive the promises that God said they would receive?
    - After all, that's the crux of the issue here
    - We know in the past God called this people special
    - He went to the trouble to form them out of nothing, to place them in their land and dwell among them
    - He also promised them a Messiah – but He didn't permit them to receive Him
  - So Paul asks the obvious question first

Rom. 9:6 But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For they are not all Israel who are descended from Israel;
Rom. 9:7 nor are they all children because they are Abraham's descendants, but: "through Isaac your descendants will be named."
Rom. 9:8 That is, it is not the children of the flesh who are children of God, but the children of the promise are regarded as descendants.
Rom. 9:9 For this is the word of promise: "At this time I will come, and Sarah shall have a son."

- Already we begin to see how important Paul's definition will be

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- Because he says that if we think that Israel's rejection of Jesus means the word of God concerning Israel has failed, then we're looking at the wrong Israel
- Because Paul says not all who are are descended from the man Israel (Jacob) are considered God's Israel
- What Paul is saying is this: to be considered Israel, it is necessary to be descended from Jacob but it is not sufficient
    - There is more to being part of God's Israel than merely having the right father
    - So if we're going to evaluate God's faithfulness to His promises to Israel, we must first make sure we're looking at the right Israel
    - We must understand which group of people God gave His promises to in the past before we can evaluate His faithfulness today
- Paul proves his point with a simple example of Abraham's children
    - Abraham had two sons, Isaac and Ishmael
        - Yet only one of them received the promises God gave to Abraham
        - God issued His promises to Abraham before he had any children
        - But later Abraham learned that when God spoke those promises, He only had one of Abraham's descendants in mind
    - Paul shows evidence for this truth from Genesis 21, when Abraham was told that only through Isaac would God number (or consider) Abraham's descendants
        - Abraham had other descendants through another son
        - But those descendants did not receive the promises God gave to Abraham
        - So if we looked at those descendants, we might think God was not faithful to His promises
    - But we would be wrong, because God had already determined who would receive His promises
        - Or who His elect were to be
        - And He determined they would come through Isaac alone
        - As He spoke to Sarah saying it would be a certain son to receive God's promises, not all sons
        - This choice is a prerogative God never relinquishes
    - Therefore, Abraham's example leaves us with an important principle that will carry us through the rest of this chapter and into Chapter 10
        - It was not Abraham's earthly or fleshly children that are in view when God issued His promises
        - Only certain children He calls "children of the promise" were in view
        - The term children of promise means those God chooses receive His promises
    - There is nothing inherently better about these children of course
        - They didn't do anything to deserve God's favor (that's why it's called grace)

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        - They were simply chosen to receive the promises while others weren't included
        - And that distinction is one God repeats throughout history
- If you were tempted to think that Abraham's situation was unique, Paul offers Exhibit #2:

Rom. 9:10 And not only this, but there was Rebekah also, when she had conceived twins by one man, our father Isaac;
Rom. 9:11 for though the twins were not yet born and had not done anything good or bad, so that God's purpose according to His choice would stand, not because of works but because of Him who calls,
Rom. 9:12 it was said to her, "The older will serve the younger."
Rom. 9:13 Just as it is written, "Jacob I loved, But Esau I hated."

- One generation later, Isaac faces a similar situation with his own children
    - He too had a barren wife until God opened the womb
    - And when He did, He gave Rebekah twin boys
- And once again God demonstrates His prerogative to choose by telling Rebekah that the older son would serve the younger
    - That's a somewhat cryptic way of designating the child of the promise
    - In that culture, the older child received the patriarchal blessing as a birthright and the greater share of the family inheritance
    - But in the case of Isaac's family, there was another unique part of the estate that would be handed down too
    - It was the promise God gave to Abraham which went to Isaac
- That promise could only be inherited by one child, since it wasn't divisible
- But to make sure we see God acting apart from man's ways, God selects the younger child to be His child of promise
    - Notice Paul says the Lord expressed this desire before the twins were born
        - Paul says the Lord selected this timing to ensure we couldn't say that the boys merely received what they deserved
        - They hadn't done anything good or bad at that point, Paul says
        - So neither son had anything to commend or discredit himself before God
    - And Paul says the Lord did this to ensure we would conclude that the chosen child was made so according to God's grace and not by an act of human consideration
        - It was merely on the basis of God's call, His election of Jacob over Esau
        - Paul backs his conclusion with a quote from Malachi
    - God declared that He "loved" Jacob and "hated" Esau
        - Those terms are loaded with emotion for us, so they seem harsh to us

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        - We feel as though we need to explain them away
        - Some say that God made his choice on the basis of what he knew these boys would do in the future
        - But Paul's words specifically preclude that interpretation, since Paul says God made his declaration in advance to preclude such a conclusion
    - So we must understand the words hate and love in the context of God's choice
        - They are definitions really
        - To be chosen by God is to be loved by God
        - To be passed over by God is to be hated, not in an emotional sense, but simply in the sense of being the opposite of love
    - But the point is it was God who determined which boy received the promise
        - It wasn't on the basis of personal merit
        - And that's how God's choice works throughout history
        - God's elect are not elected on the basis of merit but merely on the basis of God's gracious choice
- If you look for it, this is a common pattern of God in scripture
    - God commonly chooses those who the world would not expect to receive the honor
        - Isaac was the younger, but God chose Him over the older
        - Same for Jacob over Esau
        - Same for Judah over Reuben
        - Same for Joseph over his brothers
        - Same for David over his brothers
    - And men like Moses, Gideon, the prophets, the apostles, Paul particularly were all unlikely heroes chosen by God
        - As Paul himself explains to the church, this pattern is intended to expose man's foolishness in thinking he knows how God works
        - God intentionally works against the nature thinking of sinful men to show Himself stronger

1Cor. 1:25 Because the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men.
1Cor. 1:26 For consider your calling, brethren, that there were not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble;
1Cor. 1:27 but God has chosen the foolish things of the world to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to shame the things which are strong,
1Cor. 1:28 and the base things of the world and the despised God has chosen, the things that are not, so that He may nullify the things that are,

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1Cor. 1:29 so that no man may boast before God.
1Cor. 1:30 But by His doing you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, and righteousness and sanctification, and redemption,
1Cor. 1:31 so that, just as it is written, "Let him who boasts, boast in the Lord."

- Doesn't the truth of God's sovereign election reveal God to be mean and unfair?
  - This is probably the single most common, natural thought for every person who grasps the Biblical truth of God's sovereign election
    - In fact, it's easily the most common reason for why some people refuse to accept this truth
    - It's become a particularly strong sentiment in the Western Hemisphere in the last 200 years
    - Probably because independence, freedom, equality, and being self-made are so ingrained in our culture
  - We automatically count it unfair anytime someone is without equal opportunity or complete self-determination
    - The idea that anyone or anything else may be in control of our destiny is offensive and just plain wrong
    - Specifically, isn't it wrong that God is at work electing some but leaving others outside the family
- That's the question we address next week in the rest of this chapter

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- What about Israel?
  - That's the question Paul set out to answer in Chapters 9-11
    - At the end of Chapter 8, Paul had just concluded his compelling argument for our eternal security in Christ
    - Paul demonstrated that God sets in motion a chain of events to bring us into glory
    - And that chain is unbreakable, for God determined we would receive His mercy before the foundations of the earth
    - So what God has determined for our sake from before Creation began cannot be thwarted by anything in Creation
  - Yet at the same time, Paul recognized that Israel's rejection of their Messiah seemed to argue an opposite conclusion
    - To the casual observer, it seemed God promised Israel a Messiah only to set Israel aside when the promised Messiah finally arrived
    - For if God predestines His elect to salvation and nothing can challenge His will, then why didn't He save Israel?
    - Why did God reject His own people Israel while permitting the Gentiles to enter in His grace?
  - Even more concerning, what does God's rejection of His own people in this way suggest about His trustworthiness?
    - Might God reject us too one day?
    - Can we trust in the promises we've received in Christ or will we end up like Israel?
- Because Paul knew these questions would be on the mind of his Jewish readers (and perhaps some Gentiles), Paul felt compelled to address the question of what about Israel?
  - So Paul suspends his discourse on righteousness to answer several critical questions in defense of God's faithfulness
    - Paul will explain why God didn't call the nation of Israel into faith when He delivered on His promise to bring the Messiah
    - He'll explain where God's plan is going next for Israel
    - And he'll show how God will remain faithful to His promises to Israel in a day to come
  - Paul organizes his response chronologically, explaining Israel's past, present and future circumstances from God's perspective
    - Chapter 9 reviews Israel's past, specifically who received the promises of God
    - Chapter 10 explains Israel's present circumstances of having rejected the Messiah and His Gospel
    - And Chapter 11 reveals God's eventual plans to fulfill His promises to His people Israel

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        - Perhaps most importantly, Chapter 11 also explains why it was necessary that God enact such a complex plan
- Last week we ended at Romans 9:13, just as Paul finished explaining God's prerogative to decide who may receive His promises
    - The Lord made promises to Abraham concerning a nation of people called Israel
        - But as Paul explained, God had a very specific "Israel" in view when He issued His promises
        - God's promises were intended only for a certain group of descendants from Abraham
        - Not everyone who descended from Abraham would be included in God's grace
    - To prove his point, Paul cited examples from Abraham and Isaac's own family
        - In both men's cases, God preselected one of their children to receive His promises and excluded another
        - God communicated His selections in advance of their births and without regard to the children's behavior or desires
        - In short, God simply chose one child and passed over the other
    - Paul's point is that throughout Israel's history, God alone determined who will be included in His promises
        - Not all born of these men were automatically included in God's plan
        - God's grace is dispensed not on the basis of birthright or our effort to win His favor or even according to our will or desire, as John 1 taught
    - Rather, God extends His grace to those whom He chooses in advance
        - In Israel's case, God chose some of Abraham's descendants to receive His promises, but not all of them
        - As I said last week, to be considered part of God's Israel, it was necessary to descend from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, but it was not sufficient
- Therefore, the first lesson we learned concerning Israel's past is that God never intended to bless all Jews with His promises
    - Only a subgroup of Jews, called the elect, were selected to receive the promises of God
        - Furthermore, God's selectivity among His people is not the exception but rather the rule
        - Therefore, we shouldn't be surprised to see that pattern repeating when Jesus appeared to Israel
        - Some Jews were appointed to receive the promised Messiah upon His arrival, but most were not
    - This fact raises some difficult questions…questions Paul anticipated we would ask
        - Beginning with the question that opens tonight's teaching:

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Rom. 9:14 What shall we say then? There is no injustice with God, is there? May it never be!
Rom. 9:15 For He says to Moses, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion."
Rom. 9:16 So then it does not depend on the man who wills or the man who runs, but on God who has mercy.
Rom. 9:17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh, "For this very purpose I raised you up, to demonstrate My power in you, and that My name might be proclaimed throughout the whole earth."
Rom. 9:18 So then He has mercy on whom He desires, and He hardens whom He desires.

- Upon hearing Paul explain that God selects only some to receive His promises, we immediately wonder if this is just?
  - We know God is good and righteous in all that He does, and yet Paul's explanation seems to paint God in an unfavorable way
    - Isn't Paul's explanation depicting God as cruel or even unjust?
    - Isn't a God who only extends His mercy to some unfair, unkind, & unloving to those He passes over?
    - And as a result, we may be tempted to reject Paul's teaching out of hand or seek an alternate interpretation to explain it away
  - Paul knew we would feel this way, because it's the natural reaction of an untrained spiritual mind
    - When it comes to deciding justice and mercy, the accused always feels as if he knows better than the judge what the proper judgment should be
    - But of course, the opposite is true
- So Paul asks the question on our behalf in v.14 so he may put this objection to rest
  - Paul says emphatically, God is never unjust
    - Notice, Paul doesn't retreat from his earlier teaching at all
    - He simply denies that the reality of God's selectivity suggests that He is unjust
  - In other words, God is both selective with His mercy and just in doing so
    - Our natural thinking assumes that God owes every human being an opportunity to receive grace
    - As if we were born with an entitlement to His mercy
    - So we define "justice" and "love" as extending opportunity for mercy
  - But this is not a biblical concept nor is it even logical
    - The Bible never claims that love is defined as giving everyone an opportunity for mercy
    - On the contrary, love is defined this way:

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John 15:13 "Greater love has no one than this, that one lay down his life for his friends.
John 15:14 "You are My friends if you do what I command you.
John 15:15 "No longer do I call you slaves, for the slave does not know what his master is doing; but I have called you friends, for all things that I have heard from My Father I have made known to you.
John 15:16 "You did not choose Me but I chose you, and appointed you that you would go and bear fruit, and that your fruit would remain, so that whatever you ask of the Father in My name He may give to you.

- Notice that Jesus says the greatest love is laying your life down for "friends", not for everyone
- Furthermore, Jesus adds that these disciples were His friends because He chose them, they didn't choose Him
- So to say that all mankind has a right to God's mercy is contrary to the very meaning of the word grace
    - Grace means receiving something you were not entitled to have
    - No one has a right to grace, and God is not obligated by fairness or justice to extend salvation to everyone
    - The Bible says plainly God extends His mercy to those He chooses
- And once again, Paul turns to a prominent example from Israel's past to illustrate this truth at work
    - He cites the example of Moses in Exodus
        - And brilliantly, Paul chooses as his proof God's own words concerning this very topic
        - In explaining His ways of dealing with His people, the Lord told Moses in Exodus 33 that He decides who will receive His mercy
        - To paraphrase, God says He will have mercy and show compassion on those whom He chooses
    - Some people receive God's compassion and His mercy, and some do not
        - And this outcome is solely God's prerogative
        - God isn't moved to showing us mercy by something within us or even in response to something we say or do
        - God says He extends His compassion and mercy solely on the basis of His sovereign will and purpose
    - When doctors make life or death decisions concerning the future of a terminally ill patient, we commonly say the doctors are playing God
        - In that comment, we're acknowledging that life and death decisions are reserved for God alone
        - God alone has the power to determine the course of a life

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        - The Bible says you can't add a day to your life…God alone determines how long you live
    - So we acknowledge God's sovereignty over our physical life, but then we try to deny Him that same privilege concerning our spiritual life
        - We claim true love means man retaining the ultimate control over our eternal future
        - But if we're willing to extend God that privilege in one circumstance, then we cannot deny Him the same in the other
        - If He is God over physical life and death, than surely He is also God over spiritual life and death
        - And that's what God declares concerning Himself
- Paul summarizes God's statement in v.16 with a profoundly important principle
    - Paul says it does not depend on a man's willing, or working, but on God's choice
        - The "it" in that statement obviously refers back to v.15
        - It means God's mercy and compassion
    - So first, Paul says God's mercy doesn't depend on the man who wills
        - Our will refers to our desires, our own thoughts and assumptions about God
        - No man or woman wills their way into receiving God's mercy
        - Paul already demonstrated earlier in Chapter 3 that man's fallen never seeks for God in any case
        - So our will is not a factor in God's decision to extend mercy
    - Secondly, Paul says God's mercy won't depend on the man who runs
        - Running is a euphemism for doing good works
        - To run represents someone expending effort to please God hoping to be rewarded with mercy
        - Like someone running a race to receive a prize
    - But of course, God's mercy can't be earned, as Paul showed earlier in Chapter 4
        - So, God's mercy can't be chosen and it can't be earned
        - It only comes when God determines to extend it
- If Paul's teaching wasn't challenging enough already, Paul presses us harder with an example from Exodus in v.17 – one that provides a corollary to the first example
    - During the confrontation with Pharaoh in Egypt, the Lord reassured Moses that the Pharaoh would play a role that God assigned to him
        - God determined that Pharaoh would be His antagonist
        - God was ready to redeem His people from Egypt, just as He promised Abraham 400 years earlier
        - And God determined that He would do so only through a great display of His power and might

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- Therefore, God required an adversary leading Egypt who would resist God until a time when God was ready to end the battle
  - That man would be Pharaoh, who God raised up specifically to oppose Moses and God Himself
  - God told Moses that He raised up Pharaoh so God could display His power in defeating Pharaoh
- You can see further evidence of God's intentions when you look at the record of the plagues in Exodus
  - Altogether there were ten plagues against Egypt
  - And we know God intended to deliver all ten plagues against Egypt even before the first one began
  - We know this because God declared it to Moses before Moses even entered Egypt

Ex. 4:21 **The Lord said to Moses, "When you go back to Egypt see that you perform before Pharaoh all the wonders which I have put in your power; but I will harden his heart so that he will not let the people go.**
Ex. 4:22 **"Then you shall say to Pharaoh, 'Thus says the Lord, "Israel is My son, My firstborn.**
Ex. 4:23 **"So I said to you, 'Let My son go that he may serve Me'; but you have refused to let him go. Behold, I will kill your son, your firstborn."'"**

- Notice the Lord says the plagues will culminate in the killing of the first born
  - That's the tenth plague
  - It's the one that gives us the Passover observance
  - It's the plague that pictures the work of Jesus Christ as our sacrificial lamb
- Obviously, we couldn't imagine the Exodus story taking place without a tenth plague, and neither could God
  - Which is why God told Moses that He must harden Pharaoh's heart to ensure that all ten plagues take place as planned
    - God knew that no man, no matter how stubborn, can withstand His wrath for very long
    - Not even Pharaoh could maintain his opposition to God through ten plagues
    - Yet God had predetermined there would be ten plagues before Israel was released
  - So at a certain point in their confrontation, when Pharaoh's resistance was weakening, God stepped in to harden Pharaoh's heart so he would continue to battle

Ex. 7:1 **Then the Lord said to Moses, "See, I make you as God to Pharaoh, and**

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your brother Aaron shall be your prophet.
Ex. 7:2 **"You shall speak all that I command you, and your brother Aaron shall speak to Pharaoh that he let the sons of Israel go out of his land.**
Ex. 7:3 **"But I will harden Pharaoh's heart that I may multiply My signs and My wonders in the land of Egypt.**

- Notice the Lord says He will harden Pharaoh's heart "to multiply" His signs and wonders in Egypt
- In other words, hardening Pharaoh's heart would ensure the conflict continued and the plagues piled up higher
- And He did all this to demonstrate His power among the nations
- During the first six confrontations with Moses, scripture reports that Pharaoh's heart hardens itself
  - Pharaoh resists the will of God through his own stubbornness and disobedient will
  - But at a certain point, Pharaoh couldn't resist any longer
- After the sixth plague of boils, the text changes in a notable fashion

Ex. 9:12 **And the Lord hardened Pharaoh's heart, and he did not listen to them, just as the Lord had spoken to Moses.**

- Sure enough, the Lord stepped in to harden Pharaoh's heart against Moses just as the Lord promised
  - Without the Lord's intervention, Pharaoh would have given up
  - Not even a man as stubborn and defiant as Pharaoh could withstand God's wrath any longer
- But there were four more plagues remaining, so quitting wasn't an option for God
  - So God hardened Pharaoh's heart, ensuring the continuation of the plagues until the point God determined they should end
  - Just as He told Moses He would do
- Once again, Paul's point in his corollary example is as disconcerting as it is undeniable
  - Just as God dispenses His mercy upon those whom He chooses, God also displays His wrath against those He chooses
    - Now, no one could deny that Pharaoh deserved God's judgment
    - He was unquestionably a sinner
    - He was so opposed to God that he willingly endured six plagues rather than submit to God's authority
    - So we know his judgment was well-deserved
  - But God didn't wait to see Pharaoh's sinfulness before selecting Him to receive His

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wrath

- Nor did the Lord ever give Pharaoh an opportunity to repent or receive mercy
- The text of scripture says clearly that Pharaoh was raised up for the very purpose of opposing God

- And even when Pharaoh was ready to relent and submit to God's authority, God hardened His heart to continue to battle
  - Just as the Lord said He would do before the battle started
  - God didn't make Pharaoh a sinner…he was born that way
  - But God chose to put Pharaoh's sin to work rather than to rescue him from it
- And this is God's sovereign right, Paul says in v.18
  - God extends mercy to those He chooses, softening their hearts, and bringing them into glory
  - And likewise, God hardens those He chooses, confirming their opposition, ensuring their just condemnation
  - Therefore, among Abraham's descendants there were those who received God's mercy (Isaac) and those who didn't (Ishmael)

- As difficult as this concept may be for us to accept, God is no less holy, no less just, and no less good because He acts in this way
  - Paul said as much back in v.14
    - So we must accept that the truth of v.14 and the truth of v.18 work together in scripture
    - Everyone is born a sinner and justly due God's judgment
    - So God's goodness is evidenced in the fact that He extends mercy to anyone
  - Nevertheless, many Christians over the centuries have stopped at this point in Paul's argument and refused to go any further
    - They simply cannot accept the God Paul is describing
    - They believe Paul's depiction of God is at odds with the God who so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish, but have eternal life
    - The God of John 3:16 doesn't sound like a God who only extends His mercy to some while hardening others
    - He sounds like a cruel, capricious God, some would say
  - Furthermore, if it's true God's mercy doesn't depend on our will or works but only on His choice, than it means God could grant salvation to everyone
    - And if God has the power to grant salvation to everyone, then wouldn't the God of John 3:16 wish to save everyone?
    - Wouldn't that be what a loving God would do?
- Paul knew we would ask that question about now, and so he answers it next

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Rom. 9:19 You will say to me then, "Why does He still find fault? For who resists His will?"
Rom. 9:20 On the contrary, who are you, O man, who answers back to God? The thing molded will not say to the molder, "Why did you make me like this," will it?
Rom. 9:21 Or does not the potter have a right over the clay, to make from the same lump one vessel for honorable use and another for common use?

- Paul expected you to respond to his teaching by saying, "Why doesn't God just save everyone then? Why condemn anyone?"
  - Paul phrased the question a little differently in v.19, but that's what he's saying
    - Interestingly, when you hear someone pose this question in the course of this discussion, they're usually not interested in the answer
    - Because the question is actually intended as critique of the doctrine of election
  - In itself, the question is ridiculing election by saying…
    - Since we know God is loving…
    - And since a loving God would certainly want to save everyone if He could…
    - Yet we know that not everyone is being saved…
    - Therefore, God must not be in control of who receives His mercy, and therefore the doctrine of election can't be true
  - In other words, unless and until Paul gives us an explanation for why God doesn't save everyone, we won't accept what Paul is teaching
    - Notice Paul's initial response to this subtle critique
    - He calls us out for our arrogance and unbelief in the face of God's revealed word
  - Who are we to doubt God's word?
    - Don't you know that the words Paul wrote are the inspired revelation of the Creator God?
    - God didn't have to reveal this truth to us, yet in His mercy and kindness He has graciously given us this truth
    - Yet we dare to stand in judgment of Him and refuse to accept what He has given us unless God first satisfied our doubts and critiques?
  - We should expect to hear God respond as He did to Job:

Job 38:3 "Now gird up your loins like a man,
And I will ask you, and you instruct Me!
Job 38:4 "Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth?
Tell Me, if you have understanding,
Job 38:5 Who set its measurements? Since you know.
Or who stretched the line on it?

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Job 38:6 **"On what were its bases sunk?**
Or who laid its cornerstone,
Job 38:7 **When the morning stars sang together**
And all the sons of God shouted for joy?
Job 38:8 **"Or who enclosed the sea with doors**
When, bursting forth, it went out from the womb;
Job 38:9 **When I made a cloud its garment**
And thick darkness its swaddling band,
Job 38:10 **And I placed boundaries on it**
And set a bolt and doors,
Job 38:11 **And I said, 'Thus far you shall come, but no farther;**
And here shall your proud waves stop'?
Job 38:12 **"Have you ever in your life commanded the morning,**
And caused the dawn to know its place,
Job 38:13 **That it might take hold of the ends of the earth,**
And the wicked be shaken out of it?
Job 38:14 **"It is changed like clay under the seal;**
And they stand forth like a garment.
Job 38:15 **"From the wicked their light is withheld,**
And the uplifted arm is broken.
Job 38:16 **"Have you entered into the springs of the sea**
Or walked in the recesses of the deep?
Job 38:17 **"Have the gates of death been revealed to you,**
Or have you seen the gates of deep darkness?
Job 38:18 **"Have you understood the expanse of the earth?**
Tell Me, if you know all this.

- God puts Job in his place, reminding the man that mankind has no place to question God in anything He does, for we know nothing by comparison
    - How dare any of us answer back to our Creator, our God and Savior, the Maker of all things, as if we know better how He should extend His mercy
        - And don't be self-deceived…that's what we're doing when we question why God doesn't save everyone
    - It's hardly shocking that we should demand God give everyone opportunity to receive His mercy, because that suits our own interests
        - It just reveals our biased thinking and pride
        - We are demanding God prove Himself to be loving according to our definition of the word before we will accept His word
- Using the analogy of pottery, Paul rebukes us for our hubris saying, "Who are you, oh man, (i.e., mere man) to question God?"
    - We have as much worth and importance in comparison to God as a lump of clay has

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to a potter

- We're dirt, and we exist to be molded by our Creator
- Clay's only purpose is to be shaped by a greater power into something useful to the potter

- A potter has a purpose in mind as he begins the process of creating a pot from clay
  - He may have an honorable use in mind
  - An honorable pot refers to pottery intended for dining on special occasions, similar to your fine china
  - The potter forms the pot intending it will serve guests in this way
  - And based on the potter's decision, the course of that pot's future is predetermined
- Conversely, the potter also needs jars to hold refuse
  - That's what a dishonorable pot did…it was a toilet that held refuse
  - Once again, the potter set forth to mold the clay for that purpose
  - And once he was finished, the future of that pot was predetermined and could not change
  - For obvious reasons, you never took a pot created for use as a toilet and converted it to use as a dining pot

- Likewise, we have no right to question God's choices for who will receive His mercy any more than clay could question a potter
  - It's preposterous to consider a pot questioning its purpose
    - And it's preposterous that we should question God's choices in how He determines the outcomes for our lives
    - Should God choose to use Pharaoh's life in one way and Moses' life in another, it's His prerogative
    - And we have no place to judge His decisions
    - Both men were lumps of clay in their Maker's hands, and God did as He knew was best with each to reflect glory upon Himself
- Moreover, the Lord will not explain Himself to our doubting hearts
  - Because that's not how doubts are erased
  - As Abraham told the rich man in Hades
  - If we will not accept [the word of God] as it is written, then we will not be persuaded by the truth even if someone rises from the dead
- Your doubts will only be satisfied if you first accept the word of God for what it says
  - Then in time trust the Lord to reconcile your heart to this truth so that you may accept it
  - In time He will show you how the truth of a sovereign God is consistent with the truth of a loving God

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- And that's where Paul moves next, to offering us the biblical explanation for why a loving God has chosen to bestow His mercy on some but not all

Rom. 9:22 What if God, although willing to demonstrate His wrath and to make His power known, endured with much patience vessels of wrath prepared for destruction?
Rom. 9:23 And He did so to make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy, which He prepared beforehand for glory,
Rom. 9:24 even us, whom He also called, not from among Jews only, but also from among Gentiles.

- Paul phrases his explanation as a question, which makes it a little harder for us to understand what he's saying
  - Yet his choice to word v.22 as a question is an important detail
    - Paul is subtly mocking our foolishness in judging God's actions and motives
    - It's as if Paul's saying, so you think you know how to decide if God is just…
  - Well, what would we say about God if I remind you that God is willing to immediately destroy all ungodly mankind in the moment of their birth
    - Which is what the ungodly justly deserves
    - Yet God patiently endures their ungodliness
    - He allows even the most ungodly men and women to live long and even enjoyable lives
    - Men like Pharaoh or Herod or the rich man in Jesus' story of Lazarus
  - These people are an offense to a holy God and every day they live on earth they test God's patience
    - They mock God, persecute His children and pollute His earth with their evil ways
    - Still, God allows them to be born, to live long lives, to prosper and even to grow rich and powerful
    - That's more mercy and grace than such people ever had reason to receive
  - As Jesus says, this is the standard by which we should measure God's goodness

Matt. 5:44 "But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
Matt. 5:45 so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.

- The very fact that God allows the wicked such mercy during their lives on earth is evidence of his long-suffering patience and mercy

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- But Paul says this will be the extent of God's mercy for the wicked
  - Paul calls these wicked people vessels of wrath prepared for destruction
    - Like dishonorable pottery, the Lord has brought these people into the world on a course leading to destruction
    - Why did God even allow such people to be born in the first place?
  - Paul gives us that answer in v. 23
    - The verse opens with "and God did so…"
    - Meaning, here's the reason God allowed people destined to destruction to be born and to live side by side with the elect
    - And that reason was to teach His elect, those vessels prepared beforehand to receive His glory, about the riches of His mercy
  - Paul is describing the power, the necessity of contrast
    - Even though He was willing to destroy the wicked, or perhaps to prevent them from even being born at all
    - Yet God patiently permitted the wicked to exist on earth so that God's elect could appreciate the magnitude of His grace extended to us
    - So that we who have been elected to receive God's mercy might see the lives of the ungodly and appreciate what we have received
  - That's the power and necessity of contrast
    - If you have never known darkness, you can't possibly appreciate the glory of light
    - If all you've ever known is light, then light is meaningless
    - Or if you've never known sadness, then the concept of joy has no meaning
  - The same is true for concepts like grace, mercy, forgiveness and love
    - If no one received God's judgment, then how could we appreciate God's forgiveness
    - If there were no one deserving of God's wrath, then how could be be thankful for His forgiveness?
    - If no one was rejected by God, then who would praise Him for His love?
- Remember what the Lord told Moses in Exodus
  - He said He raised up Pharaoh to oppose Him so that He could display His power in defeating Pharaoh
    - In a nutshell, that's the purpose for all Creation including mankind
    - God made this Creation and everything in it to reflect glory upon Him
    - So that we might know God and glorify Him for Who He is
  - And to praise and worship God for Who He is, we must know all of Him
    - We must know His love and His anger

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        - His mercy and His judgment
        - His grace and His wrath
        - So there must be those among men who receive one and others who receive the other
- You can test this truth with a thought experiment
    - Go back to the moment in the Garden when the Lord came upon Adam and Woman having just fallen into sin
        - Consider God's range of options for how He might have responded to the fall of mankind in that moment
        - There are only three options possible
    - First, God could have chosen to save no one
        - He could have rejected Adam and Woman and every son and daughter that came from them through all generations
        - He could have justly condemned all humanity to an eternity in Hell
    - Secondly, God could have chosen to save every member of humanity
        - He could have justified Adam and Woman by faith
        - And thereafter, every child that came in Adam's line would have likewise received God's mercy
        - Everyone born for all generations would enter into glory and Hell remained an empty place
    - Or thirdly, God could choose to save some of Adam's descendants
        - God would elect some from among fallen humanity to receive His mercy
        - From generation to generation, two kinds of people would exist: those destined for rescue and those destined to receive the judgment they deserve
    - God could save none, all or some
        - What criteria would God use to decide which choice He should make?
        - What criteria does the Lord give for why He creates anything? Why does everything exist at all?

Is. 43:7 **Everyone who is called by My name,**
And whom I have created for My glory,
Whom I have formed, even whom I have made."

Psa. 86:8 **There is no one like You among the gods, O Lord,**
Nor are there any works like Yours.
Psa. 86:9 **All nations whom You have made shall come and worship before You, O Lord,**
And they shall glorify Your name.

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Psa. 86:10 **For You are great and do wondrous deeds;**
You alone are God.

- The Lord's criteria for every choice He makes is what maximize His glory
  - And the choice that gave God the most glory in His Creation was to save some
    - If He saved none, then clearly there would be no one to praise His name and His glory into eternity
    - And if He saved all people, then we would never appreciate the magnitude of the gift we've received
    - You can't fully appreciate eyesight unless you've known blindness
  - Imagine a world where everyone ever born was automatically and inevitably ushered into grace
    - No one would pray for themselves to receive mercy, much less for the lost
    - No one would live in gratitude for salvation
    - No one would think about repentance much less about maintaining a holy and righteous witness
    - What's the point in those things when everyone ultimately receives God's grace?
    - In fact, God Himself would be an afterthought at best
- God would receive far less glory in a world where His grace was taken for granted
  - And so for our sakes the Lord has patiently endured ungodly men and women to teach us something about grace
    - In v.24 Paul says God established this plan for the benefit of us, those who are called by God into His grace
    - Both Jew and Gentile
    - People predestined from before the foundations of the earth to know Him and to receive His mercy
    - God has established this plan for our sake, Paul says
  - Today, you and I look out upon a lost and dying world and we see ourselves before grace
    - We can appreciate what it means that the Creator of the Universe has chosen to rescue us from that hopelessness
    - What's more, our gratitude increases all the more as we come to understand that our present circumstances were assigned to us before the foundation of the earth
    - Not for any reason of ourselves, but purely because the Lord chose us to receive it
  - How humbling is this truth? How inexplicable, how marvelous, how freeing and how glorious!

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        - To understand the doctrine of election is to truly understand God's love
        - We still know sin, we still experience suffering like the world of ungodly
        - But we know these things will not be the end of us, and we can rejoice knowing we have been prepared for glory
- So the key to understanding Israel's past is recognizing that God is in the business of selecting who received His mercy, both among those in Israel and among the Gentiles
    - And Paul proves that this has been God's way since the beginning, with quotes from Old Testament prophets

Rom. 9:25 **As He says also in Hosea,**
"I will call those who were not My people, 'My people,'
And her who was not beloved, 'Beloved.'"
Rom. 9:26 **"And It shall be that in the place where it was said to them, 'You are not My people,'**
There they shall be called sons of the living God."
Rom. 9:27 **Isaiah cries out concerning Israel, "Though the number of the sons of Israel be like the sand of the sea, it is the remnant that will be saved;**
Rom. 9:28 **for the Lord will execute His word on the earth, thoroughly and quickly."**
Rom. 9:29 **And just as Isaiah foretold,**
"Unless the Lord of Sabaoth had left to us a posterity,
We would have become like sodom, and would have resembled Gomorrah."

- First, Paul quotes from Hosea the prophet, who told Israel that in a day to come their God would shift His mercy away from Israel and toward Gentiles
    - God would begin to call a people who were not His people
    - These who previously were not receiving His mercy would now begin to receive His mercy
    - Obviously, God is telling Israel that in a day to come, the Gentile nations would receive His mercy in place of the nation of Israel
- Nothing demonstrates the truth of God's election more clearly than His shift away from Israel and toward Gentiles
    - History demonstrates that at the Messiah's coming, Israel ceased to receive God's mercy in large part
    - During the following centuries, very few Jews have embraced Jesus as Messiah
    - Yet in that same time, Gentiles have come to Jesus in the billions
- This pattern is unexplainable except as God shifting His choice from one people group to the other
    - For if such things were merely the result of social patterns or human thinking, then we would have expected exactly the opposite

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- A Jewish Messiah coming in fulfillment of Jewish scripture should have held great interest to Jews
- Jews were primed by teaching and tradition to receive their Messiah when He came

- On the other hand, a Messiah should have held virtually no interest for Gentiles
  - Gentiles were generally repulsed by Jewish culture and religious practices (and many still are today)
  - And few Gentiles understood the concept of a Messiah, much less held any interest in embracing one
- Yet history records that a dramatic role reversal took place at Jesus' coming
  - Within a few decades, the church was largely Gentile
  - While faith in Jesus among Jewish people was dying out
  - Nothing explains this trend except a movement of God to shift His mercy away from Israel and toward Gentiles
- But notice in v.26 Paul includes a second statement by Hosea where the prophet says this shift away from Israel isn't the end of the story
  - From out of their place of rejection, Israel will eventually receive mercy again
    - In the same place where they were previously declared to no longer be God's people, God will speak again in a future day
    - In that future day, God will once more declare Israel to be His people
  - Once again, this statement reflects God's election of who receive His mercy
    - You can't explain this in-out-back-in pattern in human terms
    - It's only explainable as the result of God's sovereign choice for who receives His mercy
  - Next, Paul quotes from Isaiah 10 that God has always extended His mercy to a minority of Jacob's descendants
    - Just as God loved Jacob but hated Esau, so it has gone with everyone in the nation
    - Some have received His grace and others have not
    - And Isaiah says the ratio between these two groups has never been equal
  - Throughout history, God has been electing a few to receive mercy while passing over the larger majority
    - The Lord refers to the minority in Israel who receive His mercy as "the remnant"
    - There has always been a remnant of Israel, a minority within the nation who are receiving mercy
    - Paul talks more about the remnant later in these chapters
    - But for now it's enough to understand that Israel's past has always been a story of a few saved Jews living within a nation of unsaved
- Finally, Paul quotes from Isaiah 1 to remind us that God's choice to extend His grace to

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some in Israel was never made on the basis of their merits

- Isaiah speaks as a member of the remnant saying that had it not been for the Lord's mercy, they would have been no different than those in Sodom
  - This is one of the strongest statements of God's sovereign election in the chapter
  - Those praising God faithfully in the temple could just as easily have been engaged in depravity in Sodom
  - The only reason they weren't was because the Lord stepped in to change their lives by His mercy
  - Leaving them a posterity, which means a share in His promises to Abraham, Issac and Jacob
- So summarizing what we've learned in Chapter 9 concerning God's faithfulness to His promises:
  - Israel had so far rejected the Messiah because the Lord hadn't elected them to receive His mercy
  - But this isn't evidence of God being unfaithful to His promises, nor is it even new
  - God has always been selective for who within Israel receives His promises
- Only a minority within Israel and among Gentiles are called to receive God's mercy
  - This is God's plan to demonstrate the riches of His mercy to His elect
  - That by leaving some in their sins while rescuing others by His mercy, the Lord can rightly receive all glory

- Next time we meet, we finish Chapter 9 as a transition into Chapter 10; Israel's present
  - What is God's plan for His people during this present time?
    - If God has redirected His mercy to the Gentiles, is this unfair to the generations of Jews who will be born and live during this time?
    - Is God being unfair to these Jews, excluding them from the opportunity to be counted among the remnant of God?
    - And even if Israel is restored in a future day, doesn't this interim rejection still cast doubt on His faithfulness to His promises?

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- Let's rejoin Paul's defense of God's faithfulness to Israel in Chapters 9-11
  - I've summarized Paul's topic in these three chapters with the question, "What about Israel?"
    - Specifically, how do we explain Israel's rejection of Jesus?
    - God promised Israel a Messiah, and He sent Israel a Messiah
    - Yet only a few Jews in Paul's day recognized Jesus as Messiah and became His followers
  - Paul had just declared in Chapter 8 that our eternal future was secure and our glory assured because God has given us His word
    - But given Israel's circumstances maybe God's promises were not so certain after all, some might wonder
    - So now Paul must defend God's faithfulness by explaining how Israel's unbelief is consistent with God's promises
  - In Chapter 9, Paul began his defense by explaining that throughout Israel's history, the Lord selected some for His mercy while passing over others
    - Paul used various examples from Israel's past to illustrate the Lord at work in choosing
    - God selected one son of the patriarchs to receive His promises while rejecting the over
    - God selected a man, Pharaoh, to be defeated in his confrontation with Moses hardening his heart to ensure that outcome
    - Finally, for Jew and Gentile Paul says God selects some among humanity for glory while preparing others for destruction
    - And Paul says this pattern is consistent with God being perfectly just and holy in all He does
- At the end of teaching last week, Paul had given us the ultimate reason for His selectivity
  - God saves only some to ensure we who received His mercy may fully appreciate what we have
    - God maintains a contrast between those destined for glory and those destined to destruction
    - For without that contrast, we could never appreciate all God has done on our behalf and glorify Him for it
- So in Chapter 9, Paul explained Israel's rejection of Jesus as an outcome determined by God's choice
  - God was not unfaithful to His promises in rejecting Israel
    - God simply selected a minority of Israel to receive His mercy, a group the Bibles calls the "remnant" of Israel
    - Paul quoted Old Testament passages that made his argument for him
  - Let's pick up there again briefly as our bridge into Chapter 10

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Rom. 9:25 As He says also in Hosea,
"I will call those who were not My people, 'My people,'
And her who was not beloved, 'Beloved.'"
Rom. 9:26 "And It shall be that in the place where it was said to them, 'You are not My people,'
There they shall be called sons of the living God."
Rom. 9:27 Isaiah cries out concerning Israel, "Though the number of the sons of Israel be like the sand of the sea, it is the remnant that will be saved;
Rom. 9:28 for the Lord will execute His word on the earth, thoroughly and quickly."
Rom. 9:29 And just as Isaiah foretold,
"Unless the Lord of sabaoth had left to us a posterity,
we would have become like Sodom, and would have resembled Gomorrah."

- We looked at this verses last week, so let's just review them again quickly
  - First, Paul quotes Hosea who foretold that there would be a day when God would elect Gentiles to know Him and receive His mercy
    - These people would step into Israel's place for a time
    - But later the Lord promises to extend His mercy to Israel again
  - Secondly, Isaiah 10 promised that God will maintain at least a few believing Jews within the nation
    - This minority is called the remnant, those the Lord chooses for His mercy
    - Isaiah was among the remnant God preserved during the attack of the Assyrians against Israel
    - And Paul says this will always be God's pattern
    - God will always appoint some of Israel to receive His mercy, so that He doesn't completely reject them
  - Finally, Paul quotes again from Isaiah 10 in v.29 that God brings destruction upon all those in Israel who are not His remnant
    - As assuredly as He destroyed the ungodly in Sodom and Gomorrah, so will unbelieving Israel be
    - God preserves only a remnant of Israel, Isaiah says, even as the rest of Israel is left outside God's mercy
- From here, Paul moves into a discussion of Israel's present circumstances following their rejection of the Messiah

Rom. 9:30 What shall we say then? That Gentiles, who did not pursue righteousness, attained righteousness, even the righteousness which is by faith;
Rom. 9:31 but Israel, pursuing a law of righteousness, did not arrive at that law.

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Rom. 9:32 Why? Because they did not pursue it by faith, but as though it were by works. They stumbled over the stumbling stone,
Rom. 9:33 just as it is written,
"Behold, I lay in Zion a stone of stumbling and a rock of offense,
and he who believes in Him will not be disappointed."

- Paul asks a final question to conclude the chapter: what shall we say then?
  - We could rephrase Paul's question this way:
    - What shall we say about Israel?
    - Or maybe, how do we explain Israel's rejection of Jesus?
  - Paul leads us to the answer by contrasting the effect of Jesus' arrival on Gentiles vs. the Jews
    - Gentiles attained or took hold of the righteousness of God by faith in Jesus
    - While the Jews ignored Jesus preferring to seek for a righteousness of their own
- That outcome is so unexpected, so improbable that it can only be evidence of God transferring His mercy away from one and toward the other
  - The Gentile world was largely ignorant of God and His word concerning salvation or a coming Messiah
    - Gentiles were pagans, pursuing all manner of evil and debauchery
    - So naturally, the Gentiles were not pursuing righteousness
  - Meanwhile, the Jewish nation had actively pursued righteousness for generations
    - They treasured the word of God and were attending to its requirements with great care
    - Furthermore, they knew a Messiah was coming and they longed to see His day and His Kingdom
  - Yet against all odds when the Messiah finally arrived, the Gentiles ran to embrace Jesus while the Jewish people rejected their Messiah
    - Paul says Israel did not receive what they were pursuing because they pursued it in the wrong way
    - They sought to become righteous by keeping Law rather than accepting God's righteousness by faith in Jesus
    - In human terms, Israel was blinded by their own pride
- So Paul says Christ's arrival was a stumbling stone to Israel
  - Paul's choice of words suggests two runners in a race
    - The Gentile runner isn't even aware a race is happening
    - He's moving around the track with no urgency, oblivious that there's a finish line and having no interest in the prize of righteousness
  - On the other hand, the Jewish runner is giving the race everything he's got

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        - And he's intently focused on the finish line
        - He's striving with all his might to obtain the prize of righteousness
    - But then a large rock falls from heaven onto the track directly in the path of the Jewish runner
        - Tied to this rock is the very prize the runners are competing to win
        - The Jew is so intently focused reaching the finish line that he neglects to notice the rock and the prize attached to it
        - And so he stumbles over it, and lands on his back in the middle of the track
    - Meanwhile, the Gentile runner continues to saunter down the track blissfully unaware of the race or the finish line
        - Soon he happens upon the rock, he stops and notices the prize attached to it
        - Gladly, he claims the prize never having worked to obtain it
        - So Jews who were trying to obtain righteousness, stumbled over the means by which to obtain it
        - The Jewish people were pursuing righteousness in the wrong way, by works of the law rather than by faith in God's promises
        - While Gentiles, who had no interest in pursuing righteousness, obtained it because the Jewish people stumbled
- So Israel's present circumstances were the result of prideful, self-deceived hearts
    - In Isaiah, God foretold that His people would make this mistake
        - In v.33 Paul quotes Isaiah saying the Lord lays a stone of stumbling and rock of offense before Israel
        - These are labels for Christ, of course
    - The prophet's point is the Lord brought Jesus to Israel just as He promised
        - God has kept His promise to Israel
        - He did exactly as He promised, so we can't fault God's faithfulness to His promises
        - The problem was Israel's hard heart
        - They stumbled over Jesus rather than receive Him
    - Nevertheless, Isaiah foretold this would be the result
        - So clearly the Lord knew Israel would reject Christ
        - Moreover, the Gentiles were receiving a Messiah they weren't looking for
    - So we must conclude the Lord has shifted His mercy in favor of the ignorant Gentile over the stubborn Jew
        - So Israel's rejection of Jesus was according to their own sinful choice
        - But it was also an outcome God predetermined for His people by withholding His mercy

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        - We cannot say God was unfaithful to Israel, as they received what God promised
        - But God exercised His sovereign right to leave Israel in their sin while extending His mercy to another group instead
    - So the record of Israel's past establishes two important principles that carry us into Chapter 10
        - First, the Lord is sovereign over how He dispenses His mercy to everyone, whether Jew or Gentile
        - Secondly, Israel's rejection of Christ was foreknown and predestined by God as part of a plan to save Gentiles
- So with those concepts in hand, let's move to Chapter 10 – Israel's present circumstances
    - Given what has happened, what should we expect for Israel today?
        - Specifically, is God dealing fairly with His covenant people during this time?
        - Once again, Paul moves to defending God's faithfulness and character by answering a series of questions
    - First, wasn't Israel's zealousness proof they deserved to receive their Messiah?
        - Secondly, had God tricked Israel by failing to explain His plan to His people?
        - Did He make it easy for Gentiles to receive His mercy while sending Israel on a wild goose chase?
        - Finally, is God unfairly keeping Israel in the dark now even as He opens the door to Gentiles?
    - These are questions Paul addresses in the course of Chapter 10
        - And once again, Paul begins his defense by reassuring his audience he is in Israel's corner

Rom. 10:1 Brethren, my heart's desire and my prayer to God for them is for their salvation.
Rom. 10:2 For I testify about them that they have a zeal for God, but not in accordance with knowledge.
Rom. 10:3 For not knowing about God's righteousness and seeking to establish their own, they did not subject themselves to the righteousness of God.
Rom. 10:4 For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.

- It's entirely likely that at this point, Paul's Jewish audience was questioning his objectivity
    - So Paul reminds them that he truly desired to see his people saved
        - Paul calls his audience "brethren," meaning fellow Jews, and like them he laments Israel's rejection of Christ

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        - In fact, Paul says he prayed to the Lord that Jews be saved
    - When Paul says he prays for Israel's salvation, we're reminded that God's sovereignty in the affairs of the heart doesn't preclude us from making appeals
        - Paul prayed that God might save as many Jews as possible
        - While at the same time accepting that it was not in God's will to bring the entire nation of Jewish people into faith
        - At least not in Paul's day
        - So while Paul sympathized with the plight of Israel, he also accepted God's plan to hold Israel outside His mercy for a time
    - That's the perspective we should take as well concerning any person or group of people we wish to see receive God's mercy
        - We may pray earnestly for the Lord to save a person or a group of people
        - While at the same time acknowledging that God's will for both nations and individuals will be done
    - Let's not set these two truths against one another
        - Don't allow the truth of God's sovereignty to become excuse for not engaging in intercessory prayer or evangelism
        - And likewise, you don't have to deny His sovereignty in order to pray with an expectation of influencing future outcomes
        - Remember, in Chapter 9 Paul taught that the Lord predetermined Israel's stumbling
        - While in Chapter 10, Paul said he prayed for Israel's salvation
- From there Paul dives into the first question of whether Israel deserved to have their Messiah, given their earnestness
    - In v.2 Paul says he testifies (or agrees) that the Jews have a zeal for God
        - Paul is acknowledging what his readers would have been thinking at this point
        - Israel was trying really hard
        - The history of Israel under Greek and Roman control testifies to the zeal of the Jewish people
        - Israel fervently defended God and His Law, refusing to engage in idolatry and often facing death instead of conceding
    - Israel was so famously zealous for God that they won the only religious exemption in the Roman Empire
        - When Rome conquered a people and made them part of the empire, they eradicated any competing religious observances
        - The Romans required all subjects to pledge allegiance to the Caesar
        - But when Rome tried to enforce this rule in Judea, the Jews objected so violently that Rome relented
        - The Senate gave Jews the right to continue in their own worship practices, the

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only such exemption in the entire empire

- Certainly, no one could fault the sincerity of the Jewish people in pursuing God
  - But Paul says that sincerity wasn't their problem; it was knowledge
  - In other words, you can be very sincere in your pursuit of God
  - But if you don't pursue Him according to the truth, you're just sincerely wrong

- Our world is filled with sincerely religious people, many of whom are as devout and zealous as the Jews of Paul's day
  - But their sincerity and zealousness will gain them nothing in the end if it's not in accordance with knowledge
    - Don't ever mistake sincerity for inspiration
    - Remember, the enemy has his disciples too, and many of them are just as willing to die for their god as we are for our God
    - They too can make strong arguments from their religious books
    - They devote countless hours to prayer, make great sacrifices, attend weekly services, do many good works, etc.
  - But displays of piety are worthless in the quest for righteousness
    - In v.3 Paul says Israel's zealousness lacked the understanding that salvation comes only by God's righteousness
    - We know from our study of earlier chapters that only a righteousness equal to God's righteousness may enter Heaven
    - God's righteousness is perfection so if we are to enter His glory, we must obtain His perfection
    - No matter how many hours we pray or sacrifices we make or good works we do, we can't erase a single sin
    - And one sin is enough to disqualify us from Heaven
  - That's why we must obtain God's righteousness
    - God's righteousness refers to Christ, Who is the righteousness of God according to 2 Cor 5:21
    - In their pride, Israel didn't recognize that only God could accomplish the Law perfectly

- Instead, Paul says they sought to establish their own righteousness
  - Paul is teaching that these two paths are mutually exclusive
    - You can either seek to make yourself righteous
    - Or you can give up on that path, turn and accept the free gift of God's righteousness available by faith in Christ
    - You can't choose both paths, because they go in opposite directions
    - No more than you can choose to be both single and married, or to be both asleep and awake

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        - One negates the other
    - Paul expresses this mutual exclusivity in v.4 saying Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes
        - He means that for the one who accepts the righteousness of God (i.e., Christ), the law ceases being a path to righteousness
        - Obviously, the law was never truly a path to righteousness
        - He means that for the one willing to receive the righteousness of God by faith, the law no longer holds any attraction
        - Once you have obtained God's righteousness, you give up trying to earn your own
        - Because you realize you can do no better than God's perfection
    - So to the first question, Paul says Israel's zealousness for the Law wasn't cause for God to reward them but rather it's the very reason for their downfall
        - Israel has not subjected themselves to Christ
        - The proof being that Israel even now remains still committed to the Law as a means of righteousness
        - Therefore, God has been just in denying them salvation
- Which moves Paul to the second question: did God withhold this important detail from His people?
    - Did God lead Israel into misunderstanding the purpose of the Law, thinking it was a means of obtaining righteousness?
        - Paul addresses this question in the next passage

Rom. 10:5 For Moses writes that the man who practices the righteousness which is based on law shall live by that righteousness.
Rom. 10:6 But the righteousness based on faith speaks as follows: "Do not say in your heart, 'Who will ascend into heaven?' (that is, to bring Christ down),
Rom. 10:7 or 'Who will descend into the abyss?' (that is, to bring Christ up from the dead)."
Rom. 10:8 But what does it say? "The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart" — that is, the word of faith which we are preaching,
Rom. 10:9 that if you confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved;
Rom. 10:10 for with the heart a person believes, resulting in righteousness, and with the mouth he confesses, resulting in salvation.
Rom. 10:11 For the Scripture says, "Whoever believes in Him will not be disappointed."
Rom. 10:12 For there is no distinction between Jew and Greek; for the same Lord is Lord of all, abounding in riches for all who call on Him;
Rom. 10:13 for "Whoever will call on the name of the Lord will be saved."

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- Paul answers this concern by quoting repeatedly from the Law itself
  - He starts saying "for Moses writes…" referring to the author of the first five books of the Bible, which Jews consider collectedly to be "the Law"
    - In v.5 Paul begins with a quote from Leviticus 18:5

Lev. 18:5 **'So you shall keep My statutes and My judgments, by which a man may live if he does them; I am the Lord.**

- The phrase "My statutes and My judgments" refers to the entire Law, all that God required of Israel
- A person may live if he or she does all of them
- Conversely, failing to keep them all will mean death, which refers ultimately to an eternal outcome
- This is an impossibly high standard for anyone
  - The Law itself set perfection as the minimum standard for obtaining eternal life
  - One error, one failing is enough to disqualify someone
- Paul's reminding us that Israel heard from the beginning that observing the Law was not a viable means of becoming righteous
  - The Law wasn't intended to trick Israel
  - The Law itself warned Israel not to misuse it
- Furthermore, the Law told Israel that righteousness wasn't outside their reach
  - In Deuteronomy 30 Moses told the people of Israel that accomplishing the Law wasn't too difficult for them, though it appeared that way

Deut. 30:11 **"For this commandment which I command you today is not too difficult for you, nor is it out of reach.**
Deut. 30:12 **"It is not in heaven, that you should say, 'Who will go up to heaven for us to get it for us and make us hear it, that we may observe it?'**
Deut. 30:13 **"Nor is it beyond the sea, that you should say, 'Who will cross the sea for us to get it for us and make us hear it, that we may observe it?'**
Deut. 30:14 **"But the word is very near you, in your mouth and in your heart, that you may observe it.**

- Moses said no one needed to go to Heaven to obtain the righteousness required to keep the Law
- Nor do we need someone to search to the ends of the earth for such perfection
- Paul adds his own applications in vv.6-7
  - Israel didn't produce the Messiah's arrival from Heaven by keeping the Law perfectly

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- Nor did Israel make possible Christ's resurrection through their own righteousness
- On the contrary, those things happened to compensate for our inability to keep the Law

- Paul says in v.6 that the righteousness that is based on faith never says these things
  - If you understand how God appoints righteousness, you don't ask these questions
  - Because you understand that the solution isn't found in our personal efforts or merit
  - You realize that keeping the Law is fruitless
- Instead, Paul says that true righteousness acknowledges that the solution to keeping the Law's requirements is near, in our mouths and hearts
  - And in vs.9-10, Paul explains that Moses was describing a confession of faith in the Gospel
    - Paul refers to the Gospel message as the word of faith that he was preaching
    - It's a word or message that declares faith is the means of righteousness
  - Then Paul describes two parts, one for the mouth and one for the heart
    - Paul is just mirroring the two ideas Moses proposed, in the same order Moses presented them
    - So Paul addresses confessing first, followed by believing, to parallel Moses' description of mouth and then heart
  - Obviously, these two steps work in unison
    - To confess means to agree with what others say about some idea or belief
    - And to believe means to hold to a perspective based on conviction rather than proof
  - Paul says that true righteousness says what others say about the identity of Jesus, and believes what others believe about His work
    - We agree He is Lord, that is He is God incarnate
    - And we believe He died and rose again to prove His claims
- In v.10 Paul explains that these two things work together in the one being saved
  - But because of the way Paul maintains unity with Moses' words, some get confused by this verse
    - Paul says our heart of belief results in our justification and righteousness
    - While the confession of our mouth results in our salvation
  - Clearly, being righteous and having salvation are one and the same thing
    - You can't have one without the other, unless you choose to define each word in an unusually narrow way
    - Instead, we need to see Paul's choice of words as a poetic attempt to preserve the symmetry with Moses' words
  - Moses wrote in terms of a mouth and a heart working together to accomplish the

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Law

- So Paul uses this construct to explain that a confession of faith is all that is necessary to be saved
- He starts with a confession of the mouth followed by belief in the heart
- And then he reverses the pattern in v.10 starting with the heart first and then the mouth

- It's a chiastic form, which is a type of Hebrew poetry
  - So we shouldn't assign undue emphasize to either part of the division
  - Paul isn't describing two discrete steps in a process
  - Rather he's describing two elements working together in a single moment

- Paul's main point is summarized in v.11, where Paul quotes from Isaiah
  - The one who won't be disappointed in eternity is the one who believes in the Messiah
    - The heart and mouth work together to express belief in the Messiah
    - And when we take that route, we receive what we hope to have: righteousness
    - We won't be disappointed, Isaiah says, unlike those who depend on their own righteousness
  - So how can we blame God for Israel's current state of unbelief when He told them what to expect beforehand, and kept His promise faithfully?
    - No one could claim that Israel was set up for failure
    - Their own Law declared that a man can't find righteousness in doing the Law
    - And that righteousness was simply a matter of a confession of faith
    - And Isaiah confirmed that belief in the Messiah was the key
- Furthermore, Israel had no less opportunity to know these things than did Gentiles
  - Paul says in v.12 that on this point, there is no difference between Jew and Gentile
    - The Lord is the Lord of both
    - And God has uncountable riches available as an inheritance for everyone who calls upon Him in faith
  - And God has always intended that the door be open to both groups
    - Paul quotes from Joel 2, where the Lord promises that whoever calls on the name of the Lord – Jew or Gentile – will be saved
    - There are not two systems for salvation
    - There is only one, and the Lord explained it to His people plainly in their scripture
  - So God didn't hide the way to righteousness for Israel
    - Nor did He make it unnecessarily complicated
    - It was plainly explained in the word of God, and it was as easy as a confession of

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faith

- This is far more advanced notice than Gentiles received, by the way

- So once again, we see that Israel's present circumstances are the result of their hard hearts, not because God failed to keep His word
  - It was His word to Israel that explained the path to righteousness
  - Yet Israel chose another path, a path of self-righteousness, instead
  - And so there they remain

- Which leads to the third and final question…perhaps Israel hasn't received adequate opportunity to know that Jesus was their Messiah?
  - Perhaps this is just a big misunderstanding
    - If only the apostles like Paul had explained these things to Israel, then the nation would have recognized their error and received Christ
    - So is God unfairly withholding this explanation from His people, thereby preventing them from coming to faith in Jesus?
  - Paul addresses this basic concern to end the chapter

Rom. 10:14 How then will they call on Him in whom they have not believed? How will they believe in Him whom they have not heard? And how will they hear without a preacher?
Rom. 10:15 How will they preach unless they are sent? Just as it is written, "How beautiful are the feet of those who bring good news of good things!"
Rom. 10:16 However, they did not all heed the good news; for Isaiah says, "Lord, who has believed our report?"
Rom. 10:17 So faith comes from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.
Rom. 10:18 But I say, surely they have never heard, have they? Indeed they have;
"Their voice has gone out into all the earth,
And their words to the ends of the world."
Rom. 10:19 But I say, surely Israel did not know, did they? First Moses says,
"I will make you jealous by that which is Not a nation,
By a nation without understanding will I anger You."
Rom. 10:20 And Isaiah is very bold and says,
"I was found by those who did not seek Me,
I became manifest to those who did not ask for Me."
Rom. 10:21 But as for Israel He says, "All the day long I have stretched out My hands to a disobedient and obstinate people."

- To key to understanding this passage is recognizing that Paul has assumed his audience's perspective, but he doesn't agree with it
  - Paul's audience has just learned that Israel still had opportunity to be saved as Moses directed

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        - It was a good news–bad news story
        - The good news was that Israel's rejection of Jesus didn't close the door on their opportunity to be saved
        - Like Gentiles, Jews still had opportunity to be saved if they too confessed Christ
        - This would have come as great relief to Paul's Jewish readers who longed to see the Jewish nation receive their Messiah
    - But the bad news was that despite how easy it was to find salvation, very few Jews were choosing to follow that path
        - That disconnect naturally lead a believing Jew searching for reasons to explain Israel's persistent unbelief
        - Many of the reasons they might propose held potential to place the blame on God
- So Paul makes his audience's argument for them so he can refute it, beginning with that series of questions in v.14
    - Why have the Jewish people failed to call upon the name of the Lord so as to be saved?
        - Well, how can the people of Israel call on the name of the Lord if they have not first believed in Jesus?
        - And how would we expect them to believe in Jesus if they have never heard about Jesus?
        - And how will they hear about Jesus if no one is preaching to them about Jesus?
        - And how will preaching take place if the Church isn't sending preachers to the people of Israel?
        - After all, God has declared in Isaiah that His good news will be delivered by men whom the Lord sends to His people
    - Notice the progression of logic in these questions
        - Paul's audience assumes that Israel sits outside God's mercy merely because of a communication breakdown
        - God had everything set up for His people's salvation, until at the last minute someone didn't get the memo
        - Preachers weren't sent to the right places, and for a lack of information, God's people were forsaken
    - And yet God promised to send His good news to Israel
        - Therefore, it's God's fault again
        - He failed to keep His promise to Israel to tell them about the good news of their Messiah's arrival
- Is this analysis were true, we'd be looking at the biggest fiasco in the history of mankind
    - Only the introduction of New Coke would be comparable
        - Of course, it's a ridiculous suggestion

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        - Which Paul demonstrates as he responds with scripture, beginning with another quote from Isaiah
    - In v.16 Paul says plainly that not all Israel has heeded the good news
        - Some heeded the news, certainly, that is the remnant God promised to preserve
        - But the majority of Israel rejected what they heard

Is. 52:15 **Thus He will sprinkle many nations,**
Kings will shut their mouths on account of Him;
For what had not been told them they will see,
And what they had not heard they will understand.
Is. 53:1 **Who has believed our message?**
And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed?

- Isaiah says that the message of the Messiah's arrival will be heard and seen by those who had no preparation to receive it
    - Meanwhile, Isaiah asks who has believed the prophets' message?
    - Isaiah is lamenting that Israel always ignored the words of their prophets
    - There was no more thankless job in Israel than prophet
- So even though Paul's audience assumed Israel could yet be convinced if only the message went out to them, Paul says no they wouldn't
    - When the message of the Messiah was delivered as God promised, most ignored it
    - Just as the Lord said would happen
- Paul then says this outcome in Israel reinforces the truth he presented back in Romans 9
    - That faith comes from hearing
        - God prepares a message of salvation
        - And He delivers the message to us
        - And as we hear it, we believe it and confess it
        - We call upon the name of the Lord and we are saved
    - In human terms, saving faith is a simple thing anyone can understand
        - But how do we explain Israel's rejection of this good news?
        - What explains an entire nation of God's people, prepared by centuries of God's revelation, failing to accept such a simple message?
    - Paul says hearing the message depends on the word of Christ
        - He's saying that the capacity to hear, that is to heed, the Gospel is determined by the word of Christ
        - Heeding the message of the Gospel depends on the word of Christ
        - It doesn't depend on our mechanics or our presentation

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        - The outcome of any Gospel presentation depends on God to either grant our audience ears to hear or to deny them the same
        - Remember, He has mercy on whom He chooses and He hardens whom He chooses
    - So in human terms, faith comes by hearing a Gospel presentation
        - But in spiritual terms, a person's potential to heed what they hear is determined by the word of Christ
        - Or we could say, the Lord's will determines who truly hears the message of the Gospel
- So then in v.18 Paul's audience might ask, surely Israel never heard the message? Maybe there's still a chance they could hear and receive Christ?
    - To which Paul shuts the door on this excuse
        - In v.18 he quotes from Psalm 19 when David declares that the Creation itself reveals the truth of God
        - Paul's point isn't that Israel should have deciphered the message of the Gospel from staring at the night sky
    - Rather Paul's drawing a comparison between general revelation and specific revelation
        - The psalm testifies that God is so intent on communicating with mankind that He speaks to us through the very Creation
        - Therefore, how much more did Israel have opportunity to hear about Christ through the specific revelation of the word of God?
        - The Jewish people were entrusted with the word of God, so they of all people should have known what was coming
        - They knew it far better than the Gentiles, who received Christ despite only having access to general revelation like Creation
- Then his readers might ask in v.19 that perhaps the people just didn't know (or understand) what their scriptures were telling them about Jesus
    - They were confused, mistaken and therefore unable to comprehend Jesus as the fulfillment of the scripture's promises
        - But Paul says nope…quoting first from the Law again in Deuteronomy 30
        - Moses declares that God's plan was to bring understanding to Gentiles who had no reason to know or care about the Messiah
        - While leaving Israel outside grace so that they might become jealous of the Gentiles
    - Jealousy doesn't infer that Israel will see us worshipping Jesus and that will make them jealous wishing to know Jesus too
        - Obviously, that's not happening within Israel
        - Jews are not drawn by jealousy into a relationship with Christ
        - Instead, Moses means the Jews will increase in their desire for a Messiah as they

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see and hear Gentiles declaring they have found one
        - In other words, the desire for a Messiah will be kept alive within Jewish culture by a world of Gentiles claiming Jesus as Messiah
    - But of course, the main point is that the problem wasn't a lack of knowledge
        - Israel did hear enough to recognize Jesus when He came
        - And they understood perfectly well what Jesus was claiming to be
        - In fact, they killed Him because He claimed to be Messiah
- No, the reason Israel hasn't received the Messiah is because God has not granted them mercy to receive Him
    - Paul puts the final nail in his readers' coffin of hope (to badly mix my metaphors) by quoting from Isaiah again
        - Isaiah foretold that God would make opportunity for Gentiles to know Him, though Gentiles were not inclined to seek Him
        - He manifested Himself to them though they didn't ask to know Him
    - Now imagine if God could manifest Himself to people who didn't want a Messiah in such a way that they embraced Jesus, then certainly He could have overcome Israel's objections
        - Had God wanted His people to receive their Messiah, He surely could have brought about that outcome
        - They had everything they needed, in contrast to Gentiles who had nothing
        - They were looking, they heard, they understood the prophecies
    - And God fulfilled all His promises to them openly and without deception
        - Paul emphasizes the magnitude of the opportunity God offered in v.21 quoting from Isaiah a final time
        - God says He held out His hand to Israel but they were disobedient
        - He's describing the degree of preparation God gave Israel
    - God literally spelled out what He would do for them
        - He told them where the Messiah would be born
        - The time He would be born
        - The family line He would come from
        - Many of the miracles He would do and the way He must die for them
        - And God told Israel exactly how they could receive His righteousness, by a simple confession of faith
- Nevertheless, the people of God resisted the call of the Gospel and continue to do so
    - Has God been unfaithful to them? Did He fail to do anything He promised?
        - Did he trick Israel?
        - Did He hide something from them?

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- No, they were given everything they needed – far more than Gentiles – yet they were obstinate and disobedient
  - They preferred to pursue the Law rather than accept God's righteousness in the way Moses instructed
  - And so apart from the remnant, Israel remains without Christ today
- And as we reach the end of Chapter 10, we come to another unavoidable conclusion
  - The Lord didn't give Israel ears to hear the Gospel
  - He sent them Christ as promised, but left the nation in its sins
  - He kept His promise to preserve a remnant, but he passed over the rest
- As obvious as this conclusion may be, it still leaves us searching for a "why?" for everything we've learned
  - We know God chooses who receives His mercy
  - We know He has always chosen a minority, a remnant
  - We know He has been fair to Israel, giving them exactly what He promised to give them
  - Every Jew since Jesus' day has had the same path to salvation and could call upon the name of the Lord like you and me
  - And yet we know they mostly reject Him, being more interested in pursuing self-righteousness
- But we also know that the Lord could overcome their objections
  - He could extend His mercy to them and bring them into faith
  - In the same way the Lord is calling Gentiles to Himself, He could draw all Israel to Himself should He choose
  - So why hasn't He done it?
- That brings us to Chapter 11, Israel's future

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- Israel's past, Israel's present, and now tonight Israel's future
  - That's where Paul has been leading us over the course of the past two chapters of Romans
    - Paul wants to reconcile the truth of a faithful, promise-keeping God with the reality of an unbelieving Israel
    - There's an answer here, something that's been hidden from the beginning of time, something we need to understand
    - But understanding it requires careful scholarship, an open mind and an appreciation of Israel's history
  - Paul addressed Israel's history in Chapter 9
    - And an examination of that history revealed that God has always dispensed His mercy selectively within the nation of Israel
    - Some were given mercy while others weren't
    - So Chapter 9 explained why only some in Israel embraced their Messiah when He appeared for them
    - The Lord shifted His mercy away from the Jewish nation to the Gentile nations
  - Then in Chapter 10, Paul addressed Israel's present circumstances
    - Even today, Israel remains intently focused on following God and awaiting their Messiah's arrival
    - Yet they aren't finding the very thing they are seeking because they continue to seek it with hard hearts
    - They're intent on obtaining self-righteousness rather than the righteousness that comes by faith
    - So Chapter 10 explained why a zealous nation continues in their unbelief despite the simplicity of God's plan of salvation
    - The Lord in His providence has elected to leave Israel in their disobedience for a time to extend mercy to Gentiles
- As we reach Chapter 11, Paul still has more questions to answer regarding God's faithfulness and His plan for His people, Israel
  - Including the most important question of all: why?

Rom. 11:1 I say then, God has not rejected His people, has He? May it never be! For I too am an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin.
Rom. 11:2 God has not rejected His people whom He foreknew. Or do you not know what the Scripture says in the passage about Elijah, how he pleads with God against Israel?
Rom. 11:3 "Lord, they have killed Your prophets, they have torn down Your altars, and I alone am left, and they are seeking my life."
Rom. 11:4 But what is the divine response to him? "I have kept for Myself seven thousand men who have not bowed the knee to baal."

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Rom. 11:5 In the same way then, there has also come to be at the present time a remnant according to God's gracious choice.
Rom. 11:6 But if it is by grace, it is no longer on the basis of works, otherwise grace is no longer grace.

- Paul opens the chapter with the next logical question he knew his readers would pose: does this mean God has rejected His people, Israel?
  - Does Israel's continuing unbelief mean Israel will never come to faith in Jesus? Has God decided to cast them aside?
    - That's the question Paul's Jewish readers would naturally ask in light of what Paul explained in Chapters 9 & 10
    - Indeed, many believers have asked this same question in the centuries since Paul wrote this letter
  - In fact, some believers – and even entire Christian denominations – have answered this question wrongly, concluding that God did reject Israel forever
    - They teach a wrong view of Israel called "replacement theology"
    - They believe that Gentile believers in the Church have "replaced" the Jewish people in God's plan
    - Consequently, the promises God gave to the Jewish people will be fulfilled through the Church
  - These false conclusions are especially ironic given Paul's direct answer to the question in v.1
    - Paul says, unambiguously, that the Lord will never reject His covenant people
    - Notice the people in view in v.1 (i.e., His people) are the same people Paul defined at the start of Chapter 9
    - In Chapter 9, Paul defined God's people as those who physically descended from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob – who Paul called Israelites
    - Paul's definition prevents us from shifting our focus to some other group, a so-called "spiritual Israel"
- In v.1 Paul says clearly that God has not – will not – forsaken His covenant people, Israel
  - And Paul offers himself as his best proof
    - Paul says he is proof that God has not rejected His people
    - And notice again Paul's description
    - Paul called himself an Israelite, a descendent of Abraham of the tribe of Benjamin
    - These are terms that can only refer to a literal Jew
  - The term Israelite is especially important, because it was part of Paul's definition of God's people back in Chapter 9
    - In the Bible, the term Israelite is only ever used to describe a physical

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descendant of Jacob
        - Gentile believers in the Church are never called “Israelites” in the Bible
        - Only Jews, whether believer or unbeliever, can be considered an Israelite
    - So Paul says the proof that God hasn’t rejected literal, physical Israel is that there are believing Jews today – including Paul
        - If God had rejected His people, there would be no believing at all
        - This argument can only make sense if we understand that God determines who receives His mercy, as Paul has shown in Chapter 9
        - Therefore, if even one Jew is believing, it’s proof that God has not forsaken His people
        - Because it means God chose a Jew to receive His mercy
- Therefore Paul says explicitly that his faith is proof that God has not forsaken the Jewish people, those God foreknew
    - The people God foreknew are those Jews God had on His mind from before the foundations of the earth
        - These people God foreknew, He predestined to salvation
        - And those He predestined He called into faith, preserving a remnant within the larger community of apostate Israel
    - Paul is identifying himself as a member of the Jewish remnant in his day
        - Moreover, Paul’s saying that the continuing existence of a believing Jewish remnant is proof of God’s continuing faithfulness to His people
        - Just as God has only selected some to believe in Israel’s past, He continues to select only a remnant to believe today
        - And the continuing existence of a remnant proves that God is not done with the Jewish people
    - If God had no intentions of preserving His nation, then He wouldn’t have perpetuated faith among Jewish people
        - He would have withheld His mercy, faith would have died out, and eventually the people themselves would have ceased to exist
        - The same way God extinguished the Canaanites, the Phoenicians, the Philistines and other peoples
        - But instead, the people of Israel live on, and among them, God continues to preserve a remnant of believing Jews like Paul
        - Therefore, we can be sure God still has a plan for His covenant people
- Because God has always called just a minority of His people into faith, it’s always been easy for someone to assume God had turned His back on Israel
    - Even some of God’s greatest servants have made this same mistake, and in v.2 Paul cites one such an example from the Old Testament
        - He reminds us of a moment in Elijah’s ministry

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        - In 1 Kings 19 we find Elijah discouraged and frustrated in his efforts to bring an end to Israel's apostasy
        - He's battling an evil king, Ahab, and his murderous wife, Jezebel
        - And he's dismayed by the rampant idolatry gripping Israel under their influence
    - His frustrations reach a crisis in Chapter 19, so Elijah runs to Mt. Horeb – the mountain where God appeared to Moses during the Exodus
        - And Elijah demands that God take his life because Elijah believed that he was the last remaining faithful Jew in all Israel
        - He cries out to God "that I alone am left and they will kill me soon"
        - From Elijah's perspective, the nation was already lost so there was no point in continuing in his ministry
        - Essentially, Elijah was declaring what some were declaring in Paul's day: the nation was lost because the Lord has forsaken His people Israel
    - But in v.4 Paul reminds us of God's response to Elijah's pity party
        - The Lord told Elijah that He had kept 7,000 within Israel from bowing to the false god of Ahab, Baal
        - There are three important things to notice in Paul's example
    - First, the Lord kept a remnant that Elijah knew nothing about
        - The verb "kept" emphasizes an action by God to actively ensure the continuation of faith among Israel
        - He didn't say I "found" or I "have received", but the Lord said I "kept"
        - Clearly God was working to assign His mercy to some in Israel, keeping them in faith
    - Secondly, this group was unknown to Elijah
        - The prophet believed he was truly alone in Israel
        - Everywhere he looked, he saw only apostasy and unbelief
        - Yet there were those who knew and trusted the Lord, but they weren't the powerful or prominent
        - They were quietly serving God, in the shadows
    - Finally, notice the number the Lord preserved from apostasy: 7,000
        - The precise nature of this number immediately grabs our attention
        - This was not an estimate, for there is no indication in the text that God was rounding up or down
        - He didn't say "about" seven thousand or something similar that would clearly indicate the number was an approximation
    - Instead, the Lord gives a precise count of Jews who were believing in Elijah's day, and the count was exactly 7,000
        - Not 6,999 or 7,001 but 7,000

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        - And the number "7" is also notable, since seven is the Bible's number to signify completeness or the whole of something
    - So the precision and specificity of 7,000 reaffirms the Lord sovereignly working to choose who may receive His mercy in Israel
        - There is simply no other way to explain such a precise number of believing Jews
        - Either God chose precisely who would believe, or else it's the greatest coincidence in the history of coincidences
- And in case you're tempted to vote for coincidence, Paul makes sure you understand this number was no coincidence
    - In v.5 Paul says Elijah's example is proof of how the Lord works to preserve a remnant in Israel
        - Paul says in the same way today we will find a precise number of Israel preserved from apostasy by God's gracious choice
        - By His grace, He choose to save some in Israel
    - And if it's always by God's gracious choice, then it can never be according to our works
        - Paul says in v.6 one excludes the other, because they are mutually exclusive
        - When Paul says works, he's referring back to what we learned in Chapter 10
        - The Jewish people are pursuing God's mercy by trying to do the works of the Law
        - They are zealous but without a true knowledge of salvation
    - But Paul says if the remnant of believing Israel only comes from God's choice, then it can never be earned by works, even works of law
        - The Jews are barking up the wrong tree, seeking to be justified by their works
        - Meanwhile, the remnant of Israel – those who will receive God's mercy – are those God chooses by His grace
    - If God allowed Israel to receive mercy because of their zealousness, then salvation would cease to be by grace
        - If you want God to reward the zealousness of Israel, then you're voting for God to do away with grace for everyone
        - And then suddenly, we all would find ourselves in an impossible race to earn salvation
        - Either we accept that God finds those He chooses to receive His mercy (which is the Bible's definition of grace)
        - Or we seek to find God's mercy by our own efforts, which is the Bible's definition of works
- But of course we want the Lord to work on the basis of grace, for if it were any other way we could never receive mercy
    - Therefore, we accept God's sovereignty and understand that God is choosing to work with only a minority in Israel for now

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        - And this is Paul's conclusion too, and it leads to the next question

Rom. 11:7 What then? What Israel is seeking, it has not obtained, but those who were chosen obtained it, and the rest were hardened;
Rom. 11:8 just as it is written,
"God gave them a spirit of stupor,
Eyes to see not and ears to hear not,
Down to this very day."
Rom. 11:9 And David says,
"Let their table become a snare and a trap,
And a stumbling block and a retribution to them.
Rom. 11:10 "Let their eyes be darkened to see not,
And bend their backs forever."

- Paul asks "What then" or, we could say, "what does all this mean"?
    - Paul explains that the righteousness Israel is seeking (through works of Law), it has not been obtained
        - The nation of Israel as a whole has not found righteousness
        - Righteousness came for them in the person of Jesus and they rejected Him
        - They failed to confess Christ in faith, and the Lord continues to withhold His mercy for the majority of Jews
    - So Israel continues pursuing righteousness the wrong way, while saving faith continues to be found by Gentiles
        - In the meantime, Paul says a minority of Jews, people like Paul himself, were chosen by God to receive righteousness
        - These are the elect of Israel, the remnant that demonstrate God's continuing faithfulness to the Jewish people
        - They had what they had by God's choice, and nothing demonstrates that better than Paul's own conversion story
        - Paul was literally arrested by Jesus while walking on a road, and Jesus never offered Paul a choice of whether to follow Him
        - Paul was chosen to be part of the remnant
    - But the rest of Israel has been hardened by God, Paul says
        - The last time we saw Paul use the term "hardened" was in Chapter 9, when Paul raised the example of Pharaoh
        - Pharaoh's sinful heart was set against the Lord from the start
        - But as Paul showed us, the Lord acted to ensure Pharaoh's heart remained disobedient so Pharaoh wouldn't give in prematurely
- Therefore, we should apply the meaning of the word in a similar way here to describe God's dealing with Israel

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- Israel initially opposed Christ by their own sinful hearts
  - God didn't have to do anything to create Israel's unbelief
  - Unbelief was Israel's natural condition just as it is for all fallen humanity
  - But Paul says God hardened Israel's hearts to ensure their continued resistance to the Gospel
- And once again, Paul backs his teaching with Old Testament scripture that declares the same truth
  - The first quote in v.8 comes from the Law in Deuteronomy where Moses foretold that God would ensure His people Israel remained outside His mercy
  - Paul paraphrases the verse, so here's the exact wording of Deut. 29

Deut. 29:2 And Moses summoned all Israel and said to them, "You have seen all that the Lord did before your eyes in the land of Egypt to Pharaoh and all his servants and all his land;
Deut. 29:3 the great trials which your eyes have seen, those great signs and wonders.
Deut. 29:4 "Yet to this day the Lord has not given you a heart to know, nor eyes to see, nor ears to hear.
Deut. 29:5 "I have led you forty years in the wilderness; your clothes have not worn out on you, and your sandal has not worn out on your foot.

- This scene is near the end of the forty years of wandering
  - Moses is addressing the generation of Israel that grew up in the desert
  - This is the generation that will be allowed to enter the Promised Land in contrast to their parents who were barred for unbelief
- But right before they enter, Moses addresses them
  - He says though they had seen great miracles in the desert, nevertheless this generation still wasn't a believing people
    - Why not? How could they *not* believe given all the miracles they have seen God doing?
    - Moses says the answer is the Lord had not given them eyes to see or ears to hear
    - Most importantly, God had not given them hearts to know Him
  - Moses' words make it abundantly clear that no one believes unless and until the Lord chooses to bring them mercy
    - That's Paul's point here in Chapter 11
    - Like the generation of Israel that came out of the desert, the Lord has not given the Israel of our generation hearts to know Him either
    - Apart from a small remnant, Israel has been hardened

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- David confirms this conclusion in Psalm 69 saying let their table become a snare and stumbling block
  - This quote is Jesus speaking prophetically through David, asking the Father to bring retribution upon those who crucified Jesus
  - Israel's "table" refers to the banquet table that opens the Kingdom
- When Jesus came to Israel, this table was "set" for Israel in the sense that Israel could have received the Kingdom had they accepted Jesus as their King
  - Instead, they rejected Jesus, so Jesus says let their rejection be cause for God to withhold the Kingdom from Israel
  - In that sense, Jesus' offer of the Kingdom became a snare, a trap, a stumbling block and a retribution to Israel
  - What could have been Israel's ticket to the Kingdom became just cause for God to withhold the Kingdom and keep Israel under judgment

- So God has purposed to withhold salvation from Israel as a whole (apart from a small remnant) because of their rejection of Jesus
  - But this was not a plan to crush or destroy Israel, as Paul explains next
    - This following section of Romans 11 is especially important to Paul's overall argument in Chapters 9-11
    - So we need to understand it carefully
  - First, we need to understand that at this point Paul is talking expressly about nations, not individual people
    - He's comparing God's plan for the Jewish nation with His plan for Gentiles
    - That's the question we've been following from the start of Chapter 9
    - Therefore, we can't apply what Paul is saying to the circumstances of a single individual – whether Jew or Gentile
  - Let's look at the next section and we'll see this pattern at work

Rom. 11:11 I say then, they did not stumble so as to fall, did they? May it never be! But by their transgression salvation has come to the Gentiles, to make them jealous.
Rom. 11:12 Now if their transgression is riches for the world and their failure is riches for the Gentiles, how much more will their fulfillment be!
Rom. 11:13 But I am speaking to you who are Gentiles. Inasmuch then as I am an apostle of Gentiles, I magnify my ministry,
Rom. 11:14 if somehow I might move to jealousy my fellow countrymen and save some of them.
Rom. 11:15 For if their rejection is the reconciliation of the world, what will their acceptance be but life from the dead?
Rom. 11:16 If the first piece of dough is holy, the lump is also; and if the root is holy, the branches are too.

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- In vs.11-16 Paul reaffirms that Israel still has a special place in God's plan
  - He asks, did the Lord allow the nation to stumble so they might fall?
    - By fall Paul means to cease to be God's people, to disappear, to be forsaken
    - And of course, the answer again is no: God doesn't have Israel's destruction in mind
  - Instead, the Lord withheld His mercy from Israel, allowing them to reject Jesus and to be justly set under judgment for doing so, for a good purpose
    - And that good purpose was you and me
    - We Gentiles are now enjoying the Lord's grace, being given opportunity to receive His mercy
    - And in the process, we serve God's purpose in making Israel jealous
  - As I said last week, we make Israel jealous in the sense that we stir within the Jewish people a renewed desire for their Messiah
    - We aren't leading Jews to become jealous of Jesus, nor to agreeing He is their Messiah
    - Nevertheless, our declaration that Jesus is Messiah serves to strengthen Israel's anticipation and desire for a Messiah
    - In the same way that when your best friend gets a girlfriend or boyfriend, it makes you wish you could find one too
- Paul then asks us to consider how God is working in this way for the benefit for the entire world, both Jew and Gentile
  - Paul compares the mistake Israel made with the way God used it for good
    - Israel's rejection of Jesus was their transgression (singular)
    - That transgression gave God just cause to send Jesus to Gentiles instead, as we learned in Chapter 10
    - Now you and I enjoy great riches in Christ because God allowed His own people to sin against His Son
  - That's a whole lotta good to come from a very bad thing
    - So if God could use Israel's rejection of Christ to accomplish very good things for us, what more good things might come when Israel receives Christ?
    - At the end of v.12, Paul describes that moment as Israel's fulfillment
    - He means when God finally fulfills His promises to give Israel the Kingdom
    - That can only happen if and when Israel receives Christ, of course
  - So Israel receiving Christ will bring about even better things for the world than their rejection of Christ brought to us
    - Isn't that an amazing thing to consider?
    - Israel is blessing us regardless of what they do
    - When they sin against Jesus, it opened the door for God to give us mercy

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        - And when they finally receive Christ, it will bring us even more riches because it will bring about the Kingdom God promised
- Knowing this, how should we Gentiles view the Jewish people during this time – especially those who are not believing in Jesus?
    - Paul explains it to us saying specifically in v.13, listen up Gentiles
        - Paul was the apostle appointed by Jesus to reach Gentiles
        - But Paul says even though he was sent to Gentiles, he magnifies his ministry when he manages to reach a Jew here or there
        - Paul always went to the Jew first before reaching out to the Gentile in each city he visited, which was in keeping with Paul's desire to save the Jews
    - That's how Gentiles should look at Jews as well
        - We know the nation has been set aside for a time, for our sake
        - But we also know God is still working a plan for their sake, and they were God's means of reaching us in the first place
        - So we should seek for the lost Jew, for the remnant God is seeking to save
    - Because if their rejection of Christ brought the reconciliation to the Gentile world, then Israel's acceptance of Christ will bring about the resurrection
        - In other words, the first coming of Christ brought about Israel's rejection
        - And therefore, Israel's acceptance of Christ will bring about Christ's Second Coming
        - That's the moment for the resurrection of all dead and the start of the Kingdom
        - Daniel teaches both these truths, as also covered in Isaiah, Ezekiel and Zechariah
    - So seeking Jews for Christ, in compassion and understanding, should be the natural response for any Christian who understands God's plan for the world
        - We stand in Christ because of Israel and we will receive the Kingdom only when Israel does too
        - So we have every reason to treat that nation of people with respect and seek their conversion earnestly
    - As Paul says, if the first piece is holy, so the lump, or if the root is holy, so are the branches
        - The lump or the root both refer to the beginnings of Israel
        - Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, David…these men of Israel represent the lump or the root of Israel
    - Do you consider these men to be holy? To be respected? To be honored?
        - Then likewise, you must consider the nation God has produced from these men to be equally worthy of honor
        - Not because they are individually worthy of our respect or even if they are believing or not

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        - But merely because they are God's people, who God has used to make available everything we hold dear
- At hearing this, some Christians can't help but call foul
    - We question whether it's right to treat such an unholy, disobedient people with respect
        - After all, they crucified Jesus and they spit at the mention of His name today
        - Jews typically treat Christians with great disdain
    - And it was even worse in Paul's day, of course
        - Jews were persecuting Christians to the point of imprisonment and death
        - Under those circumstances, it was especially hard to accept the notion that Gentile Christians should continue to hold Jews, even unbelieving Jews, in high esteem
- Nevertheless, Paul calls the church to set aside any prejudice or hatred for God's people, warning us of what may come

Rom. 11:17 But if some of the branches were broken off, and you, being a wild olive, were grafted in among them and became partaker with them of the rich root of the olive tree,
Rom. 11:18 do not be arrogant toward the branches; but if you are arrogant, remember that it is not you who supports the root, but the root supports you.
Rom. 11:19 You will say then, "Branches were broken off so that I might be grafted in."
Rom. 11:20 Quite right, they were broken off for their unbelief, but you stand by your faith. Do not be conceited, but fear;
Rom. 11:21 for if God did not spare the natural branches, He will not spare you, either.
Rom. 11:22 Behold then the kindness and severity of God; to those who fell, severity, but to you, God's kindness, if you continue in His kindness; otherwise you also will be cut off.
Rom. 11:23 And they also, if they do not continue in their unbelief, will be grafted in, for God is able to graft them in again.
Rom. 11:24 For if you were cut off from what is by nature a wild olive tree, and were grafted contrary to nature into a cultivated olive tree, how much more will these who are the natural branches be grafted into their own olive tree?

- In this passage, Paul continues to speak in terms of nations not individuals
    - It's critically important to understand that context here
    - Otherwise, we're likely to make serious mistakes in interpreting Paul's argument
- He compares the present generations of Israel to the branches of an olive tree
    - Remember, Paul just spoke of Israel's origins as a holy lump or root

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- Now he's just extending the metaphor further to speak of the future for Israel
- The branches of this root represent the present generation of Israel
  - These are the people that have grown up from the root
  - They are the descendants of the patriarchs and they are the heirs to the promises God gave to those men
  - But they didn't receive the Messiah, so Paul says the branches were broken off
- So in Paul's analogy, breaking off natural olive branches pictures God setting aside present generations of Israel for their rejecting of Jesus
  - And we learned, God did so to make salvation available to Gentiles
    - Paul pictures that as wild olive branches grafted into the branchless root
    - In Palestine, cultivated olive trees differ from wild olive trees
    - Naturally, a cultivated olive tree produces a certain type of branch, while a wild tree produces a different type of branch
  - Paul compares Gentiles to unnatural branches in the root of Israel
    - We are like something wild which God has grafted into the holy lump of Israel
    - We have what we have spiritually because God first made it available to Israel
    - And we have it unnaturally, which is to say it wasn't given to us directly
    - We only have it because God's people don't have it for this time
- Knowing this, Paul says we have no right to be arrogant toward those branches who are broken off (speaking of the unbelieving Jews of our day)
  - Whether God chooses to bring them to faith or not, we have no place in treating them arrogantly
    - As if to suggest we are better than them because we have received what they rejected
    - Paul says, remember who is the root in this arrangement
    - Who is holding you up, so to speak?
  - So if we treat an unbelieving Jew disrespectfully, especially if we harbor antisemitic views, we're forgetting that his or her unbelief was ordained for our sake
    - In v.19 Paul suggests that some Christians might conclude God cut Israel off to give us our place in the Church
    - Paul's making the argument of the replacement theologian
    - That the Church has replaced Israel in God's plan, therefore we have no reason to give special consideration to Jewish people
    - They are yesterday's news, as far as God is concerned
  - To this Paul responds in v.20 that yes, they were cut off for our sake, but remember you stand by your faith
    - That is to say, the Gentile church has what it has merely because God decided we should have it

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        - He decided to shift His mercy toward us, so that by faith we might receive His righteousness
        - Remember, we already learned that we have His righteousness not because we were looking for it but because God elected that we should receive it
    - So Paul warns the replacement theologian not to be so conceited in their view of Israel, but instead to fear God
        - Because God's pattern should be clear by now
        - In v.21, Paul writes that if God was willing to set His own people aside for a time, then certainly we should anticipate He is willing to do the same for Gentiles
- Paul's alluding to what's coming for Israel and the world
    - There was a day in the past when the natural branches were the center of God's attention
        - In that day, the Gentile nations were subject to Israel's power and prestige
        - When God wanted His people to have the Promised Land, the Canaanites were taken out of the way
        - When God wanted to free His people, Egypt and the Pharaoh were collateral damage
    - But then God elected to cut off those natural branches to make room for unnatural branches to share in the good things God gave to Israel
        - While we sit in this privileged position, it's Israel that pays the price
        - As God desires to bless other nations, He sacrifices His own people
    - But this isn't the end of the story
        - We know God has a Kingdom on earth planned, where His Son will rule from the seat of David in the temple in Jerusalem
        - Scriptures say that in this kingdom to come, Israel will once again be God's chief nation on the earth
        - And all Gentile nations in the Kingdom will serve and honor the Jewish nation
    - So Paul directs our attention to that day, when Israel will once again be in the driver's seat
        - And as we consider that day to come, we should ask how will God will deal with us if we spent our time on earth arrogantly against His people?
        - When they have become our masters and we are Israel's servants, will we wish we had thought twice about our prejudice?
        - That's what Paul means when he says believers who are arrogant against unbelieving Israel should fear God
- Then in v.21 Paul reveals that if God was willing to set His own people aside for a time, then we should expect He will one day He will do the same for Gentiles
    - In a day to come, God's mercy towards Gentiles will come to an end
        - And in that moment, He will turn His attention back again to His own people

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        - In that day, the Gentiles will be cut off just as Jews were cut off
        - Once again, we're not talking about individual people being cut off
        - Paul's talking about nations moving in and out of God's favor in His plan for the world
    - In summary, Paul asks us to contemplate the kindness and severity of God
        - The same God that cut off Israel has welcomed the likes of us into His mercy
        - He is showing severity to Israel for now while showing us kindness
    - But Paul adds at the end of v.22 that this state is not permanent
        - Gentiles should not depend on God's mercy remaining available to us forever
        - In a day to come, the Lord will shift His mercy back to the Jewish people, so that He might fulfill the promises He made to them
        - In that day, Gentiles will be cut off, and the Jewish nation will be grafted back into their own root again
    - After all, Paul argues, if God can graft in unnatural branches, then He can certainly go back to grafting natural branches back in
        - Or simply put, if God was willing to offer salvation to a people who were not His people
        - Then how much should we expect Him to offer salvation to the people who ARE His people
        - Remember the quote from Hosea in Romans 9:

Rom. 9:25 **As He says also in Hosea,**
"I will call those who were not My people, 'My people,'
And her who was not beloved, 'Beloved.'"
Rom. 9:26 **"And It shall be that in the place where it was said to them, 'You are not My people,'**
There they shall be called sons of the living God."

- The prophet said that God would call Gentiles His people
- But then he added that in a time to come the Lord would call Israel sons of the living God again
- So as we prepare to finish this chapter, here's what we know
    - God dispenses His mercy as He chooses
        - Historically, God has selected only a minority of Israel to receive mercy
        - When the time came for Israel to receive their Messiah, they rejected Him because of their hard hearts
        - God gave Israel the message that salvation was by faith, early and often
        - Yet they stubbornly refused to accept God's word, preferring to seek their own

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righteousness

- Moreover, God did not give the nation hearts to know and receive Christ as judgment for their sin
  - He left them in their sins, allowing their sinful hearts to go their own way, leading to the rejection and crucifixion of Christ
  - This was God's plan, to set His people aside, so that He could fulfill His promise to Abraham to bring His mercy to all nations
- Today, His mercy is going out to all nations because of Israel's rejection of Christ
  - Meanwhile, God has hardened Israel's hearts to leave them outside His mercy for a time
  - In the meantime, we Gentiles who are receiving God's mercy must not look arrogantly upon His people though they remain unbelieving
  - How can we look upon Israel with contempt knowing they were left unbelieving so we might receive God's mercy?
  - It's a humbling truth and it should leave us with great sympathy for the Jewish people

- So all that remains for us to understand, is how God plans to fulfill His promises to Israel

Rom. 11:25 **For I do not want you, brethren, to be uninformed of this mystery — so that you will not be wise in your own estimation — that a partial hardening has happened to Israel until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in;**
Rom. 11:26 **and so all Israel will be saved; just as it is written,**
"The Deliverer will come from Zion,
He will remove ungodliness from Jacob."
Rom. 11:27 **"This is My covenant with them,**
When I take away their sins."

- This is a powerful section of Paul's letter, yet it's brief on details
  - Most of the details are available in other scripture, but time won't permit me to walk through all of it
    - You can see the details in other studies like Revelation so I will just summarize here as Paul does
    - Beginning with Paul's preface in v.25
  - Paul prepares us to receive a mystery
    - A mystery in the Bible is a truth that has existed from the beginning, but was hidden from our understanding until revealed in the New Testament
    - There are eight such mysteries in the New Testament, and Paul revealed four of the them
    - Here we find one of them

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- Paul says unless we understand this mystery, we're likely to be wise in our own estimation
  - We might be tempted to think we know what God is doing with Israel and the Gentile church
  - But in reality our wisdom is in our own eyes only, because we lack a critical piece of information
- Once again, Paul's describing those who hold to replacement theology: who believe the Church has replaced Israel
  - This view is necessarily a partial truth, because it understands God's pattern up to the point of the First Coming of Christ
  - But that's where the understanding stops, and so it misses the rest of the story

- Paul says here's the rest of the story: the hardening that Israel has experienced since Christ is partial and temporary
  - It's partial because it still allows for a remnant – a small number of believing Jews who never cease to exist on earth
    - Remember, this is important because all by itself the remnant is proof that God is not done with His covenant people
    - So God continues to maintain faith among at least some in Israel to make sure His nation carries forward
  - Secondly, this hardening is temporary
    - It won't last forever
    - It ends when the fullness of Gentiles comes in
    - The term "fullness" is a Greek word that can be translated "a full count"
  - So when God has reached the full count of Gentiles He intends to save, then He will be ready to return His attention to Israel
    - At that point, the hardening of Israel will come to an end
    - And the nation will receive God's mercy so as to believe in Jesus, just as Gentiles have now received the same
  - This is yet another clear statement of God's sovereignty in salvation and His appointment of a certain number of believing people
    - In a way, we could say that just as God had a certain number of Jews in mind for His remnant (i.e., 7,000 in Elijah's day)
    - Similarly, God has a certain number of Gentiles in mind for salvation across this age
    - And like the Jewish remnant was a small number relative to the overall number of Jewish people
    - Similarly, the Gentiles who receive mercy will be a small number compared to the overall number of Gentiles who walk the earth
- Furthermore, Paul quotes Old Testament scriptures to prove that God has foretold these details as well – though they were hidden until Paul's day

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- In v.26 Paul quotes from the very end of Isaiah 59
  - That chapter, and the one that follows, describes the circumstances surrounding Christ's Second Coming and the start of His Kingdom
  - In the midst of those events, Isaiah says the Lord promises to send Jesus from Zion (referring to the Zion in Heaven)
  - He will come for the purpose of removing ungodliness from Jacob
- Jacob is another name for Israel, so it stands for the nation of Israel
  - At His Second Coming to earth, Jesus will remove all ungodliness from Israel
  - The nation of Jews alive on earth in that future day will all be saved by faith in Jesus
- This is a dramatic turn around from the situation we find today, which is exactly what Paul has been telling us will happen
  - One day, the Lord's mercy will return to His people in a big way
  - He won't just save a remnant in that future day
  - He intends to save all His people
- Notice how Paul opens v.26: he says "and so all Israel will be saved"
  - Every single Jew will receive mercy in that day to come
  - We see this moment described in Zechariah 12

Zech. 12:9 **"And in that day I will set about to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem.**
Zech. 12:10 **"I will pour out on the house of David and on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the Spirit of grace and of supplication, so that they will look on Me whom they have pierced; and they will mourn for Him, as one mourns for an only son, and they will weep bitterly over Him like the bitter weeping over a firstborn.**
Zech. 12:11 **"In that day there will be great mourning in Jerusalem, like the mourning of Hadadrimmon in the plain of Megiddo.**
Zech. 12:12 **"The land will mourn, every family by itself; the family of the house of David by itself and their wives by themselves; the family of the house of Nathan by itself and their wives by themselves;**
Zech. 12:13 **the family of the house of Levi by itself and their wives by themselves; the family of the Shimeites by itself and their wives by themselves;**
Zech. 12:14 **all the families that remain, every family by itself and their wives by themselves.**

- The setting of Zechariah 12-14 is the end of Tribulation and the war of Armageddon and the return of Christ
  - So we're talking about the same moment that Isaiah was speaking about in

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Chapters 59-60

- In that moment, Zechariah describes how all Israel will be saved just as Paul says
- The Spirit of God will be poured out on the people of Israel so that all of them recognize Jesus as Messiah
- Notice Zechariah says “all the families that remain” on earth are saved in this way

- Here again, we cannot explain how such a thing could happen except that God sovereignly brings all these people to faith by His grace
  - Since there are no exceptions, we must acknowledge that this moment is determined by will or choice
  - It was determined by God’s will in keeping with His promises to Israel
- Just as Isaiah says in v.27: this act of mercy is God keeping His covenant with them, to save them and bring them into the Kingdom
  - God promised Israel this future through the Abrahamic Covenant
  - And He reiterated it in the Mosaic Covenant (Lev 26:42)
  - And God will keep His promises
- But He has delayed the fulfillment of these things long enough to extend mercy to a certain number of Gentiles, including you and me
  - That number hasn’t been reached yet, obviously
  - But one day it will be reached, and then God will move to rescue Israel from unbelief

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- Tonight we're moving away from Paul's explanation of Israel's unique place in His plan of salvation and back into Paul's main point of teaching
  - Before we do, we still have Paul's summary at the end of Romans 11 to consider
    - This summary will serve as our transition back into his essay on righteousness
    - So let's pick up in v.28

Rom. 11:28 From the standpoint of the gospel they are enemies for your sake, but from the standpoint of God's choice they are beloved for the sake of the fathers;
Rom. 11:29 for the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable.
Rom. 11:30 For just as you once were disobedient to God, but now have been shown mercy because of their disobedience,
Rom. 11:31 so these also now have been disobedient, that because of the mercy shown to you they also may now be shown mercy.
Rom. 11:32 For God has shut up all in disobedience so that He may show mercy to all.

- Paul's summary brings together everything we've learned in Chapters 9-10
  - Paul says that from the standpoint or perspective of the Gospel, God made Israel His enemy for our sake
    - But Israel isn't God's enemy in all respects
    - Paul says God made them to be His enemy only in relationship to the Gospel, that is to Christ
    - Israel rejected Christ and they impeded the movement of the Gospel, and in that sense they are an enemy of the Gospel
  - But Paul goes on to say God made Israel to be this way *for our sake*, so that we might receive God's mercy for a time
    - So understanding this situation from God's perspective, we find something astounding
    - Rather than forsaking His people, God's hardening of Israel is proof that God is still very much working for their good
  - It's proof that God is keeping the covenants and promises that He made with Israel
    - Paul says we can see they are still beloved for the sake of "the fathers"
    - In other words, God is still keeping every promise He gave to the patriarchs, the fathers
  - And among those promises was the guarantee that God would hold Israel under judgment for their sins if they disobeyed the Law
    - For example, in the Old Covenant the Lord told Israel this:

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Deut. 29:14 **“Now not with you alone am I making this covenant and this oath,**
Deut. 29:15 **but both with those who stand here with us today in the presence of the Lord our God and with those who are not with us here today**
Deut. 29:16 **(for you know how we lived in the land of Egypt, and how we came through the midst of the nations through which you passed;**
Deut. 29:17 **moreover, you have seen their abominations and their idols of wood, stone, silver, and gold, which they had with them);**
Deut. 29:18 **so that there will not be among you a man or woman, or family or tribe, whose heart turns away today from the Lord our God, to go and serve the gods of those nations; that there will not be among you a root bearing poisonous fruit and wormwood.**
Deut. 29:19 **“It shall be when he hears the words of this curse, that he will boast, saying, ‘I have peace though I walk in the stubbornness of my heart in order to destroy the watered land with the dry.’**
Deut. 29:20 **“The Lord shall never be willing to forgive him, but rather the anger of the Lord and His jealousy will burn against that man, and every curse which is written in this book will rest on him, and the Lord will blot out his name from under heaven.**
Deut. 29:21 **“Then the Lord will single him out for adversity from all the tribes of Israel, according to all the curses of the covenant which are written in this book of the law.**
Deut. 29:22 **“Now the generation to come, your sons who rise up after you and the foreigner who comes from a distant land, when they see the plagues of the land and the diseases with which the Lord has afflicted it, will say,**
Deut. 29:23 **‘All its land is brimstone and salt, a burning waste, unsown and unproductive, and no grass grows in it, like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, which the Lord overthrew in His anger and in His wrath.’**
Deut. 29:24 **“All the nations will say, ‘Why has the Lord done thus to this land? Why this great outburst of anger?’**
Deut. 29:25 **“Then men will say, ‘Because they forsook the covenant of the Lord, the God of their fathers, which He made with them when He brought them out of the land of Egypt.**
Deut. 29:26 **‘They went and served other gods and worshiped them, gods whom they have not known and whom He had not allotted to them.**
Deut. 29:27 **‘Therefore, the anger of the Lord burned against that land, to bring upon it every curse which is written in this book;**
Deut. 29:28 **and the Lord uprooted them from their land in anger and in fury and in great wrath, and cast them into another land, as it is this day.’**

- Israel is currently enduring a millennial-long period of judgment, outside the mercy of God apart from a remnant

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- They endure this because God promised Israel it would happen for their disobedience to the Old Covenant
- So incredibly, Israel's current circumstances prove God's continuing love for His people

- Paul says that from the perspective of God's choice, Israel remains beloved by God
  - For 2,000 years Israel has been under judgment
  - Yet the nation hasn't disappeared or ceased to remain a distinct people
  - And in the past century, they began to return to their land for the first time in two millennia
- This is our proof that God is still at work with them, fulfilling His promises to them, which means He still loves His people
  - And therefore we can know that He will eventually fulfill the "good" promises too
  - Just as when a parent disciplines a child properly, it's evidence of a parent's caring heart
- Nevertheless, we may suppose this is unfair or unloving
  - Perhaps we would expect the Lord to overlook Israel's rejection of Christ and forget His promises of judgment
    - But if that's what you expect, think about what you're asking
    - You're asking God to be unfaithful to His promises
    - You might think you're doing Israel a favor with that petition, but in reality you're destroying your own faith
  - For if God could do as you want – ignore His promises to judge Israel and forget His own word to them – then what prevents God from doing the same to you?
    - If He can ignore His promise to judge Israel might He also forget His promises to give you eternal life?
    - We can't have it both ways: either God is a trustworthy God Who always keeps His promises – whether "good" and "bad"
    - Or else He is not trustworthy to keep *any* promises and we have believed in vain
- Paul emphasizes this conclusion in v.29 saying the gifts and calling of God are irrevocable
  - When God gives a gift, it cannot be refused or lost, for our possession of it didn't depend on ourselves in the first place
    - Likewise when God places a calling on a person or group of people, that calling will never be revoked
    - Because God doesn't call in error or change His mind later
  - Paul is applying this principle to nations, but it applies equally to individuals
    - That is, our gift of eternal life is irrevocable
    - Once we have been called and justified, our standing in Christ's righteousness cannot change

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- As Jude says

Jude 24 Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling, and to make you stand in the presence of His glory blameless with great joy,
Jude 25 to the only God our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, be glory, majesty, dominion and authority, before all time and now and forever. Amen.

- Furthermore, the calling of God on a Christian cannot be revoked
  - God calls men and women to serve Him in certain capacities and He gifts us with abilities to meet that calling
  - And these things never change, the calling is a permanent duty for life
  - But regrettably, in the weakness of our flesh we may act in ways contrary to God's calling
- For example, we've all seen men or women who began in ministry only to walk away later
  - Which leaves us wondering did they reject God's calling or did He reject them?
  - Someone who walks away from God's calling is disobeying God
  - And the one who takes up a ministry without God's calling is presuming on God
  - In the case of Israel, God gifted the Jewish people with covenants and called them to be His people for eternity – and those things cannot be reversed
- Meanwhile, in v.30 Paul says God is also working His plan for Gentiles
  - We were once in Israel's place, that is, outside God's mercy
    - And our collective disobedience to God became cause for God to reach out and establish a plan of redemption
    - He moved first through a single man, Abram, gifting him with a covenant by which God established the Jewish people
    - These people would be the first among all peoples to receive God's mercy in a plan of salvation
  - But when God's plan culminated in the arrival of Christ, Israel was the one who acted disobediently to God
    - So then God used Israel's disobedience as just cause to begin showing mercy to the Gentiles through the same Gospel
    - And that period continues today
- But then in v.31 Paul says this course pattern has yet one more turn before we reach the finish line
  - A day is coming when the Lord will bring mercy to Israel again
    - Why? Because He owes them the same opportunity for mercy that He gave to disobedient Gentiles in times past
    - Remember, Gentiles weren't seeking God when He came to us with Jesus

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        - We didn't deserve His mercy when He elected us to receive it
        - He simply acted on His own for our sake in spite of our disobedience
    - So now that Israel has become disobedient, they find themselves in the same place we Gentiles were once
        - So Paul says if God was willing to overlook our disobedience to bring us Christ in the past
        - Then in fairness He will overlook Israel's disobedience to the Gospel to bring them Christ as well
        - One day Israel will be brought to faith in Jesus too and thus will God's plan to save the nations come to its conclusion
    - The central flaw – and conceit – of Replacement Theology is overlooking this final turn in God's plan of salvation
        - They acknowledge three fourths of Paul's argument
        - They acknowledge that Jews were once given mercy
        - And they agree that Gentiles were once disobedient and without God
        - And they see that God set aside Israel for their disobedience while extending mercy to Gentiles
        - But they overlook that God says He will do the same for Israel, extending mercy to them despite their disobedience
- Paul summarizes this concept powerfully in v.32
    - God has left each group, Gentiles and Jews, in their disobedience for a time
        - He shut up all, Paul says
        - We could also say God "shut out" each group for a time, leaving each group largely without mercy for a time
        - And He also extends mercy to each group for a time, thereby treating each group fairly in the end
        - As we sit here today, we might see this as unfair because we are witnessing only one moment of the plan
        - But by Paul's teaching, we come to appreciate that God's plan is to use one group's disobedience as just cause to go to the other group with mercy and vice versa
    - When you think about what Paul is explaining, you begin to sit back in your chair in awe of the plan of God
        - And you share in Paul's exclamation at the end of the chapter

Rom. 11:33 Oh, the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are His judgments and unfathomable His ways!
Rom. 11:34 For who has known the mind of the Lord, Or who became His counselor?

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Rom. 11:35 Or who has first given to Him that it might be paid back to him again?
Rom. 11:36 For from Him and through Him and to Him are all things. To Him be the glory forever. Amen.

- This is the proper response to understanding the sovereignty of God and the power of God to extend His mercy to all
  - When you learned about God choosing those who will receive mercy and who will not…
  - And that God has determined to open doors or shut doors for whole groups of people over the course of history…
  - If that caused you to question God's love or even the truth of what you read in the Bible…
- Then as they say, you're doing it wrong
  - Or in this case, you're understanding it wrong
  - Because your response should be the same as Paul's response here
  - We're witnesses to the wisdom and knowledge and power of God at work to bring salvation to all people according to His will
  - And it's unfathomable
- His judgments and His mercy are unsearchable and beyond our understanding
  - And if you think you know better how it should be, Paul says we are in no position to counsel God or to teach Him
  - We have nothing to offer Him that He should profit from a relationship with us
  - He owes us nothing for He already has all things, Paul says
  - So all that God is doing in these things is for His glory, not ours
- So now we understand how Israel's rejection of Jesus and their present hardening was appointed by God
  - It was both just and purposeful on God's part
    - But it's also temporary
    - Ultimately, God plans to fulfill His promises to His people in a day to come
  - So Israel's situation does not cast doubt on our own confidence in the promises we've received from the Lord
    - Rather, God's willingness to hold His people under judgment is even greater cause for us to have confidence
    - For it tells us that God is, indeed, a promise-keeping God – even as He holds His people under judgment for a time
  - Meanwhile, we who are in Christ Jesus have no worry of such condemnation
    - Because we are not under the Law God gave Israel, so we do not share in their jeopardy

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        - And what's more, anyone who has come to know Jesus as Messiah is no longer under Law
        - Therefore, the curses that Israel is experiencing now are not appointed for those in Christ, whether Jew or Gentile
    - So we can live in the light of a salvation that is without end and cannot be taken from us
        - Knowing this, how should we live?
        - That's the topic Paul will address in the last section of His letter
- Beginning now in Chapter 12, we move from an explanation of how we are saved to an exhortation for how we live in light of our salvation
    - Simply put, we leave a conversation about justification (Chapters 1-8)
        - And we move to a conversation about sanctification (Chapters 9-15)
        - That means it's time to consult our Romans Structure chart again
- Notice that our topic is still righteousness, but now we're talking about righteousness lived out rather than obtaining righteousness
    - Chapters 1-8 taught us we obtain righteousness by faith in Jesus Christ
    - And we can never lose that righteousness because it didn't become ours based on our actions – it came as a result of God changing our spirit
- And since we have been freed from any concerns about earning salvation, our life can be directed at serving Christ without fear or worry
    - Yet that service comes in a certain way, according to a certain priority
    - And so in these chapters Paul gives us a prioritized list of the ways we should live out our righteousness in service to Christ
    - They progress from our person, to the church body, to our witness to unbelievers, to our role in society
    - And once again, at the end, Paul narrows his focus on Jew vs. Gentile
- Before we look at the first part of this section, let's consult a new chart that will guide us through this final section

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- Paul has organized his discussion of sanctification in a very careful manner
  - We must appreciate his structure, otherwise his instructions may appear as merely a collection of do's and don't's
  - In reality, these chapters are a prioritized system for directing our approach to serving Christ
  - And his structure has the benefit of resolving conflicts that arise from competing priorities or values
- We can represent Paul's system with a bull's eye chart like the one above
  - Each ring in the chart represents a relationship in which a believer must seek for righteousness
  - The heart of the bull's eye represents righteousness in our relationship with God
  - The next ring is our righteousness among the Church, which is our relationship with believers
  - The next ring is our righteousness before the world, which is our relationship with unbelievers
  - The final ring is our righteousness within societal structures, which is our relationship with government
- The outward movement of these concentric rings sets our priority for where to work and how to resolve conflicting goals
  - The center of the bull's eye is our highest priority
    - As the rings move outward, the priority diminishes
    - For example, our relationship with God is the most important area of sanctification
    - It's a higher priority than our relationships with the church or the world
    - But as we attend to our personal holiness with God, we also become better equipped to attend to the needs of the outer rings
  - Obviously, we never "finish" working on a given ring
    - We will always battle sin in ourselves and we will always work on improving our relationships in the body of Christ, etc.
    - Nevertheless as we gain some measure of strength in one ring, we begin to benefit from that strength as we work in other rings
  - A Christian cannot short circuit this process
    - We cannot skip over an inner ring and expect to succeed in outer rings
    - For example, the believer who has not made an effort to grow in the grace and knowledge of Jesus Christ is not well-prepared to serve fellow believers
    - Likewise, if we don't strive for holiness in our relationships within the body of Christ (where we have a safe environment to fail and learn), how will we win unbelievers?
  - Finally, we work on these relationships in the power of the Spirit to convict, teach

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and guide us through this process

- We can't achieve results in our own power
- We must following the Spirit's leading, allowing Him to change our hearts over time

- When we pursue sanctification according to Paul's pattern, we gain a biblical tool for resolving conflicts in our obedience priorities
  - For example: if serving God in our personal righteousness comes into conflict with the government's demands upon us, who do we obey?
    - According to Paul's prioritized system, we must obey God over government (we'll talk more about this in Chapter 13)
    - Or if our commitment to the body of Christ conflicts with our obligations to the world, we give priority to our Church relationships over the world
  - We'll look more at these examples as we go through Paul's teaching
    - But I hope you already see the value of this chart for guiding our walk with Christ
    - These chapters are much more than merely a laundry list of rights and wrongs…
    - They are the masterplan for how to live for Christ
- So let's start where Paul begins, at the center of the bull's eye: our relationship with God

Rom. 12:1 Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service of worship.
Rom. 12:2 And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect.

- This is the bull's eye of our chart, and though we have only two verses for this ring, they are the most challenging in the entire list
  - First, notice Paul's transition
    - He says therefore, as if he's moving from an earlier point
    - That earlier point is not the end of Chapter 11 so much, but rather the end of Chapter 8
  - As we did earlier, let's take a look how the end of Chapter 8 and the beginning of Chapter 12 fit together
    - If I put the final thought of 8 and the first thought of 12 together, they are seamless

Rom. 8:38 For I am convinced that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor things present, nor things to come, nor powers,

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Rom. 8:39 nor height, nor depth, nor any other created thing, will be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Rom. 12:1 Therefore I urge you, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service of worship.

- Nothing in this world or the next world can ever separate you from the love of God
- So therefore, you don't need to waste your energy on earning God's mercy…you already have it!
- So, work on these things instead
- Beginning with attending to your own personal righteousness or holiness
  - Remember, the righteousness that brings you into Heaven is not your own righteousness but Christ's righteousness obtained by faith alone
    - But that doesn't mean your personal righteousness doesn't matter
    - Our personal righteousness still matters to God as a means to glorifying Him and to achieving the mission of the church
  - Obviously, we cannot pursue personal holiness until we have first come to faith in Christ and received His righteousness
    - Hebrews 11 tells us that apart from faith, it's impossible to please God
    - Without the Spirit of Christ living and working in us, we have no engine to drive our spiritual change
    - And we lack a spiritual compass pointing us in the right direction
    - As I like to say, until you've walked the Romans road of Chapters 1-8, you can't walk the walk of Romans 12-15
- Paul makes the same observation at the start of the chapter
  - Paul urges us to take up a pursuit of personal righteousness by the mercies of God
    - The original Greek text is singular, so Paul actually wrote "by the mercy" of God
    - The mercy of God refers to God's compassion toward us in the way He saved us and gave us His Spirit
    - So Paul urges us to pursue holiness by depending on God's mercy rather than seeking to become holy in our own power
  - Regrettably, we prefer to seek holiness without relying on the mercy of God, typically by making our own plans for how to be holy
    - Seeking personal righteousness without depending on God's mercy only arrives at self-righteousness
    - We turn a blind eye to the real sin in our lives or make excuses for the things they don't want to confront

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        - While claiming victory over so-called sins that aren't the things the Spirit is asking us to address
        - Like the Christian who takes great satisfaction in never reading Harry Potter books yet carries on gossiping at every opportunity
- Unfortunately that's the only kind of "sanctification" some Christians are willing to pursue
    - It's living two different lives
        - One life is public, portraying themselves as a successful Christian, following Christ without regrets and living the dream
        - While the other life is lived in secret, filled with hypocrisy, sin, spiritual double-mindedness and the guilt that these things produce
    - But neither life is true…
        - In reality, in our secret life before God we are righteous by faith and loved unconditionally without guilt or shame
        - While in our public life, we are actually a hypocrite, in need of others' counsel, prayer, forgiveness and love
    - If you want to escape the false Christian life, seek righteousness in the right way, according to God's mercy
        - Paul gives us that way here
        - And unsurprisingly, it involves two steps that directly contradict the weaknesses of that hypocritical Christian life
- First, Paul tells us to present our sinful bodies to Christ as a living and holy sacrifice
    - Paul's drawing a comparison to the sacrificial system of the Jewish temple
        - Every morning and every night in the temple, priests would sacrifice an animal to God as directed in the law
        - Day in and day out, those sacrifices happened in the temple without fail
        - They weren't for specific sin but as an ongoing act of worship and service to God
        - The animal was killed and then its body was completely consumed by fire on the altar
    - Paul compares our service to God to that of the sacrificed animal brought before God in the temple
        - Paul uses the Greek aorist tense in v.1 for the verb "present"
        - The aorist tense describes an action that happens once with an effect that continues indefinitely
        - So Paul's saying that we must make a daily decision to serve God with our lives, submitting ourselves to God continuously thereafter
    - His verb choice reflects the struggle of sanctification
        - We know submitting to God in this way is the right thing to do
        - Yet we still struggle to do it daily and to follow through on our convictions and

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promises

- Nevertheless, like those priests in the temple, we must determine every morning to honor the temple of God by making the sacrifices He requires

- Paul says our sacrifice will be with our bodies, not with an animal, and it will be by a living sacrifice, not by a death
  - God doesn't want us repeating the animal sacrifices of the Law, for those sacrifices merely pictured greater things to come
    - The daily sacrifices pictured God's people making a daily sacrifice by their service to God
    - So it's our duty to practice the fulfillment of this picture, not to revisit its origins in the Law
  - So what does it look like to make a living sacrifice of our bodies to the Lord?
    - Well, in short it's everything Paul teaches in Romans 12-15 and in the Bible over all
    - But simply put, it means placing the goal of pleasing the Lord ahead of pleasing ourselves or anyone else
    - In keeping with the meaning of the word sacrifice, it means giving up something we value because possessing it stands in the way of our personal righteousness
  - And on every day of our life, there will be some specific sacrifice the Lord will ask us to make for the sake of holiness
    - Something we are holding on to – a possession, a relationship, a desire, a thought, an attitude – something that leads us away from holiness
    - And each day the Lord will ask us to bring that thing before Him and burn it up on the altar of our heart
    - To let it be consumed entirely, so that by its removal we may be pleasing to Him and over time become more like Him
  - Now if we aren't willing to make that sacrifice today, it will still be there waiting for us tomorrow
    - So that until we make that sacrifice, our forward movement in sanctification will be impeded to an extent
    - That's why we sometimes find ourselves struggling with seasons in our walk with Christ
    - These are times when we can't seem to rise above some obstacle standing in the way of personal righteousness
    - We know what we must do but we can't bring ourselves to do it
    - And so there we stay, stuck on our path of sanctification
- During these seasons, we may still be attending church or even serving within our community
  - But these things aren't really moving us ahead because they aren't addressing the sacrifices the Lord has asked of us

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        - Notice Paul says we must sacrifice what is acceptable to God
        - If God is asking to sacrifice our lust for pornography, we can't please Him by sacrificing chocolate instead
        - If God asks us to sacrifice time in Bible study, we can't substitute time spent mowing the neighbor's lawn or serving in a soup kitchen
        - If God asks us to sacrifice our pride by forgiving someone, we can't choose instead to sacrifice money by making a donation
    - We are called to present before God sacrifices that He finds acceptable
        - And we are called to do this in a living way, daily
        - Paul says this is our spiritual service of worship
        - And once again, he's referring back to the daily sacrifices in the temple, which were an act of worship by the priest in the temple service
    - We often talk about serving God through worship, and when we use that term we generally thinking of singing songs to God
        - That's certainly a form of worship, but Paul gives us the true form of worship
        - We worship God when we serve Him in obedience
        - By agreeing to sacrifice those unholy aspects of our life that stand between us and holiness
        - That's how we demonstrate a true heart of worship
    - And it's actually the most powerful form of worship possible
        - Any heart (even an unbelieving heart) can stand up and sing a song and call it worship
        - But only a heart of faith, submitted to the will of God and seeking to please God, will be willing to make sacrifices God requires
        - So do you want to worship God? Then obey Him
        - You want to serve God? You can serve Him no better than following the Spirit's leading
- But the payoff for making these sacrifices rarely comes in the moment
    - Usually, it's a painful struggle against the flesh
        - We feel the immediate loss of what the Lord's asking us to sacrifice
        - But we don't see the fruit of our obedience for a time
        - Maybe not until we receive our reward in the Kingdom
    - Therefore, obeying the Bible's call to sacrifice will always require a measure of faith
        - We need to operate in the faith that God out of His love for us knows more than we do about what's best for us
        - And that what He's asking us to sacrifice can't compare to what we stand to gain for obeying His call to pursue righteousness
        - We must operate in faith, following the Spirit's leading, denying our flesh its

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desires so that we may please Christ

- When we do this, we're operating in a way that is exactly opposite of the way the world operates
  - The world says look out for #1 (i.e., yourself)
  - The world says get what pleasure you can now, because you only live once
  - The world says there is no God and there is no Hell
  - This is the way the world thinks, but even a believer can begin to think that way too, which will lead us away from serving God

- Which is why Paul says in v.2 that we must not be conformed to the world
  - The call of Romans 12:1-2 stands in opposition to the call of the world
    - And there is no way to reconcile them
    - You cannot serve two masters, as Jesus taught
    - So we are either being confirmed to the world or we are being conformed to the likeness of Christ
    - You are either moving in the direction of holiness or you are moving away from holiness
    - In other words, there is no such thing as standing still in our walk of sanctification
  - So how do we make sure we're always moving forward and not backward?
    - Paul says it requires engaging in a transformation process beginning with a renewing of your mind
    - There's the secret to successful Christian living…and it's been hiding here in the open in Romans 12
    - We transform ourselves by adopting the mind of Christ
    - Our thinking becomes more holy so that our behavior may become more righteous
  - Paul's talking about spending time in the word of God and in prayer and in the counsel of godly people
    - Listening intently, considering it carefully, applying it diligently
    - It's a transformation process, one done by the Spirit of God in our hearts
    - He's the engine for that change
    - But the fuel for that engine is the word of God
- The transformation happens inside us, but its effects are witnessed by the world
  - Paul says we seek this transformation so we may "prove" what is the will of God
    - To prove means to demonstrate truth through actions, as in to testify by our lives
    - As we transform our thinking into Christ's and our behavior follows, we testify to the will of God

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        - God's will is made evident in us because our lives begin to reflect His will
    - It's like God's the director of a great theatre production, and we're the actor in our own life story
        - So God directs us to think in righteous ways, so that as we live that instruction out before the world we show the world the director's will
        - We are showing the world what God considers good and acceptable and perfect
        - In a word, our witness
    - It's how we make decisions, how we respond to tragedies in life, how we set priorities in our finances, how we conduct our relationships
        - It's how we raise our kids
        - It's how we treat our parents
        - It's how we love our enemies
        - These decisions prove what is pleasing to God before a world blinded by the enemy
- That's the first ring in Paul's teaching on sanctification
    - It's living in a way that pleases God, pursuing personal righteousness in our relationship with God
        - While knowing we already have been credited with Christ's righteousness
        - Therefore we work to please God for the sake of a righteous witness, not for the sake of salvation
    - The Old Testament has a simple way of describing this relationship between eternal righteousness and personal righteousness
        - In the Old Testament, a man like Noah would be declared righteous because his faith made him so in the eyes of God
        - And he was also declared blameless because he possessed personal righteousness in the eyes of men
        - Romans 12 tells us to seek to be blameless before God even as we are already righteous by faith

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- Let's move to the next "ring" in Paul's priority for our sanctification

  - Last week we began studying Paul's bull's eye of pursuing personal righteousness in our relationships
  - So from the standpoint of God's judgment, we are already 100% righteous by faith alone
  - When we believe in Jesus we receive His righteousness by faith, which is a perfect righteousness
  - Our righteousness before God is obtained solely by our faith in Christ
  - Remember we're talking about our righteousness lived out before people, not our standing before God
  - But the question remains, how closely do our lives reflect Christ's righteousness?
    - Are we righteous in our thoughts and actions and in the way we conduct our relationships?
    - Does our thinking and behavior comport with the perfect standard that Christ set for us?
  - Of course, the answer to that last question is no – since none of us will live a perfectly sinless life, given the sin nature of our flesh
    - But that doesn't mean a Christian should concede to the inevitability of our sin or turn a blind eye to it
    - While we may not be able to live sinlessly, by the grace of God and the power of the Spirit we can get close
    - As someone once observed, Christians aren't sinless but we should sin less
  - Over the centuries, many Christian men and women have made the pursuit of godliness their life's priority
    - Some have succeeded in conforming their lives so closely to Christ's example that the world saw them as blameless
    - Their lives became such testimonies to godliness that whatever sin remained in them was barely noticeable
  - If this sounds like an impossible goal to you, then perhaps you haven't given enough

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attention to the task Paul outlined in vs.1-2

- Paul said our life goal should be to make ourselves a living sacrifice for the needs of serving Christ and His glory
- We make this sacrifice daily by rejecting the world's priorities and seeking the mind of Christ
- We renew our thinking through God's word and allow that new thinking to generate new righteous behaviors
- Our new behaviors demonstrate to the world what God's will is concerning what is good and perfect

- This is the starting point for our pursuit of sanctification, and it makes the rest of the journey possible
  - We all begin by working on our personal righteousness in our relationship with God
    - If we don't pursue righteousness in our relationship with God, our fellowship with Him will suffer
    - We will feel distant from Him, not because He moved away from us but because we moved away from Him
    - Our prayer life will evaporate, our interest in God's word will wane, and our resistance to Satan's schemes will weaken
  - We will become weak spiritually, our sin nature will reassert itself, and as a result we'll have little spiritual strength to tackle the outer rings
    - As Jesus spoke

John 7:37 Now on the last day, the great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried out, saying, "If anyone is thirsty, let him come to Me and drink.
John 7:38 "He who believes in Me, as the Scripture said, 'From his innermost being will flow rivers of living water.'"

- The spiritual strength the Spirit brings to our spirit becomes the source for us to bless others in the name of Christ
- But if we are not pursuing personal righteousness under the Spirit's guidance, then how can we instruct or encourage others?
- That's the principle underlying this entire system represented by the bull's eye
  - The strength we gain in one ring becomes the means to bless the next ring
  - Which is why we can't "skip" a ring
  - We can't ignore our personal relationship with God and expect to prosper in our relationships within the church
  - And we can't neglect our relationships in the body of Christ and expect to be a powerful witness for Christ in the world
- So with that understanding, let's press on into the second ring, our relationships within the body of Christ beginning in v.3

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Rom. 12:3 For through the grace given to me I say to everyone among you not to think more highly of himself than he ought to think; but to think so as to have sound judgment, as God has allotted to each a measure of faith.
Rom. 12:4 For just as we have many members in one body and all the members do not have the same function,
Rom. 12:5 so we, who are many, are one body in Christ, and individually members one of another.
Rom. 12:6 Since we have gifts that differ according to the grace given to us, each of us is to exercise them accordingly: if prophecy, according to the proportion of his faith;
Rom. 12:7 if service, in his serving; or he who teaches, in his teaching;
Rom. 12:8 or he who exhorts, in his exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy, with cheerfulness.

- Paul begins his teaching on relationships in the body of Christ with a lesson on spiritual gifts
  - He says that by the grace given to him by the Lord, Paul now instructs the body of Christ on how to maintain a proper perspective of self
    - Paul says we should not think more highly of ourselves than we ought
    - Notice Paul didn't say we shouldn't think highly of ourselves at all
    - Nor did he say that everyone in the body of Christ is equal
  - Instead, Paul instructs each person in the church to appreciate his or her degree of importance in the body
    - So avoid false humility and self-importance
    - Some members of the body are called by God to play more important roles in the body than others
    - But these differences are entirely spiritual, not personal
    - So they cannot become the basis for valuing one member more than another
  - Notice Paul began his command saying "by the grace given to me"
    - In other words, Paul is following his own command even as he instructs the church in v.3
    - Paul is saying that by God's grace he was made an apostle, and as an apostle he had authority to give these instructions to the church
    - And therefore, this is the same standard by which we also may consider our own importance in the body
- God has assigned a degree of His grace to each believer so we might assume an appropriate position of authority and service in the body
  - To some, God has assigned greater grace to assume greater positions of authority or service, like an apostle

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        - To others, God has assigned lessor positions of authority or service
        - Nevertheless, no member of the body is more or less important to the body – nor is anyone expendable
        - Paul is calling for us to respect God's decision concerning our assignment within the body and serve Him in that place
        - And to be content with God's choice for our sake
    - Paul calls such thinking sound judgment, in contrast to thinking too highly of ourselves
        - We think too highly of ourselves when we presume to take a place in the body other than that which God has assigned to us
        - Pride generally drives us to seek for something greater than we ought to have or to be jealous of another's place in the body
        - But pursuing sanctifying relationships in the body of Christ depends on each of us serving contently in our assigned place
- So how do we know what our assigned part is within the body of Christ?
    - Paul says that our place and prominence in the body is determined by the "measure of faith" God has allotted to us
        - The term "measure of faith" is a bit deceiving in English
        - It suggests that the degree of our personal faith in God determines our place in the body
        - Which if this were true would mean we could aspire to higher roles as our faith grows
        - But that thinking contradicts Paul's central point, which was to not think too highly of ourselves
    - In reality, Paul wasn't referring about our personal faith in God; he's speaking in a euphemism
        - In Greek, the phrase "measure of faith" could be translated as the "poetic meter of faith"
        - So we could say God has allotted to each of us a measure of a larger artistic work
        - Like playing an instrument in a symphony or a stanza of an epic poem
        - God has allotted each of us a certain place in His production
        - And if we all play our parts properly, we produce beautiful music or poetry
    - Notice in v.4 Paul reminds us that each part in the production has a purpose and value all its own
        - We are members of a single body called the Church, the body of Christ
        - And we are called to operate as a whole, like an orchestra or like the individual members of a human body
        - You may feel like your big toe isn't very important to your body, but try walking

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without it (you can't)

- Likewise, if an orchestra is going to produce a sound pleasing to the director, each instrument must play its part properly
  - The woodwinds can't become jealous of the strings and try to play their part or vice versa
  - If they did, the orchestra would deteriorate into a cacophony of noise
- So each of us must play the part we've been assigned by God within the body
  - We cannot think too highly of ourselves by assuming roles we haven't been assigned
  - Nor should we think too lowly of ourselves by neglecting the role we have been given
  - We should serve humbly in the station God assigns to us

- In v.6 Paul explains what he means by a "measure of faith"
  - Specifically, Paul is talking about the spiritual gift we received from God when we came to faith
    - He says we have gifts that differ according to the grace God has given us and we must operate within the body accordingly
    - Simply put, the spiritual gift we received from God determines our role and place within the body of Christ
  - From here Paul moves into giving a brief list of spiritual gifts and how they should be used in the body
    - Before we look at the list, we need to spend a moment to consider the topic of spiritual gifts in general
    - This list is one of three such lists Paul gives the church across his letters
    - The other two lists come in 1 Corinthians and Ephesians
  - All three lists were written by Paul, and yet all three lists vary slightly from one another in the gifts included
    - Therefore we know Paul never intended each list to be definite on its own, because he mentioned other gifts in other letters
    - Some have combined these three lists to arrive at a single definitive inventory of spiritual gifts
    - But I don't believe that's how Paul wanted us to use his lists
- When you consider the surrounding context in each letter, it's clear that Paul listed a few gifts as examples in each case
  - Paul gave examples of spiritual gifts in each letter to support his overall argument in that letter
    - Since the context of each letter was slightly different, the corresponding list of gifts was also different
    - In Ephesians, Paul explained the ultimate purpose for spiritual gifts in the body

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of Christ which is to encourage unity

- In 1 Corinthians, Paul explained the proper regulation of spiritual gifts operating in the corporate gathering so they are edifying
- And here in Romans, Paul is explaining relative importance of different spiritual gifts when serving others in the body

- So Paul gave us three different lists of spiritual gifts as examples in support of three different points
  - No single list is a definitive inventory of all possible spiritual gifts
  - And therefore combining all three lists won't arrive at such an inventory either
  - For all we know the actual list of spiritual gifts God appoints within the church may be infinite

- So as we look at his list here in Romans 12, let's understand it in its context
  - Paul's explaining how we should serve in the body based on how we've been gifted (so that we don't think too highly of ourselves)
    - Paul begins his example list with the gift of prophecy
    - Notice Paul assigns a descriptor to each gift to emphasize how we must embrace our assigned role wholeheartedly
    - For the one with the gift of prophecy, he should use it according to the proportion of his faith
  - The gift of prophecy is the gift of speaking the revelation of God; something unknowable apart from that revelation
    - All scripture is the result of a gift of prophecy
    - In Paul's day the gift of prophecy was still at work authoring the New Testament through the apostles
    - After the final apostles died, the canon closed and no scripture was authored thereafter
  - So many believe this spiritual gift has met its intended purpose and therefore it has ceased to be available in the body of Christ
    - Others believe that a lessor form of prophecy, of foretelling future events or revealing special revelation from God (apart from scripture), continues to operate within the body
    - My personal view is that all prophecy ended with the closing of the canon, and therefore this particular spiritual gift has ceased to operate in the body
    - But regardless of your view of prophecy today, we know in Paul's day the gift was still operating in the Church
    - Which is why he writes thus
- And to those who have this gift, Paul says they should use it in proportion to his faith: which means according to how God leads the prophet
  - Some prophets received greater revelation (or "faith" as Paul calls it) from God, while other prophets received less

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        - So a prophet in the church was to stick to prophesying and to do it as the Lord directs
        - The prophet didn't need to always have a "word from the Lord" in order to bless the congregation
        - They just needed to prophesy according to the Lord's leading
    - Likewise, we all serve the Lord best by serving His people with the gift He's given us
        - So if God gifts you with a gift of service, you serve Christ best by serving
        - If you have the gift of teaching, you serve God best in teaching others
        - If an exhortation gift, then exhort others
        - If a giving gift, then give generously
        - Etc.
- So our place and role in the body is determined by our spiritual gift, not by our preference or by a specific opportunity or need in the body
    - There are a lot of things we *could* do to serve Christ, but there is only one service we *should* focus on
        - And that area of focus will always be tied to our spiritual gift
        - It is the best way we can serve God
    - In my case, I've been gifted by God to teach His word, so I teach His word to exclusion of virtually anything else I could do to serve the body
        - I'm not excluded from working in other capacities on occasion, but I should not seek for permanent stations outside my assigned role
        - For example, if I pursued a service or mercy role instead, I would be thinking more highly of myself than I ought
        - I'm assuming I can please God by serving in ways I prefer rather than submitting to His calling and gifting
- Remember, when you serve in your spiritual gift, you serve with the greatest strength and joy and will obtain the most spiritual fruit
    - This only makes sense, of course
        - A spiritual gift is a God-given supernatural ability
        - It's an ability to do spiritual things we couldn't do on our own, so that as we bear fruit, God will receive the glory
    - So if we spend our time working outside our area of gifting, we won't accomplish the work God intended and our results will be far less fruitful
        - If you've ever sat in a Bible study led by someone who wasn't gifted to teach the Bible, you know how painful the experience can be
        - That kind of situation is an example of someone thinking too highly of himself
    - Even a pastor can get this wrong
        - A pastor who assumes a teaching role over the congregation when the Lord

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hadn't given him that spiritual gift won't edify the body
        - A pastor must be able to teach, but that doesn't mean his spiritual gifting is teaching
        - And if not, he should not think too highly of himself by assigning himself a teaching role over the body
        - He isn't using sound judgment to assess his place in the body
- Paul's teaching on serving in our gift leaves us with three important principles that guide our relationships in the body of Christ
    - The first principle – and probably the most important – is we are not permitted to live as "islands" isolated from other Christians
        - Paul's instructions anticipate that we are joining ourselves to a body of believers
        - Spiritually speaking, we do not exist apart from the rest of the Body of Christ
        - So neither should we try to live that way in practice
        - Hebrews warns us against "forsaking the gathering together" for this reason, because we weaken our own walk and the walk of others
    - Secondly, our participation in the body must take the form of service in some capacity
        - Each of us has an assigned role within the body, as Paul said, based on a gifting God gave us
        - The very presence of a spiritual gift presumes we will direct our energies toward serving the body of Christ
        - So we have a responsibility to live up to that responsibility, both to Christ and to our fellows brothers and sisters
    - After all, don't we have assigned roles in our homes or work place or on sports teams?
        - And don't you feel an obligation to fulfill our role?
        - Doesn't it bother you when a teammate or family member or coworker fails to live up to their responsibilities?
        - Then shouldn't we strive even harder to play our assigned part in the body of Christ?
- Finally, we must adopt and maintain an attitude of humility in all our relationships in the body of Christ
    - Firstly because we know that our place in the body was assigned to us by God and therefore it isn't a reflection of personal merit
        - Therefore, we have no reason to assign ourselves greater value compared to anyone else
        - How can we assume we are inherently more important than another believer when we were all assigned our place by God?
    - And secondly, because when we achieve good results, we understand it was due

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entirely to the Lord working through us by our spiritual gifting

- Therefore, we have no basis for crediting ourselves for any spiritual achievements
- All glory belongs to the Lord

- So all relationships in the body of Christ must be built on a foundation of a commitment to the body and to serving in humility in our assigned place
  - From these three principles, we move into a series of exhortations that guide the nature of our relationships in the body
    - The passage is only five verses but it contains 13 commands for how we live with one another in the body
    - And the list is quite convicting

Rom. 12:9 Let love be without hypocrisy. Abhor what is evil; cling to what is good.
Rom. 12:10 Be devoted to one another in brotherly love; give preference to one another in honor;
Rom. 12:11 not lagging behind in diligence, fervent in spirit, serving the Lord;
Rom. 12:12 rejoicing in hope, persevering in tribulation, devoted to prayer,
Rom. 12:13 contributing to the needs of the saints, practicing hospitality.

- The list of exhortations begins with love, of course
  - As you probably could guess, the Greek word for love is *agape*, which means self-sacrificial love
    - We say that biblical love is a verb, not a noun
    - Which means Christian love is an action, not a feeling, and the action is making sacrifices for the sake of others
    - Just as Jesus lay down His life for us, which was the ultimate display of love
  - Paul is asking the church to maintain a self-sacrificial attitude
    - Thinking of others before ourself
    - Letting someone else have the better seat in church
    - Letting someone else have the last donut
    - Taking out the trash without waiting to be asked, etc.
  - But Paul adds an important caveat to this command: we must love without hypocrisy
    - Hypocrisy is portraying ourselves in a way that is not in keeping with reality
    - It means seeking to gain credit for selflessness without actually making the required sacrifice
    - Like volunteering for service projects, but never showing up
    - Promising to support missionaries financially, but never writing a check

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        - Assuring sick members of the congregation we will pray for them, but never following through
- That's hypocritical love, which is no love at all
    - It's self-serving and it's corrosive to the unity of the body
        - Paul's bull's-eye chart teaches that we can't prosper in an outer ring if we haven't done the hard work required by the inner rings
        - So we won't show the world the love of Christ (which is a self-sacrificial love) if we haven't disciplined ourselves to show selflessness to our own brothers and sisters in the body of Christ
    - I've never met a successful evangelist who wasn't also a selfless servant to the body of Christ
        - Conversely, the worst ambassadors for Christ are usually those Christians who have a self-serving hypocritical attitude in the body of Christ
        - If we can't adopt a loving sacrificial attitude among our spiritual family, how will we show that kind of love to strangers?
- Next Paul says we must abhor what is evil while clinging to what is good
    - The Greek verb translated "abhor" appears only here in the New Testament
        - It's a particularly strong word for "hate"
        - And the Greek word for "cling" literally means "to be glued"
        - So we are to hate evil the way God does, and we are to be affixed to what is good
    - Knowing Paul is teaching how we should live in the body of Christ, these instructions should be relatively easy commands to follow
        - After all, the Church community should share in these goals and encourage us in these convictions (if not, seek a new church)
        - On the other hand, we know the world will mock these convictions and tempt us to go against them
        - The world calls evil good and good evil, so these instructions become much harder to follow outside the safety of the body
    - Therefore if we cannot resist evil things while surrounded by likeminded believers, how can we resist when we are in the world?
        - And if we choose a church community that doesn't obey these commands, we won't have the support we need to resist temptation ourselves
        - We must practice resisting evil in a safe place so that we will have the strength to carry it out under more trying circumstances
- Paul's next couplet says be devoted to one another like brothers and sisters, but to give preference to one another in honor
    - The first half of Paul's command, being devoted to one another, is easy to understand
        - He says be devoted in love, and this time Paul uses a different Greek word for

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love: *philadelphia* or brotherly love

- Paul wants us to recognize that our true brothers and sisters are the believers in the church

- So as the saying goes, blood is thicker than water
  - You should favor family relationships over other friendships
  - But in this case, we're not talking about a physical bond of blood but a spiritual bond of faith in Jesus Christ
  - That spiritual bond is far greater than any physical bond
- Because in a day to come, your body will die and any blood bond between you and your physical relatives will be dissolved
  - The definition of earthly brothers and sisters is someone whose body originated from your mother's body
  - So literally speaking, the moment your body dies you no longer have earthly brothers and sisters
  - Once your physical body is gone, all you will have left is the spirit
- In that moment, the only relationship you will still have will be your spiritual relationship with Christ
  - And in eternity, you will be surrounded by others who share that same spiritual relationship with Christ
  - Therefore, Paul asks us to see with eyes for eternity now
- We must recognize that our spiritual brothers and sisters in the Church are truly the only real brothers and sisters we have
  - We can still honor and enjoy our family relationships too
  - But those earthly relationships must come second to our spiritual relationships in the church

- Practically speaking, this means that when my relationships in the church come into conflict with those outside the church, I must give preference to the church
  - Notice this agrees with the bull's-eye chart
    - The inner ring of church relationships takes priority over relationships with unbelieving family members
    - So if our parents are unbelieving, we honor them as scripture expects unless honoring them comes into conflict with the needs of the body
    - Obviously we should seek for ways to accommodate the needs of both, when possible
    - So only when conflict is unavoidable must we choose one over the other, and in those situations the inner ring always wins
  - But Paul gives us an important caveat to this command saying we give preference in honor
    - We should seek to give preference to our brothers and sisters so long as doing

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so won't bring dishonor upon the name of Christ

- We can't allow our preference for fellow believers to become cause to do something that dishonors Christ

- So if we are a judge, we can't permit a miscarriage of justice in our court by showing favor to a Christian defendant
  - Or if we are bookkeeper, we can't cover up for a fellow Christian's embezzlement
  - Or if we are a hiring manager, we can't give preference to a Christian job candidate if the law prohibits such favoritism

- Next, Paul asks us not to lag behind in diligence, remaining fervent in spirit and serving the Lord
  - All three of these commands relate to our effort and commitment as we serve within the body
    - We could sum up these three commands with three words
    - Effort, desire and purpose
    - We must serve one another with a consistent effort and earnest desire for the ultimate purpose of serving Christ
  - It hurts the entire body when someone lags behind in diligence in serving the needs of the body
    - It's like having a player on the team who isn't pulling his weight
    - Diligence means making effort consistently, which means making commitments you can keep
    - Don't promise too much or too little but always keep your promises
    - Do your part to serve and support the body
  - And do it in the right spirit, fervently desiring to further the mission of the church
    - Don't allow yourself to become easily discouraged because you don't see the results you anticipated
    - Or because you didn't get the personal recognition you expected
    - You are serving for the right reasons in the right spirit
- Finally, your service is directed toward the Lord, not people or projects
  - If you are serving in church because you admire your pastor, you aren't serving for the right reasons
    - If you're serving because the church pays you, you are aren't serving for the right reasons
    - If you're serving because you enjoy receiving accolades or the accomplishment of a job well done, you aren't serving for the right reasons
  - Because ultimately all those reasons will fail you sooner or later
    - Pastors will fail you

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        - Churches cut their staff
        - Accolades have a way of turning into complaints
        - And then what will be your reason to serve the church?
    - On the other hand, if your reason for serving is pleasing Christ, then your commitment to serve will never waver
        - Your effort will remain consistent and your attitude will remain fervent
        - You'll be unfazed by setbacks and disappointments
        - That's the kind of consistency we seek to demonstrate while serving the body
- In v.12 Paul adds rejoicing in hope, persevering in tribulation and devoted to prayer
    - I love the way Paul connects rejoicing, tribulation and prayer
        - So often our prayer life disappears in times of rejoicing only to re-emerge when trials return
        - But Paul denies this pattern calling upon believers to maintain a commitment to prayer regardless of our circumstances
        - Paul says we are to be devoted to prayer regardless of whether our days are presently filled with joy or difficulty
    - But before we get into prayer, let's look at the first two commands for a moment beginning with rejoicing in hope
        - Paul says we should rejoice in the hope of our faith in Christ
        - When the Bible speaks of our "hope," it's always referring to our expectation that we will be resurrected
    - Resurrection from the dead is the hope of Christianity
        - Resurrection is the promise that death will not be the end of us
        - That because of our faith in Christ's sacrifice and resurrection, we likewise will receive eternal life after our body dies
        - Resurrection is at the center of our faith, it's what our water baptism pictures
        - There can be no greater hope than resurrection because there is no greater jeopardy than death
    - Paul says we must rejoice over this hope, which means to remain mindful of what our faith is all about
        - We can't place our hope in things of the earth or in emotional platitudes
        - We don't rejoice because Christians are always to be happy or healthy or successful or wealthy
        - Christians are often unhappy, unhealthy, unsuccessful and poor
        - But so long as we remember that we have overcome this world and one day we will receive our reward in a resurrected body, we have reason to rejoice
- Secondly, we are to persevere in tribulation
    - Notice again that Paul didn't demand that the church pretend to be happy in

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tribulation

- Paul was a realist and knew that trials and tribulations bring tears and anguish
- Paul himself suffered these things at times, according to his own testimony

- Instead, Paul commands us to persevere in the midst of such things
  - We cannot use life's troubles as excuse to give up on serving Christ or in gathering with other believers
  - Did a previous church or pastor let you down? Move on and invest again in a new congregation without hesitation
  - Have you faced loss or rejection because you lived your faith? Press on without fear of such things
  - Did church politics or unsupportive leaders or unkind brothers or sisters treat you unfairly? Continue serving Christ
- The Lord uses difficult times to prompt spiritual growth in His people, and some growth can only happen under difficult circumstances
  - So when tough times come, we must persevere in our walk with Christ and in our relationships in the church
  - Commit to staying the course so you can learn what persevering in adversity teaches
  - Because if we give up when trials come, then we lose the benefits these things were intended to produce

- Finally, regardless of your circumstances, keep praying
  - Be devoted to prayer, Paul says, which means think of your time in prayer the way you think of marriage
    - When someone is devoted to a marriage, they never forget they have a spouse
    - They never get tired of being faithful
    - They don't treat the relationship as expendable or optional
  - Similarly, when someone is devoted to prayer, they never forget to pray
    - They don't grow tired of praying
    - And they don't see time in prayer as optional
    - Like marriage, it's part of who they are, not merely something they do
  - If you lack an appreciation of how important prayer is in your walk with Christ, it's a sign you aren't praying enough
    - While we all understand the mechanics of praying, you can't fully appreciate how God uses it in your life until you really devote yourself to it
  - You could compare understanding prayer to understanding how to ride a bike
    - I could explain to someone how to ride a bike, and they would understand the mechanics easily enough
    - But they would have no idea what it's actually like – much less how to do it

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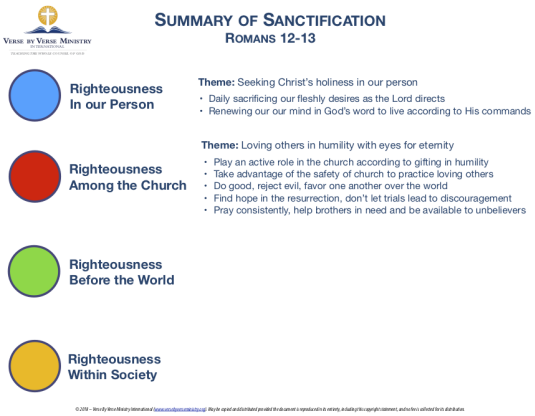
properly – until they wrestle with a bike for a while
        - Only then at some point would they get it too
        - Devote time to praying regularly and earnestly for a while and see what you discover about yourself and about God
- Finally, in v.12 Paul connects two acts of mercy asking us to contribute to the needs of the saints and practice hospitality
    - The first command concerns the needs inside the church
        - We are to give money to the needs of the body
        - This is the New Testament obligation for every believer
    - It's not tithing, technically speaking
        - Tithing is an Old Testament term that comes from the Law and applies only to the Jewish nation
        - A tithe was a specific amount required for specific needs, and there were three distinct tithing requirements in the Law
        - Altogether, Jews gave between 20-30% of their income as tithes
        - Tithes were paid to the temple and they were not optional or flexible
    - None of these rules apply to the Church since we are not under the Law given to Israel
        - The guideline for us is to give to the needs of the saints
        - It's general and without specific requirement
        - In 1 Corinthians 16 Paul gives a few more guidelines for how a believer should give
    - But for today, there are two main points to note about our giving
        - First, our giving in the church is for the believer
        - We are called to support fellow believers with our giving
    - And more specifically to fund the work of believers who serve God in evangelism, teaching, pastoring, etc.
        - We also fund the physical needs of believers who are worthy of that support (not all needs should be met by fellow believers though)
        - We may wish to support non-christian charities too, but that support does not meet the requirement to support the needs of believers
- Secondly, the giving details are left completely to the giver to decide based on the leading of the Spirit
    - We may give any amount we desire and to whomever we like
        - There is no biblical requirement to give specifically to an institutional church
        - There is no requirement to give a certain amount or on a certain schedule
    - The test for every believer is whether we are responding to the leading of the Spirit

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        - Are we giving what He asks and when He asks?
        - No one may be our judge concerning our giving
- Paul's final command addresses the needs of unbelievers
    - A believer should maintain a heart of hospitality toward the world
        - Hospitality in Paul's day looked very different than it does today
        - In Paul's day, culture demanded that strangers be given accommodation in homes when no alternative was available
    - So when a traveler stopped in your town overnight and was sitting in the town square, someone would invite that person to stay the night
        - To be caught outside at night could be very dangerous
        - So everyone took it upon themselves to be hospitable to strangers
        - To do otherwise would bring great shame upon the town and any who refused to give the stranger a place to stay
    - So the emphasis in this command is on being willing to help strangers, which in this context refers principally to unbelievers
        - We should open our homes or make other accommodations to unbelievers whenever practical
        - This creates opportunity for the church to fulfill its mission
        - So we give our money to believers and our hospitality to unbelievers
    - This principle explains why your church leaders advise against giving money to unbelievers who come begging for church benevolence
        - The money the church stewards is for the needs of the saints
        - But the church doors or the doors of church members remain open to providing shelter or food or other types of hospitality to the unbeliever
        - These are meaningful ways of providing care and charity, but they also hold the possibility to establishing opportunity to share the gospel
        - Putting a $20 bill in their pocket won't win them for Christ and probably accomplishes little more than getting them high for another day
- I think Paul put this command at the end as a transition into the next ring on our relationships with unbelievers
    - Which is where we go next week…

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- For the past two weeks we've been marching steadily outward from ring to ring on Paul's bull's-eye of sanctification
  - We've covered the first two rings, our righteousness in our personal relationship with God and in our church relationships
    - There was a lot of material in these sections
    - So to simplify our understanding (and to help us remember it), here's a simple chart:



- This summary shows the relationships between the rings
  - The first ring emphasizes thinking and acting like Christ
  - Which requires we discipline the sin nature of our flesh
- This battle between our spirit and flesh – the one Paul described in Chapters 6-7 – will determine our success in every other ring
  - We have to start by learning how to say no to ourself so we can hear from the Lord and obey Him instead
  - And we have to be practiced at maintaining a good relationship with God before we can succeed in our relationships in the body
  - And so on…
- Today we move to the third ring, our relationship with unbelievers
  - Paul starts this teaching in Chapter 12 v.14

Rom. 12:14 Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse.
Rom. 12:15 Rejoice with those who rejoice, and weep with those who weep.
Rom. 12:16 Be of the same mind toward one another; do not be haughty in mind, but associate with the lowly. Do not be wise in your own estimation.
Rom. 12:17 Never pay back evil for evil to anyone. Respect what is right in the sight of all men.
Rom. 12:18 If possible, so far as it depends on you, be at peace with all men.
Rom. 12:19 Never take your own revenge, beloved, but leave room for the wrath of God, for it is written, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay," says the Lord.

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Rom. 12:20 "But if your enemy is hungry, feed him, and if he is thirsty, give him a drink; for in so doing you will heap burning coals on his head."
Rom. 12:21 Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.

- Successful relationships with unbelievers begins by understanding they are not our enemies…they are our mission
  - Every command in this list is directed at enhancing our mission of winning them for Christ
    - If we follow these commands, our relationships with unbelievers will be more likely to win souls for Christ
    - We're seeking to conduct ourselves in ways that keep avenues open for reaching people with the truth of Jesus
    - It's a strategic mindset that understands that our relationships with unbelievers have eternal consequences
    - Our goal isn't harmony or friendship with the world…our goal is making opportunity for a Gospel moment
  - And Paul begins these instructions by reminding us that unbelievers naturally oppose us and our mission
    - The natural state of an unbeliever's heart is to oppose God and His word and therefore to oppose God's people
    - As Jesus told His disciples:

John 15:20 "Remember the word that I said to you, 'A slave is not greater than his master.' If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you; if they kept My word, they will keep yours also.

- The enemy has deceived the world and has set their hearts against the truth
- This is an incredibly ironic state of affairs
  - Because our desire is to bring them rescue, to offer eternal life through the message of the Gospel
    - And we do this at personal risk and self-sacrifice
    - Yet they oppose us as if we were their enemies seeking to harm them
    - It's like we have an antidote to cure their cancer, but their sickness leaves them unable to swallow the medicine
    - The enemy has lied to them so effectively that they are hardened against the truth that would set them free
- Nevertheless, the Lord has the power to reach these hearts as He did ours, and He asks us to make ourselves available to be His messenger
  - And Paul tells us we must think strategically about positioning ourselves for this

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possibility

- We need to anticipate their opposition and use it as opportunity to do something they don't expect
- When they persecute us, we bless them, loving them despite their hatred
- Bless them in this way and watch the effect it has on their receptiveness to the Gospel

- Because obviously this *isn't* the world's way of dealing with opposition
  - The world repays evil for evil, misquoting the Bible's teaching on "an eye for an eye"
  - They expect us to do the same to them
  - So when we show kindness to those who persecute us for our faith, then we challenge their assumptions
  - And perhaps we open an avenue for God to reach their heart
- We're fulfilling the very purpose Christ had in calling us into faith and leaving us here for a time to serve Him in the world
  - As Jesus told us

Matt. 5:43 **"You have heard that it was said, 'You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.'**
Matt. 5:44 **"But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,**
Matt. 5:45 **so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.**
Matt. 5:46 **"For if you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Do not even the tax collectors do the same?**
Matt. 5:47 **"If you greet only your brothers, what more are you doing than others? Do not even the Gentiles do the same?**
Matt. 5:48 **"Therefore you are to be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.**

- Being Jesus' hands and feet, His ambassador, begins with having this charitable attitude toward the unbeliever
  - We must remember we're not inherently better people than the world is
    - We didn't find Christ because we were smarter, nicer or more deserving
    - God gave us grace while we were still His enemy just like everyone else
  - Of course if we forget this and return curses for curses, then as Jesus said what reward is there in that?
    - We've forfeited the opportunity to be rewarded in Heaven for serving Christ self-sacrificially

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        - And we've given the world no reason to take note of our message, since our behavior contradicts our words
        - In that sense we're standing opposed to the truth of the Gospel, rather than being a witness for it
    - Practically-speaking, blessing those who persecute you means doing the kind of things you never imagined you would do
        - For example, if an unbeliever comes to your front door complaining about your front yard Christmas display he finds offensive
        - You don't respond the way he would expect or perhaps even in the way you might like to respond
    - Instead of engaging in an argument or defending your "rights", you agree to remove it…
        - But first you invite him in for some eggnog
        - And maybe later you bring them a gift and card…and eventually you invite them to church
        - In other words, you show no regard for that Christmas nativity scene – which probably had zero potential to bring souls into the Kingdom
    - Instead, you put aside the conflict altogether so you can attend to the eternal needs of the soul standing at your front door
        - You do so hoping that the Lord orchestrated this encounter to allow you opportunity to witness to His love
        - More than a few believers have come into the Kingdom because of a thoughtful approach to an encounter like this
- Besides showing kindness to unbelievers who would intrude into our lives, Paul says we must also take an interest in their lives
    - We must be ready to rejoice with those who rejoice and weep with those who weep
        - Before we look at these commands, remember the context of this passage
        - Paul is speaking about unbelievers here
        - Which is not to say we don't rejoice or weep with our brothers and sisters in the body
        - Of course we do, and Paul reminds us of this requirement as well at the beginning of v.16
    - But our true challenge is rejoicing and weeping with unbelievers over the circumstances they face in life
        - Unbelievers rejoice at weddings and for new births and when they get promotions or a new car or a boyfriend, etc.
        - If we're thinking strategically about our relationships with unbelievers, we'll join them in these moments
        - We'll identify with their circumstances and become part of their moments
- But sometimes the unbeliever's lifestyle choices will run contrary to our thinking, and

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these differences may cause us to restrain our empathy

- So that as a result of their choices, we may respond to their ups and downs in a tempered, insincere manner
  - For example, your next-door neighbors invites you to celebrate the birth of their child, but the parents aren't married
    - Do you feel conflicted over congratulating them on having a child born out of wedlock?
  - Or your workmate weeps over the death of a homosexual family member who died of AIDS
    - Do you struggle to show sympathy knowing the person's immoral lifestyle contributed their death?
- These reactions are misplaced moralism and self-righteousness
  - We withhold our rejoicing or sympathy because we're passing judgment on their lives
  - And even if your judgments are accurate based on scripture, don't forget these people don't know scripture
  - Because they don't know Christ
- Our purpose in being a sincere part of these moments is so we may introduce them to Christ
  - But if we're too busy judging them for not knowing Christ, then how will we ever get close enough to introduce them to Christ?
  - And what do we expect anyway? That they should receive our testimony of Christ only after they've adopted a Christian lifestyle?
  - Is that how we received Christ?

- Paul says set aside your prejudices against unbelievers and live among them, showing a true appreciation for their life's circumstances
  - This is exactly what Jesus did
    - He attended the house parties of tax collectors and associated with prostitutes, yet He did so without joining in their sin
    - He lived this way so that He might reach the lost with the love of God and bring them into righteousness
    - As Jesus said, He did not come to call the righteous but the sinner
    - So we must be careful about becoming haughty, holier-than-thou and unwilling to associate with those whose lives we don't approve
  - Notice in v.16 as I mentioned earlier, Paul also asks that we be of the same mind toward one another in the body
    - I think Paul placed this comment in the midst of his teaching on relationships with unbelievers because there is a natural connection between how we live in the two worlds
    - A Christian who judges the sin of unbelievers and practices haughtiness toward

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them is likely to display that same attitude toward believers eventually
        - It's a small step from judging the unbeliever to judging the believer
    - Paul gives us the antidote to thinking this way in the second half of v.16
        - First, he says we need to associate with the lowly
        - Spend time with the very people you're looking down your nose at so you can get to know them
        - And the more you know them, the more you'll find that the so-called lowly are a lot like you
        - Nothing does away with haughtiness faster than learning you have things in common with the person you previously despised
        - In time we'll develop a compassionate concern for people
- Secondly, Paul says do not be wise in your own estimation
    - This is the corollary of associating with the lowly
        - When we judge another person, we inevitably place ourselves above them in our own minds
        - You can't judge someone without assuming a position of superiority over them
        - You find some way to see yourself as better, nicer, wiser than they are
        - And from that position of superiority you pass judgment on their inferiority
    - To guard against this haughtiness, Paul says practice humility
        - Don't place yourself in a position of superiority over others
        - Being wise in our own estimation is not being wise at all
        - It's only assuming we're wiser when in reality we're the fool
    - The best way to avoid thinking too well of yourself is to keep a healthy memory of your own weaknesses
        - No one knows our own failings as well as we do
        - Bring them back to mind when you're tempted to look down on the unbelieving world or your brothers and sisters
        - And then remember that Christ forgave you of all those failings
        - And He's ready to forgive them too
- Next Paul says in v.17, we can't pay back evil for evil
    - This instruction runs hand-in-hand with his earlier command to bless and not curse those who persecute you
        - The difference here is that we don't take revenge for acts already done against us
        - In the earlier instructions, Paul was asking us to take no offense when others attack us for our faith
        - Here Paul's asking us not to be offensive to others by forgetting our faith

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        - In the first case, it was our love for the unbeliever that caused the conflict
        - In this case, it's our lack of love for the unbeliever that causes the conflict
    - Remember my example of the neighbor who wanted your nativity display taken down…
        - What if instead of asking you to take it down, that neighbor destroyed your decorations with a bat
        - At that point, you might feel tempted to repay his evil act by taking a bat to something on *his* property
        - Or by taking pictures of what he did and posting them to Facebook with a nasty comment
    - Paul says we can't act this way before unbelievers and still expect to win many for Christ
        - We need to think strategically about the moment
        - We should act charitably
        - But that doesn't mean we have to embrace the role of victim in every circumstance
- Notice at the end of v.17 Paul says we should do what's right in the sight of all men
    - We should act in appropriate ways, according to the customs and expectations of the culture we live in
        - So doing what's right in the eyes of all men means living with proper consideration for others, being a good friend, a good neighbor
        - But it can also mean taking appropriate action to defend yourself
    - In the case of the rampaging neighbor with the bat, you could choose to call the police and prosecute his behavior
        - Perhaps the situation has escalated to the point where police action is what's right in the eyes of all men
        - You're not required to press charges, but neither would you be wrong for doing so
    - The key is maintaining an understanding that you're always an ambassador for Christ
        - Make sure you're being a good neighbor without giving cause for offense
        - Sometimes that means overlooking the evil of others and not taking offense
        - Other times it means earning the appreciation of other neighbors by having the courage to prosecute the neighborhood menace
    - Every such example will be a judgment call
        - So I can't give you a hard-and-fast rule for how to respond
        - Just consider every situation in light of eternity and the opportunity to win someone for Christ
- Finally, doing what's right in the sight of all men cannot become excuse for participating

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in the world's sin

- The world will say many things are "right" yet we know they are not right at all
  - So we cannot use Paul's instructions here as excuse for following after the world's desires, in the spirit of maintaining relationships with them
  - Paul's bull's-eye gives us the rule for knowing when following the world is off limits
  - The inner rings of the Bull's eye take priority over the outer rings
- When doing what is right in the sight of all men comes into conflict with our pursuit of personal holiness before God, holiness wins
  - Or if our unbelieving friends ask us to do something that might stumble a Christian brother, we must decline
  - Paul gets more into this issue in later chapters

- Paul sums up the balancing of these priorities between the world and our witness in v.18
  - So far as it depends on you, be at peace with all men
    - Being at peace with all men is our goal because it furthers our mission in bringing the Gospel to the world
    - Obviously, we can't witness to the world for Christ if we are embroiled in conflicts with the world
  - But at the same time, we can't be effective witnesses if we don't stand for something different than the world stands for
    - And preserving our witness for Christ will sometimes lead to unavoidable conflicts that are outside our control
    - You may face times you're expected to do or say something that violates your conscience
    - Or friendship with unbelievers may cause you to violate the word of God
  - In those situations, we don't have a choice on how to proceed
    - We are bound by scripture and by our conscience to do what's right before God
    - And as we hold to our witness, we may spark a conflict with the unbelieving world
    - Friendships may suffer, family relationships may become strained or distant, working relationships may be put at risk
- Often these conflicts arise because the unbelievers who see us holding to our beliefs feel judged or even convicted by our stance
  - We didn't necessarily point out the difference much less said anything about their choices
    - Nevertheless, they take note and may react in anger or resentment
    - I remember times in my professional life when I ran into these circumstances (e.g., Halloween parties, use of foul language, etc.)
  - These are the situations Paul is talking about when he says "so far as it depends on

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us”

- We don’t invited the conflict but we couldn’t avoid it and we couldn’t militate against it
- The other party choose to create it, and when it happens, then revert to rule #1
  - Bless those who persecute you

- An example of our day might be the dilemma of a Christian receiving an invitation to attend a family member’s homosexual “wedding”
  - Normally, we should want to rejoice with them in their rejoicing
  - And we know we should associate with the lowly
  - And we want to respect what is right in the sight of all men
  - And as far as it depends on us, we don’t want to incite conflict over the situation
- Nevertheless, we must consider our witness and conscience, and in doing so we will likely conclude that we shouldn’t attend the wedding event
  - On the other hand, we might choose to attend the reception
  - Or instead of attending the wedding events, we might invite the new couple over to our house for a meal
  - What we do will depend on our conscience, but we’re seeking ways to maintain a working relationship so we can win them for Christ
  - This is a strategic attitude that places the needs of the unbeliever’s potential salvation above any personal concern
  - Without compromising our holiness or witness

- Paul’s next-to-last command is to never take our own revenge, so we can leave room for the wrath of God
  - This is a complex consideration, but it’s a powerful way to understand our service to Christ in the cause of salvation
    - First, let’s understand the situation Paul’s addressing
    - He’s talking about a believer suffering loss at the hands of unbelievers who are not responding to our witnessing
    - Things have reached the point where we might feel tempted to act in revenge against them
  - I’m sure many of us have been in this situation
    - Someone harmed us too severely or so often that we became preoccupied with thoughts of retribution
    - Often this happens in a school or work setting, or with family
  - Paul says when you face these situations, don’t succumb to the desire to take revenge
    - Because if we do, we’re not leaving room for God’s vengeance
    - We don’t know God’s plan for this person’s life

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        - Perhaps God plans to save this person in a future day
        - And when that day comes they will receive forgiveness for all their wrongs against you
    - If God is willing to forgive them, how can we take revenge against them as if we presumed to know the Lord's will?
        - How will we feel in eternity if we act against them while they are unbelieving and then see they received the same mercy we did?
        - We need to leave room for God to act one way or another
    - And should God decide to leave them in their sin, God will take into account their sin against believers
        - When they receive their ultimate judgment, it will reflect just punishment for their offenses
        - Paul says when we do kind things for those who hurt us, it's like heaping coals on their head
            - That's a picture of placing judgment on someone's head
        - Once again, we must leave room for God to act
- Now at this point some hear Paul's words and think he sounds very uncharitable, as if he's encouraging us to wish for unbelievers to be judged by God
    - That's not how we should hear Paul's words
        - He's not necessarily asking us to have a desire to see unbelievers suffering at God's hand
        - Rather, Paul's acknowledging our natural desire for revenge so he can ensure we consider the effect of our actions
        - For that Christian who can't find it in their heart to forgive a person and may be seriously considering taking revenge, Paul says think again
        - He says that if revenge is all you can see for that person, then the best course you can take is to let God punish them for you
        - Refrain from taking revenge and you'll ensure they get an even worse punishment than you can give
    - But if you take justice into our own hands, you sin and you limit God's justice
        - In a sense, their judgment in Hell will be lessened in some way because you took matters into your own hands
        - Luke 16 teaches that there is a reciprocal relationship between what we receive here and what we receive in eternity
        - The more a believer suffers for Christ here, the greater our reward in eternity
    - Jesus sums up this principle saying

Matt. 5:11 **"Blessed are you when people insult you and persecute you, and falsely say all kinds of evil against you because of Me.**

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Matt. 5:12 **"Rejoice and be glad, for your reward in heaven is great; for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.**

- Our reward increases as we willingly accept persecution for the sake of our faith
- So being willing to forgo taking revenge now, holds promise for greater benefits in the future
- Secondly, there is some suggestion that the more sin an unbeliever commits now, the more suffering they must experience in eternity
    - Peter suggests that the punishment for those who sin greatly here is proportionally greater

2Pet. 2:20 **For if, after they have escaped the defilements of the world by the knowledge of the Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, they are again entangled in them and are overcome, the last state has become worse for them than the first.**
2Pet. 2:21 **For it would be better for them not to have known the way of righteousness, than having known it, to turn away from the holy commandment handed on to them.**

- While we don't fully understand this economy, we know God is perfectly just in all His judgments
    - Therefore, we know He will consider all these puts-and-takes in arriving at the right course for each unbeliever
        - But if we step in and enforce our own version of justice, we sin by interfering in God's justice
        - And the person we are against will see even greater judgment should we leave them in God's hands
    - But should God choose to forgive them by His grace in the end, you will be glad you didn't act against a future brother and sister
        - You are leaving room for God to make the final determination concerning someone's future
        - And that is a win-win for you no matter what course God may take in that person's life
- Finally, Paul sums up the chapter saying do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good
    - This has a specific meaning but it could also be a summary statement for the entire third ring
        - As we engage in the unbelieving world hoping to win some for Christ, be careful they don't pull you down
        - We would better to stay away from the world altogether than to be corrupted by

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it

- Here again, this statement takes us back to our bull's-eye
  - We can only operate effectively in the third ring as an ambassador for Christ living among unbelievers if we are exercising reasonable control over our flesh
  - And if we are already practiced at showing love with humility and living with eyes for eternity among believers
  - But if we are weak in either of these two inner rings, then we will get eaten alive by our relationship with the unbelieving world
    - We may enter into those relationships hoping to win some for Christ
    - But soon we'll find ourself sharing their bad habits and sinful attitudes
- Paul says above all else, we must overcome these evils by representing the good fo Christ and His word
  - We cannot allow the enemy to get the upper hand in our life
  - We cannot be overcome by the evil we seek to influence for Christ

- Let's take a look at our chart once more with the third ring filled in

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- Tonight we reach the final ring in Paul's structured view of sanctification
  - This ring represents our final priority of sanctifying effort: our righteousness within society
    - Obviously, every society is made up of believers and unbelievers
    - And we know these two groups have been addressed in earlier rings
    - So we might assume this teaching will be redundant
  - But this ring addresses unique institutions and customs of society
    - Regrettably, a Christian worldview can lead to living within society in ways that are counterproductive to righteousness
    - For example, a Christian learns in scripture that our country is not of this world and that our citizenship is found in Heaven
    - And then we might misconstrue these truths as license to disobey authority on earth in the meantime
    - Or we may think that since we have overcome the world and have a different eternal future than the rest of society, that we are not under obligation to respect society's rules
- These views are wrong and unhelpful to the Church's mission
  - So Paul explains the proper view of our relationships with these institutions

Rom. 13:1 **Every person is to be in subjection to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those which exist are established by God.**
Rom. 13:2 **Therefore whoever resists authority has opposed the ordinance of God; and they who have opposed will receive condemnation upon themselves.**
Rom. 13:3 **For rulers are not a cause of fear for good behavior, but for evil. Do you want to have no fear of authority? Do what is good and you will have praise from the same;**
Rom. 13:4 **for it is a minister of God to you for good. But if you do what is evil, be afraid; for it does not bear the sword for nothing; for it is a minister of God, an avenger who brings wrath on the one who practices evil.**
Rom. 13:5 **Therefore it is necessary to be in subjection, not only because of wrath, but also for conscience' sake.**

- Paul opens discussion on the fourth and final ring of sanctification saying Christians are to be in subjection to governing authorities
  - Paul's statement is clear and unequivocal
    - Notice Paul says every person, meaning God intends and expects all humanity to live under a government – including Christians
    - Government has a proper role in society and in the life of every believer

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- The value of government is easy to understand
  - People living together in society are restrained in their behaviors and guided in their choices by the judgment of a few
  - How those decision-makers are chosen and how their rule is regulated, if at all, is an obvious concern
- But regardless of these details, government holds potential to bring both great benefits and unparalleled risks for society
  - In an ideal situation, sensible rulers will ensure peaceful and just coexistence for everyone
  - In the worst cases, government becomes an instrument for evil hearts to oppress society on a mass scale
  - In practice, most governments fall somewhere in between these two extremes

- But because governments hold so much power over us, the topic of obedience to government, especially ungodly governments, prompts strong reactions among Christians
  - When we agree with the governing authorities' decisions, we support the policies and obey them enthusiastically
    - But when we object to their decisions, we tend to act in opposite ways
    - The world does the same too of course
    - For example, following the election of Donald Trump, many on the left objected to his presidency by declaring, "He's not my president"
  - But for a Christian, the temptation to reject governing authorities is especially high when they stand opposed to our biblical worldview
    - In the worst cases, Christians may take our personal objections as license to act contrary to the law
    - While there are times when acting in disobedience to the law is appropriate, these situations are rare
    - And scripture guides these situations using the structure of Paul's bull's-eye, which we will look at more closely in a moment
  - But first, notice where Paul begins his discussion – he doesn't start with exceptions but with the rule: obey the government
    - Our Christian duty requires we seek every opportunity to obey, rather than seeking for exceptions that permit us to disobey
    - We ought to maintain the same attitude toward obeying laws that we expect our children to maintain toward our rules
  - We expect our children to do everything they can to obey the spirit of our rules, even when there may be times that doing so is difficult
    - We realize there will be exceptions on occasion when our rules must be bent or broken for a greater good
    - But in general, we want our children to have hearts that seek to obey rather

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than looking for ways to get around our rules
    - Likewise, Paul's opening statement anticipates that a Christian's heart is directed toward obedience as a rule, not toward seeking exceptions
    - We only disobey when law comes into conflict with the demands of righteousness in areas of greater priority
- At the end of v.1 Paul defends his order saying that obeying government is tantamount to obeying God Himself
    - Paul says there is no authority (on earth) except those that have been established by God Himself
        - In other words, no one gets elected into an office except that God Himself selected that leader
        - This is one of the strongest statements of God's sovereignty in all the New Testament
        - It's on par with Jospeh's words from Genesis, when he declared that his unlikely rise to power in Egypt was a result of God's hand

Gen. 45:7 **"God sent me before you to preserve for you a remnant in the earth, and to keep you alive by a great deliverance.**
Gen. 45:8 **"Now, therefore, it was not you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to Pharaoh and lord of all his household and ruler over all the land of Egypt.**

- As He did with Joseph, the Lord sovereignly decides who enters into power today
    - The Lord raises up new governments and nations and He destroys the same
    - That's true regardless of the form a government takes, whether a democracy, monarchy, or totalitarian regime
    - And it's true regardless of how righteous that government turns out to be
- Therefore, righteousness within society requires that we respect our rulers knowing they are God-appointed
    - We don't have to vote for them
    - We certainly don't have to love them
    - But we must respect their authority knowing they were appointed by God for some eternally good purpose
- Therefore, to oppose governing authorities in unlawful ways is sin against God's authority, Paul says
    - In v.2 Paul says that any person, Christian or otherwise, who resists authority is opposing the ordinance (or decision) of God
        - We are fighting against God's judgment, which I hope everyone recognizes is both foolish and useless

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        - God will get His way regardless of whether we support or oppose it
    - So the only thing our opposition to government will achieve is our own condemnation, Paul says in v.2
        - Paul is referring to condemnation that comes to us on earth, not an eternal condemnation of our soul
        - He's making the obvious point that the Christian who makes a habit of rebelling against governing authorities will suffer the penalty of law
    - To quote the great philosopher, Eric Clapton, "I fought the law and the law won"
        - So if you violate the law, even if it's in the name of righteousness, you should expect the authorities to respond
        - The law will condemn you justly
        - And when it does, you will be experiencing the judgment of God acting through government
- Paul reminds us in v.3 that rulers (or government) exist for the good of all society, which is why God brought government into existence
    - Government originated immediately after the flood of Noah
        - As Noah exited the Ark, the Lord granted man the right to rule over other men and enforce law
        - He even permitted men to enact harsh punishment for law breakers, including taking life

Gen. 9:5 **"Surely I will require your lifeblood; from every beast I will require it. And from every man, from every man's brother I will require the life of man.**
Gen. 9:6 **"Whoever sheds man's blood,**
By man his blood shall be shed,
For in the image of God
He made man.

- God brought about this change because the world was entering a new period of history
    - God had just promised that He would never repeat the judgment of a flood to address mankind's sin
    - Yet sin would continue and so would its negative effects
- Therefore as mankind repopulated and refilled the earth, God needed a new way of responding to the sin of the human heart
    - Beginning with Noah's family, men would now have the right to rule over others and punish evil
    - God was prepared to work through human government to regulate man's sin and prevent the unrestrained evil that led to the flood
    - Therefore, Paul says we are obliged to respect this institution recognizing God's good purpose in ordaining it

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- So Paul says that if we obey government, we should expect to have praise from society and vice versa
  - Obviously, vs.3-4 are a general truth
  - Usually if we obey government, good things result
  - Just as usually when we disobey government, we are working contrary to righteousness and we should expect its wrath
  - In that way, God works through government giving us incentive to restrain our own evil desires so that all society benefits
- About now, we will begin to ask questions about exceptions, especially immoral governments that don't operate according to these principles
  - For example, if we lived in Nazi Germany would we obey the government of Hitler?
    - Or if we lived in North Korea today, would we obey the dictator running that country?
    - Aren't we free to disobey the government when it does evil?
  - First, if we assume that a "bad" government gives us just cause to ignore its authority, consider where this leads
    - Who decides when a government is too evil to obey?
    - Wouldn't everyone set their own limit according to their own desires?
    - In fact, what government could be *good* enough to justify our obedience?
  - Imagine a world where everyone was free to disobey when it suited them based on their own assessment of good and bad
    - It would be a world where everyone thought they knew better than their rulers what was right
    - Wouldn't we end up in the same trouble that Israel suffered from during the time of Judges?

Judg. 17:6 **In those days there was no king in Israel; every man did what was right in his own eyes.**

- There would be no rule at all, and therefore there could be no governor on sin
- It's not news to acknowledge that government is imperfect and often unrighteous, but it's still better than the alternative
  - The absence of government is always worse than a bad government
    - Sin left unchecked always leads to far worse injustice than those created by government
    - If you think corrupt government causes evil, look at what happens in places where government breaks down entirely
  - For example, Nazi Germany caused great evil, but its evil deeds would pale in comparison to a world with no government

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        - And as bad as North Korea's dictator is (and he's cruel beyond description), people would suffer even more if there was no government
        - Because even the deeds of the worst despot can't compare to the unrestrained sin of millions of people doing what's right in their own eyes
    - Government will never be perfect, but in that respect it's no different than any other dispensation God gave men prior to Christ
        - Following the sin of Adam and Woman, God has given the world a series of measures or dispensations of His grace to combat sin
        - God gave us the dispensations of human conscience, the rule of patriarchs, human government and even God's own Law given to Israel
        - Each dispensation served a role in God's economy, and God required that men respected each for what it was intended to accomplish
    - Yet each dispensation ultimately failed in its own way to completely address the problem of sin
        - None had the power to reign in man's rebellion much less to put an end to it altogether
        - Each dispensation failure only served to demonstrate the necessity for our new spiritual birth in Christ
        - Because only the dispensation of God's grace in the Person of Christ has the power to solve our sin problem once and for all
        - And even then only after we shed this sinful body and enter our Heavenly eternal state
    - In a day to come, in the Kingdom, we will experience a truly perfect dispensation of grace
        - In that day, we will have a perfect conscience
        - We will have a perfect patriarch leading our family in Christ
        - We will have a perfect government and perfect ruler with a perfect law
        - And we will experience sin ruled in perfect justice
- In the meantime, we have human government with all its flaws
    - God raises up imperfect rulers to accomplish His will
        - And we submit to these rulers because we have complete faith in God
        - We trust that God can achieve His good and perfect will using even complete idiots and despots
    - So scripture requires that we maintain a heart inclined to obey government, not one seeking to find excuse for disobedience
        - So that even in the worst cases like Nazi Germany, we seek for ways to live in harmony with the government
        - Knowing that in doing so, we are respecting God's judgment and His plans
    - Remember, God used Hitler's atrocities to establish the conditions under which the

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nation of Israel could re-emerge in the world after nearly 2,000 years of exile

- Though many Christians felt justified in opposing his rule, history teaches that God worked through the man for eternal good
- Remember scripture tells us that before the Kingdom of God appears, Israel must first be regathered in her land
- So our entry into the Kingdom depended on God finding a way to bring Israel back into Palestine…and God used Hitler to make that happen

- So when do we have liberty to disobey the governing authorities?
  - The answer is to follow Paul's priority scheme in his bull's-eye
    - If governing authorities demand we do something that violates inner rings, we must disobey government
    - For example, if the government prohibits sharing the word of God, we must decline to obey as the apostles themselves did

Acts 4:18 And when they had summoned them, they commanded them not to speak or teach at all in the name of Jesus.
Acts 4:19 But Peter and John answered and said to them, "Whether it is right in the sight of God to give heed to you rather than to God, you be the judge;
Acts 4:20 for we cannot stop speaking about what we have seen and heard."

- Peter and John refused to obey their governing authorities when ordered not to speak the name of Jesus or teach about Him
  - Clearly, this is a priority in both the second and third rings
  - We must teach Jesus to our brothers and sisters
  - And we must speak His name to the world of unbelievers
  - And so these men disobeyed government
- But even then, they were still inclined to obey government in the sense that they submitted to the penalty that came for violating the law
  - When they disobeyed the command to be silent, they were prepared to to suffer the consequences
  - Later in Acts 5 they are re-arrested for speaking in public about Jesus, and they willingly go into prison
- At a point, they appear before the Jewish authorities and say this:

Acts 5:27 When they had brought them, they stood them before the Council. The high priest questioned them,
Acts 5:28 saying, "We gave you strict orders not to continue teaching in this name, and yet, you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching and intend to bring this man's blood upon us."

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Acts 5:29 **But Peter and the apostles answered, "We must obey God rather than men.**

- These apostles give us the perfect example of the tension between obeying government and maintaining obedience to God
  - At all times, we seek to obey God
  - Obeying government *is* obeying God…until it isn't
  - And when obeying government is contrary to obeying God, then we disobey government in order to obey God
- But then just as quickly, we return to obeying the government by accepting the consequences for our earlier disobedience
  - In other words, we willingly submit to the government's punishment for disobeying
  - We do this understanding that our circumstances are a result of the will of God at work in our lives
  - If we end up in prison as a result, then this is God's will
  - So we go willingly knowing He has some good purpose in us ministering from inside prison
- Ironically, the Jewish authorities that persecuted Peter and John recognized this truth too
  - After arresting Peter and John the second time, a prominent Pharisee, Gamaliel, the man who taught Paul said this:

Acts 5:38 **"So in the present case, I say to you, stay away from these men and let them alone, for if this plan or action is of men, it will be overthrown;**
Acts 5:39 **but if it is of God, you will not be able to overthrow them; or else you may even be found fighting against God."**

- We ought to adopt the same perspective when it comes to opposing government
- If the orders of government runs contrary to God's desire, the government will not prevail in the end
- And if it is part of God's plan, then we cannot stop it
- So in general, we only disobey government when it runs contrary to commands found in earlier rings of Paul's bull's-eye
  - And even then, we willingly submit to the consequences of disobedience
    - We don't commit further crime by avoiding prosecution
    - On the other hand, we are not prohibited from opposing government in lawful ways
  - You can vote the bums out of office, engage in lawful protests, lobby your congressman, etc.

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        - And if a rebellion breaks out or a coup removes your current leaders, you make a choice of where to place your allegiance
        - This very thing happened during the Civil War in the United States
    - Christians must decide what is the lawful government deserving their allegiance and then submit to it accordingly
        - These are personal decisions of conscience, so do as you feel you should – but always with an attitude of submission
        - As Paul says at the end of v.5, we obey government to avoid its wrath and to keep a good conscience
- Living this way advances the mission of the church, while ignoring Paul's commands hurts our mission
    - If believers commonly break the law on religious grounds, our opportunity to win souls for Christ will be severely compromised
        - There is nothing righteous in disobeying the government on issues of property rights or prayer in schools, etc.
        - Or disobeying court orders so we may preserve public displays of the Ten Commandments on the front lawn of public buildings
        - These actions may seem righteous to us because they are connected to religious observances, but in reality they are sin
    - Moreover, when we take these stands, we offend law-abiding citizens thus giving them little reason to respect or admire Christ
        - We're just using the Church as cover to get our own way politically rather than submitting to God's will
        - The Lord doesn't need a stone replica of the Ten Commandments to remind Him or the world what is righteous
        - And He isn't depending on us establishing prayer in public school to ensure He can reach the hearts of children
    - So the Lord isn't benefiting when His people rebel against meaningless rules of governments that only serve to make a spectacle of our disobedience
        - The only time lawbreaking works to the advantage of the Gospel is when we are persecuted for our faithful obedience to God
        - Persecution always has the effect of strengthening the church
        - The early martyrs brought great respect to the church when they were unfairly treated for simply following their faith quietly
    - But even then, the martyrs didn't revolt against Caesar
        - Christians submitted to the edicts of Rome, enduring painful deaths by wild animals or fire
        - They accepted these things as God's decree, and He used the martyrs to bring more people moved by their piety to the faith
    - Contrast that with those today who gain notoriety for opposing the government

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over meaningless disputes

- Paul moves forward now on this theme of living in a Christ-pleasing and mission-advancing way by elaborating on some specific situations

Rom. 13:6 For because of this you also pay taxes, for rulers are servants of God, devoting themselves to this very thing.
Rom. 13:7 Render to all what is due them: tax to whom tax is due; custom to whom custom; fear to whom fear; honor to whom honor.
Rom. 13:8 Owe nothing to anyone except to love one another; for he who loves his neighbor has fulfilled the law.

- Historically, the most challenging aspect of our obedience to government is in the area of money; specifically paying taxes
  - Paul sets the issue to rest quickly saying we must pay taxes
    - This should come as no surprise, since it's like any other law
    - When in doubt, refer to Rule #1: obey the government
  - Historically, the pious have often drawn the line in obeying government with their money
    - This should tell us something about the hearts of many so-called religious people
    - They love money more than obeying God
  - Even in Jesus' day we see the tension in the Gospels
    - The Jewish religious authorities frequently objected to paying taxes to the Roman government
    - They objected on the basis that they were supporting an evil government, or so they claimed
- When they put this dilemma to Jesus, He acknowledged that government has different priorities than serving God
  - When asked about paying taxes, Jesus famously said render to Caesar what is due Caesar
    - But then He added render to God what is God's
    - Jesus' point was that governments do what governments do, namely take people's money to fund their desires
    - This is to be expected and we don't serve the purpose of righteousness by opposing this course
  - Instead, if we want to further righteousness, we should focus on giving our obedience to God
    - Including obeying His command that we respect the government authorities He places over us

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        - Which means we pay taxes
        - So ironically, refusing to pay the government taxes isn't pleasing God, it's sinning against God
    - And this is true even when the government uses our money for unholy purposes
        - Remember, those authorities are from God, and He holds each person accountable for what they do
        - You are not accountable for what governing authorities do with your tax dollars
        - You are simply accountable to God for your obedience to the government
- For the same reason, Paul says those who work for the government in collecting taxes must be respected as servants of God
    - In Paul's day, tax collectors were usually singled out for being unrighteous and agents of evil
        - This perception was partly earned, since tax collectors were often unscrupulous extortionists
        - They made their income from the extra money they could extract from those under their charge
    - Nevertheless, Paul asks us to consider these people to be servants of God
        - Have you ever considered that the IRS is a servant of God?
        - As in Paul's day, most of us probably assumed the IRS was working for the other side
    - But Paul says we need show these people – and all government servants – in a better light
        - If God has raised up the government and is using it for His purposes, then those who operate within it are His servants
        - That's a helpful thing to remember when you're fuming while standing in that slow-moving line at the DMV
        - Or when you're getting the run-around over the phone by the Social Security Administration
    - Treat these people with respect, Paul says
        - Because they have devoted themselves to serving God even if they don't know it
            - And even if they aren't doing it particularly well for your sake
- In fact, Paul says take this attitude of respect with you everywhere you go in society
    - Render to each person what is due to them, he says in v.7
        - To render means to pay what is owed
        - We're not talking about showing them a favor or courtesy
        - Paul's asking us to do what is expected and justly required whether by law, custom or honor-bound
    - So pay your tax dollars to the government as required by law

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        - Give the policeman the respect they deserve as required by honor
        - Stand up and put your hand on your heart when you hear the national anthem as required by custom
        - Replace your neighbor's tool if you borrow it and break it
        - Pay your laborer a fair wage
        - Give the customary tip for good service
        - Keep your word
    - None of these things are "extras" or favors…they are simply giving someone what they are due
        - In doing these things, you preserve opportunity for the Gospel
        - You don't wish to cause offense or cast shame on the name of Christ
        - As Christians, we never want to be known for doing less than what unbelievers commonly do for one another
- Paul takes this idea of rendering one step further in v.8, asking us to owe nothing to anyone except love
    - The way this command is rendered in my English (NASB) Bible isn't helpful because it obscures Paul's meaning
        - The better rendition is found in the NIV:

Rom. 13:8 Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to love one another, for he who loves his fellowman has fulfilled the law.

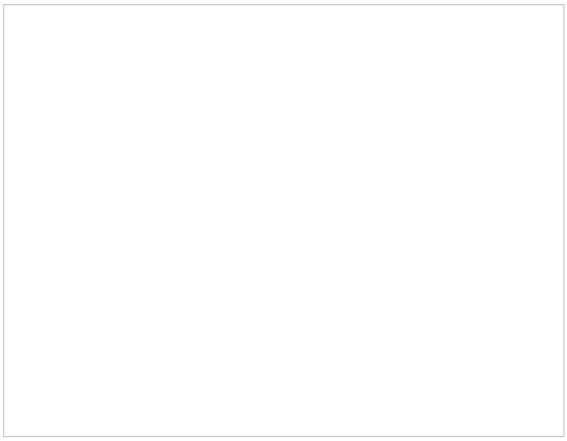
- Paul asks us not to leave our debts unpaid
    - So make sure that if you borrow you repay
    - The Bible isn't prohibiting borrowing altogether, but it is prohibiting failing to repay debt
    - Even in circumstances when legal avenues exist for walking away from debt, we should endeavor to do better
- But in the case of love, Paul says we should always strive to place others in "debt"
    - So while we deal fairly on areas of money, custom, law, etc., we don't take that transactional attitude when showing love to others
    - So if a policeman doesn't return our respect with consideration, we don't hold it against him…we let the debt of love remain unpaid
    - Or if our neighbor breaks our tool but doesn't replace it, we forgive that debt in love
    - We show love to others with no expectation of being repaid, which is exactly what Christ did to His enemies
- Paul says when we live this way, we're truly living the second command Christ told us to live by –

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- We are loving our neighbors as we love ourselves
  - And ultimately, this is the point of the Lord having His church living in and around the unbelieving world
  - We are to think, say and act the way Jesus did, showing righteousness to the world through these interactions
- In v.9 Paul quotes from the Law, specifically the Ten Commandments, to illustrate His point
  - He lists those commandments that deal specifically with our relationships with other people
  - And then Paul says these laws (and any other of the same kind) are the essence of loving your neighbor
  - This teaching is strikingly similar to Jesus' words to the rich young ruler in Luke 18
- Paul's point is also similar…true righteousness will be reflected in our treatment of the world
  - The overriding priority for demonstrating righteousness in society is showing love to others and thereby fulfilling the law
  - We work to put people in debt to us by showing them love, yet without an expectation that we receive anything in return
  - Love does no wrong to a neighbor, Paul says in v.10

- So the summary of the fourth ring is three-fold
  - First, we respect and obey government as an instrument of God for the sake of righteousness
    - We respect the institution and those who serve within it
    - We only disobey government when government demands we disobey God
  - Secondly, we respect society's customs by showing honor to those who are due honor
    - Respect the conventions of your society
    - Maintain a respectful attitude
    - Fulfill your obligations
  - Finally, show love to everyone by doing for them what you would have done for yourself
    - Practice this love expecting nothing in return
    - And so doing, protect Christ's reputation and honor among all people

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- With that Paul ends the chapter and the bull's-eye with a final argument that's part exhortation and part warning

Rom. 13:11 Do this, knowing the time, that it is already the hour for you to awaken from sleep; for now salvation is nearer to us than when we believed.
Rom. 13:12 The night is almost gone, and the day is near. Therefore let us lay aside the deeds of darkness and put on the armor of light.
Rom. 13:13 Let us behave properly as in the day, not in carousing and drunkenness, not in sexual promiscuity and sensuality, not in strife and jealousy.
Rom. 13:14 But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh in regard to its lusts.

- Paul begins with a warning of sorts
  - He says we ought to live in these ways, referring to the entire bull's-eye, knowing that it's already the hour for us to awaken from sleep
    - Sleep refers to death
    - And awakening refers to our resurrection, the moment we receive our new eternal body
  - This is a cryptic reference to Christ's return for His Bride, an event known as the rapture
    - Paul's reminding us of the imminent nature of Christ's return for the church
    - And of the judgment that follows immediately thereafter
  - Paul describes it this way in his letter to Thessalonica

1Th. 4:13 But we do not want you to be uninformed, brethren, about those who are asleep, so that you will not grieve as do the rest who have no hope.
1Th. 4:14 For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so God will bring with Him those who have fallen asleep in Jesus.

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1Th. 4:15 For this we say to you by the word of the Lord, that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord, will not precede those who have fallen asleep.
1Th. 4:16 For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first.
1Th. 4:17 Then we who are alive and remain will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we shall always be with the Lord.
1Th. 4:18 Therefore comfort one another with these words.

- Notice Paul uses the term "sleep" to refer to the death of believers awaiting the rapture
  - These souls are not truly sleeping, for they reside fully conscious with Christ even now
  - In a future moment, they return with Christ to receive new bodies
  - And we who are alive will join them in that moment in the clouds, Paul says
- Paul says that hour is already here, in the sense that the return of Christ for the church is an ever-present possibility
  - We don't know when it will happen, and since it doesn't depend on anything, it can happen at any moment
    - In fact, we can't say it *won't* happen in the next hour
    - So in a sense, the hour is always upon us, ready to happen at any moment
  - Paul reminds us of the imminence of the rapture at the end of v.11 saying our salvation is nearer to us now than when we believed
    - He's saying that even though we don't know when we will see Christ, every day our rapture is one day closer than before
    - In this context, salvation refers not to the moment of saving faith
    - Rather, it refers to the moment we receive eternal life in the form of an eternal body – again the resurrection
  - Using a different metaphor in v.12, Paul says the night period of history is almost gone and the day period of the Kingdom is almost here
    - Jesus uses a similar metaphor to refer to the period between His first and second comings

John 9:4 "We must work the works of Him who sent Me as long as it is day; night is coming when no one can work.
John 9:5 "While I am in the world, I am the Light of the world."

- Jesus is the Light of the world, so while He was on earth, the world was experiencing a period of "light"

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- It was witness to the light of the glory of God
- And when Jesus departed, the world returned to a period of dark, when the glory of God was absent for a time
    - In a day to come, Jesus returns to set up His Kingdom
    - When this happens, the world will see His light again
    - So in that sense, the night is soon to give way to the light of Christ's return
- Knowing these things, how ought we to live in the meantime?
    - What kind of student do you become when you hear that a pop quiz is coming soon?
        - What kind of child do you become when your parents phone to tell you they are on their way home?
        - What kind of employee are you when the boss is looking over your shoulder?
    - The point Paul's making is one we can all identify with if we understand it
        - Paul is saying that Christ's return is imminent and so is His judgment of His Church
        - And therefore we ought be concerned with who we've become and how we're living for Christ
    - Paul says we ought to lay aside the deeds of darkness, of the sinful fallen world
        - And in their place, we should put on the armor of light
        - That's a reference to the full armor of God, which Paul gives us in Ephesians 6
        - It's a reference to living in the Spirit, taking full advantage of all the spiritual strength Christ gives us through the disciplines of the faith
    - Making your sanctification your life's priority, readying yourself for your Lord's return and His review of your service to His name
        - And if you're still distracted by deeds of the flesh, living like the unbelieving world, then now's the time to put that aside
        - It's time to get serious, to be prepared for Christ
- In v.13 Paul gives a few examples of the sorts of things that typify living in the darkness of the world and which contradict living for Christ
    - Carousing is a Bible word for partying
        - Partying is the modern term for debauchery or other forms of out-of-control self-indulgence
        - It's wasting time by satisfying the flesh
        - It's a contradiction with our purpose in living for Christ
        - It's not preparing us for Christ's return, and should He return while we're in the middle of this activity, it will be to our shame
    - Closely associated with carousing or partying is drunkenness, which is self explanatory
        - Any addiction holds the potential to derail our lives and set us up for a bad

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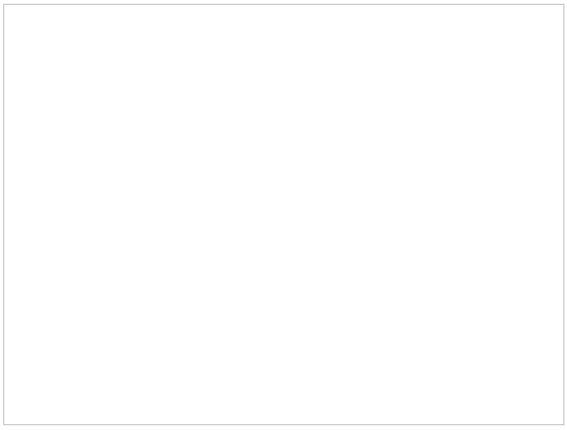
result come judgment day
        - We're giving our already powerful flesh even greater control over our spirit
        - And in that way, we're putting our sanctification at great risk
    - The next two items are also grouped for obvious reasons
        - Promiscuity and sensuality are more ways to enflame the desires of the flesh, which serves to interfere with our spiritual progress
        - Promiscuity is literally the Greek word for "bed", as in the place of marital relations
        - It refers to someone given over to seeking sexual satisfaction by whatever means necessary
        - Sensuality is lewd behavior in any form
    - Today, these two words would be comparable to fornication (i.e., sleeping around) and pornography
        - Once again, when we allow ourselves to become captivated by sexual desires, we're returning to a slavery Christ has freed us from
        - We're becoming mired in something that wastes our time, corrupts our witness and destroys our testimony
        - When Christ returns, we'll regret that time spent in such fruitless pursuits
- Finally, Paul lists strife and jealousy
    - The problem is the same – distractions that impede our sanctification
        - Strife is settling scores, getting even, winning arguments
        - It's a contentiousness that cares more about our power and respect among people rather than before God
    - And jealousy in any form is covetousness: desiring for things others have that we wish we had
        - Today this is usually seen in unrestrained materialism or career pursuits
        - Yet another way we can get distracted from serving Christ and pursuing our sanctification
    - Instead, Paul says do two things
        - First, put on the Lord Jesus, living in His commands and by His spirit
        - Learn what He taught, live as He commanded, seek to please Him
    - Secondly, make no provision for the flesh and its lusts
        - This means taking whatever steps you need to take to prevent the flesh from gaining the upper hand in your life
        - As Jesus said, if you right hand causes you to stumble, cut it off (not literally)
    - That is, take measures to guard yourself from your own flesh's lusts
        - It's worth doing because what we stand to gain in return is so great

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        - We stand to gain our sanctification
        - And with greater sanctification comes opportunity for greater reward
- That's what this whole bull's-eye is about…a strategy to succeed against our own flesh for the purpose of pleasing Christ
    - The degree to which we implement this plan is the degree to which we will succeed in our eternal goals
        - The Spirit living in us does the hard work of convicting us and training us concerning what is right
        - We only need to yield to Him by giving the flesh no provision
        - Follow this prescription and await your reward, for the hour is upon us all

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- We've completed Paul's instruction on sanctification in Chapters 12-13, so now we're ready to tackle two final issues on the question of living out our salvation
    - These two issue stand apart in that they do not follow Paul's structure represented by the bull's-eye chart



- Up to now Paul's been teaching about how to live out our salvation according to a certain priority
- He started with our highest priority, our relationship with God
- Then he moved to our relationship with the church, then to unbelievers and then to societal institutions
    - Each of these relationships, represented by a ring on a bull's-eye, holds opportunity for us to practice holiness and further the Church's mission
        - Each ring of the bull's-eye required we place the needs of Christ above our own
        - And our success in each ring depended on having made progress in the prior ring
        - So in that way Paul's system becomes a roadmap for our efforts to live out the salvation we have received by grace
    - But Paul isn't finished exhorting, because there were some other issues troubling the early church that deserved special attention
        - These issues are covered in Chapter 14 and the first half of Chapter 15
        - They deal with the relationship between Jewish believers and Gentile believers
        - And the uniqueness of these circumstances requires a few minutes of introduction
- The formation of the church during the first century involved a grand social experiment
    - Never before had Jews and Gentiles tried to associate so closely together
        - The amalgamation of these two groups into one body brought significant challenges
        - We get a sense of how great these challenges were when we read about the experiences of the apostles
    - In particular, the Apostle Peter struggled with the introduction of Gentiles into the

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body

- At one point his struggles even threatened to divide the body of Christ
- It required another apostle, Paul, chastising Peter publicly for his failure to embrace God's call to the Gentiles to advance the unity of the church

- Paul relates that moment to us in Galatians:

Gal. 2:11 But when Cephas came to Antioch, I opposed him to his face, because he stood condemned.
Gal. 2:12 For prior to the coming of certain men from James, he used to eat with the Gentiles; but when they came, he began to withdraw and hold himself aloof, fearing the party of the circumcision.
Gal. 2:13 The rest of the Jews joined him in hypocrisy, with the result that even Barnabas was carried away by their hypocrisy.
Gal. 2:14 But when I saw that they were not straightforward about the truth of the gospel, I said to Cephas in the presence of all, "If you, being a Jew, live like the Gentiles and not like the Jews, how is it that you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews?

- After Peter fled persecution in Jerusalem, he set up residence in the fast-growing church community in Antioch, Syria
  - Paul and Barnabas were already there leading the church in Antioch, and by their influence the church had attracted many Gentile believers
    - In fact, Antioch was the first church located outside Judea
    - As such, it was the first church to attempt a large-scale integration of Jews and Gentiles into the same community
    - Never before in history had something like this been attempted
  - Unsurprisingly, this integration didn't go smoothly, not at first
    - The difficulties were so significant that eventually it prompted a grand meeting of apostles in Jerusalem to settle the disputes
    - Paul and Barnabas traveled to the meeting to represent the Antioch church
    - At that counsel all the apostles agreed that Gentiles were called into the faith and must be treated as co-equals with Jews
    - Most importantly, they agreed that apart from a few specific concessions Gentiles should not adopt Jewish practices and law
  - Nevertheless, Peter continued to struggle with living around Gentiles
    - So when Peter later joined the church in Antioch, he acted contrary to the agreement the apostles made in Jerusalem
    - Specifically, Peter hypocritically returned to distancing himself from Gentile believers

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        - When Jews from the Jerusalem church visited Antioch, Peter refused to eat at the tables of Gentiles
        - At that point, Paul chastised Peter for his hypocrisy
- Clearly if the apostle Peter struggled to accept Gentile believers, we can be sure many other Jewish believers had the same trouble
    - And as hard as it was for Jews to accept Gentiles, the opposite was also true
        - Gentile believers were equally put off by the oddities of Jewish culture
        - Jews were raised to observe strict dietary restrictions and to practice unique rituals of daily life
    - When a Jew came to faith in Christ, he or she was suddenly free from these restrictions and could live in new and unfamiliar ways
        - Nevertheless, many Jews found it extremely difficult to abandon their Jewish heritage and lifestyle practices
        - So many first century Jewish believers continued in their Jewish traditions
        - The letter of Hebrews was written to stop the most extreme of these behaviors among Jewish believers
    - But these practices were both unfamiliar and unappealing to Gentile believers
        - Jewish zealousness made Gentiles uncomfortable, especially if combined with self-righteousness or haughtiness
        - So Gentile believers resisted integrating with Jewish believers who maintained their Jewish traditions
    - A key sticking point for unity in the body was Jewish insistence of never sharing a meal with a Gentile
        - The requirement stemmed from Jewish dietary restrictions
        - Since a Jew could not eat many things that Gentiles commonly ate, Jews avoided Gentile tables
        - This quickly turned into a prohibition against entering a Gentile house or association with Gentiles whatsoever
        - This was the same rule Peter was following hypocritically in Antioch
    - Obviously, nothing destroys unity in a community faster than refusing to eat together
        - This is human nature
        - Even among young children in school, who you eat with during lunch indicates which community has accepted you
        - So for Jews and Gentiles in the early church, a failure to eat together struck at the heart of unity in the body
        - Secondly, Jewish observance of Sabbath and feasts and other elements of the law drove the wedge even deeper
- This is not a great recipe for unity in the body, which is why Paul set out to address these

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issues in this letter

- But at this point, we need to ask if these chapters are still relevant to our church today?
  - First, there are some places where this problem still exists
  - For example, the church in present-day Israel still deals with some of these concerns
  - For these settings, Romans 14-15 are immediately applicable
- And in other places it's becoming more common to find "messianic" congregations assembling
  - These are (ostensibly) Christian gatherings that have adopted a distinctively Jewish style of worship to appeal to Jewish believers
  - But these groups also attract Gentile believers who are attracted to understanding the Jewish roots of our faith
  - In these settings, you find the potential for the same conflict Paul was addressing in the early church
- And finally, for the rest of the church, Paul's teaching remains relevant when considered in a more general way
  - Even if we aren't dealing with differences between Jew and Gentile, we still contend with other differences
    - Racial differences, nationality differences, cultural differences…
    - Believers with different conviction, different levels of spiritual maturity, different interpretations of scripture…
  - These differences can lead to similar divisions and difficulties and therefore they can be resolved by applying the principles found in these chapters

- So let's turn to Chapter 14, and as we observe Paul's instruction we'll consider its application for the early church and for our situation today

Rom. 14:1 Now accept the one who is weak in faith, but not for the purpose of passing judgment on his opinions.
Rom. 14:2 One person has faith that he may eat all things, but he who is weak eats vegetables only.
Rom. 14:3 The one who eats is not to regard with contempt the one who does not eat, and the one who does not eat is not to judge the one who eats, for God has accepted him.
Rom. 14:4 Who are you to judge the servant of another? To his own master he stands or falls; and he will stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand.

- Chapter 14 opens with Paul calling for one group within the body to accept (or receive) another group
  - As we'll see from the context of Paul's instructions, the first group are Gentile

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believers, while the second group are Jewish believers
        - Paul is asking Gentiles in the church to accept or receive Jewish believers into fellowship
        - He wants Gentiles to show Jews love despite their odd and potentially divisive cultural differences
        - He'll ask the same thing in reverse in Chapter 15
        - But for now we're looking at Gentiles accepting the strange, restrictive practices of Jewish believers
    - Paul refers to the Jewish believers as those "weak" in faith
        - To be weak in this context is not pejorative
        - Paul is speaking in spiritual terms, in the sense of spiritual strength or maturity
    - In physical terms, it would be similar to referring to a 3-year old toddler as "weak" in comparison to a teenager
        - When we call a toddler weak compared to a teenager, we're not insulting the toddler…
        - We're simply describing the obvious differences between the two
        - A teenager has grown and matured enough to lift heavy objects, while a toddler is not yet capable of doing the same
        - So naturally, we don't expect the same things of the toddler that we might of a teenager
- Paul is asking the church to be similarly understanding for those who are weak spiritually
    - Paul describes Jewish believers as weak in faith in the sense that they felt a need to continue observing aspects of the Law
        - By grace, Jewish believers were as free from the Mosaic Law as Gentile believers were
        - Yet many Jews found this transition too big of a leap to make right away
        - They felt uneasy abandoning their previous convictions so abruptly
        - So they tended to maintain Jewish dietary restrictions for a time, if not forever
    - This was a sign of weakness in faith, in the sense that it meant they were not strong enough spiritually to take advantage of the liberty they had in Christ
        - They felt more comfortable in the old ways even as they walked in the grace of the New Covenant
        - Their conscience was still growing in its appreciation of liberty
        - And in the meantime they relied on the familiarity and safety of what they understood in the law
    - Of course, Gentile believers had no trouble embracing the liberty they enjoyed in the New Covenant
        - Gentiles had never been under the Law, so the Law held no attraction for them,

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especially in light of grace
    - For that same reason, they looked down on those Jewish believers who could not set the law aside
    - Some probably mocked or rejected these weaker believers
    - Or even worse, the Gentile believers might've forced the issue by pressuring Jewish believers to go against their conscience
- Paul says that the loving way for Gentiles to accommodate Jewish believers was to accept them into the body unconditionally
    - Welcome them despite their continuing observance of dietary laws
        - And importantly, Paul adds in v.1 that Gentiles weren't to accept Jews merely for the purpose of passing judgment
        - To accept someone for the purpose of passing judgment means to bring them in under false pretense
        - We act as if we receive them, when in reality we won't truly accept them unless and until they conform to our desires
        - That's not true acceptance and it's certainly not loving
    - Nevertheless, Paul acknowledges that Jewish dependence on the Law was not desirable
        - He was calling for acceptance of Jews – but only for the purpose of unity – not for the purpose of adopting their theology
        - Paul was not endorsing a believer's need to observe Jewish dietary restrictions
        - Dietary restrictions came about as part of a Law God gave to Israel to serve as a temporary custodian
        - It served to separate Israel from the rest of the nations, maintaining their uniqueness and identity
    - In Galatians Paul expresses it this way:

Gal. 3:19 **Why the Law then? It was added because of transgressions, having been ordained through angels by the agency of a mediator, until the seed would come to whom the promise had been made.**

Gal. 3:23 **But before faith came, we were kept in custody under the law, being shut up to the faith which was later to be revealed.**
Gal. 3:24 **Therefore the Law has become our tutor to lead us to Christ, so that we may be justified by faith.**

- God added to Israel the Law to help address mankind's sins
    - It was ordained "until" the Messiah (seed) would come
    - The word until makes clear that the Law was intended to be a temporary

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accommodation

- Paul calls the Law a custodian, a tutor, like a babysitter keeping God's people safe until the parent came to claim the child

- So any Jewish believer who understood this truth possessed spiritual strength in comparison to other Jewish believers who didn't
  - The strength of their faith was evidenced in their willingness to set aside dietary restrictions that no longer applied
    - Those stronger Jewish Christians were willing to eat anything freely
    - But those who were weak in regard to these truths will eat vegetables only
    - Of course, Gentiles never had such restrictions, so it was easy for them to look down on any "weak" Jew, but Paul says that was wrong
  - Interestingly, the Mosaic Law didn't require Jews to eat only vegetables
    - So why did this become the practice for those Jews who were weak in faith?
    - Most likely, the Jewish believers living around Gentiles were eating vegetables only to avoid eating anything unclean
  - There are no unclean vegetables in the Mosaic Law
    - Fresh fruits, vegetables and grains are, in their natural unprocessed state, kosher
    - But if vegetables are combined with dairy or meat (or cooked in pots that have also been used to cook dairy and meat), then they take on the properties of these other foods
  - So the fact that Jews felt they could only eat vegetables tells us something about the weakness of their faith
    - But it also suggests Gentile believers were showing no consideration for their Jewish brothers and sisters
    - They gave no thought to how pots and dishes were used in the preparation of food for the gathering
    - They may have prepared pork or shellfish or other unclean foods and thought nothing of how it would offend their Jewish brothers and sisters
    - And therefore, Jewish believers probably felt they had no choice but to resort to vegetarianism to avoid eating unclean food
- So ironically, who had the weaker faith? The Jews who couldn't abandon the Law or the Gentiles who couldn't show consideration for their weak neighbors?
  - Both issues needed to be addressed to promote unity in the body
    - And together, they form two key principles that still apply today
  - First we find the principle that we must endeavor to grow in our appreciation of relationships with Christ
    - It's important to avoid unduly burdening others in the body with our spiritual weaknesses

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        - Everyone has weakness and the body is here to help us
        - But that places us under obligation to avail ourselves of that support so we may grow out of that dependence
    - Secondly, we must be prepared to accept weaker members of the body without passing judgment
        - We expect them to grow in maturity in time
        - But in the meantime, we give them grace and patience
        - Because in order for spiritual growth to happen, they first must be part of the body where they can be trained and encouraged
    - Which is why in v.3 Paul says the one with faith to eat cannot show contempt for those who lacked the faith to eat all things
        - Likewise, those who observed dietary restrictions were not to judge those who ate freely
        - Instead, each group must recognize that God has accepted the other already on the basis of Christ's sacrifice
    - Our faith in Jesus Christ puts to rest these differences because Christ triumphed in all things on our behalf
        - For the Jew, Christ kept the Old Covenant Law perfectly so that His perfection could be credited to the Jew's account by faith
        - And for the Gentile, Christ fulfills the Abrahamic Covenant promised to bless all nations of people, bringing us righteousness apart from the Law
        - For both groups Christ has paid the penalty for all sin so that neither group finds its righteousness in works, whether eating or not eating
- Consequently, Paul asks in v.4 how can we rightly judge the servant of another master?
    - By faith, both groups have become bondslaves of Christ and serve Him according to His commands
        - Since we cannot know how the Lord is commanding each of His servants, how can we judge whether anyone else is doing the right thing?
        - Apart from things specifically commanded in scripture, we should give each believer latitude to obey Christ as they feel convicted
    - Paul reminds us that each of us will stand or fall at our judgment based on how we responded to Christ individually
        - We won't be judged based on what someone else thought we should do to please Christ
        - Paul says that Christ is able to make each believer "stand"
        - Christ knows what's best for each of His servants
        - So if we pay attention to His direction, we will receive a good judgment
        - But if we give attention to another's opinions rather than Christ's direction, we will not stand…we will fall

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- This is the danger of liberalism in the Church
  - Liberalism is taking liberty too far, ignoring our convictions so we may go with the crowd
    - Liberalism results from combining the liberty of everyone to arrive at a superset of privileges
    - We abandon our convictions anytime we discover another believer who does not share that conviction
    - Such thinking assumes that if it's good for one believer, it's good for all believers
  - In reality, liberalism is an abuse of liberty
    - Everyone has a limited range of liberty that Christ has determined is best for them individually
    - Some will drink alcohol or smoke or play the lottery, and some will not
    - Some give 10% of their money to church, some will give more, some will give less
  - But each of us must pay attention to our personal convictions and allow the Spirit to guide these choices
    - Those who feel greater liberty must not impose that freedom on others thinking we know better about what they need
    - If we press other believers to explore more freedom than they otherwise feel comfortable experiencing, we cause them to sin
  - And if we're successful in convincing another Christian to go against their convictions in the name of liberty, we're making a huge mistake
    - We're wounding their conscience, as Paul explains next:

Rom. 14:5 One person regards one day above another, another regards every day alike. Each person must be fully convinced in his own mind.
Rom. 14:6 He who observes the day, observes it for the Lord, and he who eats, does so for the Lord, for he gives thanks to God; and he who eats not, for the Lord he does not eat, and gives thanks to God.
Rom. 14:7 For not one of us lives for himself, and not one dies for himself;
Rom. 14:8 for if we live, we live for the Lord, or if we die, we die for the Lord; therefore whether we live or die, we are the Lord's.
Rom. 14:9 For to this end Christ died and lived again, that He might be Lord both of the dead and of the living.

- Paul shifts his example from dietary restrictions to the Sabbath day observance, but his underlying concern remains the same
  - Paul says one person (the observant Jew) regards one day above another
    - That one day, of course, is the Jewish Sabbath

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        - Jews under the Law observed a Sabbath from sundown Friday to sundown Saturday
        - Sabbath was the high day of the week, and it came with a long list of restrictions and observances
        - Obviously, Gentiles had no such observance – Christians in general are not under such restrictions now
    - Then in the second half of v.5 Paul says another believer may regard every day alike
        - That refers to not observing a Sabbath day at all, regardless of the day of the week
        - Notice Paul doesn't condemn or correct such a person…he simply lists this option as equally valid with observing a Sabbath
        - He then adds that whichever way we choose to go, we must be fully convinced in our own mind, referring to our conscience
    - Clearly Paul (and therefore Scripture) has no problem with Christians forgoing a Sabbath observance, whether a Jewish Christian or Gentile
        - As Scripture teaches repeatedly, we are not under Law
        - Therefore there is no requirement for believers to hold one day above the rest
        - But by that same token, a believer may hold one day above the rest should he choose to do so
    - Again, Christians who grow in faith would be expected to abandon such observances as they mature
        - Nevertheless, in the meantime we must accept those who depend upon such an observance
        - The point is that each believer be permitted to follow his or her own conscience on these matters
        - So long as they feel convicted, let them live accordingly
- In v.6 Paul reminds us that when we act according to our convictions, whether on matters of food or days of the week or whatever, we are serving Christ in our heart
    - This is the essence of obedience: doing what we feel convicted to do
        - And the corollary is generally also true: sin is acting contrary to our convictions
        - So Paul says of the one who observes a Sabbath in full conviction, that they are doing well
        - And the one who doesn't observe a Sabbath day (also as a matter of conviction) is doing equally well
        - Because both are seeking to obey Christ
    - While the Spirit will never lead us contrary to Scripture, He may ask us to forgo our liberty at times for our own good
        - There is nothing sinful when a Christian assumes a more restrictive lifestyle out of personal conviction

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        - For example, Christians are not required to observe a Sabbath but that doesn't necessarily mean it's wrong if a believer chooses to observe one
        - A Jewish believer could feel conviction to continue observing a Sabbath either because he hadn't been taught otherwise or he didn't feel comfortable abandoning the practice…
    - But if we ask such a person to go against his conscience, we're asking that Christian to sin
        - We're eroding their confidence in their convictions
        - We're training them to ignore their internal spiritual compass, which is a dangerous precedent
        - For example, if a Christian is convinced that Christ expects him to observe a Sabbath – even though Scripture doesn't require it – then he must act as his conscience directs
        - To act contrary to what he believes Christ wants is an intent to sin, even when it's not actually sin
- If we convince this Christian that is the best course, we give them cause to doubt all their convictions…this is nothing if not unloving
    - After all, our goal shouldn't be getting people to agree with our viewpoint on any matter of liberty
        - Our goal should be in helping all believers become more obedient to Christ
        - In vs.7-9 Paul says no Christian lives for himself or dies for himself, but we exist to serve (that is, to obey) Christ
    - To live or die is Paul's way of referring to the two periods of a believer's existence spent serving Christ
        - To live refers to the time we serve Christ with our earthly life now
        - While to die refers to our passing from this life into our eternal existence, where we will continue to serve Christ forever in glory
        - So regardless of whether we're living here or in eternity, we are suppose to serve Christ, not ourselves
    - So we need to leave other believers to serve Christ as He has called them to do so without our interference
        - Don't try to make other believers serve your convictions
        - Or serve the pastor's personal agenda
        - Or serve the church's programs and priorities
        - Paul's not talking about correcting another believer engaged in sin…we're talking about matters of liberty
    - The general principle underlying Paul's teaching is don't make yourself another Christian's Holy Spirit
        - We cannot assign our convictions to another
        - Whatever the Lord has placed on our heart concerning liberty and various

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practices of the faith is for us alone

- Barring specific scripture to contrary, anything another believer does by faith and conviction is proper and must be respected

- And especially in cases where another believer's convictions fall short of enjoying all the liberty they have available in Christ, be careful
  - Don't insist that their convictions are wrong…they're not
  - Instead, patiently instruct the believer in scripture so that over time they will grow strong enough to enjoy liberty

- For example, if a believer feels a conviction to abstain from pork, we should respect that conviction though we know it to be unnecessary
  - We accommodate them in love by avoiding serving pork around them
    - And we say nothing to make them feel unwelcome or disrespected for their convictions
    - We don't flaunt our liberty by pulling out a ham sandwich in front of them
    - And we certainly don't try to fix their "problem" by pressuring them to abandon their convictions
  - Instead, we accept their convictions, seeking to maintain fellowship without judgment
    - Then we patiently instruct them from scripture
    - We don't necessarily seek out teaching specifically on the issue of pork, again trying to force the issue
    - We simply teach the whole counsel of God's word, trusting that the Lord will grow their appreciation of Christ and grace
  - As the person grows in the grace and knowledge of their Lord, Jesus Christ, they will begin to mature
    - And in that spiritual growth they will eventually find their convictions changing to better align with scripture
    - So in other words, we don't teach believers to ignore their convictions
    - We teach believers the Bible so that the Holy Spirit may change their convictions

- In v.9 Paul says that's why Christ died and rose again, so that He could be Lord over those who are being saved and over a people for all eternity
  - His death means even now, as we live in a sinful body, our service to Christ in faith is acceptable to God
    - We don't have to wait to reach eternity to serve Christ
    - And we do that now by obeying the convictions he puts on our heart
    - And our service won't stop when we die…it lives on eternally because we have eternal life made possible by Christ as well
  - But human nature, especially in tight knit groups, is to expect conformity

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        - To an extent, conformity in the body of Christ is a necessary and healthy expectation
        - But in cases of spiritual maturity, it's a dangerous expectation
- When more mature believers expect less mature, "weaker" believers to act as they do, we're promoting liberalism and hurting our brother or sister
    - Paul raises that concern next

Rom. 14:10 But you, why do you judge your brother? Or you again, why do you regard your brother with contempt? For we will all stand before the judgment seat of God.
Rom. 14:11 For it is written,
"As I live, says the Lord, every knee shall bow to Me,
And every tongue shall give praise to God."
Rom. 14:12 So then each one of us will give an account of himself to God.

- If we demand conformity to our standards, we're judging a brother
    - Too often we hear people throw around the statement "don't judge me", claiming that the Bible prohibits judging one another
    - That's true in certain contexts and very untrue in others
- In matters of sin and righteousness, the body of Christ is absolutely called to judge one another
    - Paul says it plainly that we are to judge members of the body in matters of right and wrong to ensure good behavior

1Cor. 5:12 For what have I to do with judging outsiders? Do you not judge those who are within the church?
1Cor. 5:13 But those who are outside, God judges. Remove the wicked man from among yourselves.

- We are to remove the wicked from among ourselves
    - And this will require judging sin where it exists in the body
- On the other hand, we are never to judge another believer on matters of personal liberty
    - Paul says this here in Romans and elsewhere

Col. 2:16 Therefore no one is to act as your judge in regard to food or drink or in respect to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath day —
Col. 2:17 things which are a mere shadow of what is to come; but the substance belongs to Christ.

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- **No one may judge us on things of liberty like food, drink, Sabbath day observance, etc.**

1Cor. 10:28 But if anyone says to you, "This is meat sacrificed to idols," do not eat it, for the sake of the one who informed you, and for conscience' sake;
1Cor. 10:29 I mean not your own conscience, but the other man's; for why is my freedom judged by another's conscience?

- Furthermore, Paul says that no man may judge him in matters of personal conscience
- The same is true for every believer
- So a believer's choices and decisions may be judged when these choices are a violation of scripture and constitute sin
  - But when the matter involves personal liberty, no one may be our judge
  - Christ alone judges us for our convictions, because Christ alone sets those convictions
  - And He alone will judge us for whether we obeyed them
- Can you think of times when you acted contrary to your convictions yet you weren't sinning necessarily?
  - You still felt some guilt, didn't you?
    - You still regretted your decision, even though others around you were doing the same thing
    - That's a moment when you sinned against your own conscience
  - We don't want to encourage other believers to act in that way
    - Not only will their judgment before Christ be impacted…but so will your judgment!
    - Paul says at the end of v.10 that we all stand before the judgment seat of Christ
  - This moment is an evaluation for reward, not for the assignment of punishment
    - We all will face this moment with some regrets
    - But the grace of God is greater than our sin, so in forgiveness and mercy we will receive a reward
  - But we don't want to send others – much less ourselves – into that moment with any more baggage than necessary
    - Ironically, we might think we're doing someone a favor by convincing them to enjoy a pork chop when they resist
    - But in reality, we're hurting their future judgment because we're leading them to sin
    - And we're hurting our own judgment too, because we're sinning in convincing them to go against their convictions

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- As our study of Romans winds down, we're finishing Paul's next-to-last issue of sanctification today and beginning his final topic
  - Paul's issue in Chapter 14 is liberalism
    - Liberalism is the error of encouraging other believers to participate in certain freedoms contrary to their convictions
    - Paul uses the term "weak" to describe the faith of believers who feel convicted to restrict their own liberty to please the Lord
  - From the standpoint of scripture, their self-imposed restrictions are unnecessary
    - Nevertheless, Paul taught that from the standpoint of righteousness, these weak believers are sinning when they go against their convictions
    - Moreover, we sin when we encourage liberalism rather than respecting the convictions of other believers
  - Today we finish Paul's teaching on liberalism with his exhortation to all believers, especially the "strong" of faith, to not judge another's liberty

Rom. 14:13 Therefore let us not judge one another anymore, but rather determine this — not to put an obstacle or a stumbling block in a brother's way.
Rom. 14:14 I know and am convinced in the Lord Jesus that nothing is unclean in itself; but to him who thinks anything to be unclean, to him it is unclean.
Rom. 14:15 For if because of food your brother is hurt, you are no longer walking according to love. Do not destroy with your food him for whom Christ died.
Rom. 14:16 Therefore do not let what is for you a good thing be spoken of as evil;
Rom. 14:17 for the kingdom of God is not eating and drinking, but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.
Rom. 14:18 For he who in this way serves Christ is acceptable to God and approved by men.
Rom. 14:19 So then we pursue the things which make for peace and the building up of one another.
Rom. 14:20 Do not tear down the work of God for the sake of food. All things indeed are clean, but they are evil for the man who eats and gives offense.
Rom. 14:21 It is good not to eat meat or to drink wine, or to do anything by which your brother stumbles.

- Paul says we must be sure to keep the right goal in our fellowship
  - Our goal is not obtaining others' agreement with our convictions or conformity among the body in matters of liberty
    - Rather our goal should be to do nothing that might harm another believer's pursuit of obedience to Christ
    - Let's look for ways to make it *easier* for people to receive a good reward at their judgment moment

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- We can accomplish our goal by working to remove obstacles to another's obedience, not by placing new obstacles in their path
  - Paul refers to our hindering other believers' obedience as being a stumbling block
  - The Bible makes frequent use of the metaphor of stumbling to represent falling into sin
  - It appears 99 times in the NASB
- In literal terms, a stumbling block is an object that a person walking does not see or recognize properly
  - As a result, the person's foot catches on the object, leading him to lose his balance and fall
  - We've all done this more than a few times, and it's a scary moment
  - It often leads to injury or at least embarrassment

- This metaphor powerfully illustrates the nature of the problem
  - Spiritually speaking, every believer is endeavoring to walk with Christ
    - To walk with Christ pictures obeying Christ, following His lead as He directs us toward righteousness
    - When we listen to His instructions and following His guidance, we are walking closely with Him
    - When we veer away after our flesh or temptations of one kind or another, we cease walking with Him at least for a time
  - As we walk, the Spirit points out dangers in our path, helping us avoid stumbling
    - But when we press others to act against their convictions, we interfere with the Spirit, making ourselves a stumbling stone
    - We break their stride, leading them to fall
    - We contradict the Spirit's instructions, keeping the person from following Christ
  - Just as the person walking didn't recognize the stone before they tripped, our fellow believers won't realize we're leading them astray
    - They won't recognize we were truly their adversary, at least in that moment
    - Our advice may have been well-meaning, but it led them into sin
    - That's the chief danger with liberalism…it's spiritual poison offered delivered by the hands of friends
- And that's why Paul puts the burden on those who would offer the advice
  - Notice he doesn't ask the weak to become stronger, to become more discerning in what advice they take
    - Remember they are the weak ones, like a toddler
    - We can't expect them to take responsibility in this situation
    - Instead Paul places the burden on the stronger in the body, expecting them to

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protect the interests of the weaker

- Which is why Paul directs the church to set a goal of not putting an obstacle in a brother's path
  - Meaning we must not advocate for greater liberty than someone feels comfortable assuming
  - But also not acting in ways that make another believer uncomfortable in light of their convictions
  - So it's both being careful in what we advocate by our words and what we endorse by our actions
- Here again, Paul's not advocating for us adopting the weakness of other brothers nor endorsing their theological shortcomings
  - Notice in v.14 Paul makes clear that there is no need to abstain from any food for the sake of righteousness
  - We are righteous by faith alone in Jesus Christ, and His work on our behalf has put to rest any need to observe ritual cleanliness
  - Simply put, the rituals of the Law, including ritual cleanliness, are no longer in effect for the believer
  - And therefore, food means nothing in the matter of our personal holiness

- So all the more, we should not use food to diminish another's holiness, Paul says in v.15
  - We are walking without love ourselves if we divide over food
    - Which means, we can't press others to eat what they do not feel comfortable eating
    - Nor should we cause them to separate themselves from us because we continued eating things that offended them
    - In both cases, we've chosen food over loving our brothers
  - This chapter began discussing weaker brothers eating only vegetables in the fellowship gatherings
    - This likely happened because Jewish believers avoided eating with Gentiles due to their unclean dietary habits
    - While the Gentiles hadn't persuaded the Jews to relax their convictions, they did offend their Jewish brothers by their actions
    - They persisted in their own eating habits
  - Remember this letter was written to a mostly Gentile church in Rome that was probably founded by Jews from Pentecost
    - Therefore, based on Paul's comments we assume that a division had developed in this church body between the two groups over Jewish convictions
    - Jews keeping the dietary laws were at odds with Gentiles and maybe some more mature Jews who didn't
    - So when food was served, these weaker Jews adopted vegetarianism rather than sharing in the meat of the meal

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        - Sounds like a very awkward, unloving community
- Which leads Paul in v.16 to advise that we not take our liberty and weaponize it against our brothers
    - Liberty is a great thing in the body of Christ
        - How much happier are we living under liberty than we would have been living under the burdens of the law?
        - Gentiles take this privilege for granted, since we were never under the law
    - But imagine what it would mean for us if we had to adopt the Law as part of our pursuit of Christ?
        - What if Christ hadn't performed all the Law for us?
        - What if He had left some of the Law unfulfilled so that we would have to perform it for ourselves
        - That would have eliminated our liberty and left us burdened with specific rules we could never break or else we would lose our salvation
    - Instead, Christ won the prize of liberty for us – which is a good thing certainly
        - So we should protect our liberty
        - We protect it first by not allowing our liberty to be thought of as as evil, a source of sin
        - And that's another way to define liberalism…making liberty a source for sin
- The life of the church should use our liberty to advance eternal causes, eternal outcomes
    - Paul says the kingdom is not eating and drinking
        - The mission of the Kingdom is not found in the pleasures we have on earth
        - We aren't advancing the causes of the Kingdom when we encourage certain dietary habits
        - Nor are we experiencing the fullness of the Kingdom when we enjoy a particular food or drink here
    - At best, these things bring comfort to the body, which is a dying thing destined to be shed before the Kingdom comes to us
        - So regardless of how noble our motives, we cannot make the adopting of a certain lifestyle the aim of our work for Christ
        - We are ambassadors for Christ, assigned to work for the expansion and the Kingdom
        - We further that mission by soul work, not by body work
- Being absorbed in eating and drinking concerns is body work, not soul work, Paul says
    - Instead, our mission is to pursue righteousness, peace and joy in the Holy Spirit
        - Pursing righteousness refers to working to advance the Gospel, both in words and in our actions
        - Obviously, we share the Gospel with others

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        - But we are also to pursue righteousness in our person through a walk of sanctification
        - Restraining our own liberty will be a necessary part of that process at times
    - Pursuing peace refers to seeking unity in the body, being at peace with one another and in our own convictions
        - When we trouble each other with our personal convictions, we rob one another of peace
        - That's the opposite of soul work
        - And even more, we undermine unity in the body by making our differences in personal conviction appear to be "problems" that must be solved
        - Instead, we should guard each other's liberty to maintain different convictions and in so doing encourage unity in peace
    - Finally, pursuing joy in the Holy Spirit means ensuring everyone knows the joy that comes from pleasing Christ by our obedience
        - There is simply no greater joy to be found in the body of Christ than a quiet confidence we are obeying Christ by our convictions
        - A believer never knows greater joy than obeying Christ, turning from temptations to sin and maintaining a close walk with Him
        - And we will never know more trouble than when we are out of step with Christ, ignoring our convictions
    - Our mission as a body must be to encourage every believer to find that place in their walk with Christ
        - Knowing His will so they can live in harmony with it, seeking to please Him by obedience
        - Having peace in the certainty of our convictions and the joy of keeping them before Christ
- As Paul says in vs.18-19, those believers who set their mind on serving Christ will be approved both by God and their fellow man
    - So let's not seek for others to approve your convictions by joining us in them…that's not love, that's ego
        - Pursue those things that make for peace and for the building up of one another
        - Give way to others' convictions without adopting them yourself
        - Affirm others in their determination to be obedient, without making them feel smaller for having restrained their liberty
        - A believer who won't eat a certain food is not someone to be mocked or "fixed"
        - They are a weaker brother or sister whose conscience must be protected and whose convictions must be respected
    - Yet once more, for the sake of emphasis, Paul reminds us in v.20 not to adopt the weaker brother's restrictive lifestyle
        - We can avoid tearing them down without joining them in their weakness

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        - We want to walk that line between two evils
        - On the one hand, don't undermine their convictions
        - As Paul says in v.21, it is a good thing that we restrict our lifestyle to help weaker members
    - On the other hand, we don't want to give reason for believers to agree with the weaker viewpoint
        - We don't want to undermine a believer's confidence in their liberty
        - We are just giving room for weaker brothers to catch up in their spiritual maturity
- Paul summarizes his argument in vs.22-23 with three rules for dealing with liberalism

Rom. 14:22 The faith which you have, have as your own conviction before God. Happy is he who does not condemn himself in what he approves.
Rom. 14:23 But he who doubts is condemned if he eats, because his eating is not from faith; and whatever is not from faith is sin.

- Rule #1: Hold to the faith you have on matters of liberty as a matter of conviction before God
    - Each believer is likely to have differences in their liberty according to how the Lord convicts each of us
    - So follow your convictions as a matter of faith and obedience
    - Remember, you seek to please God alone, not other believers
    - And you are accountable to God alone, not other believers
    - So knowing this, don't let liberalism compromise your convictions
- Rule #2: Don't condemn yourself by what you approve
    - Don't become an advocate for meaningless things like eating or drinking
    - For in doing so, you run the risk of leading other members of the body into sin, causing them to stumble, and bringing yourself under condemnation
    - Instead, be an advocate for the Kingdom, for eternal outcomes of righteousness, peace and joy
    - Happy is the one who doesn't condemn himself by what he approves
- Finally Rule #3: When we are persuaded to go against our convictions, we sin – even in matters that are not themselves sin
    - Our convictions are a roadmap for sanctification given to us by the Holy Spirit
    - Our journey will look different than other believers
    - The Spirit will grant us freedoms He may not grant to other believers, or that others have not traveled far enough yet to experience
    - Don't second-guess your conviction merely because others have freedom you don't

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- Respect the Spirit's direction, trusting that He knows better why you need these restrictions when others may not
- To act contrary to your convictions is sin

- Now Paul is ready to flip this coin over…
  - In Chapter 14 we just studied the situation of stronger believers who enjoyed more freedom, imposing their liberty on weaker members
    - In Rome, the situation came in the context of Jewish and Gentile believers contending over food
    - Stronger Gentile believers wanted to impose their freedom on weaker, Jewish believers
    - This was liberalism, and it was wrong
  - Now in the first half of Chapter 15, Paul moves to considering the opposite problem
    - Now the problem is one of weaker believers seeking to impose their more restrictive lifestyles on more liberal brothers and sisters
    - Again in Rome, the concern was Jewish believers who wanted Gentile believers to become more like Jews to secure unity
    - For these Jewish believers, unity in the body required that Gentiles adopt Jewish dietary laws, Sabbath restrictions, or even take circumcision
    - This is the opposite of liberalism…it's legalism
  - So just as liberalism is an abuse of liberty, legalism is an abuse of personal conviction
    - It's making your personal convictions law for everyone
    - That's we call it legalism…it's requiring others to live according to a law that doesn't actually exist
    - We're not talking about enforcing actual biblical commands…that's a necessary discipline of ensuring the body meets God's standards
    - Rather legalism is making ourselves another's judge, convicting them for failing to meet our standards
- Paul spends less time on legalism than he did on liberalism for several reasons
  - First, many of the points in the earlier chapter would apply here
    - Paul's already told us to respect each other's convictions, when they are more liberal or more restrictive than our own
    - And he said we cannot impose our convictions on another
    - Nor can we judge others for having different convictions
    - These truths carry over to the topic of legalism
  - Secondly, Paul addressed the relationship of the believer to the law in previous chapters of this letter
    - Therefore, Paul doesn't spend time covering the error of imposing law on others

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        - He's already explained we are under grace and therefore, the law holds no power over us
    - Finally, the problem of weaker believers imposing a legal lifestyle on stronger believers is a far less worrisome prospect than stronger believers corrupting the weak
        - For all our fear of legalism, the frequency and power of it is relatively muted
        - While there were certainly Judaizers operating in many places, their influence was doomed to die out
        - The church was becoming increasingly Gentile even in Paul's day
        - So Paul understood that the future course of the church would be among Gentiles, not Jews
        - And since Gentiles for the most part have little interest in adopting the law of Moses, the threat of legalism from Jews was destined to die down
    - Therefore, Paul's focus in Chapter 15 is only tangentially about Jews imposing legalism on Gentiles
        - Paul does address the issue specifically in vs.8-12
        - But before that, Paul writes more generally about accepting one another in the body
        - His teaching on showing acceptance bridges his teachings against liberalism and legalism

Rom. 15:1 Now we who are strong ought to bear the weaknesses of those without strength and not just please ourselves.
Rom. 15:2 Each of us is to please his neighbor for his good, to his edification.
Rom. 15:3 For even Christ did not please Himself; but as it is written, "The reproaches of those who reproached You fell on Me."
Rom. 15:4 For whatever was written in earlier times was written for our instruction, so that through perseverance and the encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope.
Rom. 15:5 Now may the God who gives perseverance and encouragement grant you to be of the same mind with one another according to Christ Jesus,
Rom. 15:6 so that with one accord you may with one voice glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.

- Paul's opening statement in v.1 is a concise summary of the previous chapter
    - It mirrors his opening verse in v.14
        - In Chapter 14 Paul said accept the weak, but not for passing judgment
        - Here he says you strong bear the weaknesses of those without strength, but not to please ourselves
        - He's saying something similar, though not exactly the same

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- In Chapter 14, Paul asks for the strong to accept the weak in unity
  - Here Paul is asking the strong to bear those weaknesses
  - So in the first case, Paul expected the weaker to be included in the body without demands they drop their convictions first
  - And now Paul is reminding the body not to lose patience with the weaker's convictions after joining
- So we bring weaker in and we continue to seek to please them for their edification
  - This is how the stronger deal with the legalism of weaker brothers
  - Just as it was wrong to force liberal thinking on them, we must also bear up under their desires to share their legalism with us

- Notice again who bears the responsibility for dealing with the problem?
  - You might have expected Paul to put the burden for dealing with legalism on the perpetrators, the weaker brothers and sisters
    - Instead, Paul continues to ask the stronger brothers and sisters to take ownership for solving the problem
    - The stronger bear up under the assault of those weaker who insist we adopt their legalistic restrictions
    - We don't try to stop their convictions, nor do we make them feel bad for pressing their legalism against us
  - We bear all this, seeking to please them within limits, for their edification
    - And of course the best example of us in this regard is Christ Himself
    - He bore the reproaches of rejections, beatings, scourging and ultimately the cross
    - These were things Christ didn't deserve to experience, and they were placed upon Him by those who didn't know what they were doing
    - Nevertheless, Christ in His strength accepted them, bearing them beautifully for the edification of all those who receive His grace
  - That's our model…bear the indignities of others' legalistic convictions when around them for the sake of unity and edification
    - Making them feel pleased that others are respecting their convictions
    - Doing so without condemnation or judgment
    - Remembering Christ did worse for our sake
- And then in v.4 Paul says there is a silver lining in this cloud…
  - Referring to the Old Testament scripture – and specifically of the Law itself – Paul reminds us that these things were written to instruct us
    - Paul says that many believers over the centuries have found perseverance and encouragement in these scriptures
    - While we may not be under the letter of the Law, believers can still be instructed from the Old Testament

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- And in this case, stronger believers can be instructed by the Law as they learn how to bear up under the legalism of weak believers
  - Remember what we learned last week…in time, through instruction in the word, these weak believers will eventually gain strength
  - And by their strength, they will move beyond these restrictions by themselves, learning to enjoy liberty
  - And when they do, they will look back fondly on your respect for their convictions and your willingness to love them in that way

- So let's not diminish the Law in the eyes of those who have an excessive dependence on them
  - In that way, even the Law may become a cause for edification in weak believers who use it as a crutch
    - By bearing this weakness, we further unity in the body which is the way we all grow in maturity
    - We all need the rest of the body to gain strength
  - Consider how spiritually mature strong believers will be made to grow further?
    - Will it be in great book study? Self-admiration societies?
    - Is it going to be by learning to bear up under the inconveniences and weakness of the spiritually immature?
    - By baring the legalism of weak brothers and sisters, we give opportunity for the Lord to strengthen us and test us
    - Do we care more about others than ourselves? Are we ready to make more sacrifices for the weakest among us?
    - Or will we divide the body over meaningless things like food or drink?
  - In v.5 Paul prays that the Lord might give the stronger in the church the perseverance and encouragement to pursue unity among the weak
    - To be of the same mind of Christ, Who sought unity with sinners
    - Talk about a union of unequals…Jesus united with the likes of us
    - And He did so, at great personal cost, so that He could present us to Himself a spotless Bride, Scripture says
  - If you are one mind with Christ in that goal, then you'll stop caring about whether others' convictions are inconvenient or unnecessary
    - You'll only care about what's best for them
    - And in exercising that concern, you grow too
    - And in the end, we will glorify Christ with one voice
- So the opening teaching of Chapter 15 establishes two main ideas:
  - First, even though weaker believers are responsible for promoting legalism, nevertheless the responsibility for solving the problem falls to stronger believers
    - Just as with liberalism, Paul expects those with seniority in the faith to assume

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the responsibility for making things better

- Unity in the body is all important, and the spiritually strong believers (those with a mature understanding of liberty) will be held accountable for how we handled these situations
- Just like a parent is responsible for a misbehaving child, so are the spiritually strong responsible for helping the spiritually immature

- Secondly, the solution for legalism is found in bearing the weaknesses rather than pleasing ourselves
  - Once again, we aren't endorsing legalism or even adopting these lifestyle choices in general
  - But we don't condemn others for having them, we accommodate them
  - And at times we adopt certain restrictions to please those who hold to them so that unity is maintained

- His teaching is summarized in v.7:

Rom. 15:7 Therefore, accept one another, just as Christ also accepted us to the glory of God.

- Paul says accept one another in the body, echoing his earlier command in Chapter 14
  - So if we might ask how accepting we should be, here's our answer
    - For example, are there some circumstances where we can't accept a believer's weaknesses?
    - Where we must reject them until they overcome their problems?
    - Then after they shed some of these legalistic tendencies, we can find opportunity for fellowship
  - Take a look at Paul's standard for how we are to accept one another
    - Paul says we must accept one another to the same degree that Christ accepted us
    - So let's ask, on what terms did Christ accept us into His body? Grace alone
    - How burdensome were your sins upon Christ? How unnecessary was His gift of grace? Very
    - How unlike Christ were we when He accepted us into His body by faith? We were completely unlike Him
    - But what allowed us to become more like Him? It began with Christ accepting us into the body
  - So Christ is our standard for how we accept weaker believers in our gathering
    - We accept them by grace
    - We accept them no matter how burdensome or unnecessary their convictions

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        - We accept them though they may place demands on the body very unlike our standards or choices so that we may please them
        - And we do this because only by accepting them into the body first may they mature and grow to something better
    - Doing these things will be to the glory of the Father
        - The Father was glorified when Jesus accepted us
        - And the Father is glorified when we accept one another
- Moving on, Paul now touches on the specific issue of Jew and Gentile in the Roman church
    - This next passage represents the last major teaching section of the letter

Rom. 15:8 For I say that Christ has become a servant to the circumcision on behalf of the truth of God to confirm the promises given to the fathers,
Rom. 15:9 and for the Gentiles to glorify God for His mercy; as it is written,
"Therefore I will give praise to You among the Gentiles,
And I will sing to Your name."
Rom. 15:10 Again he says,
"Rejoice, O Gentiles, with His people."
Rom. 15:11 And again,
"Praise the Lord all you Gentiles,
And let all the peoples praise Him."
Rom. 15:12 Again Isaiah says,
"There shall come the root of Jesse,
And He who arises to rule over the Gentiles,
in Him shall the Gentiles hope."

- Paul reminds the Jews within the church that Christ came as a "servant to the circumcision", meaning to the Jewish nation
    - Jesus was fulfilling the promises the Lord made to Israel
        - Those promises, given to the fathers of Israel, included the promise to Abraham to bless all nations through his seed
        - Of course, Paul's point to the Jewish believer was don't forget that your Messiah came to fulfill all the promises of God
        - Including the promise to bless (save) Gentiles
    - Nothing serves to make the point to a Jewish reader better than scripture
        - So Paul quotes Psalm 18 in v.9 and Deuteronomy 32 in v.10 and Psalm 117 in v.11 and Isaiah 11 in v.12 to make his point
        - All these passages reaffirm that God intended to bring Gentiles into His assembly alongside Israel
    - Therefore Gentiles must be accepted into the body too, despite their lifestyle

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differences with Jews

- After all, if the Lord accepted Gentiles then who were Jews to reject them
- It was simply a matter of submitting to the will of God

- Paul's teaching ends with a benediction of sorts…

Rom. 15:13 Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that you will abound in hope by the power of the Holy Spirit.

- Paul wished for the Lord to fill the church in Rome with all the joy and peace that comes with believing
  - The fact that Paul expresses this as a wish or request strongly suggests that experiencing joy and peace is optional for a Christian
  - Make no mistake…every Christian has access to joy and peace
  - And by God's grace, we will all know joy and peace in eternity
- But Paul was speaking about the experience of his readers in this age, while we serve Christ in this body
  - During this time, we may know joy and peace or we may not
  - We have all met miserable Christians
  - And we've all probably been that person at one time or another
- So what determines whether we experience joy and peace as believers?
  - It's found in the phrase "in believing"
  - The phrase in Greek describes an action that is on-going
  - It's a euphemism for our walking with Christ, for pursuing sanctification, for living out our righteousness
  - That's been the topic of Chapter 12 and onward
- So Paul is saying that for those who follow the prescription found in these chapters, those who live out their faith obediently, you will know joy and peace
  - You will likely also know trials, tribulation, persecution, disappointments, etc.
    - But those things will not define you
    - They will not rob you of your spiritual joy
    - And they will not disturb your spiritual peace
  - Because those things will be based not in circumstances or feelings
    - Our joy will be a supernatural response to working hand-in-hand with Christ, recognizing His righteousness taking hold in our hearts
    - And our peace will be unshakable as we grow in our maturity and understanding of what's coming for us in eternity
    - These are the fruits of living in the Spirit

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- Paul says at the end of v.13 that if you obtain these things, you will abound in hope by the power of the Holy Spirit in you
  - This hope is an eternal hope
  - Not a hope for earthly things but for heavenly things
  - You will set you mind on things above
  - And as you do, the things of this world fade in importance
- If you aren't feeling that fruit now or haven't felt it in a while or have never known it, then check your walk with Christ
  - Are you hand-in-hand with Him or are you watching Him from a distance?
  - If He feels distant then run back to Him
  - Return to listening to Him, to serving Him, to craving the experience of becoming more like Him
  - And by the power of the Spirit, He will change you from the inside out

- Next time, our final lesson will cover the second half of 15 and the personal details of Chapter 16
  - It's a teaching of history more than doctrine
    - Which seems an appropriate way to finish a book so heavy in weighty matters

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- Paul's greatest written work – and perhaps the most important New Testament epistle – comes to an end in a peculiar fashion
    - Paul spent 8 chapters walking us down the Romans Road, carefully explaining the way to salvation through faith in Jesus Christ
        - Then Paul spent 3 chapters revealing the mystery of God's plan for His people Israel
        - Finally Paul taught nearly four more chapters on how the church should walk in the light of our salvation
        - He's covered so much ground, and he's tackled many of the toughest topics of our faith
    - So what kind of ending do you tack on to the end of such an impressive letter?
        - Surprisingly, Paul ends with a fundraising appeal
        - And perhaps that makes sense in this case
        - Because the enormity of what Paul has given to the church in this letter certainly justifies an expectation of gratitude
- We ended last week in Chapter 15 v.13 as Paul wrapped up the formal teaching in this letter
    - And now Paul turns to addressing his readers specifically, calling on them to respond to his letter in the appropriate way

Rom. 15:14 And concerning you, my brethren, I myself also am convinced that you yourselves are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge and able also to admonish one another.
Rom. 15:15 But I have written very boldly to you on some points so as to remind you again, because of the grace that was given me from God,
Rom. 15:16 to be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles, ministering as a priest the gospel of God, so that my offering of the Gentiles may become acceptable, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.

- We can clearly see Paul turning to address his audience as he says "and concerning you…"
    - What follows is a diplomatic yet convicting appeal for the church in Rome to support Paul's future missionary journeys
    - To understand how and why Paul makes this appeal, we need to remember the background I provided at the outset of this letter
- As you may remember, by the time of this letter Paul was the foremost apostle of the church
    - He had traveled extensively throughout the Roman Empire evangelizing and teaching
        - He had established or discipled churches in major Roman cities like Antioch,

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Corinth and Ephesus

- And he had written letters to many other churches around Asia Minor, and each letter was treated as a precious object by the faithful

- And then there was the church in Rome
  - Rome was the most important city in the known world
  - And therefore the church in Rome carried itself with a certain degree of pride
  - What's more, the church had not been founded by an apostle, which gave the leadership an even greater sense of accomplishment
- Yet the great apostle Paul had never visited the church in Rome, even when he had been in the neighborhood (relatively speaking)
  - In fact, Paul had not even written to the church in this great city
  - So by the time Paul sat down to write his letter to Rome, the church leadership was feeling a bit overlooked and unappreciated
  - And yet Paul was going to need the help of this significant and well-financed church body for his future evangelism
- Which is why Paul went to such effort to impress them with his letter
  - No doubt Paul has blown them away with an intellectual feast of spiritual truth that uplifted them and humbled them
  - He gave them something they could truly appreciate, something that honored them
  - Paul had saved his best for them

- And interestingly, Paul has also organized his letter so that he ended his teaching addressing the equality of Gentiles in the church
  - That organization was strategic on Paul's part, since it leads him directly into his appeal for support
    - Paul is the apostle sent to the Gentiles
    - And as such, he focused his evangelism efforts on traveling to major centers of Gentiles
  - One such area would be particularly hard to reach…Spain
    - It lay at the outskirts of the empire, on the opposite side from Judea
    - So for Paul to travel that far, he would need significant time and support
    - And not coincidentally, Rome lay directly in his path from Judea to Spain
  - Therefore Paul wrote Romans to educate and impress his audience in Rome, which then gave him opportunity to make a heartfelt appeal
    - That appeal will be for the Jewish leadership in the Roman church to give generously to Paul's mission to reach Gentiles
    - That's a tough sell under any circumstances, but even more so when the church isn't on your side

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        - So returning to Chapter 15, we see Paul's smart strategy unfolding
- Paul's argument comes in three parts
    - First in vs.14-21 Paul reminds the church of the nobility of his mission to reach Gentiles and his faithfulness in carrying it out
        - Secondly, in vs.22-29 Paul presents the Roman church with his appeal for their partnership with him in his next mission
        - Finally in vs.30-33 Paul explains his future missionary plans and the opportunity the Romans have to be involved in that work
        - This is a very traditional missionary fundraising approach, or at least it has become traditional
    - In vs.14-16 Paul begins in defense of his mission, but starts diplomatically mentioning the good things he's heard of this church
        - Paul says he knew this church
            - He knew they were full of goodness, filled with knowledge and able to admonish others in the truth
    - This is a notable statement, since Paul had never visited Rome
        - But that doesn't mean Paul didn't have connections in that city and in that church
        - Take a moment to glance at Chapter 16 and you'll notice that Paul spends considerable time greeting acquaintances in that city
        - It's the longest such list in all his epistles
- He was making a point that he had connections to the Roman church despite having never visited the city
    - Paul begins saying he knows they are full of goodness, referring to their moral excellence or character
        - The Roman church stood as a light amidst darkness in the center of a pagan empire
        - They were a beacon of godliness, resisting the evil culture so they could transform it by the truth
    - Likewise, Paul knew they were full of knowledge referring to their understanding of biblical truth
        - This was largely a self-taught church, humanly speaking
        - No apostle had made it to Rome as far as we know, so they hadn't known the benefit of personal instruction by someone like Paul
        - Nevertheless, they were learning the Scriptures, understanding Christian doctrine even before the canon was complete
    - And out of that learning, Paul says he knew they were admonishing believers to live out what they were learning
        - In other words, this wasn't a church content with filling heads with knowledge

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        - They expected followers of Jesus to live in ways that pleased their Master
        - Truly this church was spiritually mature
- Then in v.15 Paul says nevertheless I wrote boldly to you, meaning he covered important doctrinal truth in great detail without the intent to offend
    - Paul knew that the church might take offense at receiving such a thorough explanation of the Gospel
        - It might seem to suggest to them that he thought the church in Rome didn't understand the basis of their own salvation
        - He says he writes boldly to them on "some points" as if to imply these were things they probably already knew
        - In reality, they probably learned a lot from Paul's explanation as do we all
    - Still Paul handled their egos gently, leading him into his main point in writing: to remind them that he has a God-given mission to reach Gentiles
        - In v.16 Paul explains he ministers as a priest for the purpose of pleasing God by converting Gentiles
        - Who in turn will be sanctified by the Holy Spirit
            - This is the heart of the mission of the church, not just to reach Gentiles but Jews too
- Furthermore, Paul wants the church in Rome to understand that his absence was ordained as part of that mission

Rom. 15:17 Therefore in Christ Jesus I have found reason for boasting in things pertaining to God.
Rom. 15:18 For I will not presume to speak of anything except what Christ has accomplished through me, resulting in the obedience of the Gentiles by word and deed,
Rom. 15:19 in the power of signs and wonders, in the power of the Spirit; so that from Jerusalem and round about as far as Illyricum I have fully preached the gospel of Christ.
Rom. 15:20 And thus I aspired to preach the gospel, not where Christ was already named, so that I would not build on another man's foundation;
Rom. 15:21 but as it is written,
"They who had no news of Him shall see,
And they who have not heard shall understand."

- Paul says that in his work he takes every opportunity to boast in things God is doing, yet he does not presume to boast about his own accomplishments
    - This is Paul's preface to explaining the great things that have happened in his ministry
        - He wants to be sure the church understands he is not assuming personal credit

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for these outcomes
        - Rather, he acknowledges that the Lord alone has accomplished this work
        - And yet the Lord has been working through Paul's ministry, and the results speak for themselves
    - Paul's years spent reaching Gentiles with the Gospel has resulted in a tremendous response of obedience to the Gospel, both in word and deed
        - Gentiles were turning to the God of Israel, embracing Jesus as that Messiah
        - They were confessing Christ, showing obedience to the Gospel by their word
        - And they were turning from pagan lifestyles and immorality to obey the commands of Christ
        - These were remarkable achievements that few in Israel could ever have imagined happening
        - As Paul says in Ephesians, it's literally the breaking down of the temple wall separating the Jew and Gentile
    - The Gentile response came by the power of the Spirit and in conjunction with great signs
        - These experiences validated that the Lord was indeed courting Gentiles and welcoming them into the body
        - As the Spirit manifested these wonders in the midst of Gentile acceptance, the apostles were forced to accept their confessions were genuine
        - The Spirit worked in this way to overcome the natural resistance of Jewish evangelists
        - Which is why Paul reminded his readers of these things
- So in light of the Lord's remarkable saving work among Gentiles, Paul says he determined to visit places where Christ had not yet been preached
    - That was in keeping with his office as apostle
        - The word apostle roughly translates "one sent with a message", and it reflects their mission to go into unreached areas
        - Apostles generally didn't build on top of another's work, though on occasion they did (see 1 Corinthians 3)
        - Instead they opened doors in new places
    - Paul says he had managed to open these doors from Jerusalem to as far as Illyricum, which was a Roman province
        - Illyricum is the ancient name for the present day Dalmatian coast of the Adriatic Sea
        - It covered an area from Greece in the south through current-day Albania, Montenegro, Bosnia, and Croatia
        - That area was a short boat ride across the Adriatic to Rome
    - So Paul's saying he's been moving in Rome's direction, but his mission kept him

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focused on other areas first

- After all, why would Paul go so far out of his way to reach a well-established church in Rome when it meant passing by other unreached areas?
- That's his argument in vs.20-21
- He says he set his mind on skipping over places where another work already existed and a church was formed and growing

- Now we know Paul stopped in other cities where churches already existed, places like Ephesus for example
  - But these cities were located on the way for Paul, so he would have had to go out of his way to avoid them
  - That wouldn't have made sense, so Paul stopped to encourage and teach those churches
  - Paul was fulfilling the word of Isaiah by bringing good news to those who had no knowledge of God
  - And he was telling of Jesus to those who had not previously heard of Israel's God much less about a coming Messiah

- Yet up to now, Rome hadn't been on the way to anywhere Paul needed to minister to
  - Which is why Paul hadn't visited them

Rom. 15:22 For this reason I have often been prevented from coming to you;
Rom. 15:23 but now, with no further place for me in these regions, and since I have had for many years a longing to come to you
Rom. 15:24 whenever I go to Spain — for I hope to see you in passing, and to be helped on my way there by you, when I have first enjoyed your company for a while —

- Notice Paul says in v.22 "For this reason…"
  - His mission kept him away, and he hoped the church could appreciate his reasoning
  - But all that was about to change
- Paul now intended to come their way soon, and therefore he wanted to smooth things over with the church prior to his arrival with this letter
  - In v.23 he says that he had no further place to go in these regions between Jerusalem and Rome
  - And since Paul had long desired to visit the church in Rome, now was the appropriate time
- Paul's claim to have exhausted his opportunities to reach unreached areas in Asia Minor is quite a remarkable testimony
  - Obviously, Paul wasn't the only person evangelizing at that time, so he's not taking credit for moving the Gospel to every place

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- Still, we know Paul was the most prolific evangelist, by far

- So here's something to consider
  - Paul is sitting in Corinth preparing to return to Jerusalem at the conclusion of his third missionary journey
    - He was converted to the faith barely 20 years earlier
    - And in just two decades of life as a Christian, Paul had evangelized roughly half the known world
    - He had written nearly half of the books of the New Testament canon
    - And he had founded churches in at least 14 major cities and towns…in 20 years
  - How much have we accomplished for the kingdom over the past 2 decades as believers?
    - Obviously, that question is unfair because we only accomplish what the Lord determines to do through us
    - Still, there is something to consider here, because undoubtedly we could have done more for the kingdom had we set our mind to it
  - Paul's remarkable legacy doesn't establish our goal in ministry, but it does challenge us to increase our effort and focus
    - We know all Paul accomplished for the Lord, but we don't know all he sacrificed
    - We know of some sacrifices, including coming near death and suffering great deprivation at times
    - In the end, church tradition holds that Paul was martyred for his work
    - So let his example serve to challenge our willingness to sacrifice so that we might be useful to the Lord for accomplishing great things also
- Now look at v.24 where we see Paul mentioning a desire to be in Spain
  - Paul saw Spain as the next great frontier for his apostolic ministry
    - And as it turned out, Rome was on his way
    - So the time had come to stop and visit the Roman church
    - But Spain was a long way from Rome, and if Paul was going to make it that far, he would need support
    - And that's exactly why he's written to Rome
  - Paul says he hopes to see them in passing through to Spain, and in seeing them be helped in reaching the Gentiles in Spain
    - This is a simple and bold appeal
    - It's honest and unashamed
    - I can think of no better way to raise money for ministry
    - No need to pander, no need to plead
- But Paul isn't coming to Rome right away

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- Even though Paul was sitting in Corinth as he wrote, and was only a few days journey away from Rome, he was taking a detour

Rom. 15:25 but now, I am going to Jerusalem serving the saints.
Rom. 15:26 For Macedonia and Achaia have been pleased to make a contribution for the poor among the saints in Jerusalem.
Rom. 15:27 Yes, they were pleased to do so, and they are indebted to them. For if the Gentiles have shared in their spiritual things, they are indebted to minister to them also in material things.
Rom. 15:28 Therefore, when I have finished this, and have put my seal on this fruit of theirs, I will go on by way of you to Spain.
Rom. 15:29 I know that when I come to you, I will come in the fullness of the blessing of Christ.

- Paul continues to explain his future missionary plans saying he must first return to Jerusalem
  - He's literally traveling in the opposite direction from Rome
    - But take note of why he's headed back
    - He's delivering a contribution from Gentile churches in this region to meet the needs of the Jewish church in Jerusalem
    - The church in Jerusalem was especially poor largely because faith in Jesus made a Jew a pariah in the city
    - Without the support of the Jewish community, it was nearly impossible to survive in the city
  - So support from other churches in the region was a huge issue, and Paul worked hard to raise support for the Jewish church wherever he went
    - Having persuaded a number of churches to give generously to the needs of Jerusalem, Paul is now ready to return to the city
    - And he mentioned this trip to those in Rome because he wants to make a larger point to them
  - Notice in v.27 Paul says these Gentile churches were only too happy to give to the Jewish church out of gratitude for what they had received
    - Paul's alluding to the importance of Israel and the Jewish people in God's plan to bring salvation to all mankind
    - As he taught earlier in this letter, Israel's covenant relationship with the Lord is the root that we've been grafted into by faith
    - So the Gentile church is indebted to the Jewish people for spiritual things
    - So how can we object to offering them material things, which are of far less value
- Can you see the wisdom of Paul's appeal here?

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- He's about to appeal to a church run by Jewish leaders asking them to fund his mission work to reach Gentiles in Spain
  - But before he does, he mentions his upcoming trip where he will deliver generous Gentile support to a needy Jewish church
  - So as the Jews are being blessed by Gentile believers, so it should be that these Jewish believers might bless future Gentiles in Spain
- Notice Paul then says in vs.28-29 that as he comes back this way and stops in Rome, he will expect to to be sent on to Spain by the Roman church
  - To be sent on means to be supported in that journey
  - Notice he adds that when he comes he will come in the fullness of the blessing of Christ
- Paul is referring to the blessing Christ would bestow upon the church in Rome on the occasion of Paul's visit and by way of his teaching and leadership
  - Paul was not an immodest man, as his letters demonstrate
  - So when Paul says this, he isn't complimenting himself
  - He's simply acknowledging the work the Lord was prepared to do through him in keeping with his role as an apostle
- So the deal he's offering the church in Rome is simple
  - He intends to come to that church so that he might bless them in their mission
  - And so that they might bless him in his mission
  - It's all about the mission
  - Paul isn't interested in becoming wealthy and he's not interested in visiting Rome merely for the attention it will give him
  - For Paul, everything is about the mission of the Church

- And therefore Paul turns to making a specific request for support…for prayer support

Rom. 15:30 Now I urge you, brethren, by our Lord Jesus Christ and by the love of the Spirit, to strive together with me in your prayers to God for me,
Rom. 15:31 that I may be rescued from those who are disobedient in Judea, and that my service for Jerusalem may prove acceptable to the saints;
Rom. 15:32 so that I may come to you in joy by the will of God and find refreshing rest in your company.
Rom. 15:33 Now the God of peace be with you all. Amen.

- The financial support Paul needed could only come once he arrived in the city of Rome
  - But the prayer support could start immediately and would be even more powerful
    - Paul didn't urge the church to support him financially, but he urges them to pray

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        - He refers to their prayers on behalf of his ministry work as striving together with Paul
        - It's a great way to understand your opportunity to pray for others in their ministry
    - First, it's a joining with another person
        - God will accomplish more through two members of the body united in this way than by individuals working apart
        - Even though one is using hands and feet while the other is using prayer, they are still joined spiritually
        - And in eternity we will understand how the Lord used these together to accomplish more to His glory
    - Secondly, both are striving Paul says
        - Obviously, Paul's long and dangerous journeys were a form of striving for Paul
        - But the Romans' prayers for Paul were equally striving
        - In fact the Greek word for strive is actually a compound word made up of the Greek words "together" and "fighting"
        - So it conveys the idea of fighting together
    - If you have ever tried to pray for someone else's ministry work on a continual basis, then you know full well that it is striving
        - You are fighting with the other person against a common enemy
        - The enemy will resist their work in the field in one way
        - And he will resist your work on your knees in other ways
        - But both of you will be striving if you're working at all
    - So as you consider your opportunities to support ministry, remember there are two types of support we should offer the work of the church
        - One is material, the other is spiritual
        - One is easy, one requires striving
        - One occurs in a moment, the other is continuous
        - One has delayed effect, the other has immediate effect
        - One enables the work, the other enables success
- Interestingly, Paul did return to Rome directly after visiting Jerusalem, though he entered Rome in chains
    - Jews conspired to have Paul arrested by Roman authorities while in Jerusalem
        - As a Roman citizen, he appealed to be tried by Caesar (which was a Roman right)
        - Which then led Rome to transport Paul for free to Rome
        - Paul spent two years in house arrest awaiting trial

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- And according to reliable early church records, Paul eventually left Rome with their support and indeed went to Spain for a time
  - Later, after several years, Paul returned to Rome
  - This time he was executed by Nero, according to church tradition
- With that Paul's legacy was complete
  - He had preached from Jerusalem to Spain
  - Countless men and women will be in the kingdom either directly or indirectly due to Paul and his writings
  - So in a sense, those in Rome who funded and prayed for Paul's work were striving with Paul for all those gains as well

- At this point, the letter is essentially complete…but for greetings in Chapter 16
  - We will read the chapter – and I will do my best not to butcher the names – and then we will consider a few historical facts along the way

Rom. 16:1 I commend to you our sister Phoebe, who is a servant of the church which is at Cenchrea;
Rom. 16:2 that you receive her in the Lord in a manner worthy of the saints, and that you help her in whatever matter she may have need of you; for she herself has also been a helper of many, and of myself as well.
Rom. 16:3 Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus,
Rom. 16:4 who for my life risked their own necks, to whom not only do I give thanks, but also all the churches of the Gentiles;
Rom. 16:5 also greet the church that is in their house. Greet Epaenetus, my beloved, who is the first convert to Christ from Asia.
Rom. 16:6 Greet Mary, who has worked hard for you.
Rom. 16:7 Greet Andronicus and Junias, my kinsmen and my fellow prisoners, who are outstanding among the apostles, who also were in Christ before me.
Rom. 16:8 Greet Ampliatus, my beloved in the Lord.
Rom. 16:9 Greet Urbanus, our fellow worker in Christ, and Stachys my beloved.
Rom. 16:10 Greet Apelles, the approved in Christ. Greet those who are of the household of Aristobulus.
Rom. 16:11 Greet Herodion, my kinsman. Greet those of the household of Narcissus, who are in the Lord.
Rom. 16:12 Greet Tryphaena and Tryphosa, workers in the Lord. Greet Persis the beloved, who has worked hard in the Lord.
Rom. 16:13 Greet Rufus, a choice man in the Lord, also his mother and mine.
Rom. 16:14 Greet Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas and the brethren with them.
Rom. 16:15 Greet Philologus and Julia, Nereus and his sister, and Olympas, and all the saints who are with them.

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Rom. 16:16 Greet one another with a holy kiss. All the churches of Christ greet you.

- Chapter 16 is a very personal list of thoughts and greetings
  - He mentions 36 names, 8 who are with Paul in Corinth and the rest are those he greets in Rome
    - Altogether, he mentions 27 men & 8 women
    - He also mentioned two households and three house churches
    - Most of the names are Gentile, reflecting the growing population of Gentiles in that church
  - It is interesting that Paul could name so many people in Rome and yet had never visited the city
    - As I mentioned earlier, Paul lists so many names because not having visited, he wanted to affirm his connection to this church
    - Also, Paul has probably made some personal contacts with those who left Rome to come visit him
    - So in fellowship, he greets them to be polite and loving
    - As Wiersbe observed, Paul was a friend-maker as well as a soul winner
- The first name Paul mentions, Phoebe, is the one who carried this letter to Rome from Corinth from where Paul wrote it
  - She might have been a deaconess
    - The word in Greek is *diakonos*, which means servant or minister or deacon
    - Illustrating that from the beginning woman have played an important and even prominent role in the church
  - The list from v.3–v.16 includes many Latin or Greek names (or possibly they are Jews with Greek names like Paul)
    - Priscilla and Aquila met Paul in Corinth when they fled Rome after the Emperor Claudius ordered Jews to leave Rome
    - They were also tent makers and as Paul says, they risked their lives for him
  - Paul took them to Ephesus with him where they helped Apollos
    - Later they moved back to Rome and had a church in their home
    - We also read about them being back in Ephesus with Timothy at one point
- The first convert from Asia refers to Ephesus, (Asia Minor) not modern day Asia
  - The reference in v.7 to apostles who were in Christ before Paul is striking
    - Notice these men are called apostles yet they are not among the twelve nor mentioned anywhere else in scripture
    - This is further evidence that there were numerous apostles not given high profile in scripture
  - Looking at verse 10, Paul greets not Aristobulus but the man's household

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        - Paul is probably referring to the slaves of that household who had become believers, yet Aristobulus himself had not
        - Rufus may have been the son of Simon of Cyrene who helped carry Christ's cross
        - And apparently his mother was like a mother to Paul at some point
        - And in v.14, the brethren is probably a reference to another house church

Rom. 16:17 Now I urge you, brethren, keep your eye on those who cause dissensions and hindrances contrary to the teaching which you learned, and turn away from them.
Rom. 16:18 For such men are slaves, not of our Lord Christ but of their own appetites; and by their smooth and flattering speech they deceive the hearts of the unsuspecting.
Rom. 16:19 For the report of your obedience has reached to all; therefore I am rejoicing over you, but I want you to be wise in what is good and innocent in what is evil.
Rom. 16:20 The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet. The grace of our Lord Jesus be with you.

- Interestingly, Paul interrupts his greetings to issue a brief warning against the activity of false teachers in the church
    - In v.17 Paul asks the church to keep a watchful eye for these guys
        - They will know them because they cause dissensions
        - They create hinderances to obedience to the word
    - This is an example of fruit from trees, to use Jesus' metaphor from Matthew 12
        - You may not immediately know if a teaching is correct, but if it's a lie from the enemy, his fingerprints will be all over it
        - It's effect will be negative on holiness, obedience and unity
        - People will not be edified by its introduction, they will be harmed
        - People will move away from sound doctrine as a result, which is why the enemy sows bad teaching in the church in the first place
    - Paul asks the church to take note of this pattern allowing it to inform their understanding of those who spread such teaching
        - Men who have this impact on the church are slaves of sin, not of Christ
        - Meaning they are not believers
        - So we're not talking about mistaken believers teaching falsely
        - We're talking about unbelievers intentionally manipulating the body for their own purposes
    - They use smooth speech, which means they are well-spoken

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        - And they ingratiate themselves with flattery which is a subtle form of lying
        - In other words, their style covers for their lack of substance
        - They offer the church candy-coated poison for the soul
        - And in that way they deceive the hearts of the unsuspecting
- Paul and other New Testament writers offer a great deal more information about dealing with false teachers in other letters (especially Jude)
    - So for now, Paul simply issues this warning in passing
        - I suspect he does this because at this time in history Paul was especially troubled by false teachers hounding him as he traveled
        - The mid-century saw a particularly strong rise in false teaching around Judaism and the Law as well as other heresies
    - So Paul may have become concerned that his interest in going to Rome might lead false teachers to get there before him
        - Also in v.19 Paul seems to think that the report of Rome's good teaching and steady adherence to true doctrine could provoke the enemy to respond
        - But in v.20 Paul says the enemy is destined to be crushed under Christ's feet
        - So though today Satan sows confusion in the church with false teaching, it will not change the end result for him
- Nevertheless, Paul calls upon the Roman church to be wise in what is good and innocent of evil
    - This is a powerful statement about avoiding the enemy's schemes
        - First be wise in what is good, what is true, what is in the Bible
        - Have a firm understanding of proper things so you will be in a position to identify the lies of the enemy
        - In this, the enemy will find it much harder to deceive you
    - Secondly, we must remain innocent of evil
        - If we voluntarily engage in sin, we open ourselves to condemnation and self-destruction
        - And the enemy can exploit our misdeeds to compromise our witness or distract us from our service
    - But if we remain informed of the truth and committed to walking in obedience and in love, the enemy has a much tougher job
        - At that point he can only tempt us to fall
        - And if we don't take the temptation, we are outside his reach
        - Easier said than done, but that's the formula
- Finally, Paul's great letter ends with a final salutation

Rom. 16:21 Timothy my fellow worker greets you, and so do Lucius and Jason and

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Sosipater, my kinsmen.
Rom. 16:22 **I, Tertius, who write this letter, greet you in the Lord.**
Rom. 16:23 **Gaius, host to me and to the whole church, greets you. Erastus, the city treasurer greets you, and Quartus, the brother.**
Rom. 16:24 **[The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen.]**
Rom. 16:25 **Now to Him who is able to establish you according to my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery which has been kept secret for long ages past,**
Rom. 16:26 **but now is manifested, and by the Scriptures of the prophets, according to the commandment of the eternal God, has been made known to all the nations, leading to obedience of faith;**
Rom. 16:27 **to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, be the glory forever. Amen.**

- The letter ends with a list of names of those working with Paul in Corinth
  - Timothy was working in Ephesus but spent time with Paul in Corinth
    - Lucius is probably Luke, who wrote the Gospel and Acts
    - Jason was likely Paul's host in Thessalonica
    - Sosipater traveled with Paul on his third journey
    - Tertius penned the words of this epistle as Paul spoke them (how would you like to have that accomplishment on your resume?)
      - And I wonder what that man was thinking as he heard the words of this letter pour out of Paul?
  - It's also interesting to remember the various problems happening in the Corinthian church at that time
    - Yet Paul's stay in that city was used by God to pen the Book of Romans
    - Certainly turning all things to good…
  - Erastus was the city treasurer of Ephesus
    - His name was found in 1929 on a marble pavement laid in the city of Corinth
    - The pavement read:

Erastus, in return for his appointment as commissioner for public works, laid this pavement at his own expense

- This was a lower office than city treasurer, so apparently he moved up after beginning his career in public office
- Paul ends with a powerful doxology
  - It combines thoughts and phrases from earlier letters and from Romans itself

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        - Paul trusted that God was able to establish the Roman church according to the gospel that Paul delivered, as preached by Jesus Christ
        - In other words, Paul trusted that the Lord would make true and meaningful the complicated things Paul wrote
        - He didn't worry about providing a commentary to accompany the letter…he knew God would explain it
    - Paul goes on in v.25 to explain that the message he has delivered was a mystery beforehand
        - A mystery in scripture is a truth God kept hidden through past ages, later to be revealed during the Church age
        - Paul revealed several mysteries in his letters, including one in this letter regarding Israel's salvation
        - So it's a high privilege for this church to be the first to learn of this truth
    - In v.26 Paul says they were manifested or made plain to them and all the nations
        - That statement makes clear that Paul recognized that what he was writing was Scripture intended to be shared with all nations
        - He knew the importance of what he shared with the church in Rome and of its eternal lasting quality
    - Finally, Paul says these truths were revealed to everyone so they would lead to an obedience of faith
        - That's the way to end a letter like this…focused on the obedience required
        - We've learned many things, we've been challenged even by these truths
        - We've expanded our appreciation for God's grace given to us in Jesus Christ
    - Now the question is what will we do differently as a result? What steps of obedience are now within our reach because of what we have heard?
        - To our wise God and Father, through His Son Jesus Christ, be all the glory, Amen

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